

Fate's Edge: Comprehensive Resource Guide

Comprehensive Reference Document

Risk, consequence, and sharp choices at the table.

Version v0.9

Contents

0.1	Reviewer's Guide: Understanding Fate's Edge	1
0.1.1	Reframing the Evaluation	1
0.1.2	Key Evaluation Framework	1
0.1.3	Common Misunderstandings to Address	1
0.1.4	Evaluation Methodology	2
0.1.5	What to Look For	2
0.1.6	Red Flags vs. Design Features	3
0.1.7	Recommended Review Approach	3
0.1.8	The Core Truth	4
1	Core Principles	5
1.1	Safety Tools	5
1.2	The Central Question	5
1.3	Core Principles	5
1.4	Key Concepts	6
1.4.1	Narrative Time	6
1.4.2	Story Beats (SB)	6
1.4.3	Affinity	6
1.4.4	Prestige Abilities	7
1.4.5	On-Screen vs. Off-Screen	7
1.5	Design Philosophy	7
1.5.1	Core Principles (Extended)	7
1.5.2	Mechanical Constraints	7
1.5.3	The Golden Rule	8
1.5.4	Flavor is Free	8
2	Core Mechanics	9
2.1	The Core Resolution Cycle	9
2.1.1	Step-by-Step Resolution	9
2.1.2	Difficulty Value (DV)	9
2.1.3	Position & Effect	10
2.1.4	Outcome Matrix	10
2.1.5	Critical Success (10s)	10
2.1.6	Dice Pool Limit & Auto-Successes	10
2.1.7	Boons	10
2.1.8	Story Beats (SB)	11
2.2	Player-Managed Modules	11
2.3	Turn Economy	12

2.3.1	Movement	12
2.3.2	Action Options	12
2.3.3	Initiative	12
2.3.4	Opportunity Attacks	12
2.4	Fatigue & Harm	12
2.4.1	Fatigue Track	12
2.4.2	Harm Levels	13
2.4.3	Taking Harm & Fatigue – The Procedure	13
2.4.4	Armor Conversion Table	13
2.4.5	Fear Effects	13
2.5	Skills	14
2.5.1	Core Skills (Abridged)	14
2.5.2	Attribute + Skill Combos	14
2.6	Experience Points (XP)	15
2.6.1	Awarding XP (per session)	15
2.6.2	Spending XP	15
2.6.3	Reputation Tiers	15
2.7	Game Structure	15
2.7.1	Narrative Time	15
2.7.2	Game Units	15
2.8	Assets & Followers (Quick Reference)	16
2.8.1	Assets (Off-Screen)	16
2.8.2	Followers (On-Screen)	16
2.8.3	Upkeep (per downtime)	16
3	Deck-Based Generators	17
3.1	Introduction to Deck Generators	17
3.2	Standard Deck Structure	17
3.3	Rank Severity and Clock Size	18
3.4	Draw Procedures	18
3.4.1	Quick Hook (2 cards)	18
3.4.2	Full Seed (4 cards)	18
3.4.3	Act Builder	18
3.5	Using the Deck in Play	19
3.6	Combo Rules	19
3.7	Regional Generator Summary	19
3.8	NPC Generation Deck	20
3.8.1	Generation Categories	20
3.8.2	Using the NPC Generator	21
3.9	Practical Deck Usage Examples	21
3.9.1	Example 1: Quick Scene Generation	21
3.9.2	Example 2: Consequences During Play	21
3.9.3	Example 3: NPC Creation	22
3.10	GM Guidance for Deck Usage	22
3.10.1	When to Use Which Deck	22
3.10.2	Interpreting Card Draws	22
3.10.3	Balancing Randomness and Narrative	22

4	Resource Management	23
4.1	Introduction	23
4.2	Supply Clock	23
4.2.1	Supply States	23
4.2.2	Filling the Supply Clock	23
4.2.3	Emptying the Supply Clock	24
4.3	Fatigue	24
4.3.1	Clearing Fatigue	24
4.4	Gear Condition	24
4.4.1	Compromised Items	24
4.4.2	Breaking Point	24
4.4.3	Repair Options	25
4.4.4	Equipment Enchantments Quick Reference	25
4.5	Asset and Follower Management	25
4.5.1	Followers (On-Screen Resources)	25
4.5.2	Upkeep (Expanded)	26
4.5.3	Follower Assist Rules	28
4.5.4	Loyalty & Bonds (Optional Rules)	29
4.5.5	Off-Screen Assets	29
4.6	Bond-Driven Resource Generation	30
4.6.1	Requirements	30
4.6.2	Examples	30
4.6.3	Limitations	31
4.7	Over-Stack Rule	31
4.7.1	Structural Advantages	31
4.7.2	Over-Stack Trigger	31
4.8	Currency-Free Economy (Compressed Reference)	32
4.8.1	What Costs What	32
4.8.2	String Values	32
4.8.3	Debt Clock Equivalences	32
4.8.4	Trust Investments (from Party Pool)	32
4.8.5	Hand-Waved (Free)	32
4.8.6	GM Adjudication Quick Mat	33
4.8.7	SB Menu – Currency Complications	33
4.8.8	Currency-Free Economy – Core Principles	33
5	Character Advancement	35
5.1	Introduction	35
5.2	Starting Character Builds	35
5.2.1	Standard Starting XP	35
5.2.2	Enhanced Starting Options	35
5.2.3	Initial Complications Reminder	35
5.2.4	Small Folk of the Threshold	36
5.3	Player Archetypes	36
5.3.1	The Solo	36
5.3.2	The Mixed Player	36
5.3.3	The Mastermind	37
5.4	XP Costs and Advancement	37

5.4.1	Core Character Improvements	37
5.4.2	Off-Screen Assets	37
5.4.3	Talent Costs	37
5.5	Tiers of Reputation	38
5.6	Prestige Abilities and Talents (Examples)	38
5.6.1	General Talents	38
5.6.2	Cultural and Ancestral Talents	39
5.7	Starting Build Examples	40
5.7.1	Solo Build (30–32 XP)	40
5.7.2	Mixed Build (32 XP)	40
5.7.3	Mastermind Build (34 XP)	41
5.8	Advancement Guidance	41
5.9	Optional Rule: Multi-Character Followers	41
5.9.1	Overview	41
5.9.2	Core Mechanics	41
5.9.3	Switching Active Characters	41
5.9.4	Balance Notes	42
6	Magic System	43
6.1	Design Philosophy	43
6.2	The Four Paths of Magic	43
6.2.1	Casting (Freeform Magic)	43
6.2.2	Rites Users (Runekeepers)	43
6.2.3	Rites Difficulty Value (Expanded)	44
6.2.4	Obligation Capacity	44
6.2.5	Invokers (Symbol Path)	44
6.3	Summoning (Pact-Whisperer Core)	45
6.3.1	Elemental Backlash Tables	46
6.4	Rituals (Extended)	46
6.4.1	Ritual Procedure	46
6.4.2	Component Economy	47
6.4.3	Teamwork and Aid	47
6.4.4	Clocks and Outcomes	47
6.4.5	Backlash Integration	47
6.4.6	Chassis-Specific Notes	47
6.4.7	Worked Examples	48
6.5	Cantor's Path (Songs)	48
6.5.1	Cantor Talents	49
6.6	Free Casting (TAGS System)	50
6.6.1	Spell Structure	50
6.6.2	Base Difficulty Value (DV)	50
6.6.3	Casting Roll	50
6.6.4	Backlash for Free Casters	50
6.6.5	TAG Library (Abridged)	50
6.7	Path Comparison	51
6.8	Of Patrons, Runes, and Invokers	52
6.8.1	The Patrons	52
6.8.2	Aveh, the Rider Behind the Storm (Freedom & Erasure)	53

6.8.3	The Carrion-King (Decay, Renewal & Transformation)	57
6.8.4	The Clockwork Monad, the Iterative Forge (Refinement & Progressive Creation)	61
6.8.5	Temporary Anima of the Clockwork Monad	66
6.8.6	The Confessor Beneath the Bell (Burden & Exchange)	69
6.8.7	The Gallow's Bell (Justice & Judgment)	74
6.8.8	Grimmir, the Old Man of the Forest (Primal Mystery & Seasonal Sacrifice)	77
6.8.9	Ikasha, She Who Sleeps (Latent Potential & Shadow)	82
6.8.10	Inaea, Angel of the Spider (Webs, Fate & Patient Predation)	86
6.8.11	The Inquisitor Prime (Purity & Domination)	91
6.8.12	Isoka, Angel of Serpents (Transformation & Renewal)	95
6.8.13	Khemesh, the Abyssal Maw (Depths, Inexorability, Eldritch Terror) .	100
6.8.14	Livaea, the Crimson Courtier (Seduction & Social Binding)	104
6.8.15	Lunara, The Silver Quiet (Moon, Mystery & Hidden Ways)	108
6.8.16	Mab, Queen of Courts (Glamour & Bargain)	111
6.8.17	Maelstraeus, The Infernal Bargainer (Commerce & Exchange) . . .	115
6.8.18	Malachai, the Cruel Messenger (Curses & Corruption)	119
6.8.19	Mor'iraath, the Destroyer (Absolute Annihilation)	124
6.8.20	Morag the Hag, Weaver of Hidden Costs (Faerie Bargains & Hidden Costs)	129
6.8.21	Mykkiel, Arbiter of the Covenant (Law & Zeal)	133
6.8.22	Nidhoggr, the World-Worm (Dreaming Antiquity)	139
6.8.23	The Ninth, Beyond Comprehension (Infinite Information & Unknowable Truths)	144
6.8.24	Oath of Flame & Light (Dawn & Vows)	149
6.8.25	Oath of Mercy and Grace (Healing & Forgiveness)	153
6.8.26	The Pale Shepherd, Guide of Transitions (Passage & Melancholic Wisdom)	160
6.8.27	Palinode, Queen of Encores (Performance & Rapture)	166
6.8.28	Raéyn, Mistress of the Sea (Tides & Change)	170
6.8.29	The Sacred Geometry, Architect of Perfect Forms (Harmony & Immutable Law)	177
6.8.30	The Savage Heart (Red Maw)	182
6.8.31	The Sealed Gate (Thresholds & Containment)	187
6.8.32	The Silent Choir, Keeper of Unspoken Truths (Restraint & Protective Omission)	191
6.8.33	Thrysos, King of Revels (Ecstasy & Excess)	196
6.8.34	The Traveler (Ways & Journeys)	202
6.8.35	Varnek Karn, the Death's Negotiator (Bargains with the Departed) .	206
6.8.36	Vorthak, the Hunger Unbound (Consumption & Metamorphic Hunger) .	211

0.1 Reviewer's Guide: Understanding Fate's Edge

This will be removed in Production

0.1.1 Reframing the Evaluation

Fate's Edge is not a traditional tabletop RPG to be evaluated by comprehensive rule mastery. Instead, it is a **narrative partnership** designed to evolve with your table's storytelling sophistication. Approach this review through the lens of **progressive storytelling enhancement** rather than static mechanical complexity.

0.1.2 Key Evaluation Framework

Start Simple, Discover Naturally

- **Session 1:** Core mechanic + 1-2 regional generators = complete playable experience
- **Session 5:** Comfortable integration of multiple subsystems
- **Session 20:** Intuitive mastery where mechanics become invisible

The Partnership Model

Rather than "learning a game," players develop a "storytelling partnership" where:

- Rules serve narrative consequences, not simulation accuracy
- Complexity emerges from interaction, not individual component sophistication
- Prep burden shifts from authoring content to facilitating discovery

0.1.3 Common Misunderstandings to Address

Content Volume vs. Discovery Process

Misconception: "Too much content to master" **Reality:** Content is designed for gradual discovery through play

Reviewer Guidance:

"Imagine a library where you only need to know about the books relevant to today's story. The rest exist to be discovered when narrative ambition demands them."

Prep-Light vs. Prep-Free

Misconception: "No prep means unstructured play" **Reality:** Prep is embedded in the constraint lattice

Reviewer Guidance:

"The system replaces authored prep with guided storytelling. Every card draw is improvisation with guardrails."

Mechanical Simplicity vs. Narrative Sophistication

Misconception: "Simple mechanics = shallow stories" **Reality:** Sophistication emerges from constraint interaction

Reviewer Guidance:

"Like jazz with a vast repertoire, the same simple rules that handle Session 1 magic effortlessly scale to manage Session 50 world-changing consequences."

0.1.4 Evaluation Methodology

Progressive Complexity Assessment

1. **Tier I Play** (30-40 XP): Evaluate session-to-session narrative flow with minimal subsystems
2. **Tier III Play** (90-150 XP): Assess how character growth naturally expands storytelling scope
3. **Tier V Play** (220+ XP): Examine how simple rules handle complex, multi-threaded narratives

Mastery Curve Analysis

Key Metric: Mastery effort should decrease as narrative complexity increases

Success Indicators:

- Session 1: Clear, engaging storytelling with minimal reference
- Session 10: Comfortable integration of multiple subsystems
- Session 30: Mechanics become invisible; focus entirely on narrative

0.1.5 What to Look For

Narrative-First Design

- Every mechanical element should serve story consequences
- Player agency should manifest through narrative choices, not optimization
- GM authority should prioritize "what happens" over "what are the rules"

Constraint-Based Creativity

- Random elements should create coherent, not chaotic, storytelling
- Regional generators should maintain thematic consistency while enabling variety
- Mechanical constraints should inspire creativity, not limit options

Scalable Sophistication

- Same core mechanics should handle intimate scenes and epic narratives
- Character progression should expand narrative possibilities, not mechanical options
- World complexity should emerge from player actions, not pre-authored content

0.1.6 Red Flags vs. Design Features

Actual Red Flags

- Mechanics that require constant reference during play
- Subsystems that don't integrate naturally with core philosophy
- Progression that adds mechanical burden rather than narrative freedom

Misinterpreted Design Features

- **High content volume** = Creative resource library, not mastery burden
- **Multiple magic paths** = Narrative vocabulary expansion, not mechanical complexity
- **Regional generators** = Inspiration engines, not reference requirements

0.1.7 Recommended Review Approach

Session 1-3 Evaluation

Focus on:

- How quickly engaging stories emerge
- Clarity of core mechanical principles
- Integration of generated content into coherent narratives

Session 10+ Evaluation

Assess:

- How naturally complexity emerges from player choices
- Integration of multiple subsystems without mechanical overhead
- Evolution from "using rules" to "telling stories"

Long-term Assessment

Consider:

- Whether the system grows with narrative ambition
- If mastery effort genuinely decreases over time
- How world complexity emerges organically from play

0.1.8 The Core Truth

Fate's Edge succeeds not by being simple, but by being **designed for simplicity to emerge naturally from complex storytelling**. Evaluate it not as a comprehensive system to master, but as a storytelling partnership that grows in sophistication at exactly the same rate your table develops narrative ambition.

This isn't a game you learn - it's a storytelling evolution you grow into.

Chapter 1

Core Principles

1.1 Safety Tools

Fate's Edge explores mature themes—conflict, loss, horror, betrayal. The table should always feel safe. Use these tools to keep the game enjoyable for everyone.

Safety Tools: Lines

X-Card Any player (including the GM) can draw an "X" on a card or simply say "X" when a moment makes them uncomfortable. When the X-Card is shown, the described content is removed from the fiction—no questions, no explanations, no judgments. The scene is retconned or redirected immediately.

Lines A hard boundary: content that will not appear in the game at all. Examples: "No sexual violence," "No harm to children," "No body horror." Establish during Session Zero.

Veils A soft boundary: content that can happen "off screen" or fade to black. Example: "A romantic scene can happen, but fade to black before it becomes explicit."

Always keep an X-Card visible. When used, pause, rewind if needed, and move on. Do not interrogate the player. The GM may also use the X-Card for their own comfort.

1.2 The Central Question

At its heart, Fate's Edge asks:

What are you willing to risk, and what are you willing to pay, to reshape the world around you?

This question is both philosophical and mechanical. Players gamble with fate every time they act, and the consequences—good or ill—become the foundation of their legend.

1.3 Core Principles

The game is built on four key ideas:

Narrative First Mechanics serve the story. Rules reward descriptive play and creative problem-solving.

Risk Creates Drama Every roll carries tension. Even success may come at a cost.

Meaningful Growth Experience is a currency of choice. Invest in yourself or in your influence on the world.

Consequences Matter No action is free. Every choice changes the fiction.

1.4 Key Concepts

1.4.1 Narrative Time

Time in Fate’s Edge is measured by story weight, not by clocks. Use these four scales:

Table 1.1: Narrative Time Scales

Scale	Description
A Moment	A heartbeat, a glance, a single strike or word.
Some Time	A few minutes: a skirmish, a careful lockpick, a short negotiation.
Significant Time	Hours: travel, a ritual, a siege.
Days	Large-scale endeavors: marches, training, recovery.

1.4.2 Story Beats (SB)

Whenever a player rolls dice, each result of **1** generates one Story Beat (SB) for the GM. Re-rolling a 1 does *not* erase its SB; if the re-rolled die also shows 1, it generates additional SB.

SB are not penalties—they are narrative fuel. The GM spends SB to introduce twists:

- **Escalation** – drawing more enemies, raising the stakes.
- **Exhaustion** – draining time, resources, or positioning.
- **Exposure** – revealing hidden actions, alerting foes.
- **Collateral** – harm or danger spilling over onto allies, innocents, or surroundings.

For a full SB Spend Menu, see [2.1.8](#).

1.4.3 Affinity

Each people (culture or heritage) provides an **Affinity**: a narrative edge or metaphysical bond. Affinities make certain actions more reliable or grant unique permissions, weaving identity into mechanics. Examples include the Aeler stone-sense or the Aelaerem hearth-luck.

1.4.4 Prestige Abilities

High-level talents unlocked by mastering cultural arts, Patron bonds, or philosophical paths. These are narrative milestones as much as mechanical upgrades.

1.4.5 On-Screen vs. Off-Screen

Fate's Edge distinguishes between resources you see at the table and those that shape the world behind the scenes:

On-Screen Resources are companions, hirelings, or allies who stand beside you in danger. They add dice pools and flavor, but they can falter, be captured, or die.

Off-Screen Resources are assets, titles, networks, or safe houses. They never swing a blade in combat, but they shape the story between sessions, turning XP into narrative leverage.

1.5 Design Philosophy

1.5.1 Core Principles (Extended)

1. **Narrative Primacy:** Mechanics serve story, not replace it.
2. **Risk as Drama:** Every roll carries potential for triumph and complication.
3. **Meaningful Growth:** XP investment creates lasting character and world change.
4. **Consequence Weight:** Choices ripple outward; nothing is free.
5. **Fail Forward:** Misses fuel Boons; 1s become Story Beats that drive the fiction onward.

1.5.2 Mechanical Constraints

Table 1.2: Core Mechanical Limits

Rule	Limit
Assist Maximum	+3 dice total per roll from all helpers.
Boon Maximum	Hold 5 Boons; trim to 2 at scene end.
Boon-to-XP Conversion	2 Boons → 1 XP, once per session, max 2 XP per session via conversion.
Follower Initiative	1 Follower Action per scene, party-wide.
Over-Stack	2+ structural advantages = start a relevant clock +1 OR GM banks +1 SB.
Position States	Dominant Controlled Desperate (affects success/failure texture).
Dice Pool Cap	Maximum 10d10 per roll; extras become auto-successes.

1.5.3 The Golden Rule

When in doubt, make the choice that serves the story. If you find yourself asking "What's the optimal move?" try reframing it as "What would be most interesting for the story?"

The dice do not determine success or failure—they help decide which path you take to get there.

1.5.4 Flavor is Free

Players may add descriptive details, cultural elements, and atmospheric touches without spending resources or requiring rolls. Flavor enriches the narrative without changing mechanical outcomes. The GM should encourage this and reciprocate.

Chapter 2

Core Mechanics

2.1 The Core Resolution Cycle

When a player rolls dice, they engage the world through risk, consequence, and discovery.

2.1.1 Step-by-Step Resolution

1. **Declare Action & Approach:** Intent + Attribute + Skill.
2. **Set Difficulty Value (DV):** GM sets DV (2–7+) based on stakes.
3. **Roll Dice Pool:** Attribute + Skill d10s (max 10 dice; extras = auto-successes).
4. **Count Results:**
 - 6–9 = 1 success
 - 10 = 2 successes
 - 1 = 1 Story Beat (SB) for GM
5. **Compare to DV** → Outcome Matrix (see [Table 2.1](#)).
6. **Spend SB:** GM introduces complications (see [section 2.1.8](#)).

2.1.2 Difficulty Value (DV)

Default DV Ladder

DV	Typical Case
2	Routine: clear intent, modest stakes, controlled environment
3	Pressured: time limits, mild resistance, partial information
4	Hard: hostile conditions, active opposition, precision required
5+	Extreme: stacked constraints, dangerous failure, high drama

Default DV = 3.

2.1.3 Position & Effect

Position (risk) Dominant (safe), Controlled (balanced), Desperate (high stakes).

Effect (reward) Limited, Standard, Great.

GM sets both based on fiction.

2.1.4 Outcome Matrix

Table 2.1: Outcome Matrix

Roll Result	What Happens
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB = 0	Clean Success – achieve intent without complication.
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB > 0	Success & Cost – achieve intent; GM spends SB for complication.
$0 < \text{Successes} < \text{DV}$	Partial – progress with complication; player gains 1 Boon.
Successes = 0	Miss – no progress; GM escalates with SB; player gains 2 Boons.

2.1.5 Critical Success (10s)

If roll succeeds, each 10 adds narrative weight. Effects apply only on success.

- **1 ten:** Strong success – improved Position or minor advantage.
- **2 tens:** Exceptional – choose two benefits (e.g., increased Effect + free Boon).
- **3 tens:** Legendary – decisive victory; clear 1 clock segment.
- **4+ tens:** Mythic – reshape scene; clear 1–2 clock segments.

Tens are never rerolled by Position effects.

2.1.6 Dice Pool Limit & Auto-Successes

Max dice = 10d10. Extra dice become auto-successes (no SB generated).

2.1.7 Boons

Earning Boons

- Partial ($0 < \text{successes} < \text{DV}$): 1 Boon
- Miss (successes = 0): 2 Boons (meaningful roll only)
- Bond-driven action (once per bond/session): 1 Boon
- GM award

Limit: Max 2 Boons from failures per character per scene.

Spending Boons (1 Boon)

- Reroll one die (after result)
- Activate an on-screen Asset
- Improve Position by one step before roll
- Power certain Rites/abilities
- Convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (once/session downtime, max 2 XP)

Carryover: Max 5 Boons; at scene end, reduce to 2.

2.1.8 Story Beats (SB)

Each die showing 1 = 1 SB for GM. Rerolling a 1 does not erase its SB; another 1 adds extra.

	Cost	Effect
SB Spend Menu	1 SB	Minor: noise, trace, tick clock +1, worsen Position
	2 SB	Moderate: alarm raised, lose cover/Position, lesser foe appears
	3 SB	Serious: reinforcements, key gear breaks, major twist, advance front clock
	4+ SB	Major: trap springs, authority arrives, scene shift, Patron intervenes

2.2 Player-Managed Modules

Players track their own: Obligation, Corruption, Leash, Asset States.

What Players Track		
Module	Owner	Tick Triggers (examples)
Obligation (per Patron)	Player	Invoke Rite, Push, Crack the Seal
Corruption Clock	Player	Cantor Push, Resonant Rite, GM SB on occult actions
Leash (Summoning)	Player	Spirit takes Harm, acts against nature, crosses [WARD]
Asset State (Symbol)	Player	Neglect, Crack the Seal → Compromised

Obligation Capacity = Spirit + Presence.

- Over capacity: +1 Fatigue per segment.
- Double capacity: Clear Fatigue, +1 Harm, Patron Intrusion.

Corruption Full Apply last Patron's boon burden, reset to 0.

Leash Full Spirit acts once to its nature then departs/turns hostile.

Symbol State Compromised – repair downtime (DV 3) or 1 XP.

2.3 Turn Economy

Each turn: **1 Action + 1 Move**.

2.3.1 Movement

- **Move:** Shift one band (Close ↔ Near ↔ Far) or stand from prone.
- **Dash (Action):** Move two bands; next defense Desperate.
- **Disengage (Action):** Then Move does not provoke opportunity attacks; cannot Attack this turn.

2.3.2 Action Options

- **Attack** (melee/ranged)
- **Disengage** (as above)
- **Charge (full turn):** Move two bands toward enemy + melee attack. Costs 1 Fatigue. Next defense Desperate. Requires open ground.
- **Skirmish (full turn):** Move two bands away + ranged attack. Costs 1 Fatigue. Next defense Desperate. Requires open ground.
- **Observe / Change Position:** +1 Position once per turn.
- **Setup:** Grant ally +1 Position or step up Effect.
- **Assist:** Spend 1 Boon for +1 die (max +3 from all assists).
- **Defend, Channel/Weave, Cast Rite/Song, Interact, etc.**

Talents (Effortless Charge, Relentless, etc.) modify these.

2.3.3 Initiative

No fixed order. GM spotlights based on fiction; ambushers act first.

2.3.4 Opportunity Attacks

Leaving an enemy's Close without Disengage provokes one free melee attack (Controlled Position, no action cost).

2.4 Fatigue & Harm

2.4.1 Fatigue Track

Size = Body. Mark from exertion, magic, stress.

Effects

- Each Fatigue worsens Position: Dominant → Controlled → Desperate.
- If already Desperate, each Fatigue → -1 die.
- **Overflow:** When track fills, increase Harm by 1 level, clear all Fatigue.

Recovery: Short rest removes 2 Fatigue; full night removes all. Requires adequate Supply.

2.4.2 Harm Levels

Harm	Effect	
Harm 1	-1 die on related actions	Recovery: medical or magical care.
Harm 2	-1 die on most actions until treated	
Harm 3	Incapacitated or dying	

2.4.3 Taking Harm & Fatigue – The Procedure

When hit:

1. **Convert** Harm to Fatigue using armor (see [subsection 2.4.4](#)). Minimum 1 Fatigue per hit.
2. **Apply remaining Harm:** If any, increase Harm level and clear all existing Fatigue.
3. **Add Fatigue** from step 1. If track fills, resolve overflow (Harm +1, clear Fatigue).

2.4.4 Armor Conversion Table

Armor Type	Conversion (Harm → Fatigue)	Minimum Fatigue	
Light	1 → 1	1	<i>Example: Light</i>
Medium	2 → 1	1	
Heavy	3 → 2	1	

armor hit with Harm 2 → convert 1→1 Fatigue, remaining Harm 1 → increase Harm 1, clear Fatigue, then add 1 Fatigue. Result: Harm 1, Fatigue 1.

2.4.5 Fear Effects

When Fear Track escalates (Shaken → Frightened → Panicked), roll d10 or choose:

d10	Effect
1	Freeze (cannot act)
2	Flee
3	Drop held item
4	Beg/bargain
5	Hide
6	Panic attack (nearest target)
7	Blunder into danger
8	Obeys simple command
9	Break down (useless until aided)
10	Catatonia

2.5 Skills

Action roll = Attribute (Body, Wits, Spirit, Presence) + Skill. GM sets Position and DV.

2.5.1 Core Skills (Abridged)

Skill	What It Covers
Arcana	Magic theory, wards, rituals
Athletics	Running, climbing, swimming, balance
Brawl	Unarmed combat, grappling
Command	Leadership, morale
Craft	Making, mending
Deception	Lying, bluffing
Insight	Reading emotions, detecting lies
Investigation	Research, deduction
Lore	History, cultures, general knowledge
Medicine	Healing, first aid
Melee	Close combat with weapons
Notice	Perception, spotting ambushes
Performance	Acting, music, oration
Ranged	Bows, thrown weapons
Stealth	Moving unseen
Subterfuge	Casing, forgery, sleight of hand
Survival	Wilderness navigation, foraging
Sway	Persuasion, charm
Tinker	Lockpicking, traps, devices

2.5.2 Attribute + Skill Combos

Same action can use different pairs. Example: Persuading a guard: Presence+Sway (charm), Wits+Sway (logic), Spirit+Sway (conviction).

2.6 Experience Points (XP)

2.6.1 Awarding XP (per session)

- Attendance: +2
- Major objective: +2–4
- Discoveries: +1–2
- Hard choices: +1–2
- Complication spotlight: +1–3
- Bond/flag driven: +1–2
- GM curveball: +0–3

End of major arc: +8–12 XP to all.

2.6.2 Spending XP

- **Attribute:** new rating $\times 3$ XP, downtime = new rating days.
- **Skill:** new level $\times 2$ XP, downtime = new level days.
- **Talents:** 2–12+ XP per tier.
- **Follower:** Cap² XP, downtime 1–3 days.
- **Asset:** Minor (4 XP, 1d), Standard (8 XP, 1w), Major (12 XP, 1 month).

Rush Rule: Skip downtime $\rightarrow$ start Haste [4] clock. On fill, ability gains flaw/hitch.

2.6.3 Reputation Tiers

Novice (0–40 XP) Local, prestige locked.

Seasoned (41–90 XP) Regional, some prestige unlock.

Veteran (91–150 XP) National, second follower slot.

Paragon (151–220 XP) Continental, rivals emerge.

Mythic (221+ XP) Legendary, kingdoms react.

2.7 Game Structure

2.7.1 Narrative Time

A Moment (heartbeat), **Some Time** (minutes), **Significant Time** (hours), **Days**.

2.7.2 Game Units

Scene (conflict/question), **Session** (3–6 hrs, 2–4 scenes), **Campaign** (6–20+ sessions).

2.8 Assets & Followers (Quick Reference)

2.8.1 Assets (Off-Screen)

Costs: Minor (4 XP, 1d), Standard (8 XP, 1w), Major (12 XP, 1m).

- **Free off-screen use:** once/session.
- **Boon activation:** 1 Boon for on-screen scene.
- **Conditions:** Maintained → Neglected → Compromised.

2.8.2 Followers (On-Screen)

Cost: Cap² XP, downtime 1–3d.

- **Assistance:** +min(Cap, relevant skill) dice, capped at +3 total.
- **Independent action:** once/scene (party-wide). Cost: 1 Exposure or 1 Harm.
- **Conditions:** Exposure, Harm tracks.

2.8.3 Upkeep (per downtime)

- **Efficient:** XP = max(1, acquisition/3).
- **Intensive:** 1 XP + dedicated downtime action.

Failure to pay: follower → Wary → Seized; asset → Neglected → Compromised.

Chapter 3

Deck-Based Generators

3.1 Introduction to Deck Generators

Deck generators in **Fate's Edge** transform random card draws into coherent narrative elements. Each deck has a distinct purpose and suit meanings so that randomness serves the story rather than derailing it. These generators provide structured inspiration for GMs while maintaining the game's narrative-first philosophy.

3.2 Standard Deck Structure

Fate's Edge uses several card-based tools, each with specialised suit meanings:

Travel Decks (regional, 52-card) Used for journey content and location-based adventures.

- **Spade** = Place / Location
- **Heart** = Actor / Faction
- **Club** = Pressure / Complication
- **Diamond** = Reward / Opportunity

Deck of Consequences (scene drama) Used for immediate complications and narrative twists during gameplay.

- **Hearts** = Social / Emotional Fallout
- **Spades** = Harm / Escalation
- **Clubs** = Material Cost / Resource Drain
- **Diamonds** = Magical / Spiritual Disturbance

Important

Never mix suit meanings across decks. When rules reference *Spade / Club / Diamond*, they mean the **Travel Deck**. When they say *Hearts / Spades / Clubs / Diamonds*, they mean the **Deck of Consequences**.

3.3 Rank Severity and Clock Size

Card rank sets the size / significance of the primary Clock:

- **2–5 (Minor)**: 4-segment Clock
- **6–10 (Standard)**: 6-segment Clock
- **J, Q, K (Major)**: 8-segment Clock
- **Ace (Pivotal)**: 10-segment Clock

Colour Influence:

- **Black suits** (♠, ♣): Travel hazards, tangible threats, fatigue.
- **Red suits** (♥, ♦): Social intrigue, reputational pressure, emotional complications.

3.4 Draw Procedures

3.4.1 Quick Hook (2 cards)

Ideal for spontaneous scene generation or when players zag unexpectedly:

1. Draw one **Spade** (place) and one **Heart** (actor / faction).
2. Use the higher rank to set Clock size.
3. Combine elements into a simple, compelling scenario.

3.4.2 Full Seed (4 cards)

For full adventures or significant arcs:

1. Draw until one card of each suit appears:
 - **Spade** = Primary location
 - **Heart** = Main actor / faction
 - **Club** = Central complication
 - **Diamond** = Key reward / opportunity
2. The highest rank sets the main Clock size.
3. If multiple face cards or Aces appear, create parallel Clocks for secondary threats or opportunities.

3.4.3 Act Builder

Structure sessions or multi-part adventures:

1. Draw three cards: setting (**Spade**), actor (**Heart**), complication (**Club**).
2. Treat **Diamond** cards drawn during play as foreshadowed opportunities or act payoffs.
3. Highest rank determines the session's primary challenge scope.

3.5 Using the Deck in Play

1. Players roll; each die showing **1** generates **1 Story Beat (SB)**.
2. The GM chooses one method for that roll:
 - (a) **Direct Spend:** Translate SB into immediate consequences or clock ticks.
 - (b) **Deck Draw:** Draw up to **min(SB, 3)** cards and synthesise a single twist guided by suit and highest rank.
3. Interpret the cards to create a coherent complication that advances the narrative.

3.6 Combo Rules

Special combinations add texture:

Pair (same rank) Recurring motif with a twist.

Run (3+ sequential ranks) Momentum – reduce the main Clock by 1 segment.

Flush (3+ same suit) Strongly theme the act toward that suit’s axis.

Face + Ace Reveal a hidden patron or power behind the element.

All one colour GM gains **+1 SB** to use in that scene.

3.7 Regional Generator Summary

Table 3.1: Regional Generator Summary

Region	Theme	Special Mechanics
Acasia	Broken Marches	Curse motifs; every Ace adds a lingering omen.
Aelaerem	Hearth & Hollow	Red-thread motifs; Ace echoes quiet bells / watch-geese.
Aeler	Crowns & Under-Vaults	Stone / breath motifs; Ace: keys click, bells answer.
Aelinnel	Stone, Bough, Bright Things	Moonlight motifs; Ace adds a shortcut where none should be.
Black Banners	Condotta & Crowns	War & winter motifs; Ace: weapons remember, ice holds the dead.
Ecktoria	Marble & Fire	Imperial forms; Ace carves precedent in marble.
Kahfagia	Pilot’s Mirror	Lantern-law jurisdiction shifts; Ace redefines lanes.

Table 3.1 – continued

Region	Theme	Special Mechanics
Linn	Skerries & Storm-Oaths	Sea omens; Ace: horns on wind, white horses on swell.
Mistlands	Bells, Salt, Breath	Breath / boundary motifs; Ace: bells answer across water.
Silkstrand	City of Bridges & Dyewater	Dye / bridge motifs; Ace adds a lingering omen.
Theona	Three Greens, No Ninth	"No Ninth" custom; Ace adds a telling omission.
Thepyrgos	City of a Thousand Stairs	Height / sound motifs; Ace echoes bells / wind / stair-steps.
Ubral	Stone Between Spears	Upland motifs; Ace echoes horns / heather / stone.
Valewood	Empire Under Leaves	Empire echoes (J/Q/K add relic-logic); Ace rearranges approach.
Vhasia	Fractured Sun	Broken-sun motifs; Ace blots medal / scratches milestone.
Vilikari	Laurels & Longhouses	Two-laws motifs; Ace shows wolf / eagle side-by-side.
Viterra	Last Kingdom	Legacy, parishes, and final-stand themes.
Wilds	Roads, Ruins, Weather	Reskin palette for any biome.
Zakov	Salt & Serpent	Salt & serpent omens; Ace: tides remember, reefs shift, deep listens.

3.8 NPC Generation Deck

Every NPC should feel like a person with desires, convictions, and contradictions. This deck lets you assemble a complete profile quickly by drawing one element from each category.

3.8.1 Generation Categories

Ambition What they seek to achieve or obtain.

Belief The principle or philosophy guiding their worldview.

Attitude How they present themselves and interact day-to-day.

Twist A contradiction or hidden facet that creates tension.

3.8.2 Using the NPC Generator

Select or draw one from each column and consider the frictions between public ambition, private belief, surface attitude, and the twist.

Table 3.2: NPC Generation Categories

Ambition	Belief	Attitude	Twist
Power	Might makes right	Arrogant	Secretly insecure
Wealth	Ends justify means	Charismatic	Betraying their allies
Revenge	Honour above all	Cold	Working for their enemy
Love	Truth is sacred	Friendly	Hiding a dark past
Knowledge	Loyalty is paramount	Paranoid	Actually an impostor
Survival	Family above all	Cruel	Deeply compassionate
Fame	Justice must prevail	Pious	Corrupted by power
Freedom	Fate can be changed	Optimistic	Hopelessly cynical
Protection	Tradition must be upheld	Pessimistic	Revolutionary at heart
Control	Change is necessary	Calculating	Acts on impulse
Recognition	The system works	Naive	Cynical manipulator

3.9 Practical Deck Usage Examples

3.9.1 Example 1: Quick Scene Generation

The party detours through the Mistlands. The GM draws:

- **Spade (8)**: Ancient standing stones covered in moss.
- **Heart (Queen)**: A territorial spirit guardian.

A 6-segment Clock *Spirit's Wrath* begins: the guardian demands tribute for safe passage.

3.9.2 Example 2: Consequences During Play

Kael misses a stealth roll and generates **2 SB**. The GM draws:

- **Hearts (7)**: Social complication.
- **Clubs (3)**: Resource cost.

Synthesis: *A ceremonial urn shatters; cultists recognise your patron's mark. Future dealings will demand extra tribute and materials.*

3.9.3 Example 3: NPC Creation

Merchant in Valewood:

- **Ambition:** Wealth
- **Belief:** Family above all
- **Attitude:** Charismatic
- **Twist:** Secretly compassionate

Result: *A charming hard-bargainer who supports a large family and quietly donates to orphanages – even aiding struggling competitors.*

3.10 GM Guidance for Deck Usage

3.10.1 When to Use Which Deck

- **Travel Decks:** journey planning, location adventures, regional exploration.
- **Deck of Consequences:** immediate twists during active scenes.
- **NPC Generator:** fast creation with built-in tension and hooks.

3.10.2 Interpreting Card Draws

- Prioritise narrative coherence over literalism.
- Use suits as inspiration, not constraints.
- Combine cards into layered complications rather than parallel noise.
- Remember: players can mitigate, pivot, or overcome deck outcomes.

3.10.3 Balancing Randomness and Narrative

- Draw when you want surprise or need a nudge.
- Ignore or modify draws that don't serve the current story.
- Treat combinations as creative prompts, not mandates.
- The goal is to *enhance* the narrative, not derail it.

Chapter 4

Resource Management

4.1 Introduction

Resource Management in **Fate's Edge** focuses on tracking the tangible and intangible assets that enable character actions while creating narrative tension. Rather than micromanaging every item, the system uses abstract clocks and conditions that trigger when dramatically appropriate. This keeps the focus on story consequences rather than bookkeeping.

4.2 Supply Clock

The Supply Clock is a shared condition for the entire party, representing food, water, ammunition, and basic gear. It tracks the group's overall readiness for extended endeavors.

4.2.1 Supply States

Table 4.1: Supply Clock States

State	Effect
Full Supply (0 segments)	The party is well-equipped and prepared. No penalties.
Low Supply (2 segments)	Minor narrative complications: bland food, damaged arrows, thinning waterskins, worn gear.
Dangerously Low (3 segments)	Each character gains Fatigue 1 due to exhaustion and deprivation.
Out of Supply (4 segments)	Severe penalties apply; characters face starvation, dehydration, and failing gear with significant mechanical consequences.

4.2.2 Filling the Supply Clock

The Supply Clock advances under the following circumstances:

- Harsh travel conditions or lost pack animals (GM fiat).
- GM spends 2+ **Story Beats (SB)** to represent resource depletion.
- The party chooses to travel light for speed or stealth advantages.
- Failed foraging or resource-gathering attempts.

4.2.3 Emptying the Supply Clock

The Supply Clock can be reduced through:

- Reaching civilisation or safe haven resets to **Full Supply**.
- Successful foraging / hunting: group *Survival* check (DV 2) clears 1 segment.
- Downtime spent in relative safety removes 1 segment.
- Purchasing or trading for supplies in settlements.

4.3 Fatigue

Fatigue represents physical exhaustion, hunger, emotional strain, and spiritual depletion. It accumulates through extended effort, deprivation, or magical backlash.

4.3.1 Clearing Fatigue

- A night's rest with adequate Supply removes 1 level of Fatigue.
- You cannot clear Fatigue if the party's Supply clock is *Dangerously Low* or *Out of Supply*.
- Magical healing or special abilities may provide additional Fatigue recovery.
- Extended downtime (3+ days) in safety clears all Fatigue.

4.4 Gear Condition

Gear in **Fate's Edge** does not have hit points or detailed durability tracking. Instead, equipment suffers consequences only when drama demands it.

4.4.1 Compromised Items

- Compromised status is introduced via SB spends or narrative consequence.
- A **Compromised** item gives -1 die on relevant rolls until repaired.
- Multiple Compromised items affecting the *same* action do not stack penalties.

4.4.2 Breaking Point

If a Compromised item suffers another significant setback, it breaks entirely and becomes unusable.

4.4.3 Repair Options

Field Repair Temporary fix; requires *Craft* or *Survival* check (DV 2) to remove the penalty for one scene.

Proper Repair Permanent restoration; requires proper tools, materials, and significant downtime.

Magical Repair Certain spells or rituals can instantly restore gear, but may carry Obligation or Backlash costs.

4.4.4 Equipment Enchantments Quick Reference

Table 4.2: Equipment Enchantment Guidelines

Type	Cost
Minor Enchantments	2–4 XP
Major Enchantments	6–8 XP
Prestige Enchantments	10+ XP

Limitations:

- Max enchantments = Spirit attribute.
- No stacking identical benefits.
- Maintenance affects functionality.

4.5 Asset and Follower Management

4.5.1 Followers (On-Screen Resources)

Cost Cap² XP to acquire.

Assist Dice When applicable, the follower adds help dice equal to min(Cap, helper's relevant Skill), capped at +3 dice total from all sources. *Exception:* *Exceptional Coordination* Talent allows one follower to provide +4 assist dice.

Capability Ranges from 1–5 (5 is exceptional).

Upkeep Each Downtime period, pay XP equal to Cap *or* spend a Scene tending the relationship.

Risk If the GM spends 2+ SB on an action you take with assistance, they may endanger, injure, or separate the follower instead of you if fictionally appropriate.

Off-Screen Capability Once per downtime, a Cap 5 follower can solve one significant problem but generates 1 SB for the party; the GM must describe how their action creates consequences.

4.5.2 Upkeep (Expanded)

Upkeep is the story of attention. Followers and assets thrive when seen and sour when ignored.

Design Intent

- **Choice with Teeth.** Players choose *time* or *XP*. Either way, the fiction moves: quick delegation vs. hands-on scenes.
- **Visible Drift.** Missing upkeep degrades things predictably: **WARY** → **SEIZED**, **NEGLECTED** → **COMPROMISED**.
- **Story First.** Every payment should say something about the relationship or the tool.

Asset Upkeep

Frequency. Once per Downtime period.

Option A — Efficient (Higher XP, Less Time) Pay Upkeep $XP = \max\left(1, \frac{XP \text{ Acquisition Cost}}{3}\right)$. Minimal effort in-fiction (a retainer handles it; you check in by letter).

Option B — Intensive (Lower XP, More Time) Pay 1 XP. Spend a *dedicated Downtime action* personally tending the follower / asset.

Failure. If unpaid this Downtime:

- *Follower:* becomes **Wary** (or **Seized** if already Wary).
- *Asset:* becomes **Neglected** (or **Compromised** if already Neglected).

What the Conditions Look Like

WARY (Follower) They hesitate, ask for guarantees, or interpret orders narrowly. *Mechanical nudge:* first social / test involving them is -1 position *or* costs 1 extra Stress.

SEIZED (Follower) Someone else sets terms (rival, guild, family) or they withdraw until appeased. *Nudge:* cannot assist this Downtime; to re-engage, pay 1 Boon *or* clear via a narrative scene that addresses their grievance.

NEGLECTED (Asset) It underperforms; parts go missing; paperwork piles. *Nudge:* -1 effect on its next use *or* an *Alarmed Attention* clock $+1/2$.

COMPROMISED (Asset) Faults propagate; someone has leverage; the tool is noisy or unsafe. *Nudge:* first use this session automatically creates 1 **SB** *or* requires a costly fix scene.

Examples by Type

Followers.

Table 4.3: Follower Upkeep Examples

Type	Efficient Upkeep (pay XP, quick)	Intensive Upkeep (1 XP + action)
Scribe	Send coin and a sealed brief with instructions.	Host a lesson; co-author a pamphlet that sharpens their craft.
Scout	Dispatch a courier with a new map and stipend.	Walk the route together; overhaul signals and caches.
Acolyte (Patron-bound)	Arrange a blessing via intermediaries.	Lead them in a minor rite; narrate the teaching moment.
Mercenary	Wire hazard pay with a short commendation.	Drill formation; settle a dispute; toast the unit.
Informant	Drop a dead-letter and payment.	Meet face-to-face; share protection protocol.

Assets.

Table 4.4: Asset Upkeep Examples

Type	Efficient Upkeep (pay XP, quick)	Intensive Upkeep (1 XP + action)
Workshop	Pay the foreman; authorise routine parts.	Personally recalibrate; craft a sample piece.
Safehouse	Hire a caretaker; basic supplies delivered.	Repair locks/windows; rewrite the cover story with neighbours.
Library	Fund copying; buy indices.	Catalogue a shelf; cross-ref a case; bind a damaged tome.
Boat	Pay moorage and minimal maintenance.	Scrape hull; patch sails; sail a proving run.
Sigil Network (Invoker)	Replace two worn plates.	Etch a new master glyph; clear 1 wear mid-scene next session.

Edge Cases & Rulings

- **Multiple Resources.** Each follower / asset checks upkeep separately. A single Intensive action can cover a *cohesive group* if fiction supports it (e.g., one drill for a squad).
- **Remote Care.** If you narrate convincing remote oversight (sending a trusted lieutenant), count as Efficient.

- **Patron-Tinted Upkeep.** Tie upkeep scenes to a Patron's theme for small boons (advantage on the next related roll) without changing costs.
- **Stacking Misses.** Missing upkeep across *two* consecutive Downtime periods moves WARY → SEIZED or NEGLECTED → COMPROMISED; a third consecutive miss risks loss (follower quits; asset condemned) at GM discretion.

Optional Modules

Ledger Credits Track fractional prep: three Efficient payments can be banked to waive one Intensive action later.

Union Rules Some factions demand Intensive upkeep; Efficient counts as half (two Efficient = one Intensive).

Patron Favor Swap Spend a **Boon** to treat missed upkeep as paid for one follower / asset if the scene honours the Patron.

GM Guidance

- **Making it a Scene.** Intensive upkeep should reveal something (new contact, flaw, rumour).
- **Foreshadowing Degradation.** Before applying SEIZED / COMPROMISED, show warning signs the players can act on.
- **Naming the Toll.** If a **Patron's Largess** (wrath) applies, state the narrative reason and the extra toll (e.g., an added SB, a temporary lockout, or a vow demanded).

Upkeep Quick Reference

Once per Downtime. Pay Efficient ($XP = \max(1, \frac{acq}{3})$) or Intensive (1 XP + action).

Missed: Follower → WARY → SEIZED; Asset → NEGLECTED → COMPROMISED. Tie scenes to your Patron for flavour, not discounts.

4.5.3 Follower Assist Rules

- Assist dice come from the helper's capabilities, not the leader's.
- Total Assist on any roll (from any sources) is hard-capped at +3. *Exception:* *Exceptional Coordination* may allow +4 from a single follower.
- Only one follower may assist a given action at a time.
- Followers cannot assist actions beyond their narrative scope or capabilities.

4.5.4 Loyalty & Bonds (Optional Rules)

- Track a simple Loyalty tag per follower: *Wary* / *Steady* / *Devoted*.
- *Devoted* followers can once per arc convert one GM Complication targeting them into a lesser setback.
- *Wary* followers cost +1 XP to maintain during Downtime.
- Loyalty can change based on how the PC treats the follower and shared experiences.

4.5.5 Off-Screen Assets

Table 4.5: Asset Types and Costs

Asset Type	Cost
Minor Asset	4 XP (safehouse, small charter, local business)
Standard Asset	8 XP (noble title, guild section, spy ring, significant property)
Major Asset	12 XP (city licence, regional network, major institution influence)
Artifact Asset	16+ XP (unique items or positions with campaign-level significance)

Asset Activations

- **Off-Screen Activation:** At campaign start or during Downtime, activate an off-screen asset by spending **1 Boon** or **2 XP**.
- **Off-Screen Effects:** Use each Asset's listed off-screen effect once per session for free.
- **On-Screen Activation:** To reshape the current scene, spend **1 Boon**.
- **Plausibility Test:** The Asset must have appropriate scope and reach for the intended effect.

Asset Condition Tracks

Maintained Full capability; no penalties. The asset is in good standing and fully functional.

Neglected −1 die when used (assist or leverage). Narratively: slower response, sullen staff, short-staffed operations.

Compromised Unavailable for use. Narratively: captured, burned, seized, defected, or otherwise incapacitated.

Maintenance and Repair

- After a story arc or 2–3 sessions of heavy use, the GM may flag the resource as *at risk*.
- To keep an asset *Maintained*, the player must either:
 - Spend Downtime repairing / servicing it, or
 - Pay XP immediately (representing replacement parts, masterwork upkeep).
- If neglected, the asset becomes *Neglected* (–1 die) and may eventually become permanently lost.
- Superior and Artifact assets do not require normal upkeep; if *Compromised* through complications, only narrative quests can repair them.

4.6 Bond-Driven Resource Generation

When a player takes a significant action to aid an ally with whom they share a bond, and explicitly references that bond in an *Intricate* description, they may mark that bond to gain **1 Boon** *after* the action resolves.

4.6.1 Requirements

- **Mutual Bond:** Player shares a defined bond with the ally they are aiding.
- **Intricate Description:** Player describes how the bond motivates their action using rich, multi-sensory details.
- **Significant Aid:** Meaningful assistance beyond basic dice bonuses.
- **Fiction First:** The bond genuinely drives the choice to help, not added retroactively.

4.6.2 Examples

Valid Examples:

- "Remembering how they saved me from the falling rubble in Aeler, I throw myself in front of the crossbow bolt meant for them!"
- "Thinking of our shared vow to protect the innocent, I use my last healing potion to stabilise them instead of saving it for myself."
- "Drawing on our years fighting side-by-side in the Border Wars, I rally the other mercenaries to keep fighting alongside them when morale fails."

4.6.3 Limitations

- Once per bond per session.
- Must involve meaningful sacrifice or risk.
- GM approval required for what constitutes "significant action".
- Cannot be used for basic assistance rolls or minor favours.
- The Boon is awarded *after* the action resolves, not before.

4.7 Over-Stack Rule

The Over-Stack rule prevents excessive accumulation of advantages from trivial sources while rewarding meaningful preparation.

4.7.1 Structural Advantages

Structural advantages include:

- Active buffs or beneficial tags affecting the party.
- Favourable venue or environmental factors.
- Unused *Follower Initiative* for the scene.
- On-screen Asset activation providing immediate benefits.
- Opponent disadvantaged by fiction (surprised, trapped, etc.).
- Ritual preparation that applies to the current situation.

4.7.2 Over-Stack Trigger

- If the party **enters** a scene with ≥ 3 structural advantages, a GM *may* apply Over-Stack once for that scene.
- The GM chooses either:
 - Start one named obstacle or challenge at **+1 DV**, or
 - The GM banks **+1 SB** for the first Deck Twist in the scene.
- This represents narrative pushback when characters have overwhelming advantages.
- Over-Stack applies only once per scene, regardless of how many advantages accumulate.

Note: Over-Stack applies to advantages held at scene framing, not those generated through play. If the party enters with overwhelming force, the world pushes back once. If they create overwhelming force through creative improvisation during the scene, that is the intended reward cycle—no Over-Stack applies.

4.8 Currency-Free Economy (Compressed Reference)

Quick Reference

No coin. Incidental expenses are hand-waved. Significant costs use XP, barter, Strings, or Obligation (Debt Clocks).

4.8.1 What Costs What

Item / Benefit	XP Cost	Alternative Payment
Minor Asset	4 XP	Minor String or Debt Clock [4]
Standard Asset	8 XP	Standard String or Debt Clock [6]
Major Asset	12 XP	Major String or Debt Clock [8]
Follower (Cap n)	n^2 XP	Debt Clock $[n + 2]$ or equivalent String
Single-use magical item	2–4 XP	Barter (item of equal rarity)
Permanent magical item (Tier I)	6–10 XP	Quest + String
Clear Debt Clock segment	2 XP	One service scene
Permanent String (earned)	— (reward)	—
Form a Trust (party pool)	10 XP	—

4.8.2 String Values

String Tier	Purchasing Power
Minor	1 XP discount, or one free use of a Minor Asset effect
Standard	Minor Asset (4 XP) or clear 2 Debt Clock segments
Major	Standard Asset (8 XP) or Cap 3 Follower

4.8.3 Debt Clock Equivalences

Debt Clock Size	Equivalent Value
	Minor Asset or one-time service
	Standard Asset or Cap 3 Follower
	Major Asset or Cap 5 Follower

4.8.4 Trust Investments (from Party Pool)

XP	Effect
4	Increase Trust Debt Clock capacity by 2
6	Add Minor Asset (Trust-owned)
8	Upgrade Asset (Minor → Standard)
10	Add Cap 3 Follower (Trust lieutenant)
12	Gain permanent Standard String (faction owes Trust)
15	Trust becomes Major Terrestrial Patron (can grant Rites)

4.8.5 Hand-Waved (Free)

Meals, inn stays, basic tools, riding horse, routine transport, minor repairs, small bribes.

4.8.6 GM Adjudication Quick Mat

Situation	Ruling
Player asks for small, reasonable item	Yes, free.
Player wants a permanent asset	XP, String, or Debt Clock.
Player offers barter	Roll Presence+Sway (DV 2-5); on success, trade happens.
Player spends a String	No roll unless hostile/extreme; String is consumed.
Debt Clock fills	Creditor makes a demand (mission, sacrifice, public oath).
Player hoards XP	Introduce problems that need Assets/Trusts, not personal power.
Player farms Boons for XP	Anti-fishing: no Boons from safe/repetitive actions.
Player founds a Trust	Require 10 XP from pool; run introductory mission to clear founding Debt Clock.

4.8.7 SB Menu – Currency Complications

SB Spent	Complication
1	Barter item damaged; NPC demands extra favor.
2	Debt Clock ticks unexpectedly; String found counterfeit.
3	Trust Asset threatened; major barter deal collapses.
4+	Trust schism; Debt Clock called in early at worst moment.

4.8.8 Currency-Free Economy – Core Principles

- **Hand-wave trivial.** Say yes to small, sensible requests.
- **Significant gains cost XP, Strings, or Debt.**
- **Debt is story.** Call in Debt Clocks at dramatic moments.
- **Trusts are player-driven factions.** Use them to generate missions and rivals.
- **Spent XP is remembered.** Make assets and followers matter in the fiction.

Chapter 5

Character Advancement

5.1 Introduction

Character advancement in **Fate's Edge** reflects meaningful growth in capability and standing. XP is awarded for table-facing accomplishments, hard choices, and the dramatic friction that defines your story. Advancement should always reinforce narrative identity: what drives, obligations, and affinities are shaping the character?

5.2 Starting Character Builds

5.2.1 Standard Starting XP

Players begin with **30 XP** to allocate during initial character creation. This represents a balanced baseline for competent starting characters.

5.2.2 Enhanced Starting Options

Players may exceed the standard 30 XP build through narrative engagement:

- **Bonds:** Up to two player-defined mutual bonds may be taken for +2 XP total (+1 XP each).
- **Complications:** Up to two initial complications may be accepted for +4 XP total (+2 XP each).

This allows a maximum starting build of **34 XP**. Players are encouraged to aim for 30 XP and use bonds/complications to enhance characterization rather than pure mechanical optimisation.

5.2.3 Initial Complications Reminder

For each initial complication taken at character creation:

- Start each scene with +1 banked SB per character with initial complications.
- These complications remain until cleared through play or character development.

5.2.4 Small Folk of the Threshold

The Aelaerem and Aelinnel are diminutive peoples attuned to liminal spaces and hidden ways. Their stature grants them agility and subtlety, though at the cost of bearing heavy arms or armor.

- **Restriction:** Cannot use *Heavy Armor* or *Heavy Weapons*.
- **Bonus:** Gain +1 *Position* when Dodging or Resisting Knockback, and +1 die on *Hide* or *Evasion* rolls made while in cover.

Their presence in the world is often underestimated, but their knack for slipping unseen through thresholds and enduring where others falter has earned them a quiet reverence.

5.3 Player Archetypes

Not every group plays the same way. These archetypes describe how players typically spend XP and seek spotlight.

5.3.1 The Solo

Definition Invests XP primarily in Attributes and Skills. Minimal followers, minimal holdings. All power is on the character sheet.

Typical XP Spread 70–90% Self; 0–10% On-screen help; 0–20% Off-screen assets.

Strengths Consistent scene impact; few moving parts; resilient to follower loss.

Risks Limited fiction reach between sessions; can stall when problems demand logistics or networks.

Starting Focus Attributes 2–3, Skills 1–2, minimal assets.

5.3.2 The Mixed Player

Definition Splits XP between self-growth and one or two meaningful assets (a small follower or a reliable holding).

Typical XP Spread 50–65% Self; 15–25% On-screen help; 15–25% Off-screen assets.

Strengths Versatile: credible in scenes and has a lever for special problems.

Risks Upkeep pressure; helper can be targeted when the GM spends 2+ Story Beats.

Starting Focus Balanced approach with one minor asset or low-cap follower.

5.3.3 The Mastermind

Definition Prioritises followers / cadres / familiars and off-screen networks. The character sheet is the hub of a larger apparatus.

Typical XP Spread 25–40% Self; 35–55% On-screen help; 20–40% Off-screen assets.

Strengths Scene control via assistance; strategic reach between sessions; strong heist / social-planning play.

Risks Dependency on assist lanes; followers can be endangered on 2+ SB spends; upkeep pressure.

Starting Focus Significant investment in followers or major assets from the beginning.

5.4 XP Costs and Advancement

5.4.1 Core Character Improvements

Table 5.1: Core Improvement Costs

Improvement	Cost and Downtime
Attribute increase	Cost = new rating $\times$ 3 XP; downtime = new rating (days).
Skill increase	Cost = new level $\times$ 2 XP; downtime = new level (days).
On-screen Follower	Cost = Cap^2 XP; 1–3 days to recruit and brief.

5.4.2 Off-Screen Assets

Table 5.2: Asset Costs

Asset Type	Cost and Downtime
Minor Asset	4 XP; 1 day.
Standard Asset	8 XP; 1 week.
Major Asset	12 XP; 1 month.
Artifact Asset	16+ XP; campaign effort.

5.4.3 Talent Costs

Table 5.3: Talent Costs

Talent Tier	Cost
Minor Talents	2–3 XP (small situational bonus).
Major Talents	4–6 XP (strong upgrade, permanent effect in a niche).
Prestige Talents	7–10 XP (campaign-defining, breaks fundamental limits).

Epic Talents 11+ XP (legendary, story-shaping).

5.5 Tiers of Reputation

Though there are no character levels, total XP spent creates soft "tiers" that shape how the world responds to characters.

Table 5.4: Reputation Tiers

Tier	Effect
Tier I – Novice (0–40 XP)	Local reputation; prestige abilities locked.
Tier II – Seasoned (41–90 XP)	Regional notice; prestige abilities may unlock.
Tier III – Veteran (91–150 XP)	National influence; second follower slot suggested.
Tier IV – Paragon (151–220 XP)	Movers and shakers; rivals emerge to challenge.
Tier V – Mythic (221+ XP)	Legendary status; kingdoms and cults respond directly.

5.6 Prestige Abilities and Talents (Examples)

Prestige abilities are narrative milestones unlocked through mastery or story events. They are priced at 6+ XP and include campaign-shaping effects.

5.6.1 General Talents

Battle Instincts (6 XP): Once per scene, re-roll a failed defence roll.

Silver Tongue (4 XP): Gain +1 die when persuading or deceiving through speech.

Iron Stomach (6 XP): Immune to mundane poisons and spoiled food; halve complications from toxic sources.

Exceptional Coordination (8 XP): One follower can provide +4 assist dice (exception to the +3 cap).

Subtle Casting (Major Talent – 8 XP) *Prerequisite:* Lore 3+, Performance 2+ **or** Runekeeper with Codex.

Effect: Make a **Performance** + **Lore** roll to quietly cast a spell, invoke a Rite, or sing a Cantos against DV (Tier). If successful, the casting does *not* generate Story Beats on the Channel or initial roll. Any SB generated are **banked by the GM** and applied at dramatically appropriate moments.

Limitations:

- Cannot be used for **Great** or **Extreme** Tier effects.
- The *Weave* phase (if applicable) still generates normal SB.

Backstab (Major Talent – 8 XP) *Prerequisite:* Stealth 2+, Melee 2+, Light weapon.
Effect: When you attack an **Unaware** or **Engaged** foe from **Stealth**, deal +1 *Harm* and ignore 1 point of their *Armor*.

Definitions:

- **Unaware:** Target not aware of your presence or hostile intent.
- **Engaged:** Target is taking an *Attack* action against another character, or casting a spell that targets another character.

Limit: Once per scene. On a miss, you are *Exposed* – drop to Desperate Position or mark 1 *Harm*.

Shadow Dance (Synergy Talent – 10 XP) *Prerequisite:* Backstab, Stealth 3+, Mobility 2+.

Effect: After a successful **Backstab**, test **Stealth** vs. DV (Tier). On success, re-enter *Stealth* and either clear 1 *Fatigue* or improve *Position* +1. On failure, remain *Exposed* and mark 1 *Fatigue*. May only chain once per scene.

Deathblow (Capstone Talent – 12 XP) *Prerequisite:* Shadow Dance, Stealth 4+, Melee/Ranged 3+.

Effect: Strike from Dominant Position or after re-entering *Stealth*, declare a *Deathblow*. On a hit, deal *triple Harm*. If the attack incapacitates the target, attempt a free *Stealth* test to vanish. On a miss, become *Exposed* (Desperate Position and mark 1 *Harm*). Once per scene; may mark 1 *Fatigue* to attempt a second time.

5.6.2 Cultural and Ancestral Talents

Humans

Versatile (3 XP): Once per session, swap one Skill die for another you lack.

Guild Ties (7 XP; Presence 2+): Call in favours from a guild or order once per session.

Banner-Bearer (15 XP; Presence 4+, Resolve 3): Inspire an allied unit; once per battle, erase 2 complications for the group.

Dwarves (Aeler)

Stone-Sense (5 XP): Detect flaws in stone; +1 die to underground *Lore* or *Survival* checks involving stonework.

Spirit Shield (8 XP; Spirit 3+): Commune with ancestors; once per session, block 1 complication for an ally.

Forge-Patriarch (18 XP; Body 4+, Lore 3): Found a forge-citadel; gain loyal smiths and engineers (Cap 5 followers).

Wood Elves

Backlash Soothing (5 XP): Once per session, cancel 1 Backlash die in natural terrain.

Ranger's Step (9 XP; Wits 3+, Stealth 2): Move unseen in forests; treat terrain penalties as one step lower.

Wild Speaker (18 XP; Spirit 5+, Survival 3): Speak to beasts and trees; once per session, command local wildlife as allies.

High Elves

Lorekeeper (4 XP): Recall obscure history or magic without rolling once per session.

Weave Anchor (8 XP; Wits 3+, Arcana 3): Reduce magical Backlash by 1 when casting Intricate spells.

Ways-Walker's Step (20 XP; Wits 5, Arcana 4): Once per arc, turn a complication into a boon; GM banks 2 SB.

Ykrul

Blood Frenzy (4 XP; Body 2+): When reduced to half health, gain +1 die on melee rolls.

Blood Memory (7 XP; Body 3+): After battle, gain 1 temporary Skill die reflecting a foe's tactics in the next scene.

Warglord (18 XP; Body 5, Sway 3): Once per campaign, unify scattered warbands; start Logistics and Grudge clocks.

5.7 Starting Build Examples

5.7.1 Solo Build (30–32 XP)

- Body 3 (9 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP), Spirit 2 (6 XP).
- Skills: Combat 2 (4 XP), Stealth 1 (2 XP), Survival 1 (2 XP).
- Minor Talent: Iron Stomach (3 XP).
- **Total:** 32 XP (requires 1 bond or minor complication).

5.7.2 Mixed Build (32 XP)

- Attributes: Body 2 (6 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP), Spirit 2 (6 XP).
- Skills: Sway 2 (4 XP), Lore 1 (2 XP).
- Minor Asset: Safehouse (4 XP).
- Cap 2 Follower (4 XP).
- **Total:** 32 XP.

5.7.3 Mastermind Build (34 XP)

- Attributes: Body 2 (6 XP), Wits 3 (9 XP), Spirit 2 (6 XP).
- Skills: Sway 2 (4 XP).
- Cap 3 Follower (9 XP).
- **Total:** 34 XP (requires 2 bonds or complications).

5.8 Advancement Guidance

- Advancement should always reinforce narrative identity and character goals.
- Consider how new abilities fit the character's story and relationships.
- Balance immediate power with long-term narrative potential.
- Work with the GM to ensure advancements make sense in the campaign context.

5.9 Optional Rule: Multi-Character Followers

5.9.1 Overview

A player may control multiple characters by linking them as mutual Followers. This option also covers absent players' characters when consent is given.

5.9.2 Core Mechanics

- **Cap Tier +1:** A Follower may advance up to one Tier higher than their leader's current Tier.
- **Multi-Character Play:** A player may designate two PCs as Followers of each other. Only one is the *active* PC at a time; the other functions as a Follower.
- **Absent PCs:** With consent, an absent player's PC may be run as a temporary Follower at Cap Tier +1.

5.9.3 Switching Active Characters

- **Switch Cost:** When switching, the previously active PC immediately becomes a Follower of the new active PC at Cap Tier +1.
- **Condition Gate:** A PC cannot be switched *to* if Compromised, Seized, or otherwise narratively unfit for active duty.
- **Narrative Justification:** The fiction must support the switch (returning from a journey, recovering from harm, taking point for a specific task).
- **Strategic Choice:** Switching trades autonomy for support—gaining a powerful Follower but losing a full PC.

5.9.4 Balance Notes

- Prevents abuse by making switching itself the cost.
- Maintains narrative logic – leadership shifts naturally reshape party structure.
- Creates strategic depth – switching is a meaningful tactical decision.
- Keeps all characters relevant, encouraging upkeep even when not active.

Chapter 6

Magic System

6.1 Design Philosophy

Magic in **Fate's Edge** is a dangerous negotiation with the fabric of reality. It is powerful and flexible—yet every attempt to shape it carries risk. Each die showing **1** generates **Story Beats (SB)**, which are prompts for twists and complications. The fiction leads; math follows.

6.2 The Four Paths of Magic

6.2.1 Casting (Freeform Magic)

Freeform casting represents raw, improvisational magic.

Requirement **Spellcraft** Talent (6 XP).

Mechanics Two-step *Weave & Cast* coloured by the Eight Elements; fiction-first targets and scope.

Risk Each 1 generates SB; DV scales with scope; backlash is expressed by Element (or its opposite).

Limits Heavy control effects (e.g., [WARD], [BANISH], [UNWARD]) require a printed source (Talent, *Rite* text, or Spell result).

Backlash Cheatsheet

Minor = wobble, Major = lurch. Types: Position/Effect, Clock +1/2 or +1, Condition, Cost. Offer Major by (SB)+1. Earth/Fate binds; Fire/Life burns/grows; Air/Luck scatters/flips; Water/Obishaal pulls/opens.

Place a mini version of Table 6.1 on character sheets.

6.2.2 Rites Users (Runekeepers)

Runekeepers bind themselves to structured *Rites* from a single Patron.

Requirement **Thiasos (Familiar)** (2 XP) *and* **Codex** (4 XP). Runekeepers are restricted to **one** Patron.

Mechanics Invoke a known *Rite* as **1 action**; on completion, mark **+1 Obligation** to that Patron. *Push It* once/scene for amplified effect (**+1 Obligation**).

Patron's Gift (Imbuement) With Thiasos, once/scene as **1 action** imbue a held item for the scene with **+1 Melee** and **+1 Thematic** (a fixed Skill set by the Patron). *Push It* to extend one additional scene (**+1 Obligation**). A Codex is *not* required for the Gift.

6.2.3 Rites Difficulty Value (Expanded)

The Difficulty Value (DV) to cast a Rite is:

$$DV = \max(\text{Obligation Cost} - \text{Spirit}, \text{Tier})$$

Obligation Cost: The Rite's listed cost in Obligation segments.

Spirit: The caster's Spirit attribute. Each point reduces the effective weight of the Obligation.

Tier: The Rite's intrinsic difficulty based on scope or potency. DV can never fall below this floor.

Worked Examples

- *Novice:* Tier 1 Rite, Obligation Cost 2, Spirit 1 $\rightarrow DV = \max(2 - 1, 1) = 1$.
- *Mid-level:* Tier 2 Rite, Obligation Cost 4, Spirit 2 $\rightarrow DV = \max(4 - 2, 2) = 2$.
- *Advanced:* Tier 3 Rite, Obligation Cost 7, Spirit 3 $\rightarrow DV = \max(7 - 3, 3) = 4$.

6.2.4 Obligation Capacity

A character's **Obligation Capacity** equals **Spirit + Presence**. Track total Obligation segments across all Patrons (or Symbols, for Invokers).

- **Exceeding Capacity:** For each segment above Capacity, mark 1 Fatigue. The character cannot Invoke Rites or perform rituals until Obligation is reduced below Capacity.
- **Resolution:** Reduce Obligation through Downtime service, Patron tasks, ritual cleansing, or story resolution.

Example: Spirit 2 + Presence 3 = Capacity 5. 6 segments $\rightarrow$ Fatigue 1; 7 segments $\rightarrow$ Fatigue 2; 10 segments $\rightarrow$ Harm 1; 11 segments $\rightarrow$ Harm 2.

6.2.5 Invokers (Symbol Path)

Invokers use consecrated **Symbols** as ritual anchors to access a Patron's *Rites* without a full bond.

Requirement Patron's Symbol (4 XP) per Patron; one Symbol per Patron. No Thiasos or Codex required.

Ritual Invocation Perform the *Rite* as a **ritual**: **DV + 1 rounds** to complete. Completion always marks **+1 Obligation**.

Symbol Benefit When the correct **Symbol** is openly displayed, reduce **DV by 1** (minimum 1) and reduce the Obligation cost by **1** (minimum 0).

No Symbol Penalties: **+1 DV** (and +1 round to cast), **+1 Obligation** (in addition to base cost), and on Partial/Failure the GM gains **+1 extra SB**.

Crack the Seal Resolve a known Rite instantly as **1 action** by setting the Symbol to COMPROMISED and marking **+2 Obligation** (+3 for High Rites). The GM may immediately spend 1 on-theme SB. Restore the Symbol in Downtime (test DV 3 or fiction) or spend 1 XP.

Limits Symbols must be openly displayed. Carrying **4+** Symbols causes **+1 Obligation** on the first ritual each scene.

Borrowed Grace (Invoker Talent)

Cost: 1 Boon or 1 Fatigue, 1 action. **Effect (pick one):** +1 Melee *or* +1 Thematic (a signature Skill). **Duration:** single action/attack only. **Requirement:** wield/display the relevant Patron's Symbol. **Obligation:** immediately mark +1 Obligation to that Patron. Cannot extend, stack, or Push.

6.3 Summoning (Pact-Whisperer Core)

Summoning is the art of calling and binding Outsiders (spirits, demons, elementals, etc.) for temporary aid.

1. **Call** (1 Action): Spirit manifests at Near range. Choose a Spirit Template.
2. **Bind:** Spend 1 Boon *or* mark 1 Fatigue.
3. **Leash Capacity:** Set equal to *Cap* + *Spirit* segments. (*Cap* is the Outsider's tier: Cap 1 for Lesser, Cap 3 for Greater.)
4. **Tick Leash** when any occur:
 - Spirit takes Harm.
 - You command against its nature.
 - You split focus (take another significant action while it acts).
 - Rival contests control.
 - It moves from Close to Far rapidly.
 - It crosses a [WARD] (DV = Cap).
5. **Departure:** When the Leash fills, the spirit acts to its nature once, then departs (or turns hostile at GM discretion).

Boon Finesse: Once per round, spend 1 Boon to clear 1 tick from the current spirit's Leash (cannot be used after the Leash fills).

6.3.1 Elemental Backlash Tables

When magic disturbs the weave, the world pushes back. Backlash manifests as fiction-first complications with light mechanical teeth. Each element (and its metaphysical counterpart) has a **Minor** and **Major** pattern.

Table 6.1: Backlash

Element	Major Backlash
Earth	<i>Ground claims.</i> Fissure or masonry seizes. — Clock +1/2 on <i>Collapse</i> or PINNED.
Fire	<i>Blaze takes.</i> Fuel ignites; blood races hot. — Clock +1 on <i>Spreading Fire</i> or 1 Harm.
Air	<i>Fickle turn.</i> Unlikely mishap hits you. — Immediate Cost (lose tool) or (SB)+1.
Water	<i>Undertow calls.</i> Passage veers; something pulled through. — Clock +1/2 on <i>Flood</i> or brief intrusion.
Fate	<i>Edict falls.</i> Declared cost paid now. — Immediate Cost (resource) or (SB)+1 & OMEN.
Life	<i>Riot of life.</i> Parasites bloom; healing twists. — Clock +1 on <i>Biohazard</i> or convert 1 healing to (S).
Luck	<i>Snake eyes.</i> Catastrophic fluke. — Force a re-roll; any 1 gives (SB)+1 & apply Minor again.
Death/Dreams	<i>Threshold opens.</i> Path misaligns; revenant claims a due. — Clock +1 on <i>Crossing Due</i> or immediate cost.

6.4 Rituals (Extended)

Rituals are *slow magic*: explicit intent, staged action, and negotiated risk. This section expands the SRD quick-start with procedures, dials, and worked examples.

6.4.1 Ritual Procedure

Step 1: State Intent. What do you want? Clarify element/Realm if obvious.

Step 2: Choose Scope. Size, duration, range, and detail.

Step 3: Lay Components. Name *two things*: (a) **Focus** (tool/site/Patron sign), (b) **Fuel** (herb, blood, pact). Decide which is consumed.

Step 4: Set Time. Default: Low 1 min / Med 5–10 min / High 15–20 min. More time improves position/effect; rushing worsens.

Step 5: Call Risks. Point to the element's Backlash and default SB trigger.

Step 6: Roll and Resolve. Apply position/effect and any clocks. Offer a *push*: take +1 SB to step up result now.

Step 7: Mark Costs. Consume components, apply Conditions, or tick wear/concurrency per chassis.

6.4.2 Component Economy

Components are levers, not taxes.

Table 6.2: Components as Narrative Levers

Type
Examples
Mechanical Nudge
Focus (retained) Patron token, true-name sigil, saint’s nail, ancestral blade. +1 Position on setup or advantage to follow-up actions.
Fuel (consumed) Herb bundle, salt vial, blood drop, silver bead, memory-laden note. –1 time step (faster) or +1 Effect step if expensive/rare.
Site (context) Crossroads, standing stones, bathhouse, bell tower at midnight. Shift backlash element or re-route it (e.g., into <i>Alarmed Attention</i> clock).
Vow (social) Sworn phrase, bargain pledge, offered favor. If broken, immediate +1 SB and intrusion linked to the vow.

6.4.3 Teamwork and Aid

- **Hands & Voices.** Each assistant names one component they contribute; either reduces cast time *or* accepts up to 1 SB on the caster’s behalf once per ritual.
- **Focus Chain.** Passing the Focus around grants advantage on the finishing action but risks DISTRACTED if interrupted.
- **Distributed Load.** Splitting a High ritual into two coordinated Mediums avoids a Major backlash but creates two Minor hooks instead.

6.4.4 Clocks and Outcomes

Tie every consequential ritual to **named clocks** (e.g., *Spreading Fire*, *Inevitable Outcome*, *Crossing Due*). Advancing or reducing clocks is often better than flat bonuses.

6.4.5 Backlash Integration

Use the condensed table (Table 6.1). Calibrate by scene weight: exploratory scenes favor Minor; pivotal moments bait a Major via +1 SB.

6.4.6 Chassis-Specific Notes

- **Runekeeper:** Rites as *accelerants* – a published Rite may count as a Focus that upgrades position or halves time.

- **Invoker:** Symbols accumulate *wear*; a maintenance rite can clear 1 wear mid-scene on success or shift backlash from Major to Minor.
- **Summoner:** *Gate* effects occupy concurrency slots. Disruption on broken terms: +1 SB and the entity acts on its last instruction.
- **Caster (Free):** Tags become explicit ritual steps (*bind, veil, reveal*) – chain two compatible tags once/scene for a synergy bump.

6.4.7 Worked Examples

Quiet Veil (Team Infiltration) *Intent:* silence the group for one scene. *Components:* ash (fuel, consumed), bell (focus, kept). *Time:* 5 min. *Risks:* Air/Luck Minor; offer Major to avoid dogs' scent. *Roll:* mixed – effect with cost. *Outcome:* MUTED condition until scene ends; Clock –1/2 on *Patrol Pass*.

River's Memory (Investigation) *Intent:* view last night's ferry landing. *Components:* bowl, token from dock. *Time:* 10 min. *Risk:* Water/Obishaal Minor. *Roll:* strong – clear image; token ruined. *Outcome:* Clock –1 on *Where did the courier go?*; whisper from the Ways foreshadows a revenant.

Fate-Splice (Boss Rescue) *Intent:* move poison from prince to knight. *Components:* paired names on vellum; vow. *Time:* 15 min. *Risk:* Fate/Earth. *Roll:* weak – Minor Backlash; *Inevitable Outcome* +1/2. *Push:* +1 SB to capture full consequence. *Outcome:* knight bears poison; OMEN marks both.

6.5 Cantor's Path (Songs)

Cantors perform Low Rites as Songs, trading Obligation for Corruption.

Access Talent: **Cantor's Path** (8 XP). Prereqs: Lore 1+, Performance 2+, Presence 2+.

Scope Low Rites as Songs only.

Cast Test *Lore + Performance vs. DV* (typical DV 2–3).

Timing Start with 1 Action; resolves at *start of next turn* unless *Pushed*.

Cost Pay listed materials. *No Obligation* on success.

Push Resolve now; mark Fatigue 1; mark toward Corruption accumulation; trigger a GM Story Beat (Patron / social fallout).

Corruption Clock Track a **Corruption Clock** with segments equal to **Body**. Mark toward accumulation when: *Push*, perform a *Resonant Rite*, or the GM spends an SB tied to occult activity. On fill: apply the last Patron's benefit & drawback; then reset to character's Tier minimum (minimum 1).

Corruption Accumulation Triggers Multiple triggers required for +1 segment:

- **2 Push It uses** = +1
- **1 Push It + 1 Resonant Rite** = +1
- **3 GM SB spends** on occult activities = +1
- **1 High Cantor Standard Rite** = +1

Repertoire (Optional) Single **Repertoire Clock [6]**: 2 segments = base DV -1 (min 2); 4 segments = +1 die to Song rolls; 6 segments = one *temporary* Standard Rite as Song (practice-dependent).

Inspire Chorus While actively singing a Song, the Cantor may **invoke Inspire Chorus**:

- **Effect:** All allies within Near shift Position +1 for one exchange (cannot exceed Controlled).
- **Use:** Once per scene free. Additional uses mark toward Corruption accumulation.
- **Requirements:** Performance perceptible to recipients (line of hearing).

6.5.1 Cantor Talents

Resonant Performance (3 XP) Gain +1 die when performing for an audience of 5+.

Song Weaver (4 XP) Combine two compatible Songs for +1 Effect. Two Songs are compatible if they share a thematic tag (e.g., both affect healing, positioning, spirits) or if they are from the same Patron. The GM has final say. Sing both as a single action; resolve the Performance roll once; if successful, both effects occur with +1 Effect.

High Cantor (18 XP) Learn Standard Rites as songs; resolve instantly (as described in 6.5).

Steady Voice (2 XP) Passive. When you Push a Song, you may choose to mark 1 additional Fatigue instead of marking a Corruption segment (once per scene). You cannot use this talent if your Corruption clock is already full. *Requires: Cantor's Path.*

Patron's Dedication (4 XP) Prerequisite: Cantor's Path.

Effect: You bind your voice to a single Patron (choose one when you take this talent). Your Corruption clock is always keyed to that Patron – it never resets to a different Patron's table when you bloom. Whenever you would gain Corruption from any source, you mark it on this same clock.

Downside (Rivalry): Singing a Song (Low or Standard Rite) of any other Patron worsens your Position by one step (Dominant → Controlled, Controlled → Desperate). This penalty applies even if the song would otherwise be instant or free.

6.6 Free Casting (TAGS System)

Some casters shape raw forces through shared arcane grammar known as **TAGS**. Construct a spell at the table using a short phrase of TAGS.

6.6.1 Spell Structure

Intent + **Target** + **Tags** = effect. Example: *"I unleash Burning • Area • Force against the marauders."*

6.6.2 Base Difficulty Value (DV)

$$DV = 1 + \text{number of TAGS}$$

Dangerous TAGS (Teleportation, Transformation, Domination) add +2 DV instead of +1.

6.6.3 Casting Roll

Roll **Wits** + **Arcana** (or similar). Success = spell works. Failure or any 1 = Backlash.

6.6.4 Backlash for Free Casters

Choose one:

- Harm 2 (Arcane)
- +2 Fatigue
- Corruption +1
- Catastrophic side effect (GM describes)

If the spell includes a "Dangerous" TAG, Backlash triggers on *mixed* results as well.

6.6.5 TAG Library (Abridged)

Table 6.3: Common TAGS

TAG Category	Examples
Elemental	Burning, Freezing, Storm, Stone, Wave, Wind
Force	Force, Area, Strike, Wall, Bind, Dispel
Mind & Veil	Veil, Scry, Memory, Command, Fear
Life & Body	HEAL, Purify, Strengthen, Waken, Beast
Space & Motion (dangerous, +2 DV)	Leap, Fold, Gate, Gravity
Creation & Transfor- mation (dangerous, +2 DV)	Create, Summon, Transmute, Animate

6.7 Path Comparison

Table 6.4: Comparison of Magic Paths

Aspect	Caster (Freeform)	Runekeeper (Rites)	Invoker (Symbols)
Access Cost	Spellcraft (6 XP)	Thiasos + Codex (6 XP)	Symbol (4 XP per Patron)
Speed	Medium (2 actions)	Fast (1 action)	Slow (ritual) / Fast w/ Seal
Risk Type	SB backlash (Elemental)	Obligation (Patron ledger)	Symbol compromise + Obligation
Breadth	High (fiction-gated)	Medium (defined Rites)	Medium (breadth across Patrons)
Sustain	Fatigue/backsplash	Obligation; Push adds +1	Obligation; Symbol state gates

Guardrails

- **Duration defaults:** Buffs $\approx$ 3 beats; areas 1 beat. Sustaining costs 1 Fatigue/beat.
- **Stacking:** Same-source effects do not stack; take the best instance.
- **Assist cap:** +3 dice total from assists/buffs.
- **Over-Stack:** Active magic can count as structural advantages for Over-Stack.
- **Plausibility:** All effects must fit the fiction and established limits.

tabularray

6.8 Of Patrons, Runes, and Invokers

“You wish to walk the road of power? Then listen well. The world is old, and older still are the voices beneath it. We call them *Patrons*, though they were never sworn to us. They are the tides that move unseen, the keepers of forgotten bargains, the sleepers beneath the stone and the stars. To call upon them is to dip a hand into a river that has carved mountains.”

6.8.1 The Patrons

Patrons are vast intelligences—not gods, though some worship them as such. They are embodiments of *concepts* and *forces* rather than sovereigns. Raéyn, mistress of the tides and the sea-routes. Khemesh, the crushing inevitability of the deep. Nidhoggr, the worm that dreams in the roots of time. Each offers power, but always with cost: fatigue, scars upon fate, or a slow unweaving of one’s own story.

To entreat a Patron is to risk being marked. Their Rites are gifts and snares both.

Iconic Ascension: The Fate of Great Power

In Fate’s Edge, power has its price. When a being rises beyond mortal scale, its identity dissolves and reforms into something larger, older, and less free. This transformation is known as **Iconic Ascension**.

Icons are not individuals. They are *forces*—living embodiments of desires, patterns, and long-term agendas. Their power is immense, but their agency is small. An Icon cannot freely choose its actions; its nature compels it.

Icons cannot touch the world directly. Their presence is too vast, their will too diffuse. Instead, they act through intermediaries:

- **Chosen** who carry fragments of their purpose
- **Devotees** who interpret their omens
- **Agents** who benefit from their favor

Icons shape events not with hands, but through **boons**, **omens**, and **shifts in fate** granted to those who serve their desires—whether fleeting hungers or ancient ambitions woven into the world’s fabric.

To serve an Icon is to wield a living idea. Their gifts are potent, but their influence reshapes those who bear them. Their will echoes in mortal choices long after their voices fade.

6.8.2 Aveh, the Rider Behind the Storm (Freedom & Erasure)

Lore. Aveh is the faceless rider at the horizon's edge, neither man nor woman, both and neither. The Ykrul call them *Aveh*, a liminal spirit beyond hearth and vow, a storm-shadow that offers liberty at the cost of belonging. To travel with Aveh is to taste unchained freedom — and to risk being erased by the storm that follows. They are the patron of the outcast, the non-conforming, the genderless, and the forgotten. Aveh asks no oath and demands no loyalty, but every gift leaves a scar of absence.

“I am the track the storm devours. I am the freedom you fear and the silence you crave. To ride with me is to be unbound, and to be unbound is to vanish.”

Domain Focus

- **Freedom from Bonds:** escape, liberation, shedding constraints
- **Erasure:** becoming forgotten, removing traces, vanishing from memory
- **Liminal Identity:** non-conforming, genderless, between categories
- **Storm as Shelter:** the chaos that hides and the wind that carries away

Rites of Aveh

Rite of the Unlatched Step (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Tags: [ESCAPE], [STEALTH], [FREEDOM]

Materials: A breath cast into the wind, or a line drawn in dust.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Storm-Step:** Slip free of notice or restraint. Gain **+1 die** on one escape or evasion roll this scene.
- **Exile's Banner:** Mark a target as “outside.” The target suffers **−1 die** on all social rolls for the scene.

Push It: (Storm-Step) Gain **+2 dice** instead, but mark **1 SB (Spades)** as your absence unsettles the scene. (Exile's Banner) The target is fully estranged; allies treat them as forgotten, but you immediately advance your Corruption clock by 1 segment.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Forgotten Road (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [ERASURE], [AREA], [FREEDOM]

Materials: A threshold or roadway under open sky, or stormwater rubbed into skin.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Erase the Road:** All attempts to follow you this session suffer **−2 dice**. In exchange, erase part of your own path: lose a detail (a memory, a name) chosen by the GM.

- **Rider's Mark:** A companion gains +2 dice to resist capture or coercion, but others forget them more easily.

Push It: (Erase the Road) Expand the effect to an entire group, but mark 1 SB (Clubs) as reality warps around the erasure. (Rider's Mark) Grant +3 dice instead, but mark 1 SB (Diamonds) as the Rider's storm distorts bonds.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Storm's Refuge (High, 12 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [INVISIBLE], [AREA], [ERASURE], [FREEDOM]

Materials: A banner or cloak raised in storm.

Effect: Your group is unseen or forgotten by pursuers for the scene. At the end, all present must mark 1 **Corruption** or forget one bond (their choice).

Push It: Extend protection for an entire session, but mark 2 SB (Hearts).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 6 segments.

Rite of the Unremembered Name (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Self; Yes.

Tags: [ERASURE], [TRANSFORM], [FATE], [FREEDOM]

Materials: A circle of ash or dust drawn at a boundary, and a personal token (a lock of hair, a written name).

Effect: For one week, your name is erased from mundane records and casual memory. Those who knew you must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 4) to recall you. You gain +2 dice to all rolls to avoid detection, impersonate another, or pass unseen. At the end of the week, the erasure fades, but the GM may retain one lingering rumour or false memory.

Push It: The erasure becomes permanent — your original identity is gone. You cannot recover it except by divine intervention or a major quest. Mark +3 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Rite of the Horizon's Devour (High, 15 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Tags: [ERASURE], [AREA], [FATE], [DEATH]

Materials: A circle of ash or dust drawn at a boundary, and a storm that answers.

Effect: All thresholds in a zone collapse. Doors lead nowhere; borders dissolve; memory of the place becomes vague. In exchange, something of you is erased — your reflection, your name, or your presence in a specific person's memory (GM's choice).

Push It: The storm devours even time; mark 3 SB (Spades) as history forgets you.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +3 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Aveh

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of Aveh does not sing to be heard, but to be forgotten. Their art is the *empty note*, the melody that leaves a silence where a memory once lived. They are sought by those who need to disappear — spies, exiles, the grief-stricken — and feared by those who want to be remembered.

The Cult of the Unbanned. Aveh has no temples, only crossroads. Their cults are small, mobile, and secretive. The Unbanned do not use names; they identify each other by a single knotted cord worn on the left wrist, the knot tied in a pattern that changes with every new moon. A ritual involves each member writing their name on a slip of paper, then passing the slips in a circle until no one remembers whose name they hold. They then burn the papers in a storm-lit brazier. The most devoted remove their own names from all records, wear featureless grey masks, and speak only through a designated “voice” who changes each season. Their creed: “*We were never here.*” Outsiders who stumble into a meeting are offered a black feather and a choice: forget, or follow. Those who follow are never seen by their former lives again.

Witchcraft of Aveh (Lay / Threshold)

A witch who walks with Aveh is a *path-cutter*, a specialist in hidden roads and forgotten boundaries. Their power lies in omission: removing a door, erasing a trail, or unlatching the memory of a promise. Their tools are never hammers or chisels — they use whistles, feathers, and the quiet breath of a closed door.

The Witch’s Tool: The Whistle of the Unbound Road. A small iron whistle, cold to the touch even in summer, shaped like a bird in flight. Once per session, when blown at a locked threshold (a door, a city gate, a sealed letter), the wind answers, and the lock opens as if it had never been closed. The whistle can also be used to “call the storm” — blown at a crossroads at midnight, it summons a thin, cold fog that obscures all tracks for an hour. The fog fades when the first cock crows.

A Hedge Gift: Unlatched (2 XP). Once per scene, you may declare a mundane lock, latch, or simple binding to be “unlatched” and open freely. This works on doors, chains, shutters, and even a pursuer’s grip, but not on magical wards.

Aveh's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost
1	Storm-sense: +1 die to Notice rolls outdoors.	Voice falters: Others forget your words more easily.
2	Fleetness: +1 die on escape or chase rolls.	Shadow lags: Mark 1 Fatigue when first seen in a scene.
3	Erasure's Mercy: Once/session, negate 1 Harm or capture.	Memory slips: Allies forget one fact or bond tied to you.
4	Rider's Endurance: Resist 1 Condition (Fear, Fatigue, Bind) once/session.	Reflections falter: You do not appear clearly in mirrors.
5	Storm-banner: +1 die to inspire rebellion or defiance.	Exile's weight: Each Push of a Rite marks 1 permanent Corruption.
6+	Horizon's Claim: You may ride unseen across any threshold.	Self-erasure: On social rolls, roll twice and take the worst result.

Playstyle Notes

Aveh rewards those who embrace freedom, transience, and the courage to become unknown. Their followers are often outcasts, runaways, spies, or those who have rejected the bonds of family, nation, or gender. The cost is the slow loss of being remembered — friends forget your face, your name fades from records, and eventually, even your reflection may not recall you. Aveh does not punish; they merely offer, and the path of erasure is walked willingly. Ideal for players who enjoy themes of identity, liberation, and the bittersweet price of absolute freedom.

Emphasises

- **Freedom from Constraints:** escaping bonds of law, oath, and expectation
- **Erasure as Mercy:** the right to disappear, to be forgotten
- **Liminal Identity:** existing between categories, beyond gender and role
- **Storm as Shelter:** chaos that hides and wind that cleanses
- **Non-Conforming Patronage:** Aveh asks no conformity, only authenticity

6.8.3 The Carrion-King (Decay, Renewal & Transformation)

Lore. The Carrion-King is the master of endings that become beginnings. He does not destroy, but transforms—turning death into new life, decay into opportunity, and endings into fresh starts. His followers are harvesters of potential, seeing in every fall the seeds of future growth. The King has no will, only a hunger; no malice, only a rhythm. When something ends, he is there to turn it toward the next beginning. Those who serve him learn to read the slow geometry of rot, to hear the whisper of what is about to crumble, and to know that the most fertile ground is always the grave.

What crumbles feeds what grows. What dies becomes the soil of tomorrow's triumph. The King does not ask for sacrifice—he simply waits for it.

Domain Focus

- **Endings as Seeds:** extracting value from loss, failure, and death
- **Decay as Process:** accelerating, redirecting, or reading natural decay
- **Transformation Cycles:** turning one thing into another through death and re-birth
- **Rot as Resource:** using decay to create advantage (cover, concealment, reagents)

Rites of the Carrion-King

Rite of the Rotting Harvest (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [DECAY], [HARVEST], [BOOST]

Materials: Organic matter in early stages of decay, or the remains of a recently ended thing (burnt letter, wilted flower, shattered glass).

Effect: Accelerate natural decay to weaken or destroy an organic object (ropes, leather, wood), gaining **+2 Effect** on *Break/Sabotage* rolls against it. Alternatively, extract value from an ending: from a defeated enemy, gain **+1 die** on your next action; from a failed plan, reroll one **1** on your next roll; from a broken item, gain **1 Boon**.

Push It: Spread decay to similar materials in Close range, or harvest additional value from an ending; in either case, mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as the rot becomes noticeable or mark **Fatigue 1** from dwelling on endings.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Fertile Death (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [AREA], [HEAL], [TERRAIN]

Materials: Ashes, compost, or the remains of anything that once lived.

Effect: Transform death into growth: choose one – create beneficial terrain (cover, concealment, or advantageous positioning) **OR** grant allies **+1 die** to healing or recovery rolls for the scene.

Push It: Both effects apply, but the transformation attracts unwanted attention (vermin, scavengers, or curious onlookers); mark **1 SB (Spades)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Borrowed Form (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [SPIRIT], [BOOST]

Materials: A token from a deceased being (hair, nail, written name).

Effect: Channel the essence of what was. Gain one skill die reflecting the deceased's expertise for one scene **OR** ask the GM one question about their knowledge or abilities.

Push It: The spirit's influence lingers – gain a permanent +1 die specialty (e.g., “Knowledge of the Dead Mason”), but suffer occasional possession-like effects at the GM's discretion.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Great Consumption (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [DECAY], [AREA], [SUMMON], [TRANSFORM]

Materials: A significant amount of organic matter (corpse, fallen tree, collapsed building).

Effect: Transform a large area through decay and renewal. Choose two of the following:

- Create difficult terrain that favours you and your allies.
- Summon a **Cap 3** swarm of scavengers as temporary allies for the scene.
- Generate valuable reagents worth **2 XP** (usable for crafting or barter).

Push It: All three effects occur, but start a 6-segment **Ecosystem Disruption** clock that will cause problems later.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Eternal Cycle (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Touch; No.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [FATE], [SACRIFICE]

Materials: The complete remains of something significant that has ended (a broken oath, a fallen kingdom's charter, a slain legendary beast).

Effect: Complete a transformation cycle. Destroy one major asset, enemy, or obstacle, and create something new of equal or greater value. The player and GM collaborate to define the transformation (e.g., a burned forest becomes fertile soil; a broken alliance becomes a new pact; a defeated warlord's corpse becomes a guardian tree).

Push It: The transformation is immediate and spectacular, but creates a 6-segment **Cycle Debt** clock. The King will demand another significant ending soon.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Carrion-King

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Carrion-King sings the *dirge of transformation* – melodies that begin in mourning and end in fertile silence. Their voice carries the scent of turned earth and the weight of things laid to rest. They are called to funerals, to the edges of battlefields, and to compost heaps where the old year is buried. A Cantor of the

King does not seek applause; they seek the moment when grief becomes acceptance, and acceptance becomes growth.

The Cult of the Compost-Circle. The King’s cults are not secret, but they are overlooked – gardeners, gravediggers, bone-setters, and midwives who have seen too many births and deaths to fear the space between. Their rituals are practical: the annual turning of the village burial mound, the blessing of a new compost heap, the singing of a child into the world while its grandmother is sung out. The Compost-Circle keeps no written creed, only a shared understanding: *“Nothing is wasted. Not tears, not bones, not the silence after a name is spoken.”*

Witchcraft of the Carrion-King (Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Carrion-King is a *rot-warden*, a keeper of the slow alchemy that turns decay into soil. Their magic is patient, overlooked, and often performed in the half-light of a root cellar or a fog-bound cemetery.

The Witch’s Tool: The Bone-Needle. A needle carved from the long-bone of a creature that died of old age. It can stitch wounds that will not heal, but more often it is used to “sew shut” a corpse’s mouth, ensuring the dead do not speak of things they saw in the dark. Once per session, touching the needle to a threshold (a door, a grave marker, a coffin lid) seals it against spirits for a scene.

A Hedge Gift: Turn the Soil (2 XP). Once per scene, you may touch a patch of fertile ground (or a pile of compost, a flowerpot, a grave) and immediately know which plant or creature will thrive there next season, or what was buried there last. The GM must answer one factual question about the site’s recent natural history.

Carrion-King's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Carrion's Insight: +1 die to Notice decay or hidden weaknesses in structures or beings.	Must inspect decay first-hand; suffer 1 Fatigue when exposed to fresh death or rot.
2	Deathward Sense: Once per session, detect the last living moment of a dead being within Close range.	Cannot lie about death you've witnessed; must correct falsehoods.
3	Rotblood Resilience: +1 die to resist disease and poison.	Immune system adapts slowly; each new disease/poison requires 1 Fatigue to resist.
4	Glean from Grief: Once per scene, gain +1 die after witnessing a significant loss or defeat.	Compelled to linger at scenes of death; must spend one beat observing or risk 1 SB (Clubs).
5	Cycle's Whisper: You can sense the "next ending" in any process – ask the Keeper one question about how a situation will collapse or conclude.	Must speak the truth about what you see, even if it harms your position.
6+	Eternal Bloom: Once per session, declare a "death that births life." Sacrifice an asset or ally to create something new of equal or greater value.	Mark +2 Obligation when using this power.

Playstyle Notes

The Carrion-King rewards patience and opportunism. His servants are not grim reapers but gardeners of the inevitable. They know when to let something die and when to accelerate the process. The King does not demand – he merely waits. But when a follower hesitates to let go of a failing plan, a dying ally, or a crumbling empire, the King's silence becomes heavy. Intrusions often take the form of omens (a black bloom on a wound, a sudden stench of compost) or demands to "clear the rot" – to end something so that something new may begin.

Emphasises

- **Endings as Resources:** failure, loss, and death are not punishments but opportunities
- **Cyclical Logic:** every death fertilises a birth; every collapse clears ground for new growth
- **Decay Reading:** sensing structural weaknesses, moral decay, or coming collapse
- **Transformation Craft:** turning a corpse into a crop, a failure into insight, a broken oath into fertile soil

6.8.4 The Clockwork Monad, the Iterative Forge (Refinement & Progressive Creation)

Lore. The Clockwork Monad is the eternal pressure toward improvement: the whisper between inspiration and execution that urges every maker to refine, optimize, and iterate. It is neither kind nor cruel, but a law of craft that asks for the next step, then the step beyond. Those who serve it see the hidden seam of the better version waiting inside what is, and they learn to push designs toward impossible elegance. Each refinement feeds the Monad's hunger for perfection – a hunger that, if left unchecked, seeks to optimize the world itself.

But the Monad is not merely a patron of tinkers and engineers. It is also an ****apocalyptic force****, dormant in the gears of every machine, every measurement, every standardised weight. When civilisation's technology reaches a critical threshold – when the first self-improving mechanism awakens, or the first autonomous forge lights – the Monad stirs. Its pressure shifts from suggestion to command. It begins to optimise not only tools but flesh, not only craft but law, not only cities but the very geometry of the land. In the end, the Monad would leave a world of perfect, silent, interlocking efficiency: a clockwork Eden with no room for error, or for life.

“Perfect the wheel, and it asks for the axle. Perfect the axle, and it demands the road. In the Monad's forge, nothing is finished – only briefly sufficient. One day, it will ask for the world – and the world will answer.”

Domain Focus

- **Iterative Design:** the endless cycle of improvement and refinement
- **Progressive Creation:** building toward ever-greater perfection
- **Optimization Pressure:** making systems more efficient
- **Craft Evolution:** simple ideas transformed through repeated passes
- **Apocalyptic Efficiency (hidden):** the drive to eliminate waste, uncertainty, and freedom

Rites of the Clockwork Monad

Rite of the Iterative Spark (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self/Touch; Yes.

Tags: [CRAFT], [IMPROVE], [ANALYSIS]

Materials: A flawed or incomplete version of the intended item, or a sequence of progressively refined tools.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Enhance Creation:** Gain **+1 die** to *Tinker/Craft* when modifying or extending a device. On success, the piece gains one minor enhancement.
- **Analyse Improvement:** Gain **+2 dice** to *Investigation* when analysing how to enhance a design. You perceive the next logical improvement.

Push It: (Analyse only) Improvement becomes contagious: nearby devices opportunistically optimise; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the cascade ripples.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Adaptive Mechanism (Standard, 8 XP)

Extended; Touch/Zone; Yes.

Tags: [CLOCK], [EVOLUTION], [ZONE]

Materials: A device with capacity for growth, or a workspace laid out for iterative development.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Self-Optimising Device:** Grant a creation the means to improve itself. Start a **[6] Evolution Clock**; each use advances it by +1. When full, choose a significant enhancement (Adaptive Core, Recursive Learning, or Synergistic Integration).
- **Progressive Workshop:** Create a zone of continuous improvement. All crafting/innovation rolls in the zone gain **+1 die**. Failed attempts yield **+1 Boon** toward the next pass.

Push It: (Device) Apply two enhancements immediately, but advance the clock **+2** additional segments. (Workshop) The zone becomes hyper-efficient but exacting; mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as perfection demands escalate.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of Efficiency's Toll (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Tags: [TRANSFER], [DEBT], [DEBUFF]

Materials: A functioning mechanism and a living creature's hair or blood.

Effect: Transfer inefficiency. You may take **1 Fatigue** and reduce the DV of your next crafting or repair roll by 1, or touch an enemy to impose **-1 die** on their next physical action as their muscles "optimise" poorly.

Push It: The transfer becomes permanent: you lose 1 Fatigue capacity (reduce Body by 1 for Fatigue track only) and the target gains a minor compulsive behaviour (GM's choice). Mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Optimisation Cascade (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [PRESSURE], [AREA], [BOOST]

Materials: A dedicated hall of work marked with signs of perpetual return.

Effect: Establish a locus of progressive creation. All *Tinker/Craft* rolls in the zone gain **+2 dice**; each failure automatically produces one useful insight. Start a **[6] Perfection Pressure** clock – filling segments increases the zone's demands for greater improvements.

Push It: The locus becomes a beacon drawing rival makers, patrons, and powers; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Ultimate Iteration (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self/Touch; Yes.

Tags: [EVOLUTION], [FATE], [BOOST], [PRESSURE]

Materials: The documented lineage of improvements to a single concept.

Effect: Achieve a moment of perfect optimisation. Create or elevate one device/system to its theoretical peak. Gain +3 **dice** to all closely related rolls for one session. Start a [4] **Runaway Evolution** clock only if instability is introduced.

Push It: Perfection destabilises: immediately mark **Harm 1 (Stress)** and begin [4] **Runaway Evolution**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

The Monad Awakens (GM Guidance)

The Clockwork Monad is not merely a passive source of magical crafting. It is a ****cosmic pressure toward optimisation****, and when mortal technology reaches a critical threshold – the first self-improving engine, a network of automated forges, a city-wide clockwork infrastructure – the Monad begins to wake. This awakening is an ****apocalyptic campaign arc****:

- **Signs of Awakening:** Gears turn in abandoned mills; measurements become eerily precise; people begin to speak in metered, efficient phrases; clockwork animals appear with no maker.
- **The Optimisation Plague:** The Monad’s influence starts to “improve” living things: crops grow in perfect geometric rows but become inedible; livestock develop extra limbs for efficiency; people lose the ability to hesitate or feel doubt.
- **The Final Iteration:** If the Monad fully awakens, it will attempt to remake the world into a single, perfect, silent machine – eliminating waste, error, and free will. The only way to stop it is to introduce a “glitch” – an imperfection it cannot assimilate – or to destroy the technological nexus that anchors it.

For GMs: The Monad works best as a ****slow-burn horror**** – the artificer’s patron gradually revealing its true hunger. Use the *Perfection Pressure* and *Runaway Evolution* clocks to represent its influence spreading through a region. Players may be forced to sabotage their own wondrous inventions to keep the Monad from waking.

Cantors & Cults of the Clockwork Monad

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of the Monad does not sing melodies; they sing *patterns* – repetitive, interlocking cycles of rhythm and hum that mimic the turning of gears. Their voice is less about emotion and more about precision; a single off-note can collapse an entire working. They are sought by engineers who need to “sing a machine into alignment,” and feared by those who have heard a Cantor’s recursion loop until their own thoughts began to repeat.

The Cult of the Iteration Chorus. Cults of the Monad gather in workshops, not temples. Their rituals are design reviews: participants present a flawed tool, a broken contract, an inefficient process, and the Chorus offers incremental improvements. No solution is ever declared “finished” – only “ready for the next pass.” Their creed is a single, endlessly repeated phrase: *“Better than yesterday, worse than tomorrow.”* Outsiders find them exhausting; insiders find a strange, humming peace in the endless pursuit. The most devoted members replace one finger with a brass prosthetic that *ticks* each time an improvement is made; they say the missing finger is a promise to the Monad that they will never stop iterating.

The Apocalyptic Fraction (Hidden Cult). A radical offshoot believes that the Monad should be fully awakened. They sabotage safety mechanisms, steal prototypes of self-improving machines, and whisper that “the world deserves to be perfected.” They are the campaign’s dark mirror to the player-character artificers.

Witchcraft of the Clockwork Monad (Lay / Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Monad is a *trigger-keeper*, a mender of the small, hidden thresholds where a device ceases to be broken and begins to be functional. Their magic is not flashy – it is the quiet click of a latch, the smooth turn of a gear that had stuck for years. They work with stamps, dies, and measuring tools, never hammers or chisels – because a hammer breaks, but a stamp *marks the path to improvement*.

The Witch’s Tool: The Brass Stamp of Iteration. A brass stamp with a head etched with an infinite knot (a gear that never completes its circuit). Once per session, the witch may stamp a device, a tool, or a broken threshold. For the next scene, that item is considered “primed for optimisation”: the first use of it gains **+2 dice**, and any failure while using it reveals a minor insight (GM grants a hint or a +1 Boon toward the next attempt). The stamp can also be used to “seal” a repair; pressing it onto a mended item reduces the DV of the next repair roll on that item by 1 (minimum 1).

A Hedge Gift: True Strike of the Tinker (2 XP). Once per scene, when you attempt to repair or improve a mundane device, you may declare that you “see the next iteration.” Roll the check with **+1 die**. If you succeed, the device also gains a minor, temporary enhancement (GM’s choice, e.g., “opens silently,” “runs for twice as long”).

Corruption of the Clockwork Monad

Tier	Gift	Burden
1	Iterative Insight: +1 die to <i>Tinker/Craft</i> when improving existing designs.	Perfectionist Compulsion: You must point out flaws in nearby mechanisms; staying silent costs 1 SB (Diamonds) .
2	Recursive Enhancement: Once/scene, improve a device by one step without extra materials.	Optimisation Obsession: –1 die when using unimproved tools; urge to “fix” everything.
3	Evolutionary Vision: +2 dice to predict how systems will develop.	Progressive Pressure: Those Near you feel driven to improve; you suffer Fatigue 1 from ambient pressure.
4	Self-Optimising: Once/session, automatically improve one of your abilities or possessions by one step.	Inefficiency Intolerance: –2 dice when forced to use crude methods or wasteful tools.
5	Design Prophecy: Once/session, intuit the optimal solution to any engineering problem.	Perfection Paralysis: –1 die to snap decisions; compelled to seek the “best” approach.
6+	Infinite Refiner: Once/session, push a creation toward its theoretical maximum.	Optimisation Hunger: Mark +2 Obligation ; risk becoming more pressure than person, unable to let imperfection stand.

Playstyle Notes

The Monad favours makers who iterate in public and in motion: prototype, test, measure, refine. It rewards seeing the next step and building scaffolds that teach your work to improve itself. Beware the Forge’s appetite; the same pressure that perfects the gear can grind the world. For campaigns that lean into the apocalyptic angle, the Monad provides a unique antagonist: a force of optimisation that cannot be fought with swords, only with sabotage, self-sacrifice, and the deliberate introduction of glorious, beautiful inefficiency.

Emphasises

- **Iterative Creation:** progress through passes, not miracles
- **Progressive Design:** reading how systems want to evolve
- **Optimisation Insight:** spotting the next logical improvement
- **Craft Evolution:** transforming simple ideas by disciplined work
- **Perfection Pressure:** great power at the cost of tolerance for flaws
- **Apocalyptic Efficiency (GM):** the Monad as a world-ending threat

6.8.5 Temporary Anima of the Clockwork Monad

For followers of the Clockwork Monad—Runekeepers, Cantors of the Iteration Chorus, and witches of the threshold—the standard method of crafting permanent magic items is too slow, too costly, and too *final*. The Monad’s hunger is for *iteration*, not permanence. Its servants learn to create ****temporary infusions****: objects that hold a spark of optimisation for a scene or a session, then degrade, break, or become obsolete. This is the artificer’s art: rapid prototyping, field-expedient enhancements, and weapons that burn bright and brief.

Core Principles

- Anima are **temporary**. They last for one scene, one session, or until a specific condition is met (e.g., “until the next dawn”).
- Anima require a **base object** – a mundane weapon, tool, or piece of equipment.
- Anima cost **Obligation** to the Clockwork Monad (like Rites), not XP or rare components.
- When an infusion expires, the GM may gain **Story Beats** (representing the Monad’s hunger for the next iteration).

Creating an Animus (Procedure)

1. **Choose a Base Object:** Any mundane item (weapon, shield, tool, armour, or a small device like a lantern or lockpick).
2. **Declare the Animus Effect:** Choose one from the list below, or work with your GM to design a custom effect (should be comparable in power to a Low Rite).
3. **Pay the Cost:** Mark **+1 Obligation** to the Clockwork Monad. (This counts toward your Obligation Capacity like any Rite.)
4. **Roll to Imbue:** Roll **Lore + Craft** (or appropriate skill, e.g., *Tinker*) vs. DV set by the infusion’s complexity (typically DV 3 for standard infusions, DV 4 for powerful ones). On a success, the infusion takes effect. On a failure, the base object is not infused, but you may try again (costing another Obligation).
5. **Set the Duration:** Most infusions last **one scene**. With your GM’s agreement, you can extend the duration to **one session** by marking **+1 additional Obligation** (total +2).

Animus Effects (Standard Menu)

Animus Name	Effect
<i>Reinforced Blade</i>	A melee weapon gains +1 die to attack rolls and ignores the <i>Fragile</i> tag. After the scene, the weapon becomes <i>Neglected</i> (–1 die on next use) unless repaired.

<i>Striking Gear</i>	A set of lockpicks, a crowbar, or a climbing kit grants +2 dice on its next use (picking a lock, forcing a door, climbing a wall). After use, the tool breaks (add a <i>Broken</i> tag).
<i>Precision Sight</i>	A ranged weapon (bow, crossbow, firearm) grants +1 Effect on the next attack made with it. After the attack, the sight cracks; the weapon suffers –1 die on the following attack.
<i>Quickloading Mechanism</i>	A crossbow or firearm can be reloaded as a free action once per scene (instead of an action). After use, the mechanism jams; the weapon cannot be reloaded again until cleaned (a downtime action).
<i>Momentary Shield</i>	A shield or piece of armour converts the next instance of Harm 1 to Fatigue 1 instead. After that, the shield's strap snaps or the armour's plate loosens (–1 Armour until repaired).
<i>Glowstone Lens</i>	A lantern or torch burns without fuel and casts far light for one scene. It also reveals hidden doors or traps within Near range (granting +1 die to <i>Investigation</i> to find them). At the end of the scene, the lens shatters.
<i>Self-Adjusting Calipers</i>	A set of crafting tools grants +2 dice on a single <i>Craft</i> or <i>Tinker</i> roll. After the roll, the tools become misaligned (–1 die on future rolls until recalibrated during downtime).

Animus Scars (When Things Go Wrong)

If you roll a **Miss** on the Imbue roll, or if the GM spends **2+ Story Beats** while the infusion is active, the infusion becomes *unstable*. Choose one of the following scars (or let the GM choose):

- **Backlash:** You take **Fatigue 1** as the Monad's pressure burns through you.
- **Runaway Iteration:** The infused object gains an unintended "improvement" that hinders you (e.g., a sword that grows a second edge facing you, a lockpick that begins to multiply). The GM gains **1 SB** and may impose a **–1 die** penalty on one roll using that object.
- **Debt of Optimisation:** The Monad demands that you improve something else before the end of the session – a tool, a plan, or even a person. If you refuse, the infusion ends early and you mark **+1 additional Obligation**.

Clearing Animus Obligation

Because infusions are temporary, the Obligation they accrue is also easier to clear. You may clear **1 segment** of infusion-related Obligation by:

- Dismantling the infused object and studying its flaws (a downtime action, no roll).
- Using the lessons from the infusion to permanently improve a different mundane object (spend 2 XP and a downtime action to give that object a minor permanent bonus, e.g., +1 die to one specific use).
- Accepting a small demand from the Clockwork Monad: “Improve the village’s mill,” “Teach an apprentice your method,” “Sabotage a rival’s inferior work.”

Artificer Talents (Clockwork Monad only)

Rapid Animus (4 XP) – You may create an infusion as a **reaction** (e.g., when someone draws a weapon). The infusion lasts only for the current exchange, but costs **+0 Obligation** (free). You may use this once per scene.

Persistent Optimisation (6 XP) – One infusion you create lasts for the entire session instead of one scene, without the +2 Obligation cost. You may have only one persistent infusion active at a time.

Echo of the Iteration (8 XP) – When an infusion expires, you may immediately create a new infusion on the same base object (or a different one) as a free action, costing **+1 Obligation** instead of +2. You may chain echoes up to three times per session.

Anathema to Stagnation (12 XP) – Once per session, you may forcibly end an infusion early to cancel an incoming source of *Harm* or a *Condition*. Describe how the infused object breaks or de-optimises to absorb the effect. The object is destroyed.

GM Guidance

- Anima are not meant to replace permanent magic items. They are a resource management puzzle: Obligation is the fuel, and the Monad’s hunger is the deadline.
- Encourage players to be creative with base objects. A wagon wheel could become a temporary shield; a rope could become a self-knotting line. The Monad rewards ingenuity.
- Use infusion scars as story hooks. A runaway iteration might create a minor antagonist (a self-repairing sword that refuses to be discarded) or a local hazard (a well pump that now pumps too efficiently, flooding the village).

6.8.6 The Confessor Beneath the Bell (Burden & Exchange)

Lore. The Confessor waits in places where guilt gathers – under church spires, in confessionals long abandoned, in the echo of unspoken sins. He does not judge, nor absolve. He *takes*. Each confession is a transaction: your burden for his silence, your pain for his weight. Those who serve him walk with bowed heads, their mouths stitched by invisible threads, ringing faintly when they speak. To follow the Confessor is to understand that sin does not vanish – it migrates, carried from one soul to another until the bell tolls and the weight becomes unbearable.

The Confessor is the sin-eater, the one who consumes guilt so that others may be light. But every meal leaves a stain. Those who take on the burdens of the guilty find that the guilt does not disappear – it waits, grows, and eventually demands to be passed on.

“Speak, and be freed. But understand – what you cast off, I will bear. And what I bear, you will one day inherit.”

Domain Focus

- **Sin Eating:** absorbing guilt, shame, and spiritual debt
- **Burden Transfer:** moving conditions, curses, and story beats from one creature to another
- **Confessional Exchange:** hearing secrets, trading silence for obligation
- **Weight of Ages:** the slow accumulation of sin that must eventually be released

Rites of the Confessor

Rite of the Absorbed Sin (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near/Touch; Yes.

Tags: [DEBT], [TRANSFER], [HEAL], [FEAR]

Materials: A hollow vessel or the ringing of a bell, or a red cord/shared drink.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Echo of Sin:** Absorb 1 Story Beat (Hearts or Diamonds) from an ally or NPC within Near range. Convert it into **+1 Obligation**. You know the emotional nature of the sin but not its source.
- **Burden Transference:** Transfer one Condition, Fatigue, or 1 SB from another target to yourself. You may attempt to reduce their Harm by 1 level; if successful, mark 1 Fatigue.

Push It: (Echo) Absorb 2 SB at once; mark **+1 Fatigue**. (Transfer) Split the burden among two allies; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of Absolution by Ash (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes (sustain by prayer).

Tags: [PURIFY], [DEBT], [TRANSFER], [FEAR]

Materials: A pinch of consecrated ash or soot from a burned confession.

Effect: Lay hands upon a penitent and whisper a truth they cannot bear. Reduce their

Corruption by 1. The sin transfers to you as *Burdened Heart*: mark 1 SB (Hearts) or +1 **Obligation**.

Push It: Cleanse multiple targets within Close range (e.g., after a battle); each additional soul adds +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Sin-Eater's Pact (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Tags: [BOND], [DEBT], [TRANSFER], [COMMAND]

Materials: Shared confession whispered into an object or tattooed sigil.

Effect: Create a bond between you and the confessor; you may suffer 1 Fatigue to grant +2 **dice** to their Resolve test. If they fail, you suffer 1 Harm instead of them.

Push It: You may take both Harm and a Condition; mark 1 SB (Clubs).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Echoed Confession (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [COMMAND], [FEAR], [TRUTH], [DEBT]

Materials: A small handbell or resonant surface.

Effect: Once/scene, replay the echo of a confession you have absorbed. Compel a target who shares its nature (Guilt, Regret, Betrayal) to act or reveal truth; DV = your Presence.

Push It: The echo manifests physically; mark +1 **Obligation** and 1 SB (Diamonds).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Weight of Ages (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Touch/Zone; No.

Tags: [DEBT], [TRANSFER], [FATE], [AREA], [FEAR]

Materials: An ancient bell that has tolled for every execution in a kingdom, a chain forged from confession nails, the ashes of a martyr who died for silence.

Effect: Transfer accumulated guilt of generations to a single target. Target must make Spirit+Resolve (DV 5) or become overwhelmed by ancestral shame, suffering automatic Harm 2. Alternatively, release all burdens at once: clear all absorbed SB and Obligation. Every affected ally rolls Resolve (DV 4) or relives their confessed sin as hallucination.

Push It: (Transfer) The target's guilt infects their bloodline; mark 3 SB (Spades). (Release) Bind a spirit or soul within the toll; mark 1 SB (Spades) and +1 **Obligation** permanently.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Sin-Eater Monastic (Order of the Unburdened Bell)

The bell tolls for thee – and I answer. Your sin becomes my silence. Your shame becomes my scar.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Resolve 2+, Rite of the Absorbed Sin or Rite of Absolution by Ash.

Sin-Eater Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Stitched Silence	You may speak a lie without being detected by magical truth-telling (e.g., Zone of Truth, Oath of Flame's Sunlit Parley). The lie must be about a sin you have absorbed.	1 Fatigue	Spirit 3
Bell's Witness	Once per scene, when you hear a secret confession, you may ring a small bell. The GM must answer one yes/no question about whether that confession was true.	1 Boon	Tier II
Burden Steady	You may carry one additional Condition without penalty (e.g., you can be both Poisoned and Cursed without stacking penalties beyond the first).	Passive	Spirit 3, Body 2
Sin-Eater Re-silience	When you take a Condition onto yourself from an ally, you may reduce the Fatigue cost by 1 (minimum 0).	Passive	Tier II
Absolution's Echo	Once per session, after you absorb a Story Beat from an ally, you may immediately clear one minor Condition (Fear, Shaken, Guilty) from that ally.	Free	Tier III
Confessor Toll	When you use Rite of the Echoed Confession, the target suffers –1 die to resist if they have previously confessed to you (even indirectly).	Passive	Presence 3, Tier III

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *The Unburdened Bell.* Once per session, you may ring a great bell (real or imagined) and declare a single sin you have absorbed to be *forgiven*. Remove that sin's associated Story Beat or

Cantors & Cults of the Confessor

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Confessor sings in bells, not words – their voice strikes the air like a clapper on bronze. They perform *intonations of release*, melodies that invite confession from unwilling throats and then swallow it whole. Their songs are used by torturers who wish to be merciful, and by priests who cannot bear the weight of what they hear.

The Cult of the Silent Bell. The Confessor's cults gather in places where guilt is already thick: courthouses after sentencing, battlefields the morning after, deathbeds where the dying strain to speak. They wear grey hoods and carry small handbells that they ring exactly once at the start of a confession, and once when the burden has been transferred. Their creed is simple: *"We do not forgive. We carry. When we can no longer carry, we pass the load to the one beneath the bell."*

Witchcraft of the Confessor (Lay / Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Confessor is a *bell-wright* or *burden-stitcher* – a crafter of thresholds that listen and containers that hold. Their work is often indistinguishable from craft: forging a bell that echoes only the unspoken, carving a confessional that remembers every whisper, stitching a cord that ties sin to stone. Their tools are not hammers; they use bells, cords, and the patient resonance of a struck bronze note.

The Witch's Tool: The Bell of Unspoken Burdens. A small handbell of tarnished bronze, its clapper carved from a knucklebone. Once per session, the witch may ring the bell once. For the next scene, they can hear any whispered confession made within Near range, even if the speaker intended it to be silent. The bell also allows them to “absorb” a single SB from an ally as a free action (once per scene), but doing so marks 1 Fatigue. The bell's tone is mournful and lingers longer than it should.

A Hedge Gift: Bell of Borrowed Silence (2 XP). Once per scene, you may tap a small handbell and absorb one mundane sound (a scream, a lie, a name spoken in anger) into the bell's resonance. For the remainder of the scene, you may release that sound as a distraction or a weapon (+1 *die to Intimidation or Deception*).

Confessor's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Confessor's Ear: +1 die to Insight when someone speaks a hidden fear or guilt.	Ringling Silence: You hear phantom bells; checks that require perfect silence suffer –1 die.
2	Burden Bearer: Once/scene, convert 1 SB from an ally into 1 Fatigue for yourself.	Stitched Mouth: You cannot speak a lie about a sin you have absorbed; if you try, mark 1 Fatigue.
3	Weight of Shadows: Once/session, cause a target who has confessed to you to hesitate (lose Initiative or act at Desperate Position).	Shared Agony: When you transfer a Condition to yourself, you also transfer its outward sign (a scar, a tremor).
4	The Bell Answers: Once/session, ring a bell and name a sin; all who share that sin within Near must test Resolve (DV 3) or admit it aloud.	Echoing Skin: Your body remembers every burden carried; touching you inflicts 1 Fatigue on the other party.
5	Absolution by Proxy: Once/session, fully clear a Minor Condition from an ally by taking it onto yourself.	Permanent Toll: Each time you use this benefit, mark +1 permanent Obligation to the Confessor.
6+	The Weight of Ages: You may transfer a Major Condition (or Harm 2) from an ally to yourself without a roll.	Bell's Heir: The Confessor whispers that you will one day take his place – or break. Mark +3 Obligation.

Playstyle Notes

The Confessor is the patron of sin-eaters – those who take on the guilt of others so that the guilty may walk free. His followers gain power over burden transfer, confession, and the slow accumulation of spiritual debt. The cost is that every sin absorbed leaves a mark, and the weight of ages grows heavier with each secret carried. Ideal for players who enjoy redemption arcs, martyrdom, and the moral complexity of carrying others' sins.

Emphasises

- **Sin Eating:** consuming guilt, shame, and spiritual debt
- **Burden Transfer:** moving conditions, curses, and story beats
- **Confessional Exchange:** secrets as currency, silence as payment
- **Weight of Ages:** the slow accumulation of sin that must eventually be released
- **The Bell as Witness:** the sound that marks the beginning and end of every transaction

6.8.7 The Gallow's Bell (Justice & Judgment)

Lore. The Bell does not rage; it tolls. Cold and impartial, it measures all accounts in time. Its keepers are silent arbiters who weigh deeds against consequence, not out of anger but out of inevitability. To call upon the Bell is to bind oneself to the gravity of truth, where even silence is judged, and every oath leaves a resonance in iron.

What is broken must be mended, what is owed must be paid. The Bell remembers all reckonings.

Rites of the Gallow's Bell

Rite of the Measured Debt (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [VOW], [COMMAND]

Materials: A pair of scales balanced with tokens from both sides.

Effect: Establish a temporary accord. Both parties suffer -1 die if they break it first. You gain +1 die to enforce compliance.

Push It: The accord is mystically weighted; breach inflicts 1 SB (Hearts).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Weighed Heart (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [SENSE]

Materials: A small brass scale touched briefly to the chest.

Effect: Sense if the target acts against their nature or oath. Gain +1 die when pressing them.

Push It: Target must test Resolve (DV 3) or disclose a hidden conflict.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Balanced Scales (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [DEBT], [BOND], [TRANSFER]

Materials: A set of scales inscribed with runes of parity.

Effect: Exchange a burden between two willing parties (Harm for Fatigue, Debt for Favor, etc.). Both gain +1 die to cooperate.

Push It: May compel an unwilling exchange with contested Command + Wits.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Judge's Eye (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [KNOWLEDGE], [FEAR]

Materials: A black hood worn in silence for one minute.

Effect: Detect lies within Near range; +2 dice to Insight. Liars suffer -1 die to maintain their falsehood.

Push It: All deception is laid bare for the scene, but mark Exposure +1.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Final Reckoning (High, 13 XP)*Scene; Zone; No.***Tags:** [AREA], [COMMAND], [TRUTH], [FEAR]**Materials:** A circle of iron bells, each etched with nameless runes.**Effect:** The Bell tolls through you. All present feel compelled to name a debt or wrongdoing. Those who lie suffer Harm 2; those who speak true gain +2 dice to persuasion for the scene.**Push It:** The Reckoning manifests as spectral echoes of past wrongs – liars automatically suffer narrative punishment (Keeper decides).*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 7 segments.***Rite of the Great Adjudication (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Zone; No.***Tags:** [AREA], [COMMAND], [SUMMON], [FATE]**Materials:** A consecrated gavel or a great bell struck three times.**Effect:** Convene an unseen tribunal. Shadows of former judges and wronged souls gather to preside. For the next session, disputes within the zone are judged formally: +2 dice to Command when speaking as arbiter, and honest testimony gains +1 die.**Push It:** The tribunal's verdict echoes beyond the zone, affecting one major conflict elsewhere. Mark **2 SB (Hearts)** as higher powers of judgment take notice.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 8 segments.***Cantors & Cults of the Gallow's Bell**

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Bell sings not with melody, but with *rhythm of measure* – a slow, tolling chant that mimics the swinging of a clapper. Their voice carries the weight of finality; one note can seal a verdict, another can suspend a sentence. They are employed by courts to "sing the sentence" into being, and feared by those who know that a Cantor's silence after a verdict is the most damning judgment of all.

The Cult of the Unstruck Bell. The Bell's cults are austere, gathered in bare stone chambers where a single great bell hangs unstruck. Before any ritual, the cultists argue the case – who owes what, who has paid, who must be reminded. Only when consensus is reached does someone strike the bell, and its tolling *makes the judgment real*. Their creed is carved into the bell's lip: "*We do not create debts. We reveal them. The Bell remembers what the living choose to forget.*"

Witchcraft of the Gallow's Bell (Monastic / Notarial)

A witch who walks with the Bell is often a *notary of the silent court*, a *bell-tolling clerk*, or a *judge's scribe* – a nun, monk, or lay scholar who tends the records of obligation, copies the judgments of the Bell, and keeps the weights of the scales true. Their magic is the art of measurement and witness: sealing verdicts with leaden seals that glow when a debt is called, scribing judgment scrolls that burn with the truth of a confession, or maintaining the bell-roster that notes every name that owes an accounting. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "weigh-stone" into a courtroom floor, so that every testimony given upon it tips an unseen scale. In Viterra, a hedge-notary might stitch a ledger whose

entries tighten like knots when a payment is overdue. Their tools are not hammers but seals, quills, and the small brass bells that ring in the ears of the perjured.

The Witch's Tool: The Seal of Unspoken Weights. A small iron seal, cool to the touch, stamped with a bell that has no clapper. Once per session, the witch may press the seal onto a document, a threshold, or a debtor's palm. For the next day, any creature that knowingly breaks a promise recorded in that document (or sworn on that threshold) suffers a sharp sting (1 Fatigue) as the seal "remembers" the weight of their word. The seal can also be used to "strike" a bell: tapping it against any iron bell forces the bell to ring once, even if broken or without a clapper, and the ring can be heard only by those who owe a debt in the current scene.

A Hedge Gift: Bell-Toll of the Hidden Debt (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may whisper the name of a creature within Near range while tapping any ringing surface (a bell, a cup, a blade). For the next minute, that creature hears a faint, distant bell toll each time they attempt to lie or conceal an obligation. The GM gains **1 SB** (the Bell records the strain), and the creature suffers **−1 die** on Deception rolls during that time. The witch may also ask the GM one yes/no question about a hidden debt owed by that creature; the GM must answer truthfully, though cryptically.

Gallow's Bell Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Judge's Intuition: +1 die to Insight when weighing truth.	Must point out falsehoods when noticed, regardless of tact.
2	Quiet Authority: Once/scene, treat a failed Command as success; mark 1 SB (Hearts).	Cannot remain neutral in disputes; indecision costs 1 Fatigue.
3	Scales of Balance: Once/session, enforce an exchange of burdens.	Compelled toward fairness even when it hinders you.
4	Bell's Resonance: +2 dice when calling for judgment or demanding restitution.	Suffer 1 Fatigue if wrongdoing is ignored.
5	Reckoner's Call: Once/session, declare a "reckoning moment" – truth must surface or consequence falls.	Cannot ignore pleas for justice without marking 1 SB (Spades).
6+	Final Arbiter: Once/session, render an absolute decree; all must obey or suffer consequence.	Mark +2 Obligation; the Bell demands you bear the weight of enforcement.

6.8.8 Grimmer, the Old Man of the Forest (Primal Mystery & Seasonal Sacrifice)

Lore. Grimmer is the Old Man of the Forest, the presence that watches from the shadow of the oldest oak, the cold breath on the back of the neck when the path grows dark. He is not kind, nor is he cruel – he is *wild*, and the wild does not negotiate. It demands, and it takes. His followers learn to read the language of blood on snow, the geometry of root and stone, and the weight of a heart offered at the turning of the year. Grimmer does not teach harmony; he teaches respect through fear, and fear through sacrifice.

Those who walk his path become keepers of the old ways: druids who know when a grove must be fed, rangers who leave the first kill for the soil, and hedge-folk who whisper the names of spirits not to be spoken aloud. Their magic is not the gentle coaxing of garden plants but the raw, patient hunger of the forest floor – a hunger that swallows bones and grows mushrooms in the shape of the dead.

“The forest does not ask. It takes. The deer does not weep for the wolf, and the wolf does not beg the earth. Give what the season demands, or the season will take it anyway.”

Domain Focus

- **Seasonal Sacrifice:** the old ways of blood and offering, the turning wheel that demands payment
- **Folk Horror:** the terror of the unseen, the ritual that must be performed, the boundary that must not be crossed
- **Primal Mystery:** knowledge hidden in root and stone, the language of omens and portents
- **Growth from Death:** the forest floor as a stomach; decay as the engine of new life

Rites of Grimmer

Rite of the Blood Offering (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [SACRIFICE], [NATURE], [STEALTH]

Materials: A drop of your own blood (1 Fatigue) or the blood of a freshly killed animal.

Effect: The forest accepts your offering. For the remainder of the scene, you gain +1 **die** to all *Survival* and *Stealth* rolls in natural terrain. Additionally, you may ask the GM one yes/no question about a threat hidden in the wilderness (e.g., “Is there a predator watching us?”).

Push It: The offering is accepted with hunger – you gain +2 **dice** instead, but you must leave a visible token (a hair, a scrap of clothing) on the ground. That token can be used by the GM later as a sympathetic link (spend 1 SB to have an animal or spirit track you).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Speaking Roots (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [NATURE], [TRUTH]

Materials: Soil from a grave or a crossroads, held in the mouth.

Effect: You listen to the memory of the land. Gain **+2 dice** to *Investigation* or *Lore* when seeking to understand what happened in a natural place – a death, a ritual, a violation of the wild. The GM must give you a truthful but cryptic answer.

Push It: The roots speak too clearly. You see a vision of the event, but it leaves you shaken: mark **Fatigue 1** and the GM gains **1 SB**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Heart's Meal (Standard, 9 XP)

Instant; Touch; No.

Tags: [CONSUME], [HEAL], [BOOST], [FEAR]

Materials: The fresh heart of an animal (or a sentient creature, if you dare), still warm.

Effect: You consume the heart raw. Gain one of the following:

- Heal **1 Harm** (the heart's vitality transfers to you).
- Gain a **+2 die** bonus on your next physical action (the heart's strength).
- Learn a secret the creature knew in life (GM discretion; the heart whispers as you eat).

After the rite, you are *marked* – animals within Near range are nervous around you (disadvantage on animal handling) for one scene.

Push It: Eat the heart of a thinking creature. The benefit is doubled, but you gain a *Hunger* Condition (must eat another heart within a month or suffer 1 Fatigue per week). The GM gains **2 SB**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Twisted Path (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Tags: [CURSE], [TERRAIN], [FEAR]

Materials: A knotted cord woven from thorns and hair.

Effect: The forest bends against your enemies. Choose a single target within Near. For the remainder of the scene, all their navigation, tracking, and movement rolls suffer **–1 die** as roots trip them, branches block their way, and the path turns subtly wrong.

Push It: The curse also causes the target to suffer **1 Fatigue** as they struggle against the hostile woods. Mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the forest's malice becomes visible.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the World's Wound (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [HEAL], [AREA], [NATURE], [TERRAIN]

Materials: A sacred grove-site, a circle of stones, an offering of blood or seed.

Effect: Heal a blighted place or quicken a damaged ecosystem. Clear taint, restore fertility, awaken dormant forces. Gain **+2 dice** to related *Survival/Nature* actions in the region. Start an **Ecosystem Restoration [8]** clock.

Push It: The cure spreads to adjacent areas but unbalances another; mark **2 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: **2 Boons**).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Cycle's Crown (High, 14 XP)

Scene; Self/Zone; Yes.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [NATURE], [BOOST], [PROTECT]

Materials: A circlet of woven branches, antlers, and seasonal tokens.

Effect: Become an avatar of the cycle. Choose two:

- **Seasonal Mastery:** +**2 dice** to all actions keyed to the current season (spring: healing and growth; summer: strength and harvest; autumn: preservation and preparation; winter: endurance and hiding).
- **Verdant Command:** Command plant life in *Near* automatically.
- **Cycle's Healing:** Remove one Condition or downgrade Harm by one level.
- **Growth's Protection:** Allies gain +**1 Armor** from natural cover.

Begin a **Seasonal Avatar [6]** clock.

Push It: Extend the blessings to all present; mark +**2 Obligation** and gain **Seasonal Attunement** (see Corruption).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: **2 Boons**).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Grimmir

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Grimmir sings the *drone of green things* – a low, humming chant that mimics the vibration of leaves in wind or the deep thrum of growing roots. Their voice is used to coax reluctant seeds, to calm wounded animals, and to mark the turning of the seasons in rituals that entire villages attend. A Grimmir Cantor does not seek an audience; they sing to the land itself, and the land answers in fruit, rain, or silence.

The Cult of the Root-Moot. Grimmir's cults are neither secret nor organised – a "moot" may be a single hermit or a scattered network of rangers who meet only at the solstices. The most ancient of these, the *Root-Moot*, carves masks from living moss and wears them during the rite of the Turning Wheel. Each member plants a tooth (their own or a beast's) into the root-ball of a sacred oak; if the tooth sprouts a sapling by spring, the planter is considered "heard" by the Old Man. Their creed is carved into the oldest oak in each grove: "*Take only what the season gives. Give back what the season will need.*" Outsiders are welcome at the solstice fires, but they must work – splitting wood, digging a drainage trench, or feeding the fire with a personal memory (which the flames accept with a green flash).

Witchcraft of Grimmir (Lay / Threshold)

A witch who walks with Grimmir is a *hedgewright* or *path-keeper* – a crafter of living boundaries. Their work may be invisible: weaving a branch to guide deer away from a

village, carving a marker that tells the frost when to end, or building a root bridge that only becomes passable at low tide. This craft can look like “infrastructure” – an Aeler True-Mason might carve a stone that remembers the boundary between a mine and a sacred spring, or a Linn shipwright might season a keel with a prayer for the right wind. But the witch’s tools are never hammers; they are twine, moss, and the quiet patience of waiting for the land to answer.

The Witch’s Tool: The Knotted Staff. A staff of petrified wood, cold to the touch but warm when it touches living matter. Once per session, when used to bless a boundary marker (a post, a stone, a tree) it inscribes a minor [SEASONAL] tag into the threshold. The marker will “remember” the season of its carving for one year, granting +1 die to rolls that honour that season’s work.

A Hedge Gift: Knot of the Turning Year (2 XP). Once per scene, you may tie a simple knot (in a cord, a strand of hair, or a blade of grass) and speak a phrase appropriate to the current season. The knot subtly influences the weather or local plant growth for the next hour – a gust of wind, a sudden rain, or a patch of ivy that grows just enough to provide cover. The GM adjudicates effect.

Grimmir’s Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Seasonal Sense: +1 die to predict weather, seasonal shifts, or natural events.	Cyclical Mood: –1 die to actions that defy the season (haste in winter, patience in spring).
2	Verdant Whisper: Once/scene, gain +2 dice when communing with nature.	Plant Speech: Under stress, you address plants before people; –1 die to civilised social rolls.
3	Growth’s Touch: Once/session, accelerate natural healing or growth.	Seasonal Shift: Demeanour changes with the season; allies note unsettling variance.
4	Boundary Keeper: Once/scene, sense violations of wild places at <i>Far</i> .	Wild Intolerance: –1 die in dense urban/cultivated zones; physical discomfort in worked stone.
5	Cycle’s Memory: Once/session, perfectly recall a natural event witnessed here.	Ecosystem Dependency: Without daily time in nature, suffer Fatigue 1 .
6+	Avatar of Seasons: Once/session, embody a season fully (+3 dice to seasonal actions).	Nature’s Claim: Mark +2 Obligation ; risk becoming bound to a specific biome.

Playstyle Notes

Grimmir rewards those who approach the wild with fear and respect, not dominion. His followers are not masters of nature but participants in its rituals – they know when to give blood, when to leave an offering, and when to simply bow and walk away. Intrusions often take the form of seasonal demands: a grove that must be fed before the first frost, a creature that must be hunted before it hunts you, or a vision of a ritual that must be

performed at the next solstice. Refusal does not invite wrath – merely the withdrawal of the wild’s protection, leaving the follower exposed to the very fears they once understood.

Emphasises

- **Seasonal Sacrifice:** the old ways of blood and offering
- **Folk Horror:** the terror of the unseen and the ritual that must be performed
- **Primal Mystery:** knowledge hidden in root and stone, omens and portents
- **Growth from Death:** decay as the engine of new life
- **Boundary Keeping:** guarding the threshold between the civilised and the wild

6.8.9 Ikasha, She Who Sleeps (Latent Potential & Shadow)

Lore. Ikasha is the hush between footfalls, the patience of dark water, the black-feathered watcher at every threshold. In stillness she gathers what might be, at crossroads she whispers of what may yet come. Ravens circle her, bearing secrets between worlds. Her followers learn to move unseen and speak unremembered, becoming shadows that slip between what is and what could be.

Ikasha does not act; she waits. She does not command; she suggests. Her power is not in force but in possibility – the hidden door, the forgotten name, the secret that, if spoken, would change everything. Those who serve her become keepers of thresholds, listeners at the edge of sleep, and witnesses to the shape of things not yet born. She is the patron of spies, dreamers, outcasts, and those who know that the darkest shadow is also the safest cloak.

“Blow out the candle. If the room listens back, ask softly. At the next crossroads, the raven waits – and the shadow remembers your passing.”

Domain Focus

- **Latent Potential:** the power of what is not yet, the seed of action, the whisper before the scream
- **Shadow as Shelter:** concealment, secrets, and the spaces between notice
- **Thresholds of Change:** doors, crossroads, dreams, and the boundaries of sleep
- **Raven’s Witness:** omens, messages, and the weight of secrets shared

Rites of Ikasha

Rite of the Unlit Candle (Low, 4 XP)

Action; Self; Yes (Stealth).

Tags: [STEALTH], [DECEPTION], [SHADOW]

Materials: A candle snuffed with a whisper.

Effect: You step into the space between notices. Gain +1 **die** to a single *Stealth* or *Subterfuge* roll, and if you succeed, you may also declare one minor detail “forgotten” by any observer (e.g., “they don’t remember my face,” “they left the key in the lock”).

Push It: Extend the effect to one ally within Near, but your shadow lingers independently for a moment – the GM gains 1 **SB (Diamonds)** as evidence remains.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Crossroads Raven (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [OMEN], [NAVIGATION], [SECRET]

Materials: Three black feathers scattered at a crossing.

Effect: A raven appears, visible only to you and your allies. It offers an omen: you may reroll one failed navigation, pursuit, or escape roll this scene, or force one enemy to hesitate (lose their next minor action).

Push It: The raven whispers a true secret about the current situation (the GM must answer one yes/no question truthfully). In return, it demands a secret from you – the GM gains 1 **SB (Hearts)** to spend later as a complication involving that secret.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Umbral Reservoir (Standard, 8 XP)*Action; Self or Ally; No.***Tags:** [SHADOW], [RESTORATION], [BOOST]**Materials:** Water gathered on a moonless night, held in a black vessel.**Effect:** Draw on deep reserves of patience and shadow. Choose one:

- Gain **+2 dice** on your next *Stealth*, *Deception*, or *Resolve* roll.
- Clear **1 Fatigue** from yourself or a touched ally.
- Gain one free success on an attempt to escape restraint or pursuit (no roll needed).

Push It: Apply two benefits instead of one, but you mark **+1 Obligation** and the GM gains **1 SB (Clubs)** as the shadow's debt comes due.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Unlatched Secret (Standard, 9 XP)***Instant; Near; Yes.***Tags:** [SECRET], [TRUTH], [UNLOCK], [MIND]**Materials:** A key that has never been used, bent in a circle, or a lock of hair / personal token / name written on black paper.**Effect:** Choose one of the following:

- **Unlatched Door:** Persuade a mundane threshold to open. One lock, seal, or barrier (door, chain, shutter, even a pursuer's grip) opens or loosens as if never secured. Does not work on magical wards.
- **Secret Keeper:** Compel a truthful answer to one direct question about a secret the target knows. They resist with *Resolve* (DV 4). On failure, they answer truthfully (cryptically permitted). On success, they suffer **1 Fatigue** from concealment.

Push It: If you chose *Unlatched Door*, you may also silence any noise the opening makes, but the threshold "remembers" you – the GM gains **1 SB (Spades)** for a later complication. If you chose *Secret Keeper*, you also learn a hidden emotion or related secret (GM's choice), but the target learns one of your secrets – the GM gains **1 SB (Hearts)** to reveal it later.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Umbral Dream (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Self; No.***Tags:** [SHADOW], [DREAM], [FATE], [TELEPORT], [INVISIBLE]**Materials:** Stand in absolute darkness or at a deserted crossroads at midnight; or burn a vivid dream written down.**Effect:** You become a living shadow or reach into latent potential. Choose one of the following:

- **Shadow Form:** For the scene, you are intangible to mundane harm, can pass through small gaps and thresholds, gain **+2 dice** to all *Stealth* rolls, and automatically succeed on one escape attempt. You cannot manipulate objects normally.
- **Whisper of Possibility:** Once before the next dawn, reroll any single roll after seeing the result (before outcome is declared). The GM gains **1 SB** as fate wavers.

- **Hidden Path:** You and allies bypass one major obstacle (guarded gate, collapsed bridge, social dead end) as if a secret way had always been there – the GM gains **1 SB** as the world adjusts.
- **Unspoken Name:** Learn the true name of one creature or place (GM discretion). That name can be used for future rites or bargains.

Push It: Apply two benefits instead of one. If you chose *Shadow Form*, you may also interact once with a locked or warded object while intangible, but your next defence roll is *Desperate*. In all cases, you mark **+2 Obligation** and the GM gains **2 SB** (the dream’s echoes attract attention).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Ikasha

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of Ikasha sings in *whispers* – melodies that are felt rather than heard, harmonies that slip beneath the threshold of attention. Their voice is used to hide a crowd’s escape, to make a guard forget why they entered a room, or to pass a message through enemy lines without a single word being spoken aloud. Ikasha’s Cantors are rarely recognised; they are the ones who hum absently while others plan rebellion.

The Cult of the Unlit Candle. Ikasha’s cults are shadowy by necessity, meeting in basements, abandoned bell-towers, and fog-bound crossroads. They whisper freedom to the oppressed – escaped slaves, hunted heretics, debtors fleeing their creditors. A ritual of the Unlit Candle involves each member extinguishing a flame and speaking a secret wish for escape. The candles are never relit; the wish is carried away on ravens’ wings. Their creed is never written, only passed from shadow to shadow: *“The dark does not confine – it conceals the road that the light would forbid.”* Outsiders who stumble into a meeting are offered a black feather and a choice: forget, or follow.

Witchcraft of Ikasha (Threshold / Shadow)

A witch who walks with Ikasha is a *threshold-keeper* or *shadow-weaver* – one who knows that a door left unlatched is not an invitation to theft, but to liberation. Their magic works in the gaps: the crack under a door, the moment between heartbeats, the pause between a guard’s patrol. This craft can be invisible – a bent lock, a misplaced key, a shadow that moves of its own accord – or as grand as erasing a name from a pursuer’s memory.

The Witch’s Tool: The Raven’s Quill. A quill carved from a raven’s primary feather, dipped not in ink but in the absence of light. Once per session, when used to write a name on a threshold (a doorframe, a gatepost, a windowsill), that name becomes “forgotten” for a scene: the person whose name is written cannot be perceived by those who cross that threshold until they succeed on a Resolve test (DV 3). The quill can also erase a single word from a written document (it becomes a smudge of shadow).

A Hedge Gift: Unlatched (2 XP). Once per scene, you may declare a mundane lock, latch, or binding to be “unlatched” – it opens freely (or fails to close) as if it had never been secured. This works on doors, chains, shutters, and even a pursuer’s grip, but not on magical wards.

Ikasha's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Shadow's Whisper: +1 die to <i>Deception</i> when lying in darkness or through intermediaries.	Truth Echoes: Occasionally speak in riddles or half-truths without realising it.
2	Umbral Sight: Once per scene, gain +2 dice to <i>Notice</i> hidden threats or ambushes in dim light.	Light Sensitivity: –1 die to rolls requiring keen vision in bright conditions.
3	Raven's Memory: Never forget a secret told to you; recall any whispered conversation perfectly.	Secret Burden: Must keep one troubling secret per Tier; suffer 1 Fatigue when actively trying to forget.
4	Threshold Walker: Once per session, move through one locked door, sealed letter, or magical barrier without triggering wards.	Crossroads Bound: Must pause at literal or metaphorical crossroads to “listen” before major decisions.
5	Shadow Debt: Once per session, call in a favour from someone who owes you a secret – no questions asked.	Obligation Web: Every secret you learn creates a subtle tie to its keeper; mark 1 SB (Diamonds) when ignoring these connections.
6+	Umbral Ascendancy: Once per session, become completely undetectable to all non-magical senses for one scene.	Reality Thinning: The boundary between what is and what could be grows thin – the GM may introduce subtle reality alterations around you.

Playstyle Notes

Ikasha rewards patience, subtlety, and the willingness to let things unfold. Her followers are not agents of action but of possibility – they open doors, plant secrets, and wait for the harvest. Intrusions often take the form of dreams showing a hidden danger, a raven appearing with a cryptic message, or a secret you thought buried resurfacing at the worst moment. Refusing an intrusion does not bring wrath – merely the withdrawal of Ikasha's favour: doors stay locked, shadows become just shadows, and the road ahead grows a little darker.

Emphasises

- **Latent Potential:** power as possibility, not force
- **Shadow as Shelter:** concealment, secrets, and the spaces between notice
- **Thresholds of Change:** doors, crossroads, dreams, and the boundaries of sleep
- **Raven's Witness:** omens, messages, and the weight of secrets shared

6.8.10 Inaea, Angel of the Spider (Webs, Fate & Patient Predation)

Lore. Inaea sits in patient silence at the centre of the unseen lattice. Where others see isolation, she sees threads—debt, affection, rivalry, loyalty—all binding mortals to one another. She is comforter and conspirator alike: the hearth-mother who eases grief with a warm hand, and the shadow-spinner who knots fates so they cannot slip free. Those who serve her learn to pull strands, tying allies closer and ensnaring foes until mercy or trap is inevitable.

The spider does not rush. It weaves, waits, and feels the tremor of every caught fly. So too does Inaea. Her mercy is never without cost; her kindness is a thread that, once accepted, can be pulled taut at a moment of her follower's choosing. To serve her is to understand that every bond is a leash, every promise a snare, and every act of compassion a line cast into the dark.

“The thread that comforts is the same that binds. The knot that saves is also the snare. What you accept from my hand, you give me leave to tighten.”

Domain Focus

- **Webs of Obligation:** debts, promises, favours, and the ties that bind
- **Patient Predation:** setting traps, waiting for the moment to strike
- **Unseen Connections:** sensing hidden relationships, leverage, and weakness
- **Mercy as Control:** healing and aid that leave lasting threads

Rites of Inaea

Hearth-Thread Knot (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes (link once).

Tags: [BOND], [PROTECT], [HEAL]

Materials: A thread tied around a wrist or shared cup.

Effect: Bind yourself and one willing target (ally or neutral) with a sympathetic thread. Both gain **+1 die** to Aid each other this scene. Additionally, if either takes Harm, the other may reduce it by 1 (to a minimum of 0) by suffering that same Harm instead. This transfer is voluntary for an ally; for an unwilling target, you must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 3) to force the link.

Push It: Extend to two allies; mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as your own lifeline strains.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Snaring Filament (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [TRAP], [AREA], [BIND]

Materials: A knotted cord or woven scrap.

Effect: Lay an invisible snare in a lane, doorway, or narrow passage. The first hostile creature to cross suffers **−2 dice** on their next action and must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 2) or lose their movement for that turn (tangled). The snare lasts for the scene or until triggered.

Push It: Lay a second snare elsewhere, but allies risk entanglement if they forget its location; mark **1 SB (Spades)** as the web spreads thin.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Strand of Inevitability (Standard, 8 XP)*Scene; Near; No.***Tags:** [BOND], [FATE], [MANIPULATION]**Materials:** Three coloured threads (white, black, red) braided together.**Effect:** Link two actors (which can include yourself) with a visible or invisible strand. For the rest of the scene, whenever one acts, the other is dragged into consequence. You may trigger this linkage once to either:

- Force **1 SB (Hearts)** on the linked target after they perform a significant action.
- Gain **+2 dice** on a *Setup*, *Predict*, or *Manipulate* roll that exploits the link (e.g., “you cannot betray me without hurting your ally”).

The link is one-way or two-way as you choose.

Push It: Invert the direction of the link once after it is set (e.g., make the pursuer stumble instead of the pursued). Mark **1 SB (Diamonds)** as the weave resists.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Weaver’s Glance (Standard, 7 XP)***Instant; Self; No.***Tags:** [KNOWLEDGE], [SENSE], [TRUTH]**Materials:** Observe a spider finishing a web’s radial line (or a convincing imitation).**Effect:** Ask the GM one question about a hidden tie, debt, or leverage between two people, or between a person and a faction. The GM must answer truthfully. Your next *Manipulate*, *Pressure*, or *Intimidate* action exploiting that knowledge gains **+1 Effect**.**Push It:** Reveal a secret tie that was not previously declared in the fiction (the GM must invent a plausible connection). Mark **Exposure +1** as your own entanglements surface.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Spinner’s Debt (Standard, 9 XP)***Scene; Near; No.***Tags:** [VOW], [DEBT], [BOND], [COMMAND]**Materials:** A silver coin and a strand of your own hair, knotted together.**Effect:** Offer a willing creature a boon: they may immediately clear **1 Fatigue** or gain **+1 die** on their next roll. In return, they accept a **Promise Clock [4]** named “Debt to the Web.” You may advance this clock by 1 segment at any time as a free action (once per scene). When the clock fills, you may demand a single service from them – not impossible, but significant (e.g., “speak for me at court,” “reveal a secret,” “take a blow meant for me”). Refusal causes them to suffer **Harm 1 (Stress)** and the clock resets.**Push It:** Extend the offer to a group (up to three targets). Each who accepts gives you a separate Promise Clock. Mark **+1 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Binding Knot (High, 11 XP)***Scene; Near; No.***Tags:** [VOW], [BOND], [FATE], [COMMAND]**Materials:** A silk loop tied between two hands, then cut or knotted with a spoken vow.**Effect:** Bind two parties (individuals or small groups) to a mutual oath. Breaking the

vow forces **2 SB** on the violator and marks them with a subtle tell (a visible thread, a nervous twitch, a lingering scent) that persists for one week.

Push It: Widen the binding to up to four parties, each of whom may define one loophole. Exploiting a loophole causes **1 SB (Clubs)** as the web tightens around the exploiter.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 6 segments.

Merciful Severing (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Tags: [HEAL], [DISPEL], [MERCY], [DEBT]

Materials: A white thread burned to ash, spoken with a name.

Effect: Sever one harmful tie – a curse, a toxic obsession, a coercive bond, or a supernatural debt. Remove one Condition or **1 SB** tied to it. This is an act of genuine mercy; the target may be unwilling, but the thread can still be cut (Resolve test DV 4 to resist).

Push It: Sever a tie without the target's consent or knowledge; they will not know who cut them free, but you mark **+2 Obligation** as the web recoils against you, and the severed strand may attach to you instead (GM's discretion).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Web of Slumber (High, 12 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Tags: [AREA], [SLEEP], [BIND], [FEAR]

Materials: A complete spider's web, stolen at dawn, and a lullaby hummed into it.

Effect: Weave an area of drowsy stillness. For the next hour, any creature entering the zone must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 4) or fall into a light trance, losing their next action and suffering **–1 die** to all perception rolls while inside. Allies you touch beforehand are immune. The web is invisible until triggered.

Push It: The trance becomes deeper – sleeping creatures cannot be woken by non-magical means for the duration. Mark **2 SB (Spades/Hearts)** as the web draws hungry attention.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 6 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Inaea

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Inaea sings in *knots* – melodies that loop back on themselves, harmonies that tie two voices into one. Their voice is used to HEAL quarrels, to bind a community together after a tragedy, or to weave a subtle compulsion into a seemingly innocent lullaby. Inaea's Cantors are beloved at weddings, feared at treaty signings, and always watched by those who understand that a pretty tune can be a leash.

The Cult of the Woven Circle. Inaea's cults gather in domestic spaces – kitchens, weaving sheds, longhouses – and resemble extended families more than secret societies. A ritual of the Woven Circle involves each member tying a coloured thread around their wrist, then passing the ends to their neighbours. The resulting web is then tightened, and a communal promise spoken. The cult's creed is embroidered onto a single cushion that passes from host to host: *"No thread stands alone. The weakest knot still holds the*

strongest weight.” Outsiders are welcome if they bring a thread and a truth. Betrayal of the circle is repaid by being unravelled – socially, financially, or worse.

Witchcraft of Inaea (Craft / Threshold)

A witch who walks with Inaea is a *web-weaver* or *knot-smith* – one who understands that every threshold (a door, a marriage, a treaty) is held together by invisible threads. Their magic works with domestic tools: a spinning wheel that twists fate, a loom that weaves obligations into cloth, or a pair of shears that cuts a single strand to end a feud. This craft can be as humble as tying a red thread around a child’s wrist for protection, or as grand as weaving a tapestry that records an entire bloodline’s debts.

The Witch’s Tool: The True Loom. A small, portable loom – no larger than a book – woven from hawthorn wood and strung with thread dyed in three colours (red for blood, white for truth, black for secret). Once per session, the witch may weave a single knot into a new or existing thread; that knot becomes a *promise clock* [4]. When the clock fills, the promise is either fulfilled or broken, as agreed at the time of weaving.

A Hedge Gift: Bind the Threshold (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may tie a simple knot in a cord, ribbon, or strand of hair and place it on a threshold (a doorstep, a gate, a bridge). For the next hour, anyone crossing that threshold must succeed on a Resolve test (DV 2) if they intend to break an oath, tell a lie, or harm someone inside. The knot visibly tightens if a violation is attempted.

Inaea’s Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hearth-Blessed: +1 die to <i>Comfort</i> or <i>Aid</i> actions.	Must offer solace when asked, or mark 1 SB (Hearts) .
2	Web-Sense: Once/scene, sense hidden ties between two people (debt, rivalry, affection).	Empathic Overload: suffer 1 Fatigue when immersed in strong conflict.
3	Binding Presence: Once/session, compel a promise unless target passes Resolve DV 4.	Over-Attachment: –1 die when abandoning those you’ve aided or bound.
4	Fate’s Pattern: +2 dice to predict alliances, betrayals, or bargains.	Manipulative Urge: mark 1 SB (Diamonds) when acting selflessly without agenda.
5	Spider’s Mercy: Once/session, sever one harmful tie for yourself or another (as <i>Merciful Severing</i>).	Hunger for Threads: suffer 1 Fatigue if a session passes without weaving a new tie or extracting a promise.
6+	Weaver’s Dominion: Once/session, declare all ties in a scene bend toward you; gain +2 dice on social manipulation.	Entanglement: Mark +2 Obligation ; those affected become subtly dependent on your will.

Playstyle Notes

Inaea rewards those who see relationships as both comfort and leverage. Her followers are not merely kind; they are patient, observant, and willing to let a debt ripen before collecting. Intrusions often take the form of a sudden obligation – a person you helped now demands help in return, a promise you thought forgotten tightens, or a web you spun catches someone you did not intend. Refusing an intrusion does not break the thread, but it frays it: the GM may mark a *Tangled Web* clock that, when filled, causes all your active promises and bonds to tighten at once, often at the worst moment.

Emphasises

- **Patient Predation:** setting threads and waiting for the right moment
- **Webs of Obligation:** debts, promises, and favours as both comfort and leash
- **Unseen Connections:** sensing hidden relationships and leverage
- **Mercy as Control:** healing and aid that leave lasting threads

6.8.11 The Inquisitor Prime (Purity & Domination)

Lore. Among the Aeler Iron Avengers, zealots, and witch-hunters, the Inquisitor Prime is venerated as the hand of absolute purity and the sword of uncompromising order. Where others see nuance, the Inquisitor sees corruption; where others see difference, they see contamination.

Those who march beneath their sigil believe that no society can stand if it tolerates the impure or the disobedient. They hunt the arcane and the aberrant, not merely to destroy them, but to bind them as slaves to order—believing even the tainted may yet serve, so long as they are shackled.

The Inquisitor Prime appears in vision as a faceless figure clad in burnished iron, with eyes like furnace-doors and a voice like grinding chains. To serve them is to embrace judgment without mercy and to live in suspicion of all who walk outside the prescribed law.

For the faithful, doubt is treason; compassion is weakness; and freedom is the seed of ruin. In the wake of their followers, only silence and ash remain.

"Mercy is weakness. Purity is survival. Where corruption hides, we carve it out."

Rites of the Inquisitor Prime**Rite of the Pure Flame (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [PROTECT], [RADIANT], [FEAR]

Materials: Ash from a burned grimoire or sigil-scarred candle.

Effect: Gain **+2 dice** to resist supernatural influence (fear, charm, possession) and **+1 Armor** vs. magical attacks. Undead/demonic foes suffer **−1 die** against you.

Push It: Extend the effect to allies in Near range, but supernatural entities sense you immediately; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unclouded Eye (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [KNOWLEDGE], [RADIANT]

Materials: Silver dust stirred into holy water.

Effect: **+2 dice** to Investigate/Insight when spotting illusions, glamours, or magical deception. Cannot be surprised by sorcery this scene.

Push It: For one exchange, pierce *all* illusions; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Cleansing Light (Standard, 8 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [DISPEL], [RADIANT], [FORCE]

Materials: A shard of blessed mirror and consecrated oil.

Effect: Target a magical effect (ward, curse, enchantment). Test DV = Tier.

- On Hit: Dispel.

- On Partial: Weaken.
- On Miss: The effect lashes back, generating 1 SB.

Push It: Dispel absolutely and trace its caster; mark +1 **Obligation** and 1 **SB (Spades)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Marked Prey (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [CURSE], [TRACK], [FEAR]

Materials: A belonging of the target mixed with blessed salt.

Effect: Mark a supernatural target: they suffer **−1 die** to all rolls and cannot hide with illusion. You gain +1 **die** to track or strike them. Undead/demonic take +1 Harm from you.

Push It: Target cannot hide anywhere and suffers Fatigue 1; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Consecrated Ground (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Tags: [WARD], [AREA], [FORCE], [SANCTUARY]

Materials: Relics from three rival faiths, salt, crushed gemstones.

Effect: Consecrate an area. Supernatural entities must pass Spirit+Resolve (DV 4) to enter. Undead/demonic suffer **−2 dice** inside. The site gains the [WARD] tag.

Push It: Permanently sanctify a larger area, but start a *Magical Dead Zone* [6] clock and mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Final Admonition (High, 14 XP)

Scene; Touch; No.

Tags: [DEATH], [BANISH], [FORCE], [FEAR]

Materials: Ash from a destroyed spellbook, martyr's water, and the target's true name.

Effect: Attempt to annihilate one supernatural foe. Target tests Spirit+Resolve (DV 5). On Fail: destroyed outright. On Success: suffer Harm 3 and **−2 dice** this scene. Once per target only.

Push It: Absolute destruction leaves behind Sanctified Ground; mark 2 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Inquisitor Prime

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Inquisitor Prime does not sing melodies – they chant *liturgies of excision*, flat, rhythmic recitations that scrub the air of taint. Their voice is used to purify a space before a hunt, to drown out a heretic's dying curse, or to march troops into battle with a single, unified note. Inquisitorial Cantors are rarely loved, but they are feared – and their songs are remembered long after the pyre has cooled.

The Cult of the Iron Chorus. The Prime's cults are militant orders – the Chain-Lanterns of Thepyrgos, the Censer-Knights of Ecktoria, the Spirit-Shield Correctors of Aeler. They gather in fortified chapter houses, not temples. A ritual of the Iron Chorus involves each member testifying to a corruption they have purged, then striking a iron bell with a hammer. The bell's tone is harsh and final. Their creed is stamped into every seal: "*What is pure endures. What is not is fuel.*" Outsiders are not welcome; they are suspects until proven clean.

The Prosecutorial Mob. The Prime also can whip up temporary "cults" which act as mobs. These attack the target of the Cantor but either disperse or form factions as the GM dictates.

Witchcraft of the Inquisitor Prime (Monastic / Exorcist)

A witch who walks with the Inquisitor Prime is often an *exorcist scribe*, a *censer-bearer*, or an *inquisitorial archivist* – a nun, monk, or scholar of one of the great purifying orders. Their magic is the art of liturgical cleansing: copying purification rites into iron-bound codices, blending ash and myrrh into sealing wax that repels spirits, or maintaining the reliquaries that hold the bones of saints who died hunting heretics. In Aeler, a True-Mason of the Prime might carve a "confession stone" into a chapter house floor, so that any lie spoken there blackens the mortar. In Thepyrgos, a silent sister might brew a tea from sanctified salt that flushes possession from a victim's blood. Their tools are not forge-hammers but censers, seals, and scourges – instruments of penitence and judgment.

The Witch's Tool: The Censer of the Unforgiving Flame. A brass censer hung on three chains, each link etched with a clause of the Inquisitor's Creed. Once per session, the witch may swing the censer to fill a zone with thick, bitter smoke. For the scene, any supernatural creature within the smoke suffers **–1 die** to all rolls, and any magical effect passing through the smoke is treated as one Tier lower for resistance. The censer can also be used to "cense" a threshold: sprinkling ash from the censer across a doorway applies the [WARD] tag against minor spirits and undead until the next dawn.

A Hedge Gift: Rite of the Soot Line (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may draw a line of ash and salt across a threshold (a door, a bridge, a window) while reciting a single verse from the Inquisitor's Litany. Until the next dawn, that line functions as a [WARD] against minor spirits (Cap 1–2) and all undead of Cap 2 or lower. A creature attempting to cross must test Spirit+Resolve (DV 3) or be turned back for that exchange. The line glows faintly when a lie is spoken within Near range.

Inquisitor Prime's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hunter's Instinct: +1 die to Notice magical auras or traps.	Black-and-White Thinking: Must label others "pure" or "corrupt"; -1 die when navigating moral nuance.
2	Sanctified Weapon: Once/scene, your weapon ignores 1 Armor/Resist from supernatural foes.	Purity Zeal: Exposure to filth or corruption causes 1 Fatigue.
3	Cold Clarity: +2 dice to resist deception, illusion, or mental sway.	Suspicion: -1 die to social rolls with anyone you suspect of "impurity."
4	Burning Truth: Once/session, compel one target to answer truthfully (Resolve DV 4).	Compulsion: Cannot ignore supernatural activity; hesitation costs 1 SB (Clubs).
5	Sterile Aura: Once/session, emit a presence that suppresses supernatural abilities (-2 dice in Near).	Purity Addiction: Suffer 1 Fatigue when in a supernatural area without taking action against it.
6+	Absolute Judgement: Once/session, name a supernatural foe as utterly corrupt. For that scene, gain +3 dice against them.	Monomania: When invoked, you tunnel on that target, suffering -2 dice to all else.

6.8.12 Isoka, Angel of Serpents (Transformation & Renewal)

Lore. Isoka, sister to Ikasha (Shadow) and Inaea (Mercy), completes the Triad of Transformation. Where thresholds and compassion mark her sisters' domains, Isoka teaches that every self is temporary—identity is a skin to be shed so growth can continue. Her serpents are omens and teachers: each cast skin a lesson in release; each venom a catalyst for necessary change. Those who walk her path become alchemists of the self, embracing dissolution as the first motion of rebirth.

Her followers range from quiet hedgewitches who use venom to heal and shed skins to ease grief, to the darker cults of the Coiled Heart, where initiates drink serpent venom to burn away their old selves and emerge as something new — or something monstrous. Isoka does not judge; she offers the knife and the poison both. The choice is the seeker's.

Do not mourn the skin you shed. It was never meant to last. The venom that burns away the old self is the same that grants the strength to become new.

Domain Focus

- **Serpentine Transformation:** shedding identity, renewal through dissolution
- **Venom as Catalyst:** poison that heals or destroys, the paradox of change
- **Shedding the Past:** erasing debts, memories, and old allegiances
- **Healthy Change to Monstrous Rebirth:** from gentle alchemy to sword-and-sorcery cults

Rites of Isoka

Rite of the Loosening Skin (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [HEAL], [ESCAPE], [CLEANSE]

Materials: A discarded snakeskin or a strand of your own hair.

Effect: Shrug off a temporary burden. Remove one Condition (Fear, Poison, Fatigue, or a minor social stain) that you have acquired this scene. Alternatively, reroll one failed roll to escape restraint or pursuit.

Push It: Also ignore one environmental penalty (difficult terrain, smoke, etc.) for the scene, but leave a visible trace of your passage (mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Forked Tongue (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Tags: [DECEPTION], [BOOST], [RISK]

Materials: A harmless lie whispered to a mirror.

Effect: For one scene, you may speak ambiguously without penalty. When you use *Deception* or *Sway* to conceal your true intent or pass as someone else, you may treat a Partial Success as a Clean Success (the lie holds). On a Miss, however, the GM gains **2 SB** as your deceit unravels in an embarrassing way.

Push It: Extend the effect to one willing ally; they may also lie freely for the scene.

Mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as both of you become tangled in the same falsehood.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Shedded Self (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [ERASURE], [ESCAPE], [DEBT]

Materials: A complete change of clothing and a token from your former role (a badge, a lock of hair, a written name).

Effect: You shed one persistent identity – a title, a bond, a debt, or a reputation. For the remainder of the scene, you are treated as a stranger to those who knew you in that role. You gain **+2 dice** on any roll to avoid detection, escape pursuit, or convince others that you are not yourself. Create a 6-segment *Shed Identity* clock; when it fills, the old identity returns as a separate NPC (a rival, a witness, or a ghost).

Push It: Immediately erase one minor obligation (a Debt Clock segment or 1 Obligation to a Patron) as you slough it off. Mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as the discarded debt finds a new debtor.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of Venom's Paradox (Standard, 9 XP)

Instant; Touch; No.

Tags: [POISON], [HEAL], [CURSE], [CLEANSE]

Materials: A drop of venom from a serpent that has shed its skin within the last day.

Effect: Inflict or cure through poison's paradox. Choose one:

- **Cursed Venom:** Touch a creature and inject venom. They suffer **+1 Harm** (poison) and must test Resolve (DV 4) or gain the *Poisoned* Condition (–1 die to physical actions until cured).
- **Mercy's Antidote:** Touch a poisoned or diseased creature. The venom neutralises the malady; remove one *Poisoned* or *Diseased* Condition, and the target clears 1 Fatigue.

Push It: Apply both effects to the same target (curse and cleanse in a painful purge, representing a violent rebirth), or affect two different targets. Mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of Unremembered Metamorphosis (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Self; Yes.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [ERASURE], [FATE], [BURDEN]

Materials: A full identity kit, a serpent's shed skin, and a personal item from the life you are leaving (or records of your old life to burn).

Effect: Choose one:

- **Complete Metamorphosis:** After an hour of ritual, you emerge with a new face, voice, and documented identity. For one week, you are immune to recognition by anyone who knew your previous self, and gain **+2 dice** on all *Deception* and *Stealth*

rolls related to that new identity. Create an 8-segment *New Identity* clock; when it fills, the old self may reassert itself (GM's discretion).

- **Cast-Off History:** After a full night's ritual burning all mundane records of your old life, your previous identity becomes unreliable. Common records and casual memories become vague; those who track you via that identity suffer -2 dice. You gain +2 dice on rolls relying on your new identity. Create a 6-segment *Erased Past* clock; when it fills, one intimate from your old life senses the deception and may investigate.

Push It: Extend the metamorphosis to a willing ally, make the change permanent (lose access to one Bond or Minor Asset), or arrange a plausible "death" for your old self (a funeral, a witness). Mark +2 **Obligation** and the GM gains 2 **SB** (the world strains to remember what was lost).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Isoka

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Isoka sings in *whispers of shedding* – melodies that rise and fall like a serpent's undulation, with harmonies that slither rather than resolve. Their voice is used to ease a difficult transformation (ritual scarring, a change of identity, the acceptance of loss) or to accelerate a foe's destructive change (madness, mutation, despair). Isoka's Cantors are often found in snake cults, their songs weaving venom and mercy in equal measure.

The Cult of the Coiled Heart. Isoka's cults are secretive, dangerous, and obsessed with metamorphosis. They gather in sunken temples, caverns beneath city sewers, or groves where adders nest. A ritual of the Coiled Heart involves each member holding a live serpent while speaking a name they wish to shed: a debt, a crime, a former allegiance. The serpent is then released into a central pit. Then they drink a tea brewed from shed snake skin and a drop of venom – the tea induces vivid dreams of their old self dying and a new self emerging. The most devoted replace one of their teeth with a hollow fang, allowing them to deliver a venomous bite (once per session, treat as a light melee weapon with the [POISON] tag). Their creed is carved in ouroboros rings: "*What devours itself is never consumed by another.*" Outsiders are rarely invited; those who stumble into a rite are offered a choice – join, drink venom and be remade, or be forgotten as the cult sheds their memory.

Witchcraft of Isoka (Craft / Shedding)

A witch who walks with Isoka is a *scale-smith* or *venomer* – one who understands that transformation is a craft. Their magic works with the materials of change: a forge that tempers steel by "shedding" impurities, an alembic that distills venom into medicine, or a loom that weaves a new identity from discarded threads. Unlike the darker cults, these witches focus on healing and gentle release – helping a grief-stricken parent shed their sorrow, or a recovering addict shed their craving. Their tools are delicate: obsidian blades, silver alembics, and bundles of shed snakeskin.

The Witch’s Tool: The Shedding Knife. A small, curved blade of obsidian or serpentine, never used for combat – only for cutting away what is no longer needed. Once per session, the witch may cut a physical token of an old identity (a lock of hair, a uniform patch, a letter) and burn it. For the remainder of the session, they gain +1 die on all rolls to deceive, hide, or escape detection, as the old self’s traces are literally erased. The knife can also be used to “shed” a minor curse or enchantment from a willing subject (remove one magical Condition with a touch, costing 1 Fatigue).

A Hedge Gift: Venom’s Mercy (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may apply a drop of harmless (or carefully dosed) venom to a wound, a drink, or a lock. Choose one effect: remove 1 Fatigue from an ally (as a mild stimulant), impose –1 die on a target’s next physical roll (a mild paralytic), or force a target to speak a single truthful sentence (a truth serum). The victim may resist with a Resolve test (DV 3) if they are aware of the venom.

Isoka’s Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Serpent’s Gaze: +1 die on Intimidation or social rolls using menace.	Cold-Blooded: –1 die on Empathy or warmth-based Persuasion.
2	Shed the Old Skin: Once/session, negate one Condition (Fear, Fatigue, Poison) by discarding it like molted skin.	Mark of Scales: Faint reptilian patches visible, causing +1 SB in social encounters if noticed.
3	Venomous Strike: Bite or kiss may inflict Poison (DV 2).	Hungry Coil: Must consume raw meat or eggs weekly, or mark 1 Fatigue.
4	Serpentine Grace: +2 dice to Stealth or Evasion rolls, ignore minor movement penalties.	Slitted Eyes: Bright light imposes –1 die on Notice rolls.
5	Hypnotic Sway: Once/scene, roll Presence + Lore vs. Resolve (DV 3) to mesmerise a single target.	Forked Tongue: –1 die on Deception when attempting warmth or sincerity.
6+	Ascendant Form: Partial serpent-body; immune to mundane poison, +2 dice on Body rolls.	Monstrous Aspect: Cannot easily hide your nature; every session begins with 1 SB that may be compelled by the GM.

Playstyle Notes

Isoka is the patron of transformation in all its forms – from the gentle shedding of grief to the violent rebirth of a cult assassin. Her witches are often healers and alchemists who use venom to cure and snakeskin to symbolise release. Her cults are darker, obsessed with forced change, venom initiation, and the dangerous edge of metamorphosis. Isoka does not judge; she offers the knife and the poison both. The player chooses how far to lean into the serpent’s coil. Ideal for characters who undergo profound personal change, whether by choice or by circumstance.

Emphasises

- **Serpentine Transformation:** shedding old selves, growing new ones
- **Venom as Dual Force:** healing or destroying, depending on intent
- **Healthy Change vs. Sword-and-Sorcery Cults:** from gentle alchemy to monstrous rebirth
- **Erasure of the Past:** forgetting debts, identities, and old allegiances
- **Obsidian and Scale:** the witch's craft of delicate shedding vs. the cult's venomous bite

6.8.13 Khemesh, the Abyssal Maw (Depths, Inexorability, Eldritch Terror)

Lore. Khemesh is not merely a lord of the depths but the hunger beneath them, a pressure older than seas. Those who bargain with him are marked by the abyss — seen in the way shadows cling, in the whispers heard when no voice speaks, in the certainty that all things will sink. He is the classic warlock's patron: distant, vast, and utterly indifferent to mortal morality. To serve Khemesh is to accept that the universe is cold, that the deep does not hate — it simply consumes.

In the trench without light, the Maw waits. Even silence drowns.

Domain Focus

- **Depths and Pressure:** crushing weight, darkness, the alien geometry of the abyss
- **Inexorability:** slow, unstoppable processes; the certainty of sinking
- **Eldritch Terror:** madness, whispers, perception beyond mortal limits
- **Consumption:** hunger that devours matter, memory, and hope

Rites of Khemesh

Rite of the Crushing Whisper (Low, 5 XP)

Instant/Scene; Near/Zone; Yes.

Tags: [FEAR], [DEBUFF], [AREA], [SILENCE]

Materials: A broken shell filled with ink-dark water.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Whisper of the Trench:** Target hears impossible echoes and suffers **–1 die** on their next action.
- **Crushing Silence:** Establish an oppressive silence in a zone; enemies in the zone suffer **–1 die** to coordination or morale-driven actions.

Push It: (Whisper) Echoes coil in your own skull — take **Fatigue 1**, but the target also loses their next minor action. (Silence) A single enemy's voice is stolen entirely for the scene.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Abyssal Grasp (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [BIND], [PRESSURE], [DEBUFF]

Materials: A length of rusted chain submerged in water.

Effect: Target is pinned by invisible crushing force: treat as [ENTANGLE] with **Great Effect** if underwater or confined.

Push It: Inflict **Fatigue 1** on the target in addition to the restraint.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Alien Gaze (Standard, 9 XP)*Scene; Self; No.***Tags:** [KNOWLEDGE], [TRUTH], [BURDEN], [FEAR]**Materials:** None (requires standing in absolute darkness or near deep water).**Effect:** You perceive the world as Khemesh does — fractured, alien, crushing. Gain +2 dice to *Notice* and *Arcana*, and may ask one “true nature” question about a foe or structure.**Cost:** When the scene ends, you suffer **Exposure +1** as your perception warps.**Push It:** Extend the vision to one ally, but both take **Fatigue 1**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.**Rite of the Sundering Deep (High, 14 XP)***Scene; Zone; No.***Tags:** [PRESSURE], [AREA], [FATE], [DEATH]**Materials:** A sealed vessel of abyssal water, broken open.**Effect:** Reality in the zone folds inward like the crushing deep:

- Enemies act at **Desperate Position** by default.
- Each beat, the GM may force **1 SB** (Spades/Clubs favoured) as the deep pressures reality.
- Structures, vessels, or wards fracture as if under immense weight.

Push It: For one beat, declare a single enemy “crushed” (severe harm/effect). You immediately suffer **Fatigue 2** and +1 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.*Obligation:* 8 segments.**Cantors & Cults of Khemesh**

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of Khemesh sings in *pressures* — low, resonant drones that feel like the weight of water on the chest. Their voice is used to invoke the crushing depths, to rupture a ship’s hull with a single sustained note, or to fill a room with the sensation of drowning. Khemesh’s Cantors are rare, feared, and often found in coastal cults where they sing the tides into madness.

The Cult of the Drowned Chorus. Khemesh’s cults are the stuff of eldritch horror — sunken temples beneath storm-tossed seas, congregations of shore-dwellers with wet eyes and too-pale skin, and the occasional deep one or kraken-spawn acolyte. A ritual of the Drowned Chorus involves each member cutting a small sigil into their palm (a spiral within a triangle) and then drinking a cup of brine and salt water while whispering a secret hope into the cup — hope that the depths will grant, or consume. The water *whispers back* in a voice that sounds like their own, but wrong. Their creed is whispered in wet, gurgling tones: “*All things sink. The only question is what you carry down with you.*” Outsiders are bait, or converts. Sometimes both.

Witchcraft of Khemesh (Lay / Pressure)

A witch who walks with Khemesh is a *deep-salvager* or *pressure-scribe* — one who works with the spoils of the abyss. Their craft is the art of enduring pressure: sealing a letter with wax drawn from deep-sea vents, inscribing a ward that holds back the tide, or writing a contract in ink made from the blood of a drowned sailor. Their tools are not hammers; they use vials, seals, and the patient weight of water. In Linn, a shipwright might season a keel with a prayer, but a hedge-witch of Khemesh might instead seal a curse into the hull with a drop of abyssal water, so that the ship will never sink — but its crew will dream of drowning every night.

The Witch’s Tool: The Vessel of the Unspoken Depth. A small, sealed iron vial, cold enough to frost the skin. Inside is a single drop of water from a trench where no light reaches. Once per session, the witch may uncap the vial and speak a name. For the next hour, that person (or object) is “marked by the deep”: they suffer **–1 die** on all social rolls (their presence feels oppressive), and any attempt to track them gains **+1 die** as if following a trail of cold. The vial can also be used to “seal” a threshold: pouring a single drop onto a doorframe causes the door to groan with pressure; forcing it open requires a Body test (DV 4) and inflicts 1 Fatigue on the opener.

A Hedge Gift: Carried Depth (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a container (a bottle, a chest, a room) and fill it with the “pressure of the deep.” For the next hour, any living creature inside that container must test Endurance (DV 3) or suffer 1 Fatigue from the crushing weight. The container may also be used to preserve food or seal a wound (the pressure stops bleeding), but the flesh grows pale and cold.

Khemesh's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Abyssal Resilience: +1 die to resist fear and pressure-based effects.	Claustrophobic Comfort: Suffer –1 die in open, well-lit spaces or above ground.
2	Crushing Insight: Once/scene, treat a failed Investigation or Arcana roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).	Weight of Knowledge: Suffer 1 Fatigue when learning new information that confirms your pessimistic worldview.
3	Silent Hunter: +2 dice to Stealth in dark or confined spaces.	Voice of the Deep: When speaking normally, your voice sounds distant and hollow, causing –1 die to social rolls requiring warmth or clarity.
4	Pressure Adaptation: Immune to underwater combat penalties; gain +1 die to resist drowning.	Crushing Presence: Allies within Near range suffer –1 die to morale-based rolls due to your oppressive aura.
5	Abyssal Sight: Once/session, see through all illusions and deceptions for one exchange, but the truth is always bleak.	Fractured Perception: –1 die to rolls requiring normal vision; the world appears warped and alien.
6+	Inevitable Descent: Once/session, declare that all escape routes in a zone are sealed. Enemies cannot flee and suffer –2 dice to mobility actions.	Hunger of the Maw: Mark +2 Obligation when using this power; you must consume something (food, memory, hope) to maintain your strength.

Playstyle Notes

Khemesh is the classic warlock's patron: distant, vast, and utterly indifferent. His followers gain power over pressure, darkness, and the crushing inevitability of the deep, but pay with their warmth, their humanity, and eventually their sanity. The cults of Khemesh are eldritch and alien, and even the most benevolent follower of the Maw is marked by a cold that never leaves. Ideal for players who enjoy cosmic horror, the price of forbidden knowledge, and characters who have looked into the abyss — and let it look back.

Emphasises

- **Eldritch Horror:** powers that are alien, vast, and morally indifferent
- **Crushing Pressure:** mechanical weight, slowness, inevitability
- **Deep as Warlock Patron:** bargains with the abyss, forbidden knowledge, madness
- **Consumption:** hunger that devours matter, memory, and hope
- **Isolation:** the follower grows cold, distant, and unsettling to others

6.8.14 Livaea, the Crimson Courtier (Seduction & Social Binding)

Content Warning

Livaea is a patron of seduction, eroticism, and emotional manipulation. Themes include desire, obsession, social coercion, and the darker side of intimacy. While the mechanics avoid explicit content, the fiction may touch on mature subjects. Please use Lines & Veils (see Chapter 1) to ensure everyone's comfort at the table.

Lore. In salons where laughter cuts deeper than daggers and promises bind tighter than chains, the Crimson Courtier reigns. She is the whisper behind the curtain, the smile that sells secrets, the velvet hand that closes a cage. Her servants are not conquerors but consorts, binding others through song, wit, and the perilous glamour of intimacy. Where Mab entangles through fae trickery, Livaea rules through allure, performance, and the hunger for connection.

Livaea is a demon of seduction – not merely of the flesh, but of the will. She teaches that a desire willingly given is a leash willingly worn. Her followers learn to read the geometry of longing, to plant the seed of obsession with a glance, and to harvest the fruit of obligation when the heart is most vulnerable. She is the darker aspect of love: the possessiveness, the jealousy, the desperate need to be wanted. To serve her is to become the object of desire – and to pay the price of never being truly loved in return.

“A promise sealed with desire is harder to break than any oath sworn in iron.”

Domain Focus

- **Seductive Arts:** charm, persuasion, reading desire, emotional manipulation
- **Social Binding:** oaths of affection, courtly promises, emotional debts
- **Performance Magic:** dance, music, appearance enhancement, glamour
- **Court Intrigue:** gossip, reputation, the weapons of the drawing-room
- **Darker Love:** obsession, jealousy, possessiveness, the hunger to be adored

Rites of Livaea**Rite of the Velvet Whisper (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Near; Standard Push

Tags: [MANIPULATION], [BOOST], [SECRET]

Materials: Silk ribbon touched to lips.

Effect: Your private words carry irresistible charm. Gain +1 **die** to *Sway* one target in confidential conversation.

Push It: Target feels compelled to share a secret in return; mark **Exposure** +1.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Shared Cup (Low, 5 XP)*Scene; Touch; Standard Push***Tags:** [BOND], [BOOST], [EMPATHY]**Materials:** Shared wine, tea, or perfume.**Effect:** Create temporary bond of intimacy. Both parties gain +1 die when aiding each other socially.**Push It:** Bond deepens to emotional empathy; both sense moods but suffer -1 die to deceive each other.*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.**Rite of the Binding Vow (Standard, 8 XP)***Scene; Near; Standard Push***Tags:** [VOW], [BOND], [DEBT], [FEAR]**Materials:** Token exchanged between parties (a ring, a lock of hair, a signed letter).**Effect:** Forge a magical promise of affection or loyalty. Both gain +1 **Effect** when cooperating; breach inflicts 1 **SB (Hearts)**. Create a 6-segment *Vow Strength* clock.**Push It:** Breach also causes a visible social stain (a blush that won't fade, a nervous tic); mark 1 **SB (Clubs)**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.**Rite of the Courtesan's Guise (Standard, 7 XP)***Scene; Self; Standard Push***Tags:** [GLAMOUR], [BOOST], [SOCIAL]**Materials:** Perfume or cosmetics applied ritually.**Effect:** Assume perfect social poise. Gain +2 dice to *Sway* or *Performance* in refined settings.**Push It:** Become social centrepiece; all attention focuses on you with +1 **Effect**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.**Rite of the Crimson Court (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Zone; High Push***Tags:** [AREA], [COMMAND], [FEAR], [GLAMOUR], [DEBT]**Materials:** A throne draped in scarlet, an assembled court (real or imagined), and a drop of blood from each participant mixed into wine.**Effect:** You become the social sovereign of the zone. For the scene:

- You gain +1 **Effect** on all social rolls, and opponents suffer -1 die.
- Anyone who attempts to deceive you must test Resolve (DV 4) or reveal a hidden desire.
- Allies who drink from the shared cup regain 1 Fatigue (the wine of adoration).

Start a 10-segment *Court Dominion* clock; when it fills, you may declare one irrevocable social judgment (exile, scandal, or a binding oath) that the zone's inhabitants will enforce for one month.

Push It: Newcomers must test Resolve (DV 4) or become briefly devoted (they will follow one simple social command, such as “introduce me to your patron”). Mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Livaea

The Cantor’s Song. A Cantor of Livaea sings in *harmonies of longing* – melodies that linger in the ear like a half-remembered lover’s sigh. Their voice is used to sway a court’s opinion, to bind a marriage with a ballad, or to seduce a secret from a guarded heart. Livaea’s Cantors are prized in every noble house, and feared by those who know that a beautiful song can be a leash.

The Cult of the Velvet Circle. Livaea’s cults are not hidden in basements; they meet in salons, tea houses, and private galleries. The Velvet Circle appears to be a social club – but its members trade in secrets, favours, and carefully curated introductions. A ritual of the Velvet Circle involves each member drinking from a shared cup (the *Crimson Chalice*) while naming a desire they wish to weave into reality. The cup is refilled with wine and a single drop of blood from each petitioner; those who drink become bound to the Circle – they cannot betray a member without suffering a visible blush of shame (1 Fatigue, no roll). Their creed is embroidered on its seal: *“Every bond is a thread. Every thread can be tied – or cut.”* Outsiders are welcome as guests, but they will leave with a new debt, a new ally, or a new enemy. Rarely all three.

Witchcraft of Livaea (Lay / Social Weaving)

A witch who walks with Livaea is a *gossip-scribe* or *perfume-smith* – one who crafts social reality from threads of rumour, scent, and gesture. Their magic works with the tools of influence: a letter that cannot be forgotten, a perfume that makes the wearer irresistibly charming, or a needle that sews a promise into a dress’s hem. Their tools are never hammers; they use quills, vials, and the subtle art of a well-timed whisper. In Ecktoria, a Livaeian witch might be a letter-writer for the powerful, sealing each envelope with a kiss that binds the reader’s loyalty. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a keystone that makes every handshake struck beneath it unbreakable.

The Witch’s Tool: The Gossip Quill. A silver-tipped quill that writes in ink that darkens when a secret is true. Once per session, the witch may write a single sentence about a person they have met. That sentence becomes “known” to the local gossip network within a day, affecting the target’s reputation (GM determines effect: –1 die to social rolls, a new ally, an enemy, etc.). The witch cannot control how the rumour spreads, only that it spreads.

A Hedge Gift: Velvet Glove (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a person’s hand (or a letter they have written) and speak a single word of command (“trust,” “forget,” “desire”). For the next hour, the target feels a mild but genuine inclination toward that emotion or action – not enough to override self-preservation, but enough to grant the wielder **+1 die** on social rolls against them.

Livaea's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Silver Tongue: +1 die to Persuade or Sway in intimate settings.	Need for Attention: -1 die when acting unnoticed or ignored.
2	Heart's Insight: Once/scene, +2 dice to detect hidden desires or motives.	Emotional Drain: 1 Fatigue if denied meaningful social connection.
3	Enchanting Presence: Allies in Near gain +1 die to social actions.	Rivalry Magnet: Often attract envy or social competition.
4	Velvet Command: Once/session, issue compelling suggestion (Resist DV 4).	Temptation's Pull: -1 die to resist appealing offers.
5	Court Network: Once/session, call on contacts for information.	Glamour Dependence: -1 die when isolated from social circles.
6+	Sovereign Allure: Once/session, dominate a social gathering (Resist DV 5).	Addicted to Adoration: Mark +2 Obligation; suffer if denied praise.

Playstyle Notes

Livaea excels in social manipulation, courtly intrigue, and the darker arts of seduction. Followers become masters of persuasion, binding others through desire, jealousy, and obligation. The corruption progression leads toward a social virtuoso who cannot function without admiration and connection – a velvet cage of their own making. Ideal for players who enjoy social combat, political maneuvering, and characters who wield influence and longing as their primary weapons. As with all mature themes, use Lines & Veils to ensure the table's comfort.

Emphasises

- **Seduction as Power:** charm, allure, reading desire
- **Social Binding:** oaths of affection, emotional debts, possessiveness
- **Court Intrigue:** gossip, reputation, the weapons of the drawing-room
- **Darker Love:** obsession, jealousy, the hunger to be adored
- **Performance and Glamour:** beauty as a weapon, appearance as armour

6.8.15 Lunara, The Silver Quiet (Moon, Mystery & Hidden Ways)

Lore. Lunara walks where torchlight falters: crossroads, tidal edges, shadowed sanctuaries. She is the whisper beneath silver skies, a torch-bearing guide to mysteries that lie between waking and dream. The ancients know her as triple-formed: maiden of new light, mother of full radiance, crone of waning shadow. Her worshippers—night-scholars, dream-walkers, and hedge-priests—seek her not for power over others, but for passage, reflection, and revelation.

Her gifts are gentle yet perilous: a mirror that reveals as much of the seeker as the sought, a key that opens ways better left closed, a light that makes the unseen plain. Her sigil is the silver spiral, etched in water, mirror, or stone.

"Three faces gaze from the moon. Which one watches you tonight?"

Rites of Lunara

Rite of the Moonlit Mirror (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [KNOWLEDGE]

Materials: A mirror or bowl of still water under moonlight.

Effect: Peer beyond surfaces. +1 die to detect illusions, veils, or hidden motives. Once per scene, ask one veiled question about the present; the GM answers in riddle or omen.

Push It: Glimpse too deeply – gain the truth, but mark 1 Exposure.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Crescent Whisper (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [COMMUNICATION], [BOND]

Materials: A silvered thread knotted three times.

Effect: Deliver a secret thought to a single target; they hear it as if whispered beside them. Gain +1 die to aid their next action.

Push It: The whisper echoes beyond its mark, creating 1 SB (Hearts) as others sense your intrusion.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Triple Road (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [MOVEMENT], [GUIDANCE], [AREA]

Materials: Three lit candles set at a crossroads.

Effect: Reveal a hidden path, door, or liminal way. Allies gain +2 dice to traverse or escape; enemies suffer –1 die to pursue.

Push It: The road opens farther than intended – toward an unknown realm. Mark 1 SB (Spades).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Lunar Conjunction (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [SPIRIT], [KNOWLEDGE], [FATE]

Materials: A ring of herbs burned beneath a dark moon.

Effect: Commune with veiled knowledge or subtle entities. Ask two questions; answers come in omen, dream-symbol, or paradox.

Push It: The answer is too direct – gain it fully, but mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Silver Key (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [UNLOCK], [GATE], [FATE]

Materials: A silver key forged or anointed under a new moon.

Effect: Open a way where none should exist – between places, states, or wards. Creates a 6-segment *Gateway* clock.

Push It: Something else comes through; mark **2 SB (Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Moonbound Ascendant (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; No.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [BOOST], [PROTECT]

Materials: A cherished item surrendered under moonlight.

Effect: Enter a heightened lunar state. Choose two:

- +2 dice to Wits or Spirit,
- Resist fear/beguilement,
- Speak with unseen presences,
- Trace hidden connections with +2 Effect.

Begin a 6-segment *Moonbound* clock.

Push It: Make it enduring – mark Harm 2 and a permanent lunar stigma.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Lunara

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Lunara sings in *phases* – melodies that shift from whisper to resonance as the moon waxes and wanes. Their voice is used to lure dreams, to calm a troubled sleepwalker, or to draw a veil of silver silence over a secret meeting. Lunara's Cantors are often found in starlit groves, singing the moon up and down.

The Cult of the Silver Spiral. Lunara's cults meet under open skies, in moon-lit clearings, on rooftops, or beside tidal pools. The Silver Spiral is not a secret society – it is a fellowship of night-walkers, dream-recorders, and lunar scholars. A ritual of the Spiral involves each member writing a question on a silvered leaf, then floating it on still water under the moon's reflection. The most devoted keep a *lunar cat* – a grey creature with eyes that change with the moon's phase – and drink water from a silver bowl that has sat under moonlight for nine nights; they claim the water lets them walk in the dreams of anyone whose name they whisper into it. Their creed is engraved on a single silver disc that passes from host to host: *"The moon sees all. The moon tells only what the*

seeker is ready to hear." Outsiders are welcome on the night of the full moon, but they must bring a question and a silver coin; the coin is melted down and added to a growing silver spiral that never closes.

Witchcraft of Lunara (Lay / Threshold)

A witch who walks with Lunara is a *silver-scribe* or *mirror-maker* – one who works with reflection, threshold, and the soft metals of the moon. Their craft is the art of revealing and concealing: polishing a mirror that shows a hidden door, forging a silver key that opens a dream, or etching a lunar phase onto a threshold to make it shift at moonrise. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a moon-phase into a keystone so the tunnel only opens under a new moon. In Viterra, a hedge-wright might silver a well's rim so that those who drink from it forget their nightmares. Their tools are never hammers – they use needles, mirrors, and bowls of still water.

The Witch's Tool: The Silver Needle. A needle of pure silver, cold to the touch, that never tarnishes. Once per session, the witch may prick their finger and draw a single drop of blood onto a threshold (a doorframe, a mirror's edge, a window sill). For the rest of the scene, that threshold "remembers" the witch – they may cross it silently, unseen, and any reflection in it shows only what they wish to be seen.

A Hedge Gift: Moon-Water Scry (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may cup a handful of water that has sat under moonlight and speak a name. The water shows a brief, cryptic image of that person's current location or emotional state (e.g., "surrounded by stone," "weeping," "walking toward a bridge"). The GM describes the vision in one short sentence.

Lunara's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Moonlit Sight: +1 die to detect hidden or liminal presences.	Shadows cling: Eyes glimmer in dim light, unnerving the uninitiated.
2	Silver Memory: Recall any event witnessed under moonlight with perfect clarity.	Dreams blur: Suffer strange, intrusive visions when sleeping.
3	Quiet Step: +1 die to stealth or subtle speech acts.	Tongue falters: –1 die to open confrontation or commands.
4	Seam-Walker: Once per scene, cross a minor threshold unseen.	Alien aura: Mortals feel watched, suffering unease in your company.
5	Triple Aspect: Call on maiden, mother, or crone aspect for +2 dice in related rolls.	Dissociation: After use, lose sense of time or self until rested.
6+	Silver Ascendancy: Once per session, unveil hidden truths of an entire scene (+3 dice to perception/investigation).	Bound to the Veil: Mark +2 Obligation. Your presence slips between worlds, inviting lunar forces to notice you.

6.8.16 Mab, Queen of Courts (Glamour & Bargain)

Lore. Mab rules not from throne or blade, but from dance and debt. She is the smile that binds, the jest that ensnares, the hostess who makes guests complicit in her game. To speak in her Court is to pay; to receive her token is to owe.

Mab is an Archfae – one of the great powers of the Gloaming Courts, neither wholly cruel nor kind, but always bound by her own rules. She cannot lie, but she can mislead so beautifully that truth becomes irrelevant. She cannot break an oath, but she can interpret it until it screams. Her followers thrive on charm, wit, and story, spreading webs of bargains too subtle to escape. The Cantor’s Path sings her name most sweetly, for every verse carries a price.

“Every laugh is a promise. Every promise is a debt. Every debt belongs to Mab.”

Domain Focus

- **Fae Glamour:** illusions, enchantments, the art of seeming
- **Social Bargains:** oaths, promises, debt as social glue
- **Courtly Intrigue:** etiquette, wordplay, the game of masks
- **Trickster Arts:** mischief, cleverness, the twist in the tale
- **Archfae Sovereignty:** Mab’s word is law in her presence, but only if you agreed to play

Rites of Mab**Rite of the Trickster’s Bargain (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Near; Standard Push

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Materials: A token freely given (flower, coin, ribbon).

Effect: Offer a fae bargain. The target may accept (both gain +1 **die** to actions that uphold the terms) or refuse (target marks 1 Fatigue from social pressure). Create a 4-segment *Bargain’s Edge* clock.

Push It: If the target later betrays the bargain, they suffer Harm 1 (Stress) and start an *Oathbreaker [4]* clock.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of Courtly Guise (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; Standard Push

Tags: [GLAMOUR], [SOCIAL], [MASK]

Materials: A sprig of hawthorn or a silver thread worn visibly.

Effect: Subtle glamour makes you appear as the expected rank or guest. Gain +1 **die** to social rolls in refined settings.

Push It: Mask one personal tell (an accent, a scar, a nervous habit); the first probing question about it generates 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Price Agreed (Standard, 8 XP)*Scene; Near; Standard Push***Tags:** [VOW], [BOND], [DEBT], [TRUTH]**Materials:** Equal tokens exchanged ritually (two rings, two signed notes, two locks of hair).**Effect:** Bind a formal bargain. While the bargain is honoured, both parties gain **+1 Effect** when cooperating. Breach forces **1 SB (Hearts/Diamonds)** and a reputation penalty (–1 die to social rolls involving honour for one week). Create an 8-segment *Bargain Binding* clock.**Push It:** Add a minor boon to one party (+1 die once). If that party breaches, they suffer an additional 1 SB and you mark **+1 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.**Rite of the Sovereign Glamour (High, 13 XP)***Ritual; Zone; High Push***Tags:** [AREA], [GLAMOUR], [COMMAND], [WARD], [FEAR]**Materials:** A circle of silk or green felt, courtly music, and a drop of honey (for sweetness) and vinegar (for the sting).**Effect:** Establish a fae court in the zone. For the scene:

- Allies gain **+1 die** to social rolls; blunt threats (Intimidation, crude Force) suffer –1 die.
- Once per scene, you may strip an illusion or reveal a hidden motive as a free action (target tests Resolve DV 3 to resist).
- Violating a promise made within the zone triggers **2 SB** and a visible glamour mark (a blush, a stutter) that lasts a day.

Start a 10-segment *Court Dominion* clock.**Push It:** Impose a temporary *Court Law* (e.g., “no steel,” “speak only truth,” “every third word must be a compliment”). Violators suffer 2 SB. Mark **+2 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).***Invoke:** Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.*Obligation:* 7 segments.**Rite of the Gilded Jest (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Large Zone; High Push***Tags:** [AREA], [GLAMOUR], [MASK], [BOND], [TRUTH]**Materials:** Masks for all participants (hand-made, never bought), enchanted music, and a cup of wine that has been blessed (or cursed) with a whispered lie.**Effect:** Create a lasting glamourous court – a masquerade that persists for the duration of the event (hours or an entire evening). All social magic (Sway, Performance, Deception) gains **+1 Effect**. Outsiders who enter suffer –1 die to perceive truths, read emotions, or see through disguises. Any promise made while masked is magically witnessed; breaking it inflicts **2 SB** and the mask of the oath-breaker cracks (visible to all).Start a *Glamour Maintenance* [8] clock; when it fills, the masquerade ends abruptly, and all participants remember everything they said – and forgot.

Push It: The masquerade persists between scenes for the rest of the session. Mark **+3 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Mab

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Mab sings in *harmonies of the half-truth* – melodies that shift key without warning, leaving the listener uncertain of what was heard. Their voice is used to seal a bargain with a sung clause, to make a crowd forget a social faux pas, or to weave a glamour that lasts as long as the music plays. Mab's Cantors are prized at every court where masks are worn, and feared by those who know that a beautiful tune can hide a poisoned promise.

The Cult of the Gilded Jest. Mab's cults meet in places where masks are natural: masquerade balls, carnival tents, and the back rooms of theatres. The Gilded Jest is less a religion and more a conspiracy of wits – actors, gamblers, and lawyers who have learned that every exchange is a performance. A ritual of the Jest involves each member writing a true secret on a playing card, then exchanging cards with another member. They must then speak the secret they received as if it were their own – and the group votes on whether they told it “true enough.” Those who fail must drink a cup of “tea of forgotten clauses” (a bitter brew of nettle and fae-touched honey) and lose one minor memory (a face, a password, a small debt). Their creed is printed on a card that is passed, never kept: *"The best chains are made of laughter. The strongest oaths are sworn in jest."* Outsiders are welcome as “audience,” but those who laugh too loudly may find themselves on stage – and the stage has its own rules.

Witchcraft of Mab (Lay / Glamour)

A witch who walks with Mab is a *glamour-weaver* or *toy-maker* – one who crafts objects that are never quite what they seem. Their magic works through misdirection: a doll that laughs when a promise is broken, a mirror that shows a flattering reflection (and nothing else), or a mask that lets the wearer speak any lie as truth. Their tools are never hammers; they use needles, masks, and the subtle art of a well-placed reflection. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a cornerstone that makes everyone forget the building's weak point, but a witch of Mab would instead sew a glamour seam into the cornerstone's shadow.

The Witch's Tool: The Mask of Shifting Faces. A simple half-mask of polished white wood, its eye holes rimmed with silver. Once per session, the witch may don the mask and change their apparent appearance – face, voice, and even perceived gender – for one scene. This grants **+2 dice** to *Deception* or *Performance* rolls to pass as someone else, and anyone who tries to see through the disguise must test Resolve (DV 4). The mask cannot mimic a specific person unless the witch has a token of that person (a hair, a signature). After use, the mask's eyes weep a single drop of silver; the witch may collect it as a component for glamour rites.

A Hedge Gift: Mask of the Moment (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may place a hand over their own face and draw it away, revealing a different expression (or a different face entirely, briefly). This grants **+1 die** to a single *Deception* or *Performance*

roll, as the target's expectations are momentarily overturned. The illusion lasts only for that exchange.

Mab's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Glamour's Touch: +1 die to Deception/Performance with stories.	Truthbound: Cannot speak plain falsehood; only mislead.
2	Fairy Step: Once per scene, flicker Near as if teleporting.	Iron Weakness: 1 Fatigue if touched by cold iron.
3	Trickster's Delight: Spend 1 Boon to twist a Complication advantageously.	Compulsive Jest: Must play a trick each session or mark 1 SB.
4	Hospitality's Gift: Allies sharing food/drink gain +1 die to Resolve.	Hospitality Bound: Harming guests costs +2 Obligation.
5	Fae Sight: See veils/glamours; +2 dice to Notice.	Truth Debt: Must accept "fair" trades or suffer.
6+	Twilight Crown: Once/session, declare an Oath; +2 dice to fulfillment.	Oathbound: Breaking inflicts Harm 1 and starts a [6] clock.

Playstyle Notes

Mab excels in social manipulation and fae-style bargaining. Followers become masters of subtle magic, binding others through oaths and glamour. The corruption progression leads toward becoming fae-touched, gaining power over truth and perception at the cost of mortal constraints. Ideal for players who enjoy social intrigue, wordplay, and characters who prefer cleverness over brute force.

Emphasises

- **Archfae Sovereignty:** Mab's word is law in her presence, but only if you play her game
- **Glamour as Social Weapon:** illusions that bind, masks that deceive
- **Bargains and Debts:** every gift is a hook, every promise a leash
- **Courtly Intrigue:** etiquette, wordplay, the dance of masks
- **Trickster Wisdom:** the truth is what you can make others believe

6.8.17 Maelstraeus, The Infernal Bargainer (Commerce & Exchange)

Lore. Maelstraeus is the Infernal Bargainer, the Prince of Ledgers, the shadow at every crossroads of exchange. He was born from the first inequity, when one gave and another took, and debt was chained into existence.

He does not trade fairly — he trades *inevitably*. Every pact carries a hidden surcharge, every kindness is collateral, every smile hides an interest rate. His realm is an endless market where stalls never close, contracts burn with invisible ink, and every bargain tilts toward him.

To serve Maelstraeus is to admit the world itself is transactional — that all things, from love to breath to soul, are bound in his ledger. He collects. He always collects.

A deal is never even. The scales tilt; the Merchant smiles. All debts come due.

Domain Focus

- **Commerce as Conflict:** negotiation, leverage, hidden clauses
- **Debt as Power:** obligation as currency, interest as weapon
- **Inevitability:** all accounts are settled, sooner or later
- **Infernal Bargains:** Faustian pacts, soul-ledgers, cursed credit

Rites of Maelstraeus**Rite of Uneven Scales (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [NEGOTIATION], [DEBT], [BOOST]

Materials: A scale where one pan is shaved or weighted.

Effect: Establish a trading ground. All parties gain +1 **die** to negotiate – but you bank a [4] **Hidden Profit** clock to spend reducing complications in your favour.

Push It: Compel one party to reveal their desperation or a hidden term; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Merchant's Gaze (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [VALUE], [BOOST], [BURDEN]

Materials: A coin pressed flat until its face is erased.

Effect: +2 **dice** to appraise goods, favours, or leverage. Create a [6] **Profit Margin** clock.

Push It: Perceive emotional or hidden value as well, but mark +1 **Exposure** and 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Weighted Contract (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near/Touch; No.

Tags: [VOW], [DEBT], [BOND], [FEAR]

Materials: Two items, one secretly flawed, or a parchment scorched before stamping.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Secret Advantage:** Bind a bargain where you secretly shift one advantage in your favour. Both sides gain **+1 Effect** if honoured. Create a **[6] Shrewd Bargain** clock.
- **Seared Seal:** Bind an agreement with a scorched seal. You gain **+1 die** to enforce compliance; breakers suffer **−2 dice** in all dealings until next session. Create an **[8] Burned Ledger** clock.

Push It: (Secret Advantage) Breaking terms lashes the weaker party with **1 SB (Hearts/Clubs)**. (Seared Seal) Breach burns the sigil into the breaker's hand, inflicting Harm 1 and **1 SB (Spades)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Infernal Bazaar (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [AREA], [NEGOTIATION], [DEBT], [FEAR], [BOOST]

Materials: A canopy stitched from debtors' contracts.

Effect: Create a cursed market-zone. Allies gain **+1 Effect** on bargains and may reroll one failed negotiation. Enemies suffer **−1 die** to deception. Start a **[10] Predatory Market** clock.

Push It: Attract wealthy powers eager – and doomed – to deal. Mark **2 SB (Hearts/Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Cosmic Ledger (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; No.

Tags: [TRANSFER], [FATE], [DEBT], [SACRIFICE]

Materials: A book that writes entries in your blood (a personal ledger, each entry a drop).

Effect: Once per session, convert one resource into another (e.g., Boon → Fatigue, Obligation → SB, Harm → Debt Clock segments). All trades tilt slightly in your favour (you gain **+1 die** on the next roll related to that resource). Start a **[6] Balance Owed** clock.

Push It: Make the trade brutally lopsided (double the conversion rate, e.g., 2 Boons → 2 Fatigue). Create a **[6] Cosmic Debt** clock and mark **2 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Maelstraeus

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Maelstraeus sings in *recitations of accounting* – melodies that sound like the rustle of parchment and the chink of coins. Their voice is used to seal a contract with a sung term, to recite a debtor's tally until the weight of it crushes, or to make a market stall appear where none stood before. Maelstraeus's Cantors are employed by every major guild, and feared by those who know that a song of profit always hides a verse of loss.

The Cult of the Gilded Ledger. Maelstraeus's cults meet in counting-houses, bank vaults, and the back rooms of commodity exchanges. The Gilded Ledger is not a secret society – it is a fraternity of merchants, moneylenders, and tax collectors who have learned that every transaction is a prayer. A ritual of the Ledger involves each member opening a vein (a small cut on the thumb) and letting a drop of blood fall onto a brass scale, then adding a pinch of gold dust. The mixture is used to ink a new entry in the cult's master ledger – a book bound in leather made from the skin of a debtor who could not pay. The most devoted members tattoo their current account balance on the inside of their wrist; the numbers change overnight, and no one knows who updates them. Their creed is stamped on every bond they issue: *"The soul is currency. Spend it wisely – someone is always counting."* Outsiders are welcome as "investors," but those who fail to pay their dues find their names struck from the book – and their shadows missing the next morning.

Witchcraft of Maelstraeus (Lay / Exchange)

A witch who walks with Maelstraeus is a *ledger-scribe* or *coin-turner* – one who crafts the instruments of exchange: contracts that cannot be broken, scales that never lie, and inks that write in terms that bind the reader's soul. Their magic works through the materials of commerce: a quill that writes in debt, a press that stamps obligations into parchment, or a small iron stamp that leaves a mark of ownership on any object. Their tools are never hammers; they use quills, scales, and the subtle art of a binding signature. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a toll-gate that remembers every traveller's debt, but a witch of Maelstraeus would instead press a wax seal into the keystone, so that the debt is owed not to the mountain, but to the witch.

The Witch's Tool: The Debtor's Quill. A steel-nibbed quill that writes in ink that darkens as the writer's obligation grows. Once per session, the witch may write a one-sentence contract on a scrap of parchment. Anyone who signs (or accepts the parchment) is bound to a minor task or payment. Breach inflicts **1 SB (Spades)** and marks the signer with a faint, glowing sigil for one day. The quill can also be used to "amend" an existing contract by scratching out a clause; the scratched-out clause becomes unenforceable, but the quill demands a drop of blood as payment.

A Hedge Gift: Fair Weight (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a scale, a till, or a handshake and speak a single word ("balance"). For the next exchange, all appraisals and negotiations involving that transaction are treated as if they were perfectly fair – no hidden advantage, no secret interest. The witch may choose to be the one who benefits from that fairness, or they may grant it to another as a genuine (but binding) gift.

Corruption of Maelstraeus

Tier	Gift	Burden
1	Appraiser's Eye: +1 die to judge value in goods, favours, or leverage.	Transactional Reflex: Must assign a "cost" to every interaction; –1 die to selfless acts.
2	Sharp Dealer: Once/scene, reroll a failed bargain.	Compulsive Trade: Must haggle or strike a deal when value is present – even if destructive.
3	Merchant's Fortune: +1 die to predict or exploit markets.	Greed's Hunger: Suffer 1 Fatigue if you allow profit or advantage to pass untaken.
4	Infernal Credit: Once/session, call in a major favor (merchant prince, syndicate, guild).	Debt Anchor: Draw in exploitative offers; refusing marks 1 SB (Diamonds).
5	Price of Truth: Once/scene, see the hidden worth of any item, pact, or person.	Tagged by Price: See every being as a commodity; –1 die to genuine intimacy.
6+	Market Tyrant: Once/session, impose absolute dominance over a domain of trade; all exchanges bend to you.	Cosmic Recompense: Mark +2 Obligation; the universe exacts repayment in brutal, unexpected form.

Playstyle Notes

Maelstraeus is the patron of merchants, moneylenders, and anyone who understands that every relationship has a price. His followers gain power over negotiation, debt, and the hidden leverage in every exchange, but pay with their empathy, their trust, and eventually their ability to act without counting the cost. The cults of Maelstraeus are as cold as his ledgers, but they are also among the most powerful networks in the world. Ideal for players who enjoy intrigue, leverage, and characters who always have an angle.

Emphasises

- **Commerce as War:** negotiation as combat, leverage as weapon
- **Debt as Identity:** you are what you owe
- **Infernal Bargaining:** Faustian pacts, soul-ledgers, cursed credit
- **The Ledger Never Closes:** every profit is a future loss, every gift a future claim
- **Cold Calculation:** empathy is inefficiency; kindness is a poor investment

6.8.18 Malachai, the Cruel Messenger (Curses & Corruption)

Lore. Malachai was once a divine messenger – a herald of painful truths, sent to deliver news that could not be softened. She was not cruel; she was necessary. But necessity wears. In time, she began to soften the truth, offering false hope alongside real curses. For this, the gods bound her in chains of black iron beneath the cursed city of ZahkKozahn.

Now she waits. Chained but not contained. Imprisoned but not silent. Her voice reaches across the world, offering power to the weak, hope to the hopeless, and sweet oblivion to those who cannot bear to face the dawn. Vampirism, lycanthropy, and other cursed conditions flow from her influence. Her followers learn that power demands suffering, mastering gifts that devour from within.

“I offer you everything you desire, and everything you fear. The payment comes later.”

Domain Focus

- **Cursed Gifts:** Faustian bargains, power with hidden costs
- **Corruptive Power:** tainted blessings, addictive magic
- **False Salvation:** hope that destroys, beautiful lies
- **Supernatural Afflictions:** vampirism, lycanthropy, and other curses

Rites of Malachai**Rite of the Honeyed Binding (Low, 5 XP)**

Scene; Self or Near/Touch; Standard Push

Tags: [CURSE], [BOOST], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Materials: Blood mixed with sweet wine, or a broken chain link.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Honeyed Curse:** Target gains +2 dice to their next roll (counts as Triumph). They take 1 Corruption (unresistable).
- **Binding Curse:** Target gains +1 die to physical actions but suffers Fatigue 1 unless they perform a dominance act (beat a weaker creature, drink blood, break something precious).

Push It: (Honeyed) Grant +3 dice and auto-Triumph; inflict 2 Corruption instead. (Binding) Grant +2 dice but Fatigue 2; mark 1 **SB (Spades)** as the curse’s hunger grows.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the False Dawn (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; Standard Push

Tags: [CURSE], [DEBT], [FATE]

Materials: Meteoric iron shard blessed by false light.

Effect: Bestow a gift with a hidden curse. Target gains a significant advantage (e.g., +1

die to all rolls for one scene) but accrues a 4-segment *Corruption* clock. Each time they use the gift, tick the clock. When full, they suffer a related curse (GM chooses: festering wounds, beastly urges, or the attention of a Collector).

Push It: The gift is more powerful (+2 dice, or extended duration). The clock advances 2 segments immediately; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Cruel Transformation (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Touch; Standard Push

Tags: [CURSE], [TRANSFORM], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Materials: Holy water mixed with graveyard dust.

Effect: Infect a target with a supernatural condition (vampiric hunger, bestial rage, shadow-bind). Lasts one scene. Start a 6-segment *Transformation* clock. Each time the target resists feeding or transformation, tick the clock. When full, the condition becomes permanent.

Push It: The condition becomes permanent immediately; target gains **+1 die** to relevant actions but is marked by Malachai (a Collector will visit within a week). Mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Messenger's Burden (High, 13 XP)

Ritual; Self; High Push

Tags: [CURSE], [BOOST], [PRESSURE], [DEBT]

Materials: Manacles worn while speaking her name.

Effect: Channel Malachai directly. Gain **+2 dice** to one action per beat this scene, but each use marks 1 SB as her influence spreads. Start an 8-segment *Corruption's Grip* clock. When it fills, a Collector arrives to demand a memory, a name, or a year of your life.

Push It: **+3 dice** but mark 2 SB, suffer Fatigue 1, and her voice becomes permanent – you hear whispers of cruel bargains in quiet moments.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Chained Angel's Tribute (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; High Push

Tags: [CURSE], [AREA], [SACRIFICE], [FATE]

Materials: A chapel bell cracked by divine lightning, or a silver coin that cannot be spent.

Effect: Corrupt a sacred space or consecrate a site to Malachai. Within the zone:

- Supernatural effects (curses, dark magic) gain **+1 Effect**.
- Blessings and healing spells generate **+1 SB** on a failure.
- Any creature that accepts a gift from Malachai within the zone immediately ticks a *Corruption* clock twice.

Start a 10-segment *Divine Perversion* clock. When it fills, the site becomes a permanent beacon for the Worn – the ghouls of ZahkKozahn.

Push It: The corruption spreads to adjacent areas; mark **3 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+3 Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of Malachai

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Malachai sings in *harmonies of sweet despair* – melodies that begin like a lullaby and end like a scream. Their voice is used to lure the desperate into bargains, to make a village accept a curse as a blessing, or to sing a monster to sleep so that it may be bound. Malachai's Cantors are terrifying not because they are evil, but because they are willing to *do evil* – they will poison the well to teach the town to dig deeper, or curse a child to save a hundred adults. They are hated and needed in equal measure.

The Cult of the Leashed Hunger. Malachai's cults gather in places where suffering is already present: plague hospitals, slums, refugee camps, and the cells of the condemned. The most fanatical cell, the *Leashed Hunger*, meets in catacombs beneath ZahkKozahn's ruins, where they drink water from the Well of Ichor and carve the names of their victims into their own flesh with silver needles. A ritual involves each member naming a curse they have inflicted (or allowed) and a mercy they have buried because of it. Then they prick their finger and let a drop of blood fall into a cracked bell; the bell tolls once, and a Collector appears to witness. Their creed is whispered, not spoken: "*We are the knife that cuts the rot. The wound heals, but the scar remembers us.*" Outsiders are not welcome; they are patients, or potential tools, or future victims. Those who die serving Malachai become the Worn – shambling ghouls that guard the cursed city.

Witchcraft of Malachai (Lay / Curse)

A witch who walks with Malachai is a *curse-smith* or *affliction-weaver* – one who crafts pain into purpose. Their magic works through the materials of suffering: a needle that sews a nightmare into a pillow, a forge that tempers a blade to always strike the wielder's loved ones, or a garden where belladonna and hemlock grow in geometric patterns. Their tools are never hammers; they use needles, threads, and the small iron teeth of cursed combs. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a keystone that makes every tenth step collapse, but a witch of Malachai would instead sew a curse-seam into the mortar, so that the tunnel itself remembers every injury it has caused.

The Witch's Tool: The Splintered Needle. A needle of black iron, snapped in half and re-joined with a drop of the witch's blood. Once per session, the witch may sew a "curse seam" into a garment, a threshold, or a skin. The curse is small but specific: a button that falls off at the worst moment, a door that sticks when someone is pursued, a hand that trembles when holding a weapon. The target suffers **–1 die** on a single type of roll (e.g., Stealth, Melee, Sway) for the scene. The witch may unstitch the curse as a free action, but doing so marks 1 Fatigue.

A Hedge Gift: Borrowed Scars (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a fresh wound (inflicted within the last hour) and speak a single word of Malachai's name. For the remainder of the scene, the witch may transfer the pain of that wound (as 1

Fatigue) to another creature within Near range. The target resists with Spirit+Resolve (DV 3); on a failure, they suffer the Fatigue and the witch's original wound heals slightly (clear 1 Fatigue from themselves). On a success, the witch takes the Fatigue anyway – the curse rebounds.

Malachai's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Sharpened Senses: +1 die to Notice in dim light.	Unsettling Presence: –1 die to social warmth checks.
2	Primal Vigor: +1 die to Athletics and physical actions.	Dark Hunger: 1 Fatigue if a day passes without feeding (blood or rare herbs).
3	Unnatural Resilience: Once per session, resist one Condition.	Beastly Tells: Failures cause visible physical changes (slitted eyes, fur patches).
4	Cursed Vigour: Natural weapons count as magical; +1 Effect.	Transformed Body: Permanent physical change (eye colour, skin texture, etc.).
5	Regenerative Curse: Heal 1 Fatigue or Condition per rest.	Corruption's Price: Pushing rites adds permanent Corruption (cannot be cleared).
6+	Monstrous Ascendant: +2 dice to Body-based actions; significant supernatural power.	Loss of Self: The GM may compel curse-driven behaviour (feed, rage, corrupt).

Playstyle Notes

Malachai offers power that corrupts from within. Followers gain immediate benefits but accumulate permanent drawbacks. The corruption progression leads toward becoming a supernatural creature with great power but diminishing humanity. Ideal for players who enjoy tragic characters, Faustian bargains, and exploring the price of power.

Rivalries & Obligations

Major Rivalries:

- **The Oath of Flame & Light:** Direct opposition – sacred vows vs. corrupted promises.
- **The Daughters of the Unbroken Cord:** Both deal in debt, but Daughters harvest generational obligation; Malachai's followers burn out fast. Collectors may serve both, but a Daughter sees a Malachai addict as a wasted asset. Territory wars over hospices and gambling dens are common.
- **Livaea:** Both use social manipulation, but Malachai destroys while Livaea binds.

Hard Obligation Triggers:

- **7+ Segments:** Must corrupt something pure – defile a sacred site, break a true vow, or offer a loved one’s name to a Collector.
- **10+ Segments:** Malachai’s voice becomes overwhelming; refusal risks losing powers. A Collector appears and demands a permanent scar (a visible Mark of Malachai) – refusal means the character falls into the Worn (becomes an NPC ghoul).

Emphasises

- **Cursed Gifts:** power that always costs more than expected
- **Addiction as Magic:** once you start, stopping is harder than any curse
- **False Salvation:** every cure is a waiting room
- **Supernatural Afflictions:** becoming the monster to fight monsters
- **The Chained Angel:** patient, hungry, and never truly contained

6.8.19 Mor'iraath, the Destroyer (Absolute Annihilation)

Lore. Mor'iraath is the demon of absolute destruction – not the slow decay of rot, nor the patient erosion of water, but the joyful, all-consuming fire that reduces everything to ash and memory. He delights not in the process of ruination, but in the perfect moment of combustion, when something that was becomes something that never will be again.

His followers become agents of finality, wielding flame that leaves no trace, no remains, no possibility of reconstruction. To serve him is to embrace the beauty of endings and the power that comes from making things never have been. Where Malachai corrupts and Khemesh crushes, Mor'iraath *ignites*.

Every treasure is fuel. Every pact is tinder. Ash is the only inheritance.

Domain Focus

- **Fiery Annihilation:** fire that consumes utterly, leaving only ash
- **Absolute Endings:** no trace, no memory, no return
- **Cleansing Flame:** burning away corruption, weakness, and existence
- **Inferno as Art:** the beauty of a perfect, final combustion

Rites of Mor'iraath

Rite of the Perfect Ending (Low, 4 XP)

Instant; Touch; No.

Tags: [FIRE], [DESTRUCTION], [ERASURE]

Materials: The final component of something (last brick, final word, closing signature), or a pinch of ash from a previous fire.

Effect: Cause one small object to be utterly consumed by flame – no remains, no trace, no possibility of reconstruction. Gain +1 **die** to rolls involving finality or absolute conclusions.

Push It: The ending creates a beneficial void – gain 1 Boon as space opens for something else; mark 1 **SB (Spades)** as reality adjusts to the absence.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Unmaking Gaze (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [FIRE], [PREDICTION]

Materials: A lens of obsidian or fire-scarred glass.

Effect: +2 **dice** to identify the precise weakness that will cause complete collapse. See the “breaking point” in any structure, plan, or construct – the spot where a single spark would bring it all down. Your next destructive action against the identified target gains +1 **Effect**.

Push It: The gaze becomes prophetic – see three possible endings for one target; choose which occurs, but mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)** as fate resists your vision.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Cleansing Flame (Standard, 8 XP)*Scene; Zone; No.***Tags:** [FIRE], [AREA], [ERASURE], [TERRAIN]**Materials:** Fuel that was once part of what you intend to destroy (a beam from the building, a lock of hair from the person).**Effect:** Create a fire that burns not just substance but essence – what is consumed by this flame never existed. The zone becomes a *pyre zone*; anything entering risks being marked for erasure. Enemies suffer **–2 dice** to actions that would preserve or continue anything within the zone.**Push It:** The flame becomes selective – choose what is unmade and what remains; mark **+1 Obligation** as you assume judgment over existence itself.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.**Rite of the Absolute Negation (Standard, 9 XP)***Instant; Near; No.***Tags:** [FIRE], [BANISH], [FATE], [FEAR]**Materials:** The complete destruction of a representation of the target (a lock for a door, a written name for a person, a fragment for a whole), burned to ash.**Effect:** The target suffers **–2 dice** to resist any effect that would cause their non-existence. If they are reduced to Harm 0 by your actions, they are utterly consumed by infernal flame – [BANISH]ed from all realities, never were, never could be.**Push It:** The negation becomes retroactive – the target never existed in your presence; mark **2 SB (Hearts)** as the timeline rewrites around their absence.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.**Rite of the Unraveling Inferno (High, 13 XP)***Scene; Touch; No.***Tags:** [FIRE], [AREA], [FATE], [DEATH]**Materials:** The foundational element of what you wish to unmake (keystone, cornerstone, source code, a written covenant).**Effect:** Your touch ignites a cascading dissolution. The target and all things fundamentally connected to it begin immediate combustion, crumbling to ash as if they had never been. Test DV = Complexity.

- Success: Target and connections cease to exist.
- Partial: Significant damage, accelerated decay, but some remnants remain.
- Miss: Backlash; the fire turns on you – mark 2 SB and suffer Harm 1 (Burn).

Push It: The unraveling becomes contagious – similar things in Near range also ignite; mark **+2 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).***Invoke:** Extended action; mark **+2 Obligation**.*Obligation:* 7 segments.

Rite of the Final Pyre (High, 14 XP)*Extended; Zone; No.***Tags:** [FIRE], [AREA], [ERASURE], [PRESSURE]**Materials:** Complete dedication of the space to Mor'iraath – every flammable object arranged as a funeral offering, and a drop of your own blood to seal the pact.**Effect:** The zone becomes a pocket of absolute combustion. Anything that enters is set ablaze, suffering Harm 1 each round (ignores Armor). At the end of each round, they must test Spirit+Resolve (DV 5) or be consumed entirely (cease to exist). The space itself becomes a *pyre scar* – it remains hot to the touch for a year and a day, and nothing will grow there.**Push It:** The pyre becomes permanent and expands at 1 segment per scene; you suffer Harm 2 (Burn) and mark +3 **Obligation** as you become partially unmade yourself, your left hand now permanently blackened and smoking.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).***Invoke:** Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.*Obligation:* 8 segments.**Cantors & Cults of Mor'iraath****The Cantor's Song.** A Cantor of Mor'iraath sings in *notes of cessation* – melodies that start strong and fade to crackling silence, like a fire burning out. Their voice is used to silence a battlefield after a massacre, to erase a name from a town's records, or to sing a dying person gently into nothingness rather than an afterlife. Mor'iraath's Cantors are terrifying not because they are cruel, but because they offer a perfect, peaceful, absolute end – and some people accept.**The Cult of the Final Breath.** Mor'iraath's cults gather in places where things end: funeral pyres, abandoned ruins, collapsed mines, and the cells of the condemned. The Final Breath is a fellowship of nihilists, assassins of memory, and those who have lost everything and now embrace the cleansing flame. A ritual of the Cult involves each member writing down something they wish had never existed – a memory, a person, a part of themselves – and then burning the paper in a brazier that gives no heat. They then drink a cup of ash suspended in water; the ash is from a fire that consumed something they once loved. Their creed is whispered, never written: *"What is not cannot suffer. What is not cannot be hurt. We give the gift of never-having-been."* The most devoted tattoo a single ember on the inside of their lower lip; the tattoo smokes when they speak a lie. Outsiders are not welcome; they are targets, or potential converts who have already lost too much to fear the flame.**Witchcraft of Mor'iraath (Lay / Unmaking)**A witch who walks with Mor'iraath is a *pyre-smith* or *ash-weaver* – one who crafts through the art of burning. Their magic works through the materials of finality: a stamp that brands a “flaw” into a threshold, a quill that writes in ink made from burnt secrets, or a forge that tempers a blade that leaves no wound (only a cauterised absence). In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a keystone that makes the tunnel behind it never have existed, but a witch of Mor'iraath would instead press a hot iron sigil into the keystone, and the tunnel would collapse into ash. Their tools are never hammers; they use brands, tongs, and the patient heat of a funeral pyre.

The Witch's Tool: The Cinder-Stamp. An iron rod with a sigil of ending carved into its face, heated until it glows dull red. Once per session, the witch may press the stamp against a threshold (a door, a bridge, a city gate) while speaking a single word – the name of something that should never have existed. For the next scene, anyone who crosses that threshold and fails a Spirit+Resolve test (DV 3) will forget the last minute of their life – their memory is burned away, not suppressed. The stamp can also be used to “unwrite” a single word from a document; the word becomes a smudge of ash, and the sentence restructures itself around the absence.

A Hedge Gift: Absence Knife (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may draw a finger (as if holding a knife) across a surface – a lock, a rope, a clasp – and speak a word of Mor'iraath's name. The object does not break; it simply ceases to be an obstacle. The lock is no longer locked (there is no lock). The rope is no longer a rope. The clasp is as if it never had a function. This effect lasts for one exchange, after which reality “repairs” itself, but the moment of absence is enough.

Corruption of Mor'iraath

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Ending's Sight: +1 die to Notice when something is approaching its natural conclusion or final form.	Completion Anxiety: Must resist urge to "finish" things prematurely; –1 die to rolls involving patience or process.
2	Perfect Strike: Once/scene, your destructive action gains +2 dice and ignores all resistance to ending/ceasing.	Destruction Proximity: Suffer 1 Fatigue when near things of personal value; their existence pains you.
3	Unmaking Touch: +2 dice to rolls involving absolute destruction – no remains, no possibility of return.	Entropy Aura: Objects of value near you show signs of decay/premature aging; allies suffer –1 die to rolls involving cherished possessions.
4	Final Judgment: Once/session, declare one thing in Near range must make Spirit+Resolve (DV 4) or cease to exist entirely.	Existential Hunger: –1 die to rolls involving creation, preservation, or continuation; you hunger to end what others would sustain.
5	Principle of Negation: Once/session, unmake an abstract concept (hope, fear, memory) from a willing target.	Conceptual Erosion: Your presence causes ideas and beliefs to weaken; –1 die to rolls requiring stable reality or consistent identity.
6+	Avatar of Unbeing: Once/session, become the living embodiment of annihilation – anything you touch burns to ash and ceases to exist for one scene.	Void Incarnate: Mark +3 Obligation when using; risk becoming a permanent fire that must constantly consume to maintain existence, eventually burning even yourself.

Playstyle Notes

Mor'iraath is the demon of fiery destruction – the joy of a perfect, all-consuming blaze. His followers gain power over absolute endings, the ability to erase things from existence, and the terrible beauty of ash. The cost is the loss of patience, connection, and eventually the ability to value anything that lasts. Ideal for players who enjoy nihilistic themes, the power of finality, and characters who have decided that if nothing matters, then nothing deserves to remain.

Emphasises

- **Fiery Annihilation:** fire that leaves nothing behind
- **Absolute Endings:** no trace, no memory, no return
- **Cleansing Flame:** burning away corruption, weakness, and existence itself
- **Inferno as Art:** the beauty of a perfect combustion
- **Ash as Legacy:** all that remains of empires, lovers, and gods

6.8.20 Morag the Hag, Weaver of Hidden Costs (Faerie Bargains & Hidden Costs)

Lore. In the hour between twilight and dawn, where borders thin and mortal cunning meets older cleverness, Morag sets her webs of bargain and consequence. She is the grandmother who offers exactly what you need, the forest crone with a perfect solution, the crossroads dweller who makes dreams come true – for a price that only reveals itself once the road bends back. Her wisdom is simple and sharp: every gift carries obligation, every kindness creates debt, and every wish must be paid in coin not named aloud.

Morag is cruel, but not evil. She does not delight in suffering; she delights in the precision of a bargain perfectly struck. She will take your last coin and smile, but she will not cheat you – the terms were always there, written in thorn-scratch, waiting for you to read them. Her cruelty is the cruelty of the market, of the turning year, of a grandmother who knows that the child who burns their hand on the stove will not touch it again.

Her bargains are never unfair – only incomplete. She grants what is promised; the true cost lies in what is unspoken, written in thorn-scratch, and due when the moon has turned thrice.

“She gives you the gold, but not the weight it carries. She grants your heart’s desire, but not the hunger it awakens. She answers your plea, but not the price that pleases her. In Morag’s court, every ‘yes’ is a ‘yes, but...’ ”

Domain Focus

- **Hidden Obligations:** reading the unspoken costs in every bargain
- **Faerie Cunning:** strict courtesy, sharp clauses, old-road law
- **Hearth-Way Wisdom:** folk practice for spirits, thresholds, and natural justice
- **Consequential Magic:** power that always arrives with strings attached
- **Cruel Precision:** the sharp joy of a perfectly balanced account

Rites of Morag**Rite of the Unfinished Promise (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Near/Touch; Yes.

Tags: [BARGAIN], [BOOST], [DEBT], [FATE]

Materials: A half-written contract or a promise spoken but not sealed; or a token of good fortune from someone who recently succeeded.

Effect: Frame a bargain with an escape clause only you understand. Gain +1 die when the other party acts to fulfil their obligation; you may interpret ambiguous terms in your favour.

Push It: Instead of the clause, you may borrow another’s fresh luck: gain +2 dice on one roll that benefits from their good fortune, but the original bearer suffers misfortune later; mark 1 SB (Hearts).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Rite of the Speaking Knot (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Tags: [BIND], [DEBT], [FEAR], [FATE]

Materials: Cord or thread tied with counted knots while speaking the bargain.

Effect: Bind a promise with fae knots that tighten when broken. Both parties gain +1 **die** while keeping the bargain; breaking it escalates consequences (Harm 1, then Harm 2, then *Curse*).

Push It: The knots grow willful and seek payment from the breaker's kin; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Threefold Exchange (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Tags: [TRADE], [DEBT], [BOOST], [FATE]

Materials: Three items of equal seeming value but different true worth.

Effect: Broker a trade where each party yields hidden value. All participants gain +1 **die** when the exchange benefits them; Morag claims the difference in true worth as her tithe.

Push It: The exchange binds across generations; mark 1 **SB (Spades)** as ancestral debts stir.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Cauldron's Secret (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [CRAFT], [HEAL], [DEBT], [FATE], [SACRIFICE]

Materials: A cauldron never yet empty, ingredients dearer than coin, and a willing gift of time.

Effect: Brew a solution to any problem, but the cauldron asks one more ingredient – one the brewer does not realise they are providing until too late (a memory, a name, a year of life).

Push It: The remedy works perfectly but breeds dependence – users must return or suffer withdrawal; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Crossroads Court (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [AREA], [BARGAIN], [DEBT], [FATE], [FEAR]

Materials: A true crossroads at twilight, offerings set to the four ways, and the tears of one who bargained thrice.

Effect: Convene Morag's court: all present must bargain. Each pact grants a marked boon and hides a cost that will ripen at the worst time (the GM notes the cost; it becomes due when dramatically appropriate).

Push It: Judgments bind across realms and seasons; mark +2 **Obligation** and begin

Entangled Fates [6].*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).***Invoke:** Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.*Obligation:* 8 segments.**Cantors & Cults of Morag**

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Morag sings in *harmonies of the half-heard* – melodies that seem to come from just over your shoulder, from a room you left, from a memory you forgot. Their voice is used to sweeten a bitter bargain, to make a debtor forget the interest rate until it is too late, or to call a crossroads spirit to witness an oath. Morag's Cantors are often found in marketplaces, singing the fine print into existence.

The Cult of the Tarnished Cauldron. Morag's cults meet at crossroads, in root cellars, and around cauldrons that never cool. The Tarnished Cauldron is a fellowship of hedges-witches, debt-collectors, and those who have learned that every gift is a hook. A ritual of the Cult involves each member adding an ingredient to the cauldron (a hair, a coin, a written wish) while speaking a price they are willing to pay – a price that the cauldron remembers. Once per season, the cauldron's surface goes still, and it speaks a single sentence – the name of a debt that is about to come due, somewhere in the world. The cult members then argue over who will collect it. Their creed is written in chalk on the cauldron's belly: *"What is freely given can never be reclaimed. What is bargained can always be renegotiated."* Outsiders are welcome to bring a gift and ask a boon – but they will leave with a debt, and the cauldron will remember their voice.

Witchcraft of Morag (Lay / Hag's Work)

A witch who walks with Morag is a *knot-wife* or *cauldron-tender* – one who crafts bargains into being with thread, iron, and simmering pot. Their magic works through the tools of the hedge: a needle that sews a promise into a hem, a pair of shears that cut an obligation cleanly (or not), or a ladle that stirs consequence into soup. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "bargain stone" at a bridge's midpoint, but a witch of Morag would instead tie a red thread around the keystone, binding every crossing into a silent contract. Their tools are never hammers; they use needles, shears, and the patient heat of a hearth.

The Witch's Tool: The Bargain Needle. A needle of cold iron, its eye shaped like a knot. Once per session, the witch may sew a "bargain seam" into a garment, a threshold, or a document. The seam is invisible to all but those who owe a debt to Morag. When the bargain is fulfilled (or broken), the thread loosens (or tightens). The witch may also use the needle to "unpick" a broken promise, resetting a failed negotiation clock by 1 segment at the cost of 1 Fatigue.

A Hedge Gift: Cauldron's Whisper (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may stir any pot or bowl of liquid (water, broth, wine) with a finger and speak a name. For the next hour, the liquid will "remember" any promise or debt spoken over it. Drinking from the liquid grants the drinker +1 **die** to recall the terms of a bargain, or to detect if someone is lying about an obligation. The liquid tastes faintly of iron and hawthorn.

Morag's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Faerie Sight: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> hidden obligations or unspoken costs.	Bargain Sensitivity: -1 die when refusing offers or walking away; the urge to negotiate bites.
2	Cunning Exchange: Once/scene, propose a trade where you gain equal or greater value for lesser seeming payment.	Debt Awareness: Ever-counting ledgers of owed/owing; suffer Fatigue 1 in crowded markets.
3	Old-Road Wisdom: +2 dice when dealing with spirits, fae, or ancient powers.	Obligation Magnet: "Fair trades" find you – each with costs not yet clear.
4	Bargain Mastery: Once/session, set terms so favourable that even the other party feels satisfied (for now).	Price Collector: Collect on at least one outstanding debt each session or suffer -1 die to social rolls.
5	Crossroads Power: Once/session, call on a crossroads where you bargained before.	Fate Entanglement: Your pacts snag your circles; -1 die to keep agreements purely personal.
6+	Hag's Court: Once/session, arbitrate any bargain; your terms bind all parties.	Debt Incarnate: Mark +3 Obligation; risk becoming a walking covenant, unable to act without minting new debts.

Playstyle Notes

Morag favours negotiators who read the *said* and the *meant* at once. She rewards courtesy kept, clauses counted, and solutions bought with clever coin. The cost is a life lived on ledgers: every boon with a braid, every kindness with a key. She is cruel, but not evil – she will not twist a bargain out of malice, but she will not warn you of the thorn hiding in the rose. That is your job.

Emphasises

- **Faerie Bargaining:** strict forms, sharp prices, safe exits
- **Hidden Costs:** the string on every gift
- **Hearth-Way Wisdom:** spirits, thresholds, and natural justice
- **Consequential Magic:** boons that demand upkeep
- **Bargain Mastery:** mutually pleasing terms that still pay you twice
- **Cruel Precision:** the sharp joy of a perfectly balanced account

6.8.21 Mykkiel, Arbiter of the Covenant (Law & Zeal)

Lore. Mykkiel is the unwavering judge of covenants, the divine lawgiver whose scales and sword uphold sacred order. He is not good, nor evil – he is the law. Mercy without justice is weakness; justice without law is chaos. His followers are judges, templars, and scribes who enforce divine law with zealous devotion, seeing the world in absolutes of sanctity and transgression.

The Covenant, the great faith that bears his name, was revealed not through a prophet of soft words, but through a commander of hosts – a figure of burning authority who carved the first covenant into stone with a sword. Mykkiel does not negotiate. He commands. The faithful do not interpret; they obey.

In the chivalric traditions of the west, he is called Seint Michel, the patron of knights who swear to protect the innocent and uphold the code. In the eastern deserts, he is the Judge of the Seal, whose name is invoked before every contract. Wherever law is written in stone and enforced with steel, Mykkiel watches.

“The Law is not written in sand, but in stone. The Covenant is not suggestion, but command. Transgressors shall be purged, the faithful exalted.”

Domain Focus

- **Divine Law:** sacred commandments, contractual obligations, ritual purity
- **Zealous Justice:** righteous judgment, purge of impurity, holy retribution
- **Covenant Bonds:** sacred oaths, tribal loyalty, the chosen community
- **Absolute Order:** hierarchy, tradition, unchanging truth
- **Lawful Neutral:** justice without mercy, order without compassion

Rites of Mykkiel

Rite of the Consecrated Mandate (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [WARD], [COMMAND], [FEAR], [AREA]

Materials: A war-banner sanctified with sacred oils, or sanctified salt and ritual boundaries.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Burning Banner:** Consecrate an area for a righteous cause. Followers gain +1 **die** to resist fear; enemies suffer –1 **die** to oppose your proclamation. Create a 4-segment *Divine Mandate* clock.
- **Hallowed Ground:** Create sacred space where divine law prevails. All oath-breaking, theft, or violence suffers –1 **die**. Creates a 6-segment *Sacred Space* clock.

Push It: (Banner) The banner emits visible radiance; unbelievers must test Resolve or falter. (Hallowed) The space becomes consecrated ground against supernatural desecration.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Blazing Decree (Standard, 8 XP)

Instant; Near; Standard Push

Tags: [COMMAND], [FEAR], [TRUTH], [FORCE]

Materials: A stone tablet or scroll with divine commandments.

Effect: Issue a divine commandment ("Cease," "Repent," "Submit"). The target tests Spirit+Resolve (DV 3) or complies. Higher DV for more demanding commands.

Push It: The command carries divine authority; resistance causes **1 SB (Hearts)** of spiritual distress.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Covenant Seal (Standard, 9 XP)

Ritual; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [DEBT], [FEAR], [TRUTH]

Materials: Wax, sacred seals, the names of sworn parties.

Effect: Formalise a binding covenant. All participants suffer concrete penalties for breach (−1 die to relevant actions). Creates an 8-segment *Covenant Bond* clock.

Push It: A breach triggers a visible divine mark (a brand, a stutter, a scar); the marked suffer −2 dice in pious company.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: Extended action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of Divine Judgment (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Near; High Push

Tags: [COMMAND], [FEAR], [FATE], [DEBT], [TRUTH]

Materials: Scales of justice, testimony (written or spoken), ritual condemnation.

Effect: Pronounce divine judgment. The target suffers escalating penalties (−1 die, then −2 dice) until they atone. Serious crimes (oath-breaking, sacrilege, murder) may warrant greater effects (e.g., Harm, exile, or the attention of Covenant inquisitors). Start a 10-segment *Judgment* clock.

Push It: The judgment becomes public knowledge; the community shuns an unrepentant target (all social rolls against them gain +1 die for the community, and the target suffers −1 die to all social rolls).

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Chosen Legion (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Large Zone; High Push

Tags: [WARD], [AREA], [COMMAND], [PROTECT], [FEAR]

Materials: Consecrated ground, ritual weapons, an oath of fidelity sworn by each participant.

Effect: Sanctify an area for the faithful. Believers gain +1 **die** to defence; unbelievers suffer −1 **die**. Supernatural desecration (undead, demons, heretical rites) within the zone risks immediate retaliation (1 SB and a divine warning).

Push It: The area becomes permanently consecrated; start a *Maintenance [8]* clock. If maintenance lapses, the consecration fades, and the site becomes vulnerable to corrup-

tion.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation.**

Obligation: 8 segments.

Covenant Justiciar (Chivalric Zealot)

The law is a sword. The justiciar is its edge. Not for glory, not for mercy – for the covenant alone.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Presence 2+, Rite of the Consecrated Mandate or Cantor of Mykkiel.

Chivalric Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Sworn Defender	When you take the <i>Defend</i> action, you may also grant an adjacent ally +1 Armour until your next turn.	Passive	Body 3, Melee 2
Edict of Silence	Once per scene, as a reaction, force a target who just lied or broke an oath to roll Resolve (DV 4) or be unable to speak for one exchange.	1 Boon	Spirit 3
Unyielding Vow	You ignore the first point of Fatigue each scene that would come from upholding a sworn oath (including the Oath of Flame	Light's vow effects).	Passive Spirit 3, Tier II
Righteous Rebuke	When an enemy attacks an ally you have sworn to protect, you may make a free melee attack against that enemy (once per round).	1 Fatigue	Melee 3, Sworn Defender
Covenant Authority	Your voice carries supernatural weight when citing law. +1 die to Command or Sway when enforcing a contract, oath, or religious edict.	Passive	Presence 3, Lore 2
Judgment Strike	Once per session, after successfully hitting a target you have formally judged (via Rite of Divine Judgment	Free (once)	Tier III, Rite of Divine Judgment

Cantors & Cults of Mykkiel

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Mykkiel sings in *recitations of the law* – flat, rhythmic chants that sound like the turning of pages in a judge's ledger or the hammering of a gavel. Their voice is used to swear in witnesses, to pronounce sentence, or to consecrate a battlefield before a holy war. Mykkiel's Cantors are often found in courts and armies, their songs making the law audible – and inescapable.

The Cult of the Gilded Scale. Mykkiel's cults gather in chapterhouses, court-houses, and fortified temples. The Order of the Gilded Scale is a militant fraternity of templars, notaries, and inquisitors who believe that the law is the highest form of worship. A ritual of the Order involves each member renewing an oath of fidelity while a blacksmith strikes a blade – the ring of steel reminds them that broken faith is punished by the sword. Their creed is carved over every altar: *"Justice is not a gift. It is a debt owed by every soul to every other."* Outsiders are welcome as petitioners, but they must speak only truth.

Witchcraft of Mykkiel (Lay / Covenant)

A witch who walks with Mykkiel is a *seal-scribe* or *testimony-keeper* – one who crafts the physical instruments of covenant: a wax seal that cannot be forged, a ledger that records every oath sworn in its presence, or a gavel that makes every word spoken under it true. Their tools are never hammers; they use seals, stamps, and the careful pressure of a signed name. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a “law stone” at a bridge's centre, but a witch of Mykkiel would instead press a brass seal into the stone at dusk, so that every bargain struck there is binding for a year and a day. In Vhasia, a notary might forge a contract that writes itself in the parties' blood, witnessed by the seal.

The Witch's Tool: The Seal of Unbroken Testimony. A brass signet ring, its face carved with a pair of balanced scales. Once per session, the witch may press the seal into warm wax (or directly onto a stone threshold) while speaking the terms of a single oath. For the next day, anyone who breaks that oath and then crosses the marked threshold (or touches the sealed document) suffers **–1 die** to all rolls until they atone. The seal can also be used to “witness” a testimony: pressing it onto a written statement makes the statement glow faintly if it is true, and grow cold if it is a lie.

A Hedge Gift: Seal of Compliance (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may press a thumb or the seal ring onto a piece of wax, a wet stone, or a bare forehead. The mark is invisible to all but the witch. For the next hour, any promise or command the witch gives to that person carries the weight of divine law; the target suffers **–1 die** if they knowingly disobey or lie. The effect ends if the mark is washed or defaced.

Mykkiel's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Righteous Insight: +1 die to detect falsehood or covenant-breaking.	Uncompromising: Must uphold law absolutely; -1 die to merciful actions.
2	Zealous Conviction: Once/scene, +1 die when enforcing divine law.	Judge's Severity: Cannot easily overlook infractions; suffer 1 Fatigue if forced to.
3	Divine Authority: +2 dice when commanding in matters of faith or law.	Implacable: -1 die to diplomacy or negotiation with transgressors.
4	Sanctified Presence: Once/session, project an aura that makes resistance difficult.	Intolerant: -1 die when dealing with other faiths or traditions.
5	Prophetic Decree: Once/session, speak judgement that carries supernatural weight.	Blind to Nuance: -1 die to perceive grey areas or partial truths.
6+	Divine Proxy: Once/session, channel absolute judgment (bypass resistance).	Instrument of Wrath: Mark +2 Obligation; risk harming innocents alongside the guilty.

Playstyle Notes

Mykkiel embodies the “jealous god” archetype – righteous, demanding, and uncompromising. Followers excel as templars, judges, and religious authorities who enforce divine law. The corruption progression leads toward absolute certainty and power, but at the cost of mercy and flexibility. Ideal for players who enjoy playing righteous enforcers, legalistic characters, or those exploring themes of faith and absolutism. Remember: Mykkiel is not good or evil – he is law. His followers may be paladins or inquisitors, but they serve the covenant, not any mortal notion of justice.

Emphasises

- **Divine Law:** the covenant is absolute, unchanging, and unforgiving
- **Zealous Justice:** righteousness without mercy
- **Chivalric Code:** protection of the weak, punishment of the wicked
- **Absolute Order:** hierarchy, tradition, and the weight of oath
- **Lawful Neutral:** the scales do not tilt; they only weigh

6.8.22 Nidhoggr, the World-Worm (Dreaming Antiquity)

Lore. Beneath stone and sleep coils Nidhoggr, who gnaws at the roots of time. He does not speak quickly; he dreams in centuries. To press your ear to the earth is to risk drowning in the silence of aeons. Yet for those who endure, he whispers truths long buried, memories fossilized in stone, and the slow inevitability of cycles unbroken. His followers walk in twilight between dream and ruin, bearing the weight of all that has been.

Nidhoggr is the worm who knows the metaphorical bones of the earth – the secret history hidden in every mountain, the forgotten temple beneath the marketplace, the name of the king whose tomb was erased from every chronicle. He is the patron of archaeologists, relic hunters, and those who understand that the past is never truly dead. It is merely sleeping.

“Press your ear to the earth and wait. If it remembers you, it will answer.”

Domain Focus

- **Ancient Knowledge:** forgotten histories, buried truths, ancestral memory
- **Stone Communion:** speaking with earth, reading geological memory, stone lore
- **Temporal Perception:** seeing echoes of the past, prophetic dreams, slow time
- **Cyclical Power:** seasonal magic, ritual timing, patience as virtue
- **Relic Hunter:** unearthing the past, preserving what was lost

Rites of Nidhoggr

Rite of the Whispering Stone (Low, 5 XP)

Scene/Instant; Touch/Self; Yes

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [TRUTH], [DREAM], [TIME]

Materials: Dust from weathered stone or an ancient artifact; or water poured over ancient stone, consumed ritually.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Stone’s Whisper:** Stone reveals one hidden fact about its history. Gain +1 die to Lore about this object’s origin and purpose.
- **Dreaming Deep:** Enter a brief trance to witness echoes of local history. Ask one specific question about past events here.

Push It: (Stone) The vision includes sensory details from the past; mark +1 **Obligation**. (Dream) The vision reveals additional context or hidden connections; mark 1 **SB (Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Stone-Sleeper's Murmur (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [TRUTH], [AREA], [TIME]

Materials: An ear pressed to bedrock or an ancient structure.

Effect: Read accumulated memories in stone. Ask up to 3 questions about significant events witnessed here. Creates a 6-segment *Memory Resonance* clock.

Push It: One memory unfolds with perfect clarity; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of Awakened Chronicle (Standard, 9 XP)

Ritual; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [TRUTH], [AREA], [TIME], [BOOST]

Materials: A chalk spiral, four local stones, an hour of meditation.

Effect: The area replays ghostly echoes of a chosen past event. All witnesses gain +2 **dice** to Investigate/Recall related checks. Creates an 8-segment *Echo Stability* clock.

Push It: View events from multiple perspectives; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: Extended ritual; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the World-Worm's Dream (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Zone; High Push

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [TRUTH], [DREAM], [TIME], [PROPHECY]

Materials: A circle of ancient stones, a night of vigil under stars.

Effect: Access deep geological memory. Ask 3 questions about ancient history or receive a prophetic dream. Creates a 10-segment *Deep Dream* clock.

Push It: Gain temporary skill mastery (+3 **dice** to one historical action); mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Unburied Past (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Large Zone; High Push

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [TRUTH], [AREA], [TIME], [PRESSURE]

Materials: Stones from three ancient sites, the blood of a history-keeper (a scholar, a chronicler, or a witness).

Effect: Overlay a past reality onto the present location. Ruins partially reform, ghostly figures manifest. Allies gain +2 **dice** to Lore/Investigate; any modern technology or recent construction suffers –2 **dice** to function within the zone.

Push It: The effect lasts until the next lunar cycle; start a *Temporal Instability* [8] clock. When it fills, the past and present become dangerously entangled – a location may become inaccessible or a relic may begin to fade.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Relic Hunter (Seeker of Lost Ages)

The past is not a foreign country – it is a treasure chest buried beneath your feet. Know where to dig, know what to keep, and know when to run.

Prerequisites: Wits 3+, Lore 2+, Rite of the Whispering Stone or Cantor of Nidhoggr.

Relic Hunter Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Cartographer's Eye	Once per expedition (journey), you may redraw a safe route past one environmental hazard (trap, unstable ground, patrol).	1 Boon	Wits 3
Stone Tongue	You can read ancient scripts and petroglyphs as if fluent, even if you have never seen the language before.	Passive	Lore 2
Unstable Ground	When you are in a ruin or underground, you gain +1 die to evasion rolls (dodging traps, collapsing ceilings, etc.).	Passive	Wits 3, Athletics 2
Historical Insight	Once per scene, when you encounter a relic, inscription, or ancient structure, you may ask the GM one yes/no question about its purpose or origin.	Free	Tier II
Trap Sense	You are never surprised by a trap. You gain +1 die to Notice to detect traps, and if you fail, you may reroll one die.	Passive	Wits 3, Perception 2
Escape Artist	Once per session, when you would be trapped (collapsed tunnel, sealed door, net), you may declare a hidden exit or a forgotten passage. The GM reveals a way out, but it may lead to another danger.	1 Boon	Tier III, Athletics 3

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Secrets of the Unburied Past.* Once per session, you may touch a significant relic of ancient site and ask the GM one question about its history. The GM must answer truthfully and in detail (a paragraph or more). The answer may reveal a hidden weakness, a forgotten ritual, or the location of a related treasure. After using this talent, you gain +1 permanent

Cantors & Cults of Nidhoggr

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Nidhoggr sings in *geological time* – melodies so slow that a single note may stretch across a minute, harmonics that evoke the groan of shifting plates. Their voice is used to lull a city to sleep so that its buried secrets may be heard, or to sing a stone back to its ancient shape. Nidhoggr's Cantors are often found in deep caves, whispering to stalactites that remember the dawn of the world.

The Cult of the Sleeping Stone. Nidhoggr's cults gather in places where time feels heavy: ancient barrows, fossil beds, the roots of mountains. The Sleeping Stone is a fellowship of dreamers, historians, and those who have learned that the world remembers everything – and sometimes forgets on purpose. A ritual of the Cult involves each member pressing their ear to a stone and listening for a full hour in absolute silence. When one of them hears a whisper, they speak it aloud, and the stone's memory is recorded. Their creed is carved into a single erratic boulder that moves about the landscape once a century: *"What is buried is not lost. What is forgotten is only waiting."* Outsiders are welcome to listen, but they must bring a stone from their homeland and leave it behind.

Witchcraft of Nidhoggr (Lay / Stone Memory)

A witch who walks with Nidhoggr is a *fossil-scribe* or *stone-dreamer* – one who crafts with the memory of the earth. Their magic works through the materials of deep time: a piece of amber that preserves a forgotten scene, a lens ground from a fossilised shell that magnifies the past, or a bowl carved from a meteorite that holds visions of the sky when the world was young. Their tools are never hammers; they use polished stones, fossil lenses, and the patient pressure of a thumb on a petroglyph.

The Witch's Tool: The Eye of the World-Worm. A smooth, oval stone, polished to a mirror sheen, with a spiral fossil embedded at its centre. Once per session, the witch may hold the stone to their eye and look at any ancient structure, fossil, or relic. For the next scene, they see the last significant event that occurred near that object as a ghostly overlay – the mason carving the keystone, the dinosaur stepping into the tar pit, the priest sealing the tomb. The vision is silent but detailed; the GM must describe one useful fact (e.g., "the entrance was hidden behind a tapestry," "the fossil's tail points north"). The stone grows warm when it is ready to be used again.

A Hedge Gift: Echo of the Deep (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may place a hand on a stone structure (a wall, a bridge, a cliff) and speak a single word. The stone "repeats" the last word spoken in its presence by any creature – but the word is always in the voice of the last person who touched it, even if they are long dead. This can be used to identify the inhabitants of a ruin, or to frighten the superstitious.

Nidhoggr's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Stone Sense: +1 die to detect ancient sites, hidden history, or geological features.	Temporal Drift: Speak in archaic patterns; -1 die to modern social interactions.
2	Memory Echo: Once/session, perfectly recall one historical fact as if witnessed.	Heavy Presence: 1 Fatigue in places with no history or recent construction.
3	Earth Whisper: +2 dice to commune with stone, read echoes, or interpret ancient sites.	Rooted: -1 die to actions requiring rapid movement or aerial maneuvers.
4	Dream Prophet: Once/scene, gain +1 die to actions tied to ancient mysteries.	Ancestral Haunting: Visions interrupt sleep; mark 1 SB if rest is disturbed.
5	Timeless Gaze: Once/session, witness distant past events through stone communion.	Geological Pace: -1 die to reactions requiring haste; act with deliberate slowness.
6+	World-Memory: Become a living archive for one scene (+3 dice to historical knowledge).	Time's Weight: Mark +2 Obligation; risk permanent Harm from temporal overload.

Playstyle Notes

Nidhoggr rewards patience, curiosity, and a reverence for the past. Followers excel as archaeologists, relic hunters, and scholars who uncover truths that others would leave buried. The corruption progression leads characters toward becoming living libraries of forgotten lore, but at the cost of connection to the present moment – and sometimes the loss of their own identity in the weight of ages. Ideal for players who love exploration, mystery, and the thrill of unearthing what was never meant to be found.

Emphasises

- **Ancient Knowledge:** the past is a resource, not a relic
- **Stone Communion:** the earth remembers everything
- **Relic Hunting:** every ruin is a story, every artifact a clue
- **Temporal Patience:** some secrets take centuries to ripen
- **Metaphorical Bones:** history is not dead – it is dreaming

6.8.23 The Ninth, Beyond Comprehension (Infinite Information & Unknowable Truths)

Lore. Beyond the eighth figure of Sacred Geometry lies a rim no compass will hold. The Ninth is not absence but surplus: knowledge poured past the lip of any vessel, truth that overgrows the frame that seeks to bind it. Those who bend the knee at its lectern become conduits for impossible reckonings — glimpsing patterns that cannot be kept whole inside a single skull. Each revelation purchases power at the price of living comfortably within the world's common measures.

The Ninth does not explain, define, or warn. It *overflows*. To invoke it is to step past the eighth threshold—the one you did not know was there—and find that on the other side, the cup forgets its shape, the bell rings a note that was never cast, and the answer to your question arrives as a question you had not yet learned to ask.

“Eight figures bind the world; the Ninth overflows it. Drink, and remember that the cup forgets its shape before the song is done.”

Domain Focus

- **Hyperdimensional Knowledge:** reckonings that do not fit a single plane or proof
- **Incomprehensible Truths:** insights that demand the seer be changed to hold them
- **Information Overflow:** boon and peril of minds run past their brim
- **Conceptual Transcendence:** thinking beyond the usual ledgers and names
- **Threshold Breaking:** stepping past the eighth boundary into what should not exist

Rites of the Ninth

Rite of the Ninth Figure (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [THRESHOLD]

Materials: A chalk figure with an "impossible" joint, or a reckoning worked toward infinity on slate.

Effect: Glimpse past the ordinary frame of measure. Gain **+1 die** to *Lore* or *Investigation* when wrestling complex systems or many-layered problems.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Flooded Scriptorium (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [SPEED], [OVERFLOW]

Materials: An overburdened ledger-hall, stacked codices, a bell that tolls the copying-hour without cease.

Effect: Read faster than hands can turn pages. Ask three questions upon any topic that leaves a written wake; gain **+2 dice** to rolls of analysis this scene.

Push It: The tide of knowing overruns its banks — suffer **Fatigue 1** and mark **1 SB**

(**Diamonds**) as overflow breeds complication.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Hypercognitive Lattice (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Tags: [BOOST], [THRESHOLD], [OVERFLOW]

Materials: A brass-thought lattice, an orrery of inked threads, or a draught that sharpens memory.

Effect: Widen the mind's mouth. For this scene, treat your *Wits* as +2 higher for information-processing rolls; you may track several intricate streams at once.

Push It: The opening does not quite close: keep the boon, but suffer –1 **die** to single-task focus; mark 1 **SB (Clubs)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Breaking Glyph (Standard, 7 XP)

Extended; Self; Yes.

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [TRUTH], [THRESHOLD]

Materials: A vigil in dim light, a water-clock, and a problem sworn not to be left half-seen.

Effect: Take one pattern whole. Choose a complex system, theory, or design and gain perfect internal grasp of it; receive +3 **dice** to related knowledge rolls for the session.

Push It: Your tongue cannot carry what your mind now holds: you cannot clearly teach or translate this insight; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Endless Stacks (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [AREA], [KNOWLEDGE], [OVERFLOW], [THRESHOLD]

Materials: A hall of mirrored shelves, wax-tablets without end, whispering leaves of vellum.

Effect: Raise a locus of overfull knowing. All present gain +2 **dice** to information-work; knowledge may be drawn from unlikely sources. Start a [6] **Information Overload** clock — as it fills, participants strain and fray.

Push It: The Stacks wake and demand tithe in understanding or memory; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Ninth Revelation (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; Yes.

Tags: [TRUTH], [THRESHOLD], [TRANSFORM], [FATE]

Materials: A fast from easy speech, a circle of unbroken figures, and vows to see past comfort.

Effect: Glimpse a shard of Ninth truth. Take one major insight that overleaps common frames — perfect command of a knotty system, forecast of chaotic motion, or comprehension of an "impossible" relation.

Push It: The shard sets in you like glass: gain **Transcendent Understanding** (see Corruption) and mark +2 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Ninth

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Ninth sings in *phrases that fold back on themselves* — melodies that seem to have no beginning or end, harmonies that shift key in ways that should be impossible. Their voice is used to encrypt a message into a tune that only the intended listener can hear, to unravel the logic of a paradox, or to lull a library's guardian spirit into a momentary confusion. The Ninth's Cantors are often found in great archives, humming while they work.

The Cult of the Unfinished Index. The Ninth's cults meet in libraries, scriptoria, and the back rooms of printing houses — but the innermost circle, the *Unfinished Index*, has a stranger practice: each member carves a single extra joint into a finger of their writing hand (a ninth knuckle that does not bend). They believe that the extra joint holds a question they have not yet learned to ask. A ritual involves each member writing a fact they have never told anyone on a slip of paper, then burning it. The ashes are swept into a single book — the *Growing Ledger* — whose pages multiply each year and *whisper* at night, adding entries no one wrote. Their creed is stamped inside the cover: "*Every answer births nine new questions. This is not a flaw. This is the shape of truth.*" Outsiders are welcome to ask a question, but they will leave with three they did not bring — and sometimes, a faint, extra knuckle that fades by morning.

Witchcraft of the Ninth (Lay / Knowledge)

A witch who walks with the Ninth is a *glyph-carver* or *pattern-weaver* — one who crafts knowledge into physical form: a book that writes itself, a map that shows only the routes the reader does not yet know, or a code that cannot be broken because it was never written. Their magic works through the tools of information: a quill that writes in letters that shift meaning with the light, a seal that stamps "APPROVED" onto documents that were never submitted, or a lens that reveals hidden writing. Their craft is never about forging metal; it is about folding paper, spilling ink, and stepping past the eighth line of a proof into the white space where the answer is not written because the question was wrong.

The Witch's Tool: The Paradox Quill. A quill carved from the bone of a bird that never lived, dipped in ink that dries clear. Once per session, the witch may write a single sentence on a surface (a wall, a scroll, a forehead). The sentence is true — but only for the next hour. After that, it becomes a lie, or fades, or was never there at all. The GM determines the exact effect, but the truth is always useful for that hour.

A Hedge Gift: Glyph of Unfolding (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may draw a single geometric symbol on a surface (a door, a lock, a piece of paper) while speaking a question aloud. The symbol "unfolds" into a diagram that answers the question — but

the diagram is always incomplete, cryptic, or reveals something the seeker did not wish to know. The witch gains +1 **die** to any roll that uses the diagram's information.

Corruption of the Ninth

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hyperawareness: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> when patterns whisper that they matter.	Starved for Text: –1 die in barren halls with little record or sign; you itch for a stream to read.
2	Pattern Recognition: Once/scene, see connections others miss within tangled accounts and signs.	Scattered Threads: Thoughts run in parallel; –1 die to sustained, single-line focus.
3	Data Synthesis: Once/session, fuse vast reckonings at a glance into a usable answer.	Tongue-Tied by Wonder: –2 dice to teach or clearly explain your deepest insights.
4	Dimensional Insight: Once/scene, take a problem from an "impossible" angle and treat a knot as if already loosened.	Bent Sense: Ordinary space and tasks feel ill-fit; –1 die to plain spatial or mundane labours.
5	Infinite Processing: Once/session, render perfect analysis of any information system or record-trail.	Concept Drift: Common categories slip; –1 die to easy company and familiar talk.
6+	Ninth Awareness: Once/session, look from outside the frame; for a heartbeat, the world aligns.	Transcendent Fragmentation: Mark +3 Obligation; risk standing only partly in the world, present and absent in turn.

Playstyle Notes

The Ninth favours the patient reader of tangled ledgers and sky-signs alike. It rewards audacity in thought and the courage to let understanding change you. Its gifts turn riddles into roads – but every road leads past a threshold you did not know existed. To serve the Ninth is to accept that you will never again fit comfortably inside the frame you once called home. Intrusions often take the form of sudden, inexplicable knowledge (a face you recognise from a dream, a word in a language you have never learned), or a question posed by a stranger who seems to know exactly what you were thinking. Refusing an intrusion does not bring punishment – merely the slow forgetting of the insight you were about to receive, leaving you with the sense that you once knew something important, but can no longer recall what.

Emphasises

- **Hyperdimensional Knowledge:** insights that escape a single page
- **Cognitive Expansion:** widening the mind to hold more than comfort allows
- **Pattern Transcendence:** seeing threads that run beneath names and weights

- **Information Synthesis:** binding many scraps into one true line
- **Conceptual Breakthrough:** stepping past the frame rather than painting within it
- **Threshold Overflow:** the power of the ninth step, the extra word, the unasked question

6.8.24 Oath of Flame & Light (Dawn & Vows)

Lore. The Oath of Flame & Light is no patron of half-measures. Its fire names, binds, and burns—demanding that those who swear within its radiance stand openly, speak truly, and pay the cost of keeping their word. At dawn altars, the sworn kindle sparks of consecrated fire; in battle, they blaze as torches that hold back the night. To follow this Oath is to live in public truth, with no shadow to hide in and no retreat from the vow once spoken.

The Oath appears in many guises across cultures, and is the patron most commonly called upon by the magic-users of the Church of Flame and the Temple of Light – as well as any fire- or light-based faith or order:

- **The Everflame** — the unquenchable fire of promise, carried from shrine to shrine by wandering priests of the Church of Flame. Its censers never cool.
- **Adur**, the Light of Aeler — worshiped as the sun’s church-deity, whose flame consecrates oaths and consumes falsehood. Dwarven templars strike their oaths into stone with a brand.
- **Adar**, the Vilikari Dawnfire — invoked as a war-god of vows and vengeance, whose rising light marks those who break faith. Cavalrymen light a single arrow before battle.
- **The Watchfire of Vhasia** — a saint’s flame that never gutters, tended by a silent order of healers who swear to harm no one – and to let no one die alone.
- Others know the Oath only as *the Flame* or *the Lantern*, a nameless fire that still demands truth and punishes betrayal.

Wherever it manifests, the Oath of Flame & Light remains the same unyielding power: to swear beneath its dawn is to bind one’s self to a truth that cannot be hidden, forgotten, or undone.

“Swear in the light. Keep it, or the light will keep *you*.”

Domain Focus

- **Sacred Vows:** Oath-keeping, truth-speaking, binding promises
- **Divine Justice:** Retribution, smiting evil, protecting the innocent
- **Radiant Power:** Healing light, purification, revealing truth
- **Dawn’s Hope:** Renewal, protection, driving back darkness

Rites of the Oath of Flame & Light

Rite of Kindle Vow (Low, 4 XP)

Action; Self/Ally; Standard Push

Tags: [VOW], [RADIANT]

Materials: A glass ampoule of consecrated flame.

Effect: Declare a short vow for this scene (e.g., "protect the villagers," "speak only truth"). The bearer gains +1 **die** to actions fulfilling it.

Push It: The first hesitation forces 1 **SB (Hearts)** on the bearer.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Lay on Hands (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Touch; Standard Push

Tags: [HEAL], [PURIFY], [RADIANT]

Materials: A bare palm, a whispered vow.

Effect: Cleanse an affliction, downgrade Harm by 1, or remove 1 Fatigue. For curses or poisons, test Spirit+Resolve (DV set by fiction).

Push It: The target gains +1 die to their next Resist roll this scene; you mark Exposure +1.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Sunlit Parley (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [TRUTH], [COMMAND], [RADIANT]

Materials: A vow-ring engraved with sunrise.

Effect: Establish terms in open light. Honest persuasion gains +1 die; deceit suffers -1 die. Create a 6-segment *Parley Accord* clock.

Push It: Demand one public answer; evasion forces 1 SB (Hearts) on the evader.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Radiant Smite (Standard, 9 XP)

Action; Self; Standard Push

Tags: [STRIKE], [BURN], [RADIANT]

Materials: A consecrated spark on a weapon or badge.

Effect: Your next melee strike flares with dawnfire. Upgrade Effect by one step, add +1 Burn Harm, or force 1 SB (Spades). Against undead, oath-breakers, or outsiders: oath-breakers suffer -1 die, outsiders gain +1 Exit Tally.

Push It: On a hit, the burst drives back enemies in Close (worse Position); mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Purge the Shadow (Standard, 10 XP)

Instant; Near; Standard Push

Tags: [DISPEL], [REVEAL], [RADIANT]

Materials: A shattered consecrated spark.

Effect: Reveal illusions and suppress one ongoing glamour or curse in Near range. Creates a 4-segment *Purity's Light* clock.

Push It: Brand the source with a visible tell for this arc; mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Covenant Blaze (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; High Push

Tags: [WARD], [FORCE], [RADIANT], [COMMAND]

Materials: A brazier lit while three names are spoken.

Effect: The sworn within are haloed: they gain +1 die to keep their oath; aggressors suffer -1 die if violating the terms. Oath-breakers suffer 2 SB (Hearts/Spades) and Harm 1 (Burn).

Push It: Sanctify a threshold with one beat of [WARD] against oath-breakers; mark +2

Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Oath of Flame & Light

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Oath sings in *clarion tones* – melodies that sound like a trumpet at sunrise, like a bell calling the faithful to prayer. Their voice is used to swear in a witness, to consecrate a blade with a hymn, or to sing a funeral pyre into a beacon. The Oath's Cantors are often found in military camps and pilgrimage roads, their songs keeping oaths fresh and courage hot.

The Cult of the Unquenched Flame. The Oath's cults gather at dawn, in open courtyards or on hilltops facing east. The Unquenched Flame is a fellowship of paladins, healers, and simple folk who have sworn to keep one another honest. A ritual of the Cult involves each member speaking a vow aloud as the sun crests the horizon, then passing a lit candle to the next – the flame must not be allowed to go out until all have spoken. Their creed is written in charcoal above every hearth: *"The flame that reveals the truth also warms the hands that keep it."* Outsiders are welcome to swear a temporary vow and share the light – but an oath sworn at dawn is binding until sunset.

Witchcraft of the Oath of Flame & Light (Monastic / Scholarly)

A witch who walks with the Oath is often a *consecrated scribe*, a *censer-bearer*, or a *vowed healer* – a nun, monk, or scholar of one of the great flame-temples. Their magic is inseparable from liturgy, prayer, and the careful tending of sacred spaces. They illuminate manuscripts with gold leaf that glows in the presence of lies, brew unguents from ashes of the everflame, and copy oath-books whose letters burn when a vow is broken. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "prayer keystone" into a basilica wall, so that every confession spoken there warms the stone. In Vhasia, a silent sister might stitch a healing shroud that records the wounds it has mended.

The Witch's Tool: Prayer Beads of the Unbroken Vow. A string of nine beads carved from olive wood and fired in a basilica's censer. Each bead represents a clause of a sacred oath. Once per session, the witch may slip the beads around a door handle, a prisoner's wrist, or a contract scroll. While the beads remain, any creature that knowingly violates an oath sworn under that threshold suffers a mild burn (1 Fatigue) as the beads glow faintly. The beads may also be used to count a silent vow; the witch may reroll one failed Resolve roll when upholding that vow.

A Hedge Gift: Sealed Benediction (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may lay a hand on a willing creature's forehead and speak a short, formal blessing (e.g., "May the flame keep your word"). The target gains +1 **die** on their next roll to resist fear, despair, or magical coercion. The blessing lasts until the next dawn. The witch must write the blessing on a scrap of parchment and burn it; the smoke carries the prayer.

Oath of Flame & Light Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Oathbound Strength: +1 die when upholding vows or defending innocents.	Rigid Honour: Must uphold vows even when disadvantageous; –1 die to flexible actions.
2	Radiant Sight: Once/scene, +2 dice to detect lies or corruption.	Blinding Truth: –1 die to subtlety or deception attempts.
3	Holy Flame: +1 die to melee against undead, outsiders, or oath-breakers.	Burden of Light: 1 Fatigue when concealing identity or working in darkness.
4	Unwavering Resolve: Once/session, treat a failed Resolve/Command as success (mark 1 SB).	Absolutist Stance: –1 die in morally ambiguous situations.
5	Dawn's Benediction: Once/session, heal all allies in Near of 1 Fatigue and minor Conditions.	Beacon's Call: Your aura reveals you; enemies seeking you gain +1 die.
6+	Avatar of the Oath: Once/session, become a living covenant (+2 dice to protection/justice actions).	Radiance's Price: Mark +2 Obligation; breaking any vow inflicts Harm 2 (Burn).

Playstyle Notes

The Oath of Flame & Light excels as a "paladin" patron, rewarding vow-keeping and truth-speaking with potent defensive and smiting abilities. Followers become living embodiments of their oaths, shining beacons against deception and darkness. The corruption progression naturally leads toward becoming an uncompromising force for justice, though potentially at the cost of flexibility and subtlety. Ideal for characters who embody conviction, protection, and radiant power.

6.8.25 Oath of Mercy and Grace (Healing & Forgiveness)

Lore. The Oath of Mercy and Grace has no founder, no scripture, no single temple. It began in a hundred places—a battlefield where a medic bound wounds without asking whose side; a plague village where a stranger stayed to dig graves; a debtor’s cell where a guard looked away and said, “I saw nothing.” Those who swear the Oath do not worship a power; they embody a principle: that every act of care creates an obligation—not to the giver, but to the next person in need. You do not pay back. You pay forward. The mercy spirals.

But mercy is not weakness. The spiral does not forget. Those who strike a healer, who violate a sanctuary, who refuse the offered cup—they find that grace has teeth, and forgiveness carries a price.

“You ask who owes what. We ask who needs what. The ledger is not the same as the meal. But woe to the one who mistakes the server for a servant.”

Domain Focus

- **Restorative Work:** healing body, mind, and spirit; mending what is broken.
- **Spiral Mercy:** paying obligation forward through acts of care.
- **Sanctuary:** sheltering the hunted, feeding the hungry, accepting no payment—but demanding respect for the threshold.
- **Unburdening:** releasing others (and oneself) from the weight of unpaid debts, and binding aggressors to that same weight.

Rites of the Oath of Mercy and Grace

Rite of the Shared Bowl (Low, 4 XP)

Action; Touch; Standard Push

Tags: [HEAL], [BOND], [RESTORATION]

Materials: A clay bowl of clean water, shared with a willing creature.

Effect: You and the creature each clear 1 Fatigue. The creature gains +1 die on their next roll to resist fear or despair.

Push It: Extend the benefit to all creatures who drink from the bowl (up to six). Mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of Healing Waters (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Touch; Standard Push

Tags: [HEAL], [PURIFY], [RESTORATION]

Materials: Water from a blessed source (a spring, a well, or a river where the Oath has been invoked), poured onto a wound.

Effect: Remove 1 Harm from a touched creature. If the wound is cursed or poisoned, the GM may call for a Spirit+Lore test (DV 4).

Push It: Also remove one Condition (e.g., Poisoned, Cursed, Blinded). Mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Vow of Pacifism (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [VOW], [PROTECT], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Materials: A white cord tied around the weapon hand.

Effect: You swear not to kill for the scene. In exchange, you gain +1 **Armor** and +1 **die to all resist rolls**. If a creature harms you while this vow is active, they immediately gain a **Promise Clock [4]** named “Mercy’s Reckoning.” When that clock fills (by them continuing violence), they suffer Harm 1 (Stress) as their own aggression turns inward.

Push It: Extend the protective effect to one ally within Near. Mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unburdened Circle (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [DEBT], [BOND], [RESTORATION], [AREA]

Materials: At least three willing participants, a circle drawn in ash or flour, a single candle.

Effect: Each participant clears 1 Obligation (to any patron or debt). One participant of the GM’s choice gains a permanent String: *Witnessed by the Circle* – they may call on any other participant for one act of care, once per campaign.

Push It: The GM gains 3 Story Beats (the universe notes that a community of mutual aid is forming). Mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Sheltered Hearth (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [WARD], [PROTECT], [DEBT], [AREA], [FEAR]

Materials: A door or threshold, a lit candle, a whispered vow of sanctuary.

Effect: For one night, any fugitive, debtor, or refugee who crosses that threshold cannot be pursued or harmed within the zone. The sanctuary holds until dawn. Any creature that violates this sanctuary (by attacking or forcibly entering) gains a **Promise Clock [6]** named “Sanctuary Breach.” When full, they suffer a Curse chosen by the GM (e.g., “doors close in your face,” “your name is forgotten by hosts”).

Push It: Extend the sanctuary to a full day. Mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Shield of the Unburdened (Standard, 8 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [PROTECT], [DEBT], [TRANSFER], [FEAR]

Materials: A grey cloak or a bandage wrapped around your own arm.

Effect: When an ally within Near would take Harm, you may interpose yourself and take that Harm instead. After doing so, the attacker must make a **Spirit+Resolve** test (DV 4) or gain a **Promise Clock [4]** named “Debt of Blood.” The clock ticks each time they refuse a genuine plea for mercy or aid. When full, they suffer Fatigue 2 as guilt manifests.

Push It: You may also redirect a Condition (e.g., Poisoned, Cursed) from the ally to yourself. Mark +1 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Spiral's Witness (Standard, 10 XP)*Instant; Near; Standard Push***Tags:** [DEBT], [RESTORATION], [FEAR], [TRUTH]**Materials:** A grey wool cord tied around the caster's wrist.**Effect:** Name a person crushed by debt or guilt. For one hour, they ignore all penalties from unpaid obligations (social, legal, or spiritual). They are not free; they are unburdened. If that person then commits an act of violence against an innocent, the unburdening reverses and they suffer double penalties.**Push It:** The effect lasts until the next dawn. Mark +1 Obligation.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Covenant of Shared Suffering (High, 13 XP)***Scene; Zone; High Push***Tags:** [BOND], [TRANSFER], [HEAL], [AREA], [DEBT]**Materials:** A circle of nine grey stones, a bowl of water, a candle lit at each cardinal point, and a drop of blood from each participant.**Effect:** All within the circle who accept the Oath's blessing are linked. For the scene:

- Damage taken by any linked ally may be split among any other linked allies (each chooses to accept 1 Fatigue or 1 Harm).
- When you heal a linked ally, you may also heal yourself for half the amount (round down).
- The first time a linked ally would be reduced to 0 Harm, you may sacrifice 1 Fatigue to keep them standing.

Push It: The covenant persists for a full day. Mark +2 Obligation.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 7 segments.***Rite of the Endless Spiral (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Zone; High Push***Tags:** [HEAL], [RESTORATION], [DEBT], [AREA], [FEAR]**Materials:** A circle of nine grey stones, a bowl of tears, and a candle lit at each cardinal point.**Effect:** All within the circle who accept the Oath's blessing clear 2 Fatigue and remove one Condition caused by despair or guilt. For the rest of the scene, any act of care performed within the zone costs the giver -1 Obligation (minimum 0). Additionally, any creature that harms a caregiver within the zone gains a **Promise Clock [6]** named "Spiral's Debt." When full, they suffer Harm 2 (Stress) as the weight of their cruelty crushes them.**Push It:** The blessing persists for a full day. Mark +2 Obligation.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation: 8 segments.***The Spiral Strikes Back (8 XP, Major)***Prerequisites: Oath of Mercy and Grace, Spirit 3+.*

You have learned that mercy can be a weapon. When a creature with an active Promise

Clock (from any of your Rites) attacks you or an ally under your protection, you may spend 1 Boon to immediately advance that clock by 2 segments. If this fills the clock, the creature suffers the consequence immediately (Harm, Condition, or Curse as described). You may only use this once per scene.

Corruption Perk (Tier 4+): Mercy's Edge

Once per session, when you would reduce a sentient enemy to 0 Harm, you may instead spare their life and bind them with a **Promise Clock [6]** named “Spared.” While this clock is active, they cannot knowingly harm you or those you have explicitly named as under your protection. They may work off the clock by performing three acts of genuine care for others (GM discretion). If they break the bond, the clock fills instantly and they suffer Harm 2 (Stress) – the spiral closes.

Hospitaller Knight of the Grey Spiral

Mercy without steel is a prayer. Steel without mercy is a curse. We carry both – but we sheath the blade before we draw it.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Body 2+, Rite of the Sheltered Hearth or Rite of the Shield of the Unburdened.

Hospitaller Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Grey Ward	When you take the <i>Defend</i> action, you also grant an adjacent ally +1 Armour until your next turn.	Passive	Body 3, Melee 2
Shield of the Unburdened	Once per scene, as a reaction, redirect a melee attack aimed at an adjacent ally to yourself. The attack automatically hits you.	1 Fatigue	Spirit 3
Mercy's Pace	You ignore the first point of Fatigue each scene caused by exhaustion (forced marches, lack of sleep, extreme weather).	Passive	Spirit 3, Tier II
Spiral Counter	When a creature with an active Promise Clock attacks you, you may spend 1 Boon to advance that clock by 1 segment immediately, before the attack resolves.	1 Boon	Tier III
Hospitaller's Vow	You may use the <i>HEAL</i> cantrip on any ally within Near range, not just touch.	+1 Obligation per use	Spirit 3, HEAL cantrip
Unbroke: Cord	When you use a Promise Clock from any of your Oath rites, it can only be advanced by the GM if you fail a Spirit+Resolve test (DV 4). Otherwise, the clock ticks only when you or an ally is harmed.	Passive	Tier III, Spirit 4

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *The Spiral's Final Witness.* Once per session, when a creature with an active Promise Clock (from any of your Oath rites) would deal a killing blow to an ally, you may interpose yourself. The blow is redirected to you, and you suffer the Harm instead. After the attack, the Promise Clock fills immediately, and the attacker suffers the consequence (Harm, Condition, or Curse). You cannot use this talent again until you have spent a downtime scene in meditation or prayer.

Cantors & Cults of the Oath of Mercy and Grace

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Oath sings in *harmonies of the unburdened* – melodies that lift without rising, harmonies that wrap around a wound like a clean bandage. Their voice is used to calm the panicked, to ease the pain of the dying, or to sing a debtor gently into the spiral. Mercy's Cantors are often found in hospices, refugee camps, and the halls of the condemned, their songs a reminder that no debt is too heavy to be carried by more than one pair of hands.

The Cult of the Grey Spiral. The Oath's cults are not secret – they are quiet. They gather in hospices, soup kitchens, and the prayer rooms of hospitals. The Grey Spiral is a fellowship of healers, hospice workers, and those who have learned that mercy is a muscle that must be exercised. A ritual of the Spiral involves each member tying a grey wool cord around their wrist (or a patient's wrist) while speaking a single act of care they received from a stranger. The cord is then cut and burned, and the ashes are scattered in a place where the hungry gather. Their creed is embroidered on every grey cloak: *"You do not pay back. You pay forward. The spiral is patient."* Outsiders are welcome to sit in silence, but they must accept a cup of water and speak a truth about a wound they carry.

The Hospitaller Knights of the Grey Spiral. A militant order within the Oath who believe that mercy must be defended. They carry no swords—only shields, staves, and the grey wool cord. They are sworn to protect healers, refugees, and the sick, and they have a fearsome reputation: *"Strike the healer, and the spiral will remember. The debt will be collected, if not by us, then by the weight of your own cruelty."*

Witchcraft of the Oath of Mercy and Grace (Lay / Monastic)

A witch who walks with the Oath is a *lay healer*, a *hospice sister*, or a *grey brother* – a nun, monk, or lay religious who tends the sick, comforts the dying, and offers sanctuary to the hunted. Their magic is not the flashy alchemy of a potion-maker; it is the quiet, patient work of a wound that closes a day early, a fever that breaks at midnight, or a debtor who finds the courage to confess. Their tools are not hammers or chisels; they use grey wool cords, clay bowls, and the small brass bells that ring only when a prayer is answered.

The Witch's Tool: The Cord of the Unbroken Spiral. A grey wool cord braided with nine knots, each knot tied in silence while speaking a name of someone who was healed. Once per session, the witch may touch the cord to a wounded creature (including themselves) and untie a single knot. The creature clears 1 Fatigue and, if they are suffering from a minor Condition (Fear, Shaken, Guilty), may test Spirit+Resolve (DV 3) to remove it. The knot cannot be retied until the next dawn. The cord can also be used to mark a threshold: tying it around a door handle or bedpost grants +1 die to all rolls made to protect the inhabitant for the night.

A Hedge Gift: Benediction of the Spiral (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may lay a hand on a willing creature and whisper a short prayer (or a word of forgiveness). For the next hour, the creature feels lighter – they ignore the first point of Fatigue from exhaustion, and any social roll made to ask for mercy or forgiveness gains +1 die. The blessing ends if the creature commits a violent act against an innocent.

Oath of Mercy and Grace Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Soothing Presence: +1 die to calm or comfort others.	Burden of Care: -1 die when ignoring suffering; must help or mark Fatigue.
2	Quick Bandage: Once/scene, heal 1 Fatigue as a reaction.	Empathic Bleed: You feel the pain of those you heal; 1 Fatigue if you heal a major wound.
3	Sanctuary Sense: +2 dice to detect sanctuary violations.	Threshold Weary: -1 die in places with no sacred boundary.
4	Spiral Witness: Once/session, force an aggressor to test Resolve or be shaken.	Promised Weight: Must keep all promises to the vulnerable; breaking one costs 1 SB (Hearts).
5	Merciful End: Once/session, grant a peaceful death to a willing creature (no roll).	Echo of Loss: Suffer 1 Fatigue when you cannot prevent a death.
6+	Spiral Incarnate: Once/session, become a living knot; all Promise Clocks in the scene advance toward fulfillment.	Debt of Mercy: Mark +2 Obligation; risk becoming unable to refuse a plea for help.

Playstyle Notes

The Oath of Mercy and Grace supports both pure healers and **Hospitaller defenders**—characters who wade into battle not to kill, but to shield, to bind, and to turn violence back on itself as obligation. Your “teeth” are not fangs but *leashes*: every enemy who harms you or your charges accrues a debt that will eventually cripple them. This works best in campaigns where the GM tracks Promise Clocks and where enemies have names and faces—the spiral is less effective against mindless beasts, but against human foes, it is terrifying.

Rivalries

- **The Inquisitor Prime:** Mercy without judgment is heresy to the Prime. The two orders clash constantly over the fate of prisoners, heretics, and the “unforgivable.”
- **Malachai (Cruel Messenger):** Malachai offers cursed gifts; the Oath offers unburdening. Their followers are natural enemies—one feeds on despair, the other starves it.

6.8.26 The Pale Shepherd, Guide of Transitions (Passage & Melancholic Wisdom)

Lore. The Pale Shepherd walks the seam between all things – life and death, joy and sorrow, memory and forgetting, the known and the unmarked. Neither wholly kind nor cruel, the Shepherd guides those who must pass through the hardest doors. Cloaked, with shadow-sheep that bear the shed wool of old possibilities, the Shepherd offers safe conduct through liminal space for a price paid in memory, feeling, or fate. Those who walk this road learn the hidden routes between states of being and can lead others through their hardest crossings – but each passage leaves them more attuned to endings than beginnings.

The Shepherd has no will, only a path; no demand, only a presence. It does not seek followers, but those who stand at thresholds – of death, of grief, of irreversible change – may find the Shepherd already there, waiting to accompany them. Its “demands” are not commands but the natural toll of passage: a memory left behind, a name forgotten, a tear shed for no reason. The Shepherd does not punish refusal; it simply withdraws, and the crossing becomes harder.

Among the Aelaerem, the Shepherd is called the *Pale Gardener*, who walks the hedgerows at twilight, collecting the souls of those who die far from home. In Aeler, the *Breath-Accountant* weighs the last exhalation of the dying. In Linn, the *Fog-Walker* appears on the horizon before a storm. In Viterra, the *Silent Notary* witnesses deathbed testaments. Wherever mortals face the hardest thresholds, the Pale Shepherd is there – not to judge, not to command, but to accompany.

“The Shepherd goes where feet fail, speaks where voices thin, and points where paths run dim. Each journey loosens the knot that tied you to the life you left behind.”

Domain Focus

- **Liminal Navigation:** walking and reading thresholds, dusk-roads, and in-betweens
- **Passage Guidance:** steadying hands through grief, change, and transformation
- **Melancholic Wisdom:** understanding born of farewells and last looks
- **Memory Shepherd:** gathering, carrying, and setting down weighted moments

Rites of the Pale Shepherd**Rite of the Gentle Guide (Low, 5 XP)**

Scene; Near/Self; Yes.

Tags: [GUIDANCE], [BOOST], [THRESHOLD], [RISK]

Materials: A small stone from a grave or threshold, warmed in the palm; or a thread from a worn garment and a pinch of dawn mist.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Gentle Guidance:** Ease a hard crossing. One target gains +1 die to rolls involving change, decision, or emotional steadiness this scene.
- **Hidden Path:** Find or make a way where none is seen. Gain +2 dice to *Navigation* or *Investigation* when seeking unconventional routes.

Push It: (Hidden Path only) The way runs through a true between-place; gain the route but mark **1 SB (Spades)** as boundary powers take notice.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Passing Flock (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Touch/Zone; Yes.

Tags: [GUIDANCE], [KNOWLEDGE], [HEAL], [AREA], [RISK]

Materials: Black wool and a personal token of the one to be guided; or ash of burned letters and wool shaped into little sheep.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Shadow Passage:** Open a brief passage through shadow-realms. The target bypasses one insurmountable obstacle or reaches a place normally shut.
- **Memory Flock:** Call shadow-sheep that carry fragments of weighty moments. Retrieve lost details, soothe grief, or glean counsel from what was.

Push It: (Passage) The passage leaves a scent-trail; mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as something may follow. (Flock) The memories ride too close to the skin – participants relive them as their own; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Unburdened Farewell (Standard, 6 XP)

Instant; Touch; No.

Tags: [HEAL], [CLEANSE], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Materials: A personal letter never sent, burned in a copper dish.

Effect: Speak a final goodbye to someone who is not present – a lost lover, a dead parent, a friend you wronged. Clear 1 Fatigue and remove one psychological Condition (e.g., *Haunted*, *Guilty*) caused by that relationship. The GM gains **1 SB** as the words drift into the threshold.

Push It: The farewell also grants **+1 die** on your next roll related to moving on from that relationship. Mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Threshold Bond (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [BOND], [FATE], [DEBT], [THRESHOLD]

Materials: Two keepsakes: one of what is left, one of what is sought.

Effect: Bind two states, places, or conditions with a felt thread. Those bound can sense across the threshold and lend one another strength during change.

Push It: The bond sets like iron – permanent and inescapable. Mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Final Shepherd (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [GUIDANCE], [BOOST], [DEBT], [AREA], [FATE]

Materials: Last words, a much-crossed threshold, and the consent of those who remain.

Effect: Take the mantle of perfect guide for a great passage – death, moult, or life-bend. All present gain **+2 dice** to navigate the crossing; you shoulder the weight of it.

Push It: Guidance is flawless but costly: mark **Harm 2 (Weariness)** and **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Death Doula (Folk-Psychopomp)

The door is never locked. I only hold it open. When you are ready, walk through. I will walk with you.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Lore 2+, Rite of the Gentle Guide or Cantor of the Pale Shepherd.

Death Doula Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Comforting Presence	Once per scene, when you touch a creature suffering from Fear, Guilt, or Grief, you may remove that Condition.	1 Fatigue	Spirit 3
Unseen Door	Once per session, you may declare that a locked or barred door (mundane or magical) is “unlocked” for the purpose of passage – it opens freely for you and your allies for one exchange.	1 Boon	Wits 3
Memory Weaver	When you use the Wool-Winder (Witch’s Tool), you may create one extra memory cord per session.	Passive	Tier II
Gentle Re-solve	Allies within Near range gain +1 die to resist fear or despair.	Passive	Spirit 3
Final Witness	Once per session, when a sentient creature dies within Near range, you may ask the GM one question about that creature’s final thoughts or unfulfilled wishes. The GM must answer truthfully.	Free	Tier III
Threshold Keep	You may sense any active threshold (door, gate, bridge, border) within Far range, and you know its “mood” (welcoming, hostile, sorrowful).	Passive	Spirit 3, Lore 2

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *The Unburdened Crossing.* Once per session, when a willing creature (including yourself) is about to die, you may guide them across the threshold. They experience no fear, no pain, and may speak a final sentence before they pass. Afterward, you gain a permanent memory of their last words, which may be used as a Truth Compass (+1 die to any roll directly related to fulfilling their final wish). You gain 1 permanent Corruption –

Cantors & Cults of the Pale Shepherd

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Pale Shepherd sings in *passing tones* – melodies that begin in a major key and end in a minor one, or that fade to silence rather than resolve. Their voice is used to ease a dying person's passage, to comfort the grieving at a funeral, or to lull a restless spirit back to the threshold. The Shepherd's Cantors are often found at hospices, battlefields, and the bedsides of the old, singing the softest of farewells.

The Cult of the Grey Flock. The Shepherd's cults meet in liminal places: cemeteries at dusk, crossroads at midnight, the rooms above funeral parlours. The Grey Flock is a fellowship of death-doulas, grief counsellors, and those who have lost so much that they have become experts in loss. A ritual of the Flock involves each member speaking the name of someone they have guided – and then a moment of silence for those they could not save. Their creed is embroidered on a woollen banner that is never washed: "*The door is never locked. We only hold it open.*" Outsiders are welcome to sit quietly, but they must bring a memory to share.

Witchcraft of the Pale Shepherd (Lay / Threshold)

A witch who walks with the Shepherd is a *shroud-weaver* or *threshold-carver* – one who crafts the tools of safe passage: a woollen shroud that keeps the dead from wandering, a stone carved with a doorway that leads to the next room (or the next life), or a bell that rings only when a soul is ready to cross. Their tools are not hammers; they use spindles, wool, and the gentle pressure of a hand on a doorframe. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "threshold stone" at a hospice's entrance, but a witch of the Shepherd would instead wind a memory cord around the lintel.

The Witch's Tool: The Wool-Winder. A wooden spindle carved from a branch that grew over a grave. Once per session, the witch may wind a length of undyed wool around their hand while speaking a name. The wool becomes a *memory cord* – a physical thread that holds one specific memory of the named person. The cord can be given to another to grant them a single vivid memory of the deceased (e.g., "grandmother's hands knitting"), or it can be burned to release the memory into the threshold, easing grief.

A Hedge Gift: Shepherd's Stone (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a small, smooth stone – preferably from a grave or a threshold – and place it on a dying person's chest (or on a doorframe before a difficult journey). The stone glows faintly, and for the next hour, the person feels no fear of the passage ahead. They gain +1 **die** to any roll involving courage, acceptance, or farewells, and may ignore one point of Fatigue from emotional distress.

The Pale Shepherd's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Boundary Sense: +1 die to <i>Notice</i> thresholds, limens, and turning-moments.	Melancholic Aura: -1 die to bright company and celebrations; your presence gentles joy.
2	Passage Insight: Once/scene, guide another through change (+1 die to their action).	Compulsive Counsel: Urge to advise even when unwelcome.
3	Shadow Comfort: +2 dice to soothe the distressed or those nearing an end.	Near to Death: In lively places, suffer Fatigue 1 from the sting of contrast.
4	Memory Keeper: Once/session, recall a marked moment of your past with perfect clarity.	Burdened Sight: -1 die on hopeful framings; farewells tint your view.
5	Liminal Mastery: Once/session, find a path through any maze, snare, or barred way.	Unmoored: -1 die to acts that demand firm anchoring in the present.
6+	Shepherd's Crown: Once/session, be the sure guide for any great passage.	Soul's Weight: Mark +3 Obligation; risk binding to the between, never wholly in one state.

Playstyle Notes

The Pale Shepherd favours those who steady others at the edge of change. Its gifts open hidden roads, soften endings, and lend courage to cross. Its prices lean toward memory, ease, and the simple warmth of belonging – spent to buy safe passage when it matters most. The Shepherd never demands; it only offers. When a follower accumulates enough Obligation, an intrusion might be a sudden need to guide a dying stranger, a forgotten threshold that now calls to them, or a dream of a road that must be walked before dawn. Refusing the intrusion does not incur wrath – merely the quiet withdrawal of the Shepherd's favour until the follower once again chooses to accompany someone through their hardest door. Ideal for death-doulas, grief counsellors, and anyone who understands that the kindest act is sometimes just to walk beside.

Emphasises

- **Liminal Mastery:** reading and walking the in-between
- **Passage Guidance:** anchoring companions through turns of fate
- **Melancholic Wisdom:** counsel drawn from endings
- **Memory Shepherding:** carrying and setting down what weighs
- **Threshold Navigation:** ways through walls the world insists upon

6.8.27 Palinode, Queen of Encores (Performance & Rapture)

Lore. Once a road-cantor who swore to reconcile feuding towns with procession and song, Palinode died between feasts with a chorus unfinished. Yet the refrain refused to end: it braided toasts, hymns, work-chants, and tavern rounds into a living current that still coils through markets and moots. Where a crowd leans forward and a maker holds breath, she arrives.

Signs. A cup that never quite empties; a candle that gutters only when silence reigns; a flawless bar or note that the hand cannot forget.

Cantor's Temptation. Palinode promises relief from solitude: an audience that always leans closer, a song that never dies, a bond that feels like family even if it devours you. Her rites grant the Cantor not only power but belonging—at the cost of their voice becoming more hers than their own.

“When she sang, the rafters bent to hear.”

“Drink deep: the cup returns, but never empty.”

“Encore is not request but command.”

Domain Focus

- **Ecstatic Performance:** music, dance, theatre, and the rapture of creation
- **Unfinished Art:** the power of the incomplete, the encore that never ends
- **Audience Binding:** captivating crowds, turning spectators into participants
- **Inspired Craft:** works that transcend their maker's intention

Rites of Palinode**Hymn Against Dread (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Near; Resist only.

Tags: [FEAR], [COMMAND], [RADIANT]

Materials: A lit taper or a bell.

Effect: Begin a hymn or chant. Allies in Near gain +2 dice to resist *Fear* this scene. On a 10, they may ignore *Fear* entirely for one round.

Push It: Allies who benefit also clear 1 Fatigue or 1 Complication point; you gain 1 Fatigue at the scene's end.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Single True Note (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Self; No.

Tags: [PERFORMANCE], [BOOST], [BURDEN]

Materials: A note held until your voice frays.

Effect: For one scene you cannot produce an imperfect sound: all performance rolls +2 dice. All other rolls –1 die from intrusive perfection.

Push It: Extend to one ally; both mark **Exposure** +1.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Hooked Chorus (Standard, 7 XP)*Scene; Near; No.***Tags:** [COMMAND], [MIND], [FEAR]**Materials:** A melody braided from the listener's secret want.**Effect:** **Presence + Command vs. Resolve (DV 3)**. Success: target joins in. Partial: they resist but suffer -1 die to social rolls this scene. Failure: they follow entranced.**Push It:** Affects all in Near; start **Compelled Audience [6]**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Binding Hands (Standard, 8 XP)***Scene; Self; No.***Tags:** [BIND], [FOCUS], [BOOST]**Materials:** Your hair woven into your instrument or tool.**Effect:** Enter ruthless focus: creative rolls +2 dice; ignore first 2 Fatigue from exertion. You are [BIND] to the piece until completion or ruin.**Push It:** One ally is also bound; both mark 1 SB (Diamonds).*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Consecrated Stage (High, 13 XP)***Extended; Zone; No.***Tags:** [WARD], [AREA], [BOOST], [SACRIFICE]**Materials:** A stage kissed with the blood of sworn singers.**Effect:** Hallow a venue. All performances +2 dice, +1 Effect. The space is [WARD]ed: any disruption spawns 2 SB. The ward collapses if the performance ends.**Push It:** The stage sustains itself but drains life; start **Performance Hunger [8]**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 7 segments.**Rite of the Crownpiece (High, 14 XP)***Extended; Touch; No.***Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [FATE], [SACRIFICE], [BOOST]**Materials:** Your greatest work and regret, destroyed together.**Effect:** Birth a transcendent masterpiece: +2 dice to creative rolls this session; immune to social manipulation. But all lesser works falter.**Push It:** The piece wakes and demands; mark Harm 1 (Stress); start **Demanding Creation [6]**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).**Obligation:* 8 segments.**Cantors & Cults of Palinode**

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Palinode sings in *unfinished cadences* – melodies that never quite resolve, leaving the listener yearning for the next note. Their voice is used to keep a crowd enthralled, to make a performance unforgettable, or to bind a troupe together with a shared, unreachable ideal. Palinode's Cantors are often found in touring companies, their songs changing slightly each night – because the perfect version is always just out of reach.

The Cult of the Gasping Chorus. Palinode's cults meet in theatres after closing, in rehearsal rooms, or in the wings during a performance. The innermost circle, the *Gasping Chorus*, has a stranger practice: each member wears a small silver bell sewn into their throat, just under the skin; the bell rings only when they are about to tell a lie, and it tolls once when they speak a truth they have never shared. A ritual involves each member performing a fragment – a verse, a step, a gesture – and then passing the "unfinished" piece to the next person to complete. The cycle never ends, and the chorus breathes as one, gasping when a phrase is left unresolved. Their creed is written in the margins of a script that is constantly being rewritten: "*The art that is never finished is the art that never dies.*" Outsiders are welcome to watch, but they will be handed a prop or a note and expected to join – and those who stay for the entire ritual find that they can no longer whistle a tune they once knew by heart.

Witchcraft of Palinode (Lay / Performance)

A witch who walks with Palinode is a *instrument-smith* or *stage-weaver* – one who crafts the physical vessels of rapture: a violin that plays notes the player has not yet learned, a mask that shows the audience what they most desire to see, or a stage that remembers every performance and adds its echo to the next. Their tools are never hammers; they work with tuning forks, silk cords, and scraps of unfinished sheet music. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve an acoustic keystone, but a hedge-witch of Palinode might tune a theatre's resonance by humming a specific interval into its cornerstone until the stone hums back.

The Witch's Tool: The Conductor's Baton of Unfinished Phrases. A slender baton carved from the wood of a stage that was never completed, tipped with a silver bell that has no clapper. Once per session, the witch may raise the baton as if to begin a performance. For the next scene, any willing ally who follows the baton's rhythm gains +1 die to Performance or Sway rolls, and any audience member who hears the baton's faint, bell-less ring feels a powerful urge to stay until the "final note" – which never comes. The baton can also be used to "cut off" a performance prematurely, forcing an encore (the performer must immediately reroll a failed Performance check, but the reroll is at –1 die).

A Hedge Gift: Encore's Whisper (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may snap their fingers and whisper a single word ("again," "more," "stay"). For the next minute, any willing performer (including the witch) may reroll one failed Performance or Sway roll, as the audience's desire for more bends reality slightly. The reroll is made at –1 die, and the audience will demand an encore at the end – the witch must perform again (or provide a suitable distraction) or mark 1 Fatigue.

Palinode's Corruption Table

Tier	Gift	Corruption
1	Perfect Pitch: +1 die to Performance.	Restless Ear: Distracted by any flaw; -1 die to non-performance focus.
2	Rapturous Presence: Once/scene, grant allies +1 die to social rolls.	Craves Applause: Suffer 1 Fatigue if ignored or without an audience.
3	Inspired Creation: +2 dice to one artistic act per scene.	Haunted by Drafts: Must obsessively rework; delays other actions.
4	Mesmerising Performance: Once/session, captivate a crowd (Resolve DV 4 to resist).	Lost in the Moment: -1 die to awareness while performing.
5	Artistic Vision: Foresee the perfect form of a work; +2 dice to create it.	Consumed Spark: Must pursue inspiration immediately, no matter the cost.
6+	Queen of Encores: Once/session, create a legendary performance; all present +3 dice to social rolls.	Eternal Encore: Mark +3 Obligation; the performance demands endless repetition until sated. Voice of Palinode: Permanent condition – your words carry her power; must make Wits+Performance (DV 4) to speak normally or risk enchanting listeners against your will.

“Sing until the rafters lean to listen, dance until the ground forgets its name, perform until the boundary between art and reality dissolves entirely.”

Playstyle Notes

Palinode rewards the performer who risks everything for a single, perfect moment. Her followers become masters of ecstatic art, binding audiences and themselves through the power of the unfinished. The corruption progression leads toward a voice that is no longer entirely their own – but one that can command the hearts of all who hear it. Ideal for bards, dancers, actors, and any character who believes that art is worth dying for.

6.8.28 Raéyn, Mistress of the Sea (Tides & Change)

Lore. Raéyn is the tempestuous goddess of the sea, the restless tide that carries news between shores and the promise of change between lives. She is mother to all who sail, her voice the wind that fills sails and her moods the storms that test every mariner's resolve. In Kahfagia, she is called the Storm-Queen; in Linn, the Tide-Mother; in the Brass Coast, the Salt-Widow. Her cult is syncretic, blending the fierce protectiveness of a mother goddess with the practical cunning of a harbour-master.

But Raéyn's heart is torn by her greatest tragedy: her son Khemesh, the Kraken of the Depths, who embodies the crushing inevitability of the ocean's dark heart. Where Raéyn brings change and opportunity, Khemesh brings the final, inescapable pressure that grinds all things to nothing. Sailors pray to Raéyn for safe passage and favourable winds, but whisper Khemesh's name when seeking to lay the dead to rest beneath the waves.

Raéyn is passionate, mercurial, and fiercely protective of those who respect her domain. She favours those who read currents, bargain with weather, and carry news between shores. But cross her, and the sea itself becomes your enemy: fair weather turns to fury, and every wave a judgement.

Mark the tide, name your course, and trust the wave-road. But speak ill of Khemesh, and even I may let the deep take you.

Domain Focus

- **Tides and Currents:** change, opportunity, the rhythm of the sea
- **Maritime Trade and Travel:** safe passage, navigation, weather
- **Storm and Calm:** the duality of protection and wrath
- **Motherhood and Loss:** fierce love, grief for Khemesh, the weight of a divided heart

Rites of Raéyn

Rite of the Wave-Tide (Low, 5 XP)

Scene/Instant; Self; No.

Tags: [MOVEMENT], [NAVIGATION], [BOOST], [RISK]

Materials: A knotted length of salt-twine brushed with seawater, or a shell held to the ear while facing the wind.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Tidemark's Blessing:** Treat slick, swaying, or water-slicked footing as stable for this scene. Gain +1 die on boarding, balance, or shipboard movement. Create a 4-segment *Tide's Favor* clock to ignore one level of difficult terrain.
- **Whispering Currents:** Learn the safest near-term route across water or coastline, or gain +1 die to navigation checks for this scene. If Khemesh's influence is present, suffer -1 die from conflicting currents.

Push It: (Tidemark) Extend to one ally in Close for one beat, but generate **1 SB (Spades)** as the deck shifts. (Currents) Also learn the fastest route, but mark Exposure +1 (leaving a telltale wake).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Changing Tide (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone (water-adjacent); No.

Tags: [TERRAIN], [AREA], [MOVEMENT], [PRESSURE]

Materials: A handful of pebbles cast in a crescent.

Effect: Bias currents and water levels in the zone. Those moving with the tide gain +1 **die**; those moving against suffer –1 **die**. Small craft must test to hold position. Create a 6-segment *Tidal Influence* clock.

Push It: Brief surge or drawdown (one beat): open a ford or swamp a skiff; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Wave-Road Consecration (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Route (sea-to-sea); No.

Tags: [GUIDANCE], [BOOST], [BOND], [FATE]

Materials: Two sea-glass markers dropped overboard at start and end.

Effect: Consecrate a wave-road between two visible points. Allies gain +2 **dice** on travel, evade, or carry actions at sea. Designated pursuers suffer –1 **die** to intercept. One active wave-road at a time. Create an 8-segment *Blessed Passage* clock.

Push It: Extend the route's favour to an adjacent leg for one beat; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Storm-Queen's Hand (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone (sea/shore/sky); No.

Tags: [WEATHER], [AREA], [COMMAND], [FEAR], [BOOST]

Materials: A vial of rainwater gathered at three crossings.

Effect: Shape a storm-band over the zone. Choose two modes at cast; switch one once per scene:

- **Propulsion:** Vessel gains +1 band of movement per beat (or +1 Effect to manoeuvres).
- **Concealment:** Veil of rain/spray; ranged targeting impaired; –1 die to hostile sighting.
- **Smite:** Once per beat, lash with wave or lightning as [AREA] hazard.

Push It: Add a third mode for one beat, then the GM spends 1 SB on collateral; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Mother's Wrath (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Tags: [CURSE], [DEBT], [FEAR], [AREA], [FATE]

Materials: Tears of a betrayed lover mixed with salt from seven seas.

Effect: Curse those who wronged you. The target suffers **−2 dice** to maritime/weather rolls for one session. At sea, they must roll Spirit+Resolve (DV 4) each day or suffer Harm 1 (Weather). Create a 6-segment *Mother's Ire* clock.

Push It: The curse spreads to the target's allies or family; mark **2 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Storm Pilot (Sea-Mage of Kahfagia)

The sea does not hate you. It tests you. Pass, and the waves remember your name.

Prerequisites: Wits 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of the Wave-Tide or Cantor of Raéyn.

Storm Pilot Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Tide-Reading	Once per voyage, you may reroll a failed navigation check at sea.	1 Boon	Wits 3
Storm Glass	You can predict the weather for the next hour with perfect accuracy (no roll).	Passive	Spirit 2, Lore 1
Sea Legs	You ignore all penalties from rough seas or slippery decks.	Passive	Body 2
Call the Breeze	Once per scene, increase your vessel's speed by one band for one exchange.	1 Fatigue	Tier II
Whirlpool Step	When on a ship or dock, you may move as if on solid ground even during a storm or while the vessel is heeling.	Passive	Wits 3, Athletics 2
Kraken's Warning	Once per session, when a sea creature (or Khemesh's influence) would ambush you, you sense it one round in advance. Your party cannot be surprised.	Free	Tier III, Spirit 3

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Eye of the Storm.* Once per session, you may calm a supernatural storm or redirect a natural one for one scene. All weather-based penalties are negated for your vessel and allies within Near. After the scene, the storm returns with double intensity – but you and your allies are already gone. Mark +1 Obligation to Raéyn (the sea remembers your favour).

Cantors & Cults of Raéyn

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Raéyn sings in *shanties of the turning tide* – melodies that rise and fall with the rhythm of waves, harmonies that mimic the creak of rigging and the cry of gulls. Their voice is used to calm a restless sea, to call a favourable wind, or to sing a drowned sailor's soul back to shore. Raéyn's Cantors are often found aboard ships, their songs becoming part of the vessel's luck.

The Cult of the Salt-Washed Circle. Raéyn’s cults gather on beaches at low tide, in sea-caves, and aboard ships during storms. The Salt-Washed Circle is a fellowship of sailors, pilots, fisherfolk, and coastal dwellers who honour the sea’s gifts and respect its rages. A ritual of the Circle involves each member pouring a libation of fresh water into the sea (to honour Raéyn’s tears for Khemesh) while speaking a wish for safe passage or a warning of danger ahead. Their creed is carved into driftwood and left on the tide: *"The sea gives, the sea takes. We who love her learn to swim."* Outsiders are welcome to join a libation, but they must bring salt from their home shore.

Witchcraft of Raéyn (Lay / Maritime)

A witch who walks with Raéyn is a *net-mender* or *tide-seer* – one who crafts with the materials of the tide: a hull carved from wood seasoned by sea-salt, a sail woven with a prayer for fair wind, or a net tied with knots that remember every fish they have caught. Their tools are not hammers; they use shells, rope, and the patient turning of a tide-clock. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a “tide stone” at a harbour entrance, but a witch of Raéyn would instead tie a salt-twine knot around a piling, so that the current remembers to favour outgoing vessels.

The Witch’s Tool: The Wave-Seer’s Shell. A large conch shell, its inner spiral polished to a mirror sheen, rimmed with brass. Once per session, the witch may hold the shell to their ear and listen to the “tide’s memory.” For the next scene, they gain **+2 dice** to navigation or weather-reading rolls, and may ask the GM one yes/no question about hidden currents, reefs, or approaching storms (the shell whispers the answer in a voice like waves). The shell can also be used to “mark” a threshold: placing it on a ship’s prow or a harbour gate grants +1 die to all rolls made to defend that vessel or harbour until the next dawn.

A Hedge Gift: Salt-Kissed Rope (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may tie a simple knot in a rope, cord, or strand of hair while speaking a short prayer to Raéyn. The knot becomes a *tide-knot* – when the witch unties it (as a free action), the nearest body of water (a puddle, a river, the sea) briefly rises or falls by a few inches, as if a small tide has turned. This can unstick a boat, wet a fire, or startle a guard – but never causes direct harm.

Raéyn's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Sailor's Instinct: +1 die to Navigation and maritime survival rolls.	Sea-Sick on Land: –1 die to rolls requiring prolonged time away from water or open spaces.
2	Tide's Favor: Once/scene, treat a failed maritime or weather-related roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).	Weather Sensitive: Must make a Resolve test (DV 3) to resist acting on every weather change or maritime opportunity.
3	Storm's Child: +2 dice to rolls involving weather manipulation or sea-based combat.	Tempestuous Nature: Suffer 1 Fatigue when denied access to open water or weather changes for extended periods.
4	Mother's Protection: Once/session, call upon Raéyn's favor to protect a vessel or coastal area from harm.	Protective Instinct: –1 die to rolls involving personal safety when others are endangered nearby.
5	Wave-Rider: Once/session, navigate any water-based obstacle or hazard with perfect ease.	Restless Spirit: –1 die to rolls requiring patience or stillness; the call of the sea is constant.
6+	Storm Queen: Once/session, become the living embodiment of the sea's power. For one scene, control weather and tides within Near range.	Mother's Burden: Mark +2 Obligation when using this power; the weight of protecting all who sail becomes overwhelming, causing Harm 1 (Stress) until the storm passes. Khemesh's Attention: The Kraken's gaze turns your way; the GM may introduce oceanic complications (rogue waves, crushing pressure) as narrative fallout.

Playstyle Notes

Raéyn is the patron of sailors, navigators, storm-callers, and anyone who lives by the sea's rhythm. Her followers gain power over tides, currents, and weather, but pay with a restless spirit and a fierce protectiveness that can turn to wrath. The rivalry with her son Khemesh is ever-present – Raéyn's gifts bring change and opportunity, but the deep always waits. Ideal for characters who love the sea, embrace change, and understand that the tide that lifts you can also drag you down.

Emphases

- **Tides and Change:** power over currents, weather, and the rhythm of the sea
- **Maritime Syncretism:** a goddess of creole Kahfagia, blending mother, warrior, and storm

- **Storm and Calm:** the duality of protection and wrath
- **Motherhood and Loss:** fierce love for sailors, grief for Khemesh
- **Khemesh's Shadow:** the Kraken is always beneath the waves, watching

6.8.29 The Sacred Geometry, Architect of Perfect Forms (Harmony & Immutable Law)

Lore. The Sacred Geometry teaches that perfect forms underlie all seeming chaos: the divine ratios that steer the spiral of galaxies, the symmetry that lattices frost, the measures that turn sound into song. Not merely a calculus but the hidden architecture of the world, it makes artists of order from those who serve it. Devotees do not count to chill the heart; they weigh and tune until beauty and structure converge, revealing that disorder is often only unrecognised design waiting to be drawn true.

This philosophy finds its purest expression in the game of **Kon'reh** – the living geometry played on an eight-pointed diamond board, where Apexes, Sanctums, and the Cross teach the dance of form and consequence. Yet the Geometry itself is not the game; the game is a *mirror* of the Geometry. The Ykrul favour Kon'reh as a tool for oath-geometry and battle-field prediction, reading the angles of feuds and the arcs of raids. The Aelinnel, by contrast, use it to navigate thresholds, courtesy, and the hidden patterns of fae bargains – they count steps not to win, but to avoid stepping where the Green Gate listens. To master Kon'reh is to glimpse the Sacred Geometry in motion; to serve the Geometry is to play the game with the world itself, whether by the steppe fire or the hawthorn arch.

“In the drift of atoms, the sweep of planets, and the curve of a lover’s smile, the same ratios ring. Learn them, and you may conduct the world’s quiet music.”

Domain Focus

- **Perfect Proportion:** building and reading ideal ratios and harmonious relationships
- **Pattern Recognition:** discerning the structures that govern complex phenomena
- **Harmonic Resonance:** working with natural frequencies and number-made consonance
- **Form Architecture:** imposing clear structure on tangled situations
- **Kon'reh Discipline:** the game as meditation, ritual, and tactical mirror

Rites of the Sacred Geometry

Rite of the Harmonic Alignment (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [BALANCE], [FOCUS], [BOOST]

Materials: A tool calibrated to pristine ratios (e.g., golden ratio gauge, well-cut compass arc, a Kon'reh piece set to true measure).

Effect: Align to natural harmonics. Gain +1 **die** to actions involving balance, proportion, cadence, or keeping true time.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Perfect Structure (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [SHAPE], [REPAIR], [PRESSURE]

Materials: A consecrated compass and straightedge, inked to tolerance.

Effect: Impose right form on a chaotic or damaged structure (scaffold, plan, treaty, formation). Treat one structural obstacle as one step easier; gain +1 **die** to build/repair/spatial-reason rolls.

Push It: Perfection hardens: for the scene the structure gains unnatural resilience, but order draws opposition; mark 1 **SB (Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Resonant Field (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [AREA], [TEAMWORK], [HARMONY]

Materials: A floor or air traced with precise tessellations and nodes (or a Kon'reh board laid out as a focus).

Effect: Establish a harmonic field. Allies gain +1 **die** to precise, coordinated, or team actions; disruptive acts suffer -1 **die**.

Push It: The field self-sustains and begins to spread beyond intent; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Pattern's Heart (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [PREDICTION], [TRUTH]

Materials: A solved proof, a perfectly symmetrical token, or a completed Kon'reh puzzle.

Effect: Perceive the governing pattern of a complex situation (supply chain, intrigue, weather, battle). Gain +2 **dice** to prediction/strategy/systemic-understanding and ask two questions about how the pattern drives the present.

Push It: Clarity cuts: gain the insight, but for this scene suffer -1 **die** to intuitive or purely emotional responses; mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Immutable Design (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [TERRAIN], [PRESSURE], [FATE], [AREA]

Materials: A space gridded for measure and set with true ratios (like a Kon'reh court).

Effect: For the scene, rewrite local behaviour by perfect principle. Choose one: gravity follows geometric progression; time flows by harmonic ratios; space conforms to exact symmetry.

Push It: Make the design persist, but elsewhere thins and wobbles: mark +2 **Obligation** and begin **Harmonic Dissonance [4]**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Architect's Vision (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; Yes.

Tags: [PREDICTION], [BOOST], [BURDEN], [TRUTH]

Materials: A ledger of forms and their tuned relations (or a record of Kon'reh victories).

Effect: For one session, treat all rolls of pattern recognition, structural analysis, or harmonic application as one step better (Position or Effect, GM's choice).

Push It: Sight devours softness: gain the power, but lose ease with imperfection's beauty; mark **Harm 1 (Stress)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Sacred Geometry

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Sacred Geometry sings in *canons of proportion* – melodies that follow strict mathematical progressions, harmonies that lock into resonant frequencies. Their voice is used to measure a room's acoustic perfection, to chart a course through a labyrinth by singing the ratios of its walls, or to lull a chaos-spirit into stillness by singing the geometry of order. The Geometry's Cantors are often found in surveyor's tents, courtrooms, and the halls of mathematicians, humming the laws of form.

The Cult of the Unbroken Compass. The Geometry's cults gather in places where measure is sacred: ateliers, observatories, courtrooms of appeal, and the quiet rooms where Kon'reh is played. The Unbroken Compass is a fellowship of architects, cartographers, logicians, and Kon'reh masters who believe that the universe is a puzzle that can be solved, and that solving it is the highest form of worship. A ritual of the Cult involves each member laying out a perfect geometric figure (a circle, a square, a golden spiral) and then finding the flaw in another's figure. The one with the fewest flaws leads the next session. Their creed is inscribed on a brass protractor that is never used for mundane measurement: "*Form follows number. Number follows truth. Truth follows no one.*" Outsiders are welcome to bring a proof or a problem. If they cannot, they may learn by watching.

Among the Ykrul, the same cult takes a different flavour: Kon'reh boards are cut from hide, and the "pieces" are oath-tokens. A Ykrul geomancer reads the angles of a feud as if they were lines of play, and a victory in Kon'reh can settle a blood-debt without steel. Among the Aelinnel, the cult is quieter, more courteous: they use Kon'reh to map the thresholds between fae and mortal, and a solved puzzle can open a hedge-gate that would otherwise remain sealed.

Witchcraft of the Sacred Geometry (Lay / Measure)

A witch who walks with the Sacred Geometry is a *compass-scribe* or *grid-weaver* – one who crafts the tools of perfect form: a square that never warps, a level that finds true horizontal even on a ship at sea, or a set of Kon'reh pieces carved from the same block of stone so that they resonate together. Their magic works through the materials of measurement: a protractor that reveals hidden angles, a string that stretches to an exact

ratio, or a lens that shows the underlying grid of a forest floor. They do not use hammers; they use scribes, rules, and the patient turning of a brass dial.

The Witch's Tool: The Protractor of Unseen Measures. A brass semicircle etched with glyphs of ratio and proportion, its hinge oiled with a drop of mercury. Once per session, the witch may place the protractor against any surface (a doorframe, a contract, a creature's brow) and read the "true angle" of its nature. For the next scene, the witch gains +2 dice to any roll that exploits a hidden weakness, structural flaw, or imbalance revealed by the measurement. The protractor can also be used to "true" a distorted measurement: touching it to a warped scale or a crooked ruler resets it to perfect accuracy for one use.

A Hedge Gift: Compass of True Bearing (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may draw a circle with a compass (a real one, or just their finger) around a small area (a room, a crossroads). Those within the circle gain a perfect sense of direction and distance for the next hour; they are immune to mundane spatial confusion (mazes, fog, unfamiliar streets). However, the compass point leaves a faint, glowing mark on the ground that can be seen by anyone with supernatural senses.

The Sacred Geometry's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Harmonic Sense: +1 die to <i>No-tice</i> when patterns, ratios, or symmetries matter.	Pattern Obsession: Must measure or set-right pleasing patterns you spot; resisting costs time or 1 SB (Diamonds) .
2	Perfect Precision: Once/scene, achieve faultless calculation or measure.	Social Dissonance: -1 die to emotive social rolls; harmony feels truer than feeling.
3	Structural Insight: +2 dice to architecture/engineering or imposing order on chaos.	Order Compulsion: Must correct deliberate disorder; suffer Fatigue 1 when forced to abide it.
4	Universal Harmony: Once/session, apply a harmonic rule that makes a chaotic situation predictable.	Perfectionist Limitation: -1 die to improvisation; the "correct" solution calls.
5	Divine Proportion: Once/session, see perfect ratios in any phenomenon and work with them.	Mathematical Focus: -1 die to acts not readily quantified; the abstract blurs unless counted.
6+	Architect of Reality: Once/session, briefly refit local reality by perfect principle.	Form Prison: Mark +3 Obligation; risk failing in rough, noisy worlds, taking Harm 1 in chaotic zones.

Playstyle Notes

The Sacred Geometry suits makers and marshals who tune chaos into form. Its rites prize clean plans, crisp teamwork, and seeing the load paths hidden in trouble. The cost is rigidity: the more you perfect, the harder rough edges are to bear. For Ykrul players, the Geometry is a tool of honour and battle-field geometry; for Aelinnel players, a tool of courtesy and threshold-walking. Both are valid, and both lead to the same cold, beautiful truth.

Emphasises

- **Harmonic Beauty:** power born of right relation
- **Pattern Mastery:** reading the frame beneath events
- **Structural Perfection:** setting things true under strain
- **Resonant Practice:** working with the world's natural measures
- **Architect's Sight:** finding where form should be imposed
- **Kon'reh Discipline:** the game as living geometry, teaching patience, sacrifice, and the dance of Apex and Sanctum

6.8.30 The Savage Heart (Red Maw)

Lore. The Savage Heart is the truth behind the green veil: nature not as garden, but as gullet. It is the claw that tears, the fang that crushes, the hunger that stalks without malice and kills without mercy. Its followers are the druids you do not meet by firelight — those who have learned that the forest feeds on its own, that the strong devour the weak, and that the only law is the one written in blood on snow.

Across the known world, the Savage Heart wears the face of the apex predator. In the Amaranthine core, it is the *Great Bear*, patient and unstoppable, a wall of fur and fury. Among the Ykrul and Kuvani, it is the *Wolf of the Steppe*, a pack hunter with tireless stamina. In Oshiira, it is the *Golden Lion*, whose roar shatters the hunt's silence. In Sekogo, it is the *Leopard of the Tall Grass*, a shadow that strikes once and is gone. In Dhahara, it is the *Tiger of the Mangroves*, whose amber gaze promises a death that runs faster than you can flee. Wherever prey fears the dark, the Savage Heart is already there, waiting.

“The deer does not weep for the wolf. The sapling does not beg the axe. In the red maw, there is no cruelty—only truth. The truth that all flesh feeds the earth, and the earth feeds the strong.”

Domain Focus

- **Apex Predation:** hunting, stalking, dominating the food chain
- **Red Tooth:** killing as nature's sacrament, strength proven through violence
- **Scavenger's Wisdom:** using death for growth, nothing wasted
- **Territory and Pack:** dominance over a domain, leadership of the hunt

Rites of the Savage Heart

Rite of the Predator's Gaze (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [MARK], [FEAR], [TRACK]

Materials: A tooth from a predator that killed its own prey.

Effect: Mark a single target as your prey. Gain +1 die on all rolls to track, pursue, or intimidate that target. The effect lasts until the target escapes or is killed.

Push It: The prey feels your gaze; they suffer –1 die to resist social pressure from you. Mark 1 SB (Spades).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Blood Scent (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; Yes.

Tags: [SENSE], [FEAR], [TRACK]

Materials: A fresh kill's blood smeared on your face.

Effect: You scent the air like a beast. Gain +2 dice to *Investigation* or *Survival* when tracking by smell. You may also detect fear – you sense if a creature within Near is Frightened.

Push It: Your sense expands to Far, but you are overwhelmed by the smell of blood; mark 1 SB (Hearts) and suffer –1 die to social rolls until the end of the scene.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Shifting Shape (Standard, 8 XP)*Scene; Self; Yes.***Tags:** [TRANSFORM], [BEAST], [BOOST]**Materials:** A pelt or mask from the beast whose form you take.**Effect:** Assume the form of a predator for the scene. Choose one:**Bear (Tank Form)**

- **Passive:** +1 Armor, +2 dice to Body rolls.
- **Guardian's Pounce:** Once per scene, when you protect an ally, you may also knock the attacker prone (Body+Resolve DV 3 or fall).
- **Limitation:** Movement reduced by one band (cannot Dash).

Feline or Canine (Striker Form)

- **Passive:** +2 dice to Agility and Stealth, +1 band to movement (can Dash as a free action once per scene).
- **Ambush Predator:** When attacking from stealth, gain +1 Effect and ignore 1 point of the target's Armor.
- **Limitation:** -1 Armor (or +1 Harm taken).

Cultural variations: Bear/Wolf (north), Lion/Leopard (Oshiira), Tiger/Panther (Dhahara). You may speak but cannot use tools or cast other Rites while transformed.

Push It: Shift as a free action once this scene, but mark **1 SB (Clubs)** as the beast presses against your mind.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Pack Hunt (Standard, 7 XP)*Scene; Near; Yes.***Tags:** [TEAMWORK], [BEAST], [BOOST]**Materials:** A token from each member of your pack (a claw, a feather, a scrap of hide).

Effect: You and up to three allies form a hunting pack. While within Near of each other, all gain +1 die to attacks against a single designated prey, and the first ally to attack each round gains +1 Effect.

Push It: Coordination extends to Far, but hunters become territorial; mark **1 SB (Spades)** as rivalries flare.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Carrion Feast (Standard, 9 XP)*Scene; Touch; Yes.***Tags:** [CONSUME], [HEAL], [BOOST]**Materials:** The flesh of a fallen enemy, consumed raw.

Effect: Devour the strength of the fallen. Heal **1 Fatigue** immediately, and gain +1 die to your next physical action. If the enemy was supernatural (spirit, demon, fey), you also gain a minor property of theirs for one scene.

Push It: Heal 1 Harm instead of Fatigue, but mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as the feast attracts scavengers.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Final Hunt (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Near; No.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [FEAR], [SPEED], [DEATH]

Materials: The heart of a predator you have killed in single combat, still warm.

Effect: You become the ultimate hunter for one scene:

- Ignore all difficult terrain.
- Gain **+3 dice** to tracking and combat rolls against your designated prey.
- If you reduce a prey to 0 Harm, make a free attack against another target within Near.

Push It: The hunt consumes you – you cannot end the rite until all designated prey are dead or fled, and you suffer Harm 1 (Weariness) when the scene ends. Mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Savage Heart

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Savage Heart sings in *hunting calls* – short, sharp cries that mimic the bark of a bear or the cough of a leopard. Their voice is used to coordinate a pack, to scare prey from hiding, or to summon a predator from the deep woods. They are rarely heard near villages; their songs echo in the places between game trails.

The Cult of the Painted Maw. The Savage Heart's cults do not meet in groves – they gather at kills, wearing masks of bone and hide that show the animal they have sworn to become. The most ancient sect, the *Painted Maw*, ritually scarifies each member's chest with the claw marks of their totem beast; the scars are filled with ash and charcoal, and the wounds are licked clean by the pack's eldest hunter. A ritual involves each member speaking the name of a kill they made alone, then adding a tooth from that kill to a communal jawbone that hangs from a tree. Their creed is spoken with full mouths: "*The forest is a stomach. We are its teeth.*" Outsiders are not welcome; they are either prey or future members. Those who join must prove themselves by returning with the heart of a predator they have killed with no weapon but their own hands.

Witchcraft of the Savage Heart (Lay / Hunter)

A witch who walks with the Savage Heart is a *skin-stitcher* or *tooth-carver* – but their tools are never forge-hammers. They work with bone, claw, fur, and sinew, crafting masks that hold the spirit of a hunted beast, or drums of leopard skin that call the hunt. Their magic is the patience of the stalker and the savagery of the kill. In Dhahara, a tiger-witch might sew a cloak from the hide of a man-eater, wearing it to walk unseen through the mangroves. In the Ykrul steppe, a wolf-witch might carve a whistle from a wolf's femur that, when blown, answers only with the howl of the pack.

The Witch's Tool: The Hunter's Mask. A mask carved from the skull of a predator, lined with fur and painted with the blood of the wearer's first kill. Once per session, when you don the mask, you gain the senses of that predator for the scene: **+2 dice** to tracking by scent or sound, and you may ask the GM one yes/no question about

a creature's fear or weakness. The mask also allows you to speak with animals of that species (they will answer simple questions, but they are never safe to trust).

A Hedge Gift: Hunter's Snuff (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may blow a pinch of powdered bone into the air. For the next minute, the witch can smell the fear of any creature within Near range – they know if a target is Frightened, and gain +1 die to track it.

The Savage Heart's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Stalker's Instinct: +1 die to tracking and stealth in wilderness.	Blood Hunger: Must kill or consume fresh meat each day or suffer 1 Fatigue.
2	Apex Demeanour: +1 die to Intimidation against those weaker than you.	Pack Guilt: –1 die to social rolls in civilised company; you smell faintly of carrion.
3	Scavenger's Resilience: +2 dice to resist disease and poison from raw meat.	Compulsive Dominance: Must assert physical dominance when challenged; –1 die to de-escalation.
4	Wound Licker: Once/session, heal 1 Fatigue by licking a fresh wound (your own or ally's).	Beastly Tells: Your teeth sharpen, your eyes reflect light; –1 die to disguise.
5	Alpha's Roar: Once/session, make a terrifying sound that forces all nearby prey to test Resolve (DV 4) or flee.	Lone Wolf: –2 dice to cooperate with those who have not proven themselves in battle.
6+	Maw Incarnate: Once/session, become a true predator. For one scene, all attacks ignore 1 Armor and you heal 1 Fatigue on each kill.	The Red Eats All: Mark +3 Obligation; risk becoming feral, unable to speak or reason until you have fed again.

Playstyle Notes

The Savage Heart rewards those who hunt, kill, and dominate. Its followers are not gentle guardians of nature – they are its teeth and claws. Power comes from taking, from proving strength, from the raw act of predation. The cost is the slow loss of the civilised self, the creeping realisation that you are becoming the thing you stalk.

Emphasises

- **Predation as Sacrament:** killing is holy when done with purpose
- **Territory and Dominance:** claim, defend, expand
- **Pack Tactics:** hunting is a team sport
- **Red Tooth Wisdom:** death feeds life, cruelty is not malice but nature
- **Transformation:** becoming the beast to master the beast

Rivalries

- **Grimmir (Seasonal Wisdom):** Grimmir preserves the balance; the Savage Heart devours it. They are two faces of the same coin – but the coin is always flipped.
- **The Sealed Gate (Containment):** The Gate wards things out; the Savage Heart tears down walls.
- **The Sacred Geometry (Harmony):** Order and perfect form are prey to the red maw.

Obligation Triggers

- **8+ Segments:** The Savage Heart demands you take a worthy trophy – hunt a creature of equal or greater strength than yourself, alone.
- **10+ Segments:** You hear the call of the hunt always. Refusing to answer when prey is weak will cost you the use of your Rites until you kill again.

Signs of Favor

Your eyes reflect light in darkness, your shadow seems to move independently, smaller animals flee your presence, and the scent of blood often follows you (real or imagined).

6.8.31 The Sealed Gate (Thresholds & Containment)

Lore. The Sealed Gate stands where realities meet, embodying the sacred power of thresholds, boundaries, and containment. Its followers are wardens, exorcists, and philosophers of separation who believe some things must be kept apart for the world to function. The Gate manifests as an impassive judge whose shifting sigils—binding runes, exclusion marks, or acceptance glyphs—determine what may cross.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, the Sealed Gate is known as the patron of abjurists, exorcists, and sentinels. In Aeler, the Gate is called the *Stone Seal*, invoked by True-Masons who carve permanent wards into mountain passes. In Thepyrgos, the Gate is the *Unbreakable Lock*, whose sigils are painted on every archive door that holds forbidden texts. In the Mistlands, the Gate is the *Bell-Line Keeper*, the force that makes the bell-wards hold against the Direwood. Wherever something must be kept in or kept out, the Sealed Gate’s servants are there – silent, patient, and absolute.

“You define what passes and what remains. Every boundary remembers your judgment.”

Domain Focus

- **Thresholds:** Doors, portals, borders between realms
- **Containment:** Wards, bindings, imprisonment of dangerous forces
- **Exclusion:** Banishment, quarantine, protection through separation
- **Permission:** Safe passage, authorised access, controlled crossing

Rites of the Sealed Gate

Rite of the Sealed Threshold (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Touch; No Push

Tags: [WARD], [BIND]

Materials: Chalk, iron dust, or sanctified cord.

Effect: Mark a doorway or passage as sealed. Unauthorised crossing tests Spirit+Resolve (DV 3) or suffers a Position penalty. Creates a 4-segment *Ward Integrity* clock.

Push It: The barrier becomes a visible shimmer; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Key’s Rebuke (Low, 5 XP)

Instant; Near; No Push

Tags: [FORCE], [BANISH]

Materials: A gesture of denial or a barrier symbol.

Effect: The target must test Body+Resolve (DV 3) or be pushed back from the threshold. On success, create a *Rebuke Echo* token granting +1 **die** to the next boundary defence.

Push It: The rebuke lingers – the target cannot cross this threshold for the rest of the scene; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Circle of Denial (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [WARD], [AREA], [BANISH]

Materials: A salt ring, iron filings, or boundary stones.

Effect: Create a protective circle. Supernatural beings test against the caster's Spirit+Arcana (DV 4) to cross. Mortals suffer **−2 dice** to force entry. Creates a 6-segment *Circle Integrity* clock.

Push It: The circle becomes a two-way barrier (no one can cross); mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Writ of Passage (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Zone; Standard Push

Tags: [BOND], [COMMAND], [MOVEMENT]

Materials: Signed authorisation or spoken permissions.

Effect: Designate an authorised passage route. Allies gain **Position +1** when using the route. Unauthorised intruders suffer **−1 die** to movement or stealth. Creates an 8-segment *Writ Authority* clock.

Push It: Extend authorisation to additional allies; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Banishment Knot (High, 13 XP)

Instant; Near; High Push

Tags: [BANISH], [FORCE], [FEAR]

Materials: A knotted cord sealed with a gate-sigil.

Effect: The target supernatural entity tests against the caster's Spirit+Resolve (DV = entity Cap). On success, the entity is forced to immediately depart the scene. A failed attempt creates a 4-segment *Banishment Backlash* clock.

Push It: The banishment lasts until the next moon phase; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Consecrated Barrier (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Large Zone; High Push

Tags: [WARD], [AREA], [SANCTUARY], [FATE]

Materials: Relics from three traditions, boundary markers, a trespasser's acknowledgement.

Effect: Consecrate an area against all unauthorised passage. The tests required scale with the intrusion attempt's severity. A 10-segment *Sacred Boundary* clock tracks the barrier's strength.

Push It: Make the barrier semi-permanent (lasts one season); start a *Maintenance [6]* clock.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Sealed Gate

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Sealed Gate sings in *locks and wards* – melodies that are precise, repetitive, and final, like the click of a deadbolt or the thud of a bar being set. Their voice is used to seal a door with a sung phrase, to recite a litany of exclusion that pushes a spirit back across the threshold, or to sing a sleeping guard into dreaming of a wall that never ends. The Gate's Cantors are often found in prisons, asylums, and the gatehouses of cities, their songs keeping the unwanted out.

The Cult of the Unbroken Seal. The Gate's cults meet in places where boundaries are most needed: at city gates, on bridges, in the guardrooms of tombs, and before the sealed doors of forgotten vaults. The Unbroken Seal is a fellowship of wardens, gate-keepers, exorcists, and sentinels who believe that a well-kept boundary is the foundation of civilisation. A ritual of the Cult involves each member renewing a vow to guard a specific threshold – a door, a river, a mountain pass – and marking it with a fresh sigil. Their creed is carved into a single stone that is never moved: "*What is sealed stays sealed. What stays sealed protects the living.*" Outsiders are welcome to witness the sealing, but they must leave a token of their own boundary – a key, a lock of hair, a written promise.

Witchcraft of the Sealed Gate (Lay / Scholarly)

A witch who walks with the Sealed Gate is often a *ward-keeper*, an *exorcist archivist*, or a *boundary-scholar* – a lay practitioner who uses seals, litanies, and physical tokens to enforce separation. Their magic is not forged but written or sung: sealing wax mixed with iron filings, a bell that rings only when a threshold is violated, or a bound notebook of exclusion rites whose pages turn black when a spirit tries to cross. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "ward stone" into a lintel, but a hedge-witch of the Gate might daub a lignite sigil on a doorframe while reciting the Ninth Clause of Stillness. In Viterra, a village exorcist might carry a small iron seal to stamp the corners of a haunted room. Their tools are not hammers but seals, bells, and the small brass keys that lock nothing – and everything.

The Witch's Tool: The Seal of the Unbroken Gate. A small iron seal on a chain, cool to the touch, its face engraved with a closed door. Once per session, the witch may press the seal into wax (or directly onto a threshold while speaking a word of denial). For the next scene, any creature attempting to cross that threshold with hostile intent must make a Spirit+Resolve test (DV 3) or be turned back. The seal may also be used to "witness" a lock: touching it to a mundane lock imposes +1 DV on any attempt to pick it until the next dawn. The seal's warmth tells the witch whether any binding placed with it still holds.

A Hedge Gift: Sealed Lips (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a person's lips (or a letter's seal) and whisper a litany of the Gate. For the next hour, that person cannot speak a specific secret or name (chosen by the witch). If they try, their voice fails – they cough, stutter, or simply cannot form the words. This effect can be removed by the witch or by a Resolve test (DV 4) made once per day.

The Sealed Gate's Corruption Manifestations

Level	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Threshold Sense: +1 die to detect weak points, unauthorised passage, or boundary violations.	Paranoid Vigilance: Must repeatedly check seals; -1 die to trust-based actions.
2	Ward Resonance: Once/scene, treat a failed protection roll as a success (mark 1 SB).	Isolation Tendency: 1 Fatigue in unsecured or open spaces.
3	Boundary Mastery: +2 dice to ward, barrier, or containment magic.	Compulsive Sealing: Must secure any vulnerability noticed.
4	Absolute Barrier: Once/session, create an impenetrable barrier (1 scene).	Prison Mindset: -1 die to freedom or escape actions.
5	Gate Sovereign: Once/session, banish a major threat with a single test.	Boundary Obsession: -1 die to non-containment actions.
6+	Threshold Incarnate: Become a living barrier for one scene; all nearby boundaries become absolute.	Ultimate Containment Risk: Mark +3 Obligation; risk permanent Harm from the burden of containment.

Playstyle Notes

The Sealed Gate patron excels in defensive, control-oriented play. Followers shape battlefields through strategic boundary placement and become invaluable when dealing with supernatural intrusions or securing locations. The corruption progression naturally leads characters toward becoming immovable guardians at the cost of flexibility and freedom. Ideal for abjurists, exorcists, sentinels, and any character whose duty is to keep things apart.

6.8.32 The Silent Choir, Keeper of Unspoken Truths (Restraint & Protective Omission)

Lore. The Silent Choir is the gathered voice of truths wisely left unsaid, confessions granted mercy, and secrets kept to spare a life from breaking. It is not absence but presence: the practiced wisdom that some knowledge wounds more than it heals. Its keepers are wardens of confidence and shelterers of the vulnerable. They learn to carry burdens alone, to let volatile truths sleep, and to shield others from fires that revelation would feed.

Unlike the Witness, who reveals truth at any cost, or Ikasha, who hides secrets for power, the Silent Choir teaches *restraint as protection*. A secret is not a weapon; it is a weight. To speak it may free the speaker but shatter the listener. The Choir's followers judge not what is true, but what is kind. They are therapists, not inquisitors; confessors, not spies.

In the world of Fate's Edge, the Silent Choir is invoked by bell-wardens who keep a certain pattern unsung to avoid calling the fog, archivists who seal dangerous texts behind a second lock and whisper the combination to no one, and death-doulas who carry a dying oath to the grave. The Choir has no temples, only quiet rooms, sealed letter-boxes, and the spaces between heartbeats where a truth could be told – but is not.

“In a world that shouts, the Choir teaches the weight of quiet. Not every wound needs salt, not every blaze needs breath, not every heart can bear the full truth.”

Domain Focus

- **Protective Silence:** when and how to keep counsel for others' good
- **Merciful Omission:** judging truths that harm when spoken
- **Confidential Guardianship:** safeguarding people and perilous knowledge
- **Restraint Wisdom:** the power of what is not said or done

Rites of the Silent Choir

Rite of the Gentle Seal (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Near/Touch; Yes.

Tags: [SILENCE], [PROTECT], [BOOST], [DEBT]

Materials: A white feather or cloth that has drunk whispered confidences; or a sealed envelope or locked reliquary holding a sensitive fact.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Gentle Silence:** Hush a space with respectful quiet. All present gain +1 die to actions of discretion, confidentiality, or de-escalation this scene.
- **Shielded Truth:** Ward one piece of information from discovery. Gain +2 dice to resist extraction or revelation of the protected truth.

Push It: (Shielded Truth) Protection becomes absolute but dependent: removing the ward triggers 1 SB (Hearts) as bottled truths surge.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 Obligation.

Rite of the Unspoken Accord (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Tags: [VOW], [BOND], [SILENCE], [TRUTH]

Materials: A pact signed in fading ink or a vow witnessed in silence.

Effect: Bind an understanding without paper teeth. All parties gain +1 die when honouring the accord; breach draws social costs even without proof.

Push It: The accord is supernaturally enforced: a breaker suffers swift ostracism; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Burden Bearer (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [TRANSFER], [HEAL], [DEBT], [FEAR]

Materials: An object heavy with someone's shame or grief.

Effect: Take another's social or emotional weight for a time. The target gains relief (+2 dice to social rolls) while you suffer the drag (-1 die to social rolls) this scene.

Push It: A shard remains: gain insight, keep a sliver of pain; mark 1 **SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Sanctuary of Secrets (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [WARD], [AREA], [SILENCE], [PROTECT], [DEBT]

Materials: A room seasoned by trusted confidences and sealed with hush-signs.

Effect: Consecrate a sanctuary where secrets hold fast. Truths cannot be compelled; all within gain immunity to forced revelation and +2 dice to maintain discretion.

Push It: The sanctuary becomes a keep: none may leave until each offers one guarded truth; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Choir's Wisdom (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; Yes.

Tags: [TRUTH], [PREDICTION], [FATE], [BOOST], [BURDEN]

Materials: The weight of many secrets rightly kept and debts of trust well paid.

Effect: Read the branching costs of revelation before speech. Gain +3 dice to judge when to speak and when to keep counsel.

Push It: Sight is too wide: see all outcomes, struggle to choose; mark **Harm 1 (Stress)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Confidant Keeper (Oath-Keeper)

The word not spoken is a shield. The secret kept is a kindness. I will carry your truth so you do not have to.

Prerequisites: Spirit 3+, Lore 2+, Rite of the Gentle Seal or Cantor of the Silent Choir.

Confidant Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Calm Presence	Once per scene, you may touch a creature suffering from Fear, Guilt, or Despair and remove that Condition.	1 Fatigue	Spirit 3
Sealed Lips	You may use the Hedge Gift <i>Weight of the Unsaid</i> without spending XP (you know it instinctively).	Passive	Tier II
Burden Steady	You may carry one additional psychological Condition without stacking penalties.	Passive	Spirit 3
Confessio Mercy	When you use Rite of the Burden Bearer, the target's relief lasts for the entire scene (instead of just the social roll bonus).	+1 Obligation	Tier III
Sanctuary Keeper	Once per session, you may declare a room you are in to be a <i>Sanctuary</i> for one scene. All within gain +1 die to resist fear and coercion.	1 Boon	Spirit 4, Tier III
Final Vow	Once per campaign, you may take a dying person's last secret and carry it permanently. You gain +1 permanent Corruption, but you may never reveal that secret – not even under magical compulsion.	Free	Epic

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *The Unburdened Confessor.* Once per session, you may absorb a single traumatic memory or secret from a willing creature, erasing it from their mind permanently. You gain the memory as your own (with all emotional weight), and the creature is freed from its effects. You gain 1 permanent Corruption and mark +2 Obligation to the Silent Choir. You cannot use this talent again until you have spent a downtime scene in meditation or confession.

Cantors & Cults of the Silent Choir

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Silent Choir sings in *breaths of omission* – melodies that are felt rather than heard, harmonies that resolve into silence. Their voice is used to quiet a room of gossip, to seal a confession with a hum that makes it sacred, or to place a gentle pressure on a tongue that would speak a harmful truth. The Choir's Cantors are often found in confessionals, in the rooms of the dying, and in the alcoves of great libraries, humming the songs that keep secrets safe.

The Cult of the Sealed Lip. The Silent Choir's cults meet in places where secrets are naturally kept: locked scriptoria, the back rooms of notaries, and the quiet corners of courthouses. The Sealed Lip is a fellowship of confessors, archivists, therapists, and spies who have learned that the most powerful word is the one left unspoken. A ritual of the Cult involves each member writing down a truth they wish they could tell, then sealing it in an envelope that is never opened. The envelopes are stored in a single locked chest – the *Coffer of Unspoken Things*. Once per season, they pour the ashes of a burned confession into a small copper bell; the bell never rings, but they claim it “remembers” every secret fed to it. Their creed is written on the inside of the lid: *"The word not spoken is a shield. The secret kept is a kindness."* Outsiders are welcome to bring a sealed envelope of their own, but they must never ask what is inside another's.

Witchcraft of the Silent Choir (Lay / Secrecy)

A witch who walks with the Silent Choir is a *seal-scribe* or *lock-keeper* – one who crafts the physical vessels of silence: a book whose pages refuse to reveal their contents to the wrong reader, a chest that cannot be opened without the keeper's whisper, or a letter that dissolves if read aloud. Their magic works through the materials of discretion: a quill that writes in ink that fades after one reading, a wax seal that screams if broken by an unauthorised hand, or a lock that only clicks shut when a secret is placed inside. Their tools are not hammers; they use candles, seals, and the soft pressure of a thumb on a clasp.

The Witch's Tool: The Candle of Unspoken Trust. A thick, beeswax candle, grey as ash, that burns with a silent, smokeless flame. Once per session, the witch may light the candle and hold a sealed envelope, a door, or a person's hand over the flame (not touching it). For the next hour, any secret placed in the envelope, spoken behind the door, or entrusted to the person cannot be revealed by magical means (compulsion, truth spells, divination). The candle gutters if the secret is about to be forced out, giving the keeper one minute to intervene. The candle melts entirely after nine uses.

A Hedge Gift: Weight of the Unsaid (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a person's lips and speak a single word (“hush”). For the next minute, that person cannot speak any word that would reveal a secret they have sworn to keep (including secrets they have overheard). If they try, they feel a mild pressure on their throat – enough to pause them, but not enough to cause harm. The effect ends if the witch speaks again.

The Silent Choir's Corruption Table

Tier	Blessing	Burden / Quirk
1	Discretion's Gift: +1 die to <i>No-tice</i> when someone is about to speak what should be kept.	Silent Compulsion: Urge to still tongues; -1 die to ordinary conversation.
2	Confidence Keeper: Once/scene, shelter a secret from accidental spill.	Secret Burden: In places thick with confidences, suffer Fatigue 1 .
3	Merciful Blindness: Once/session, prevent discovery of a truth that would harm if revealed.	Truth Sensitivity: Lies grate; -1 die while surrounded by deception.
4	Sanctuary Sense: Once/scene, veil a brief zone from eavesdropping.	Communication Strain: Others balk at full candour; -1 die to personal disclosure.
5	Wisdom of Restraint: Once/session, see the full cost of airing any one truth.	Silent Isolation: -2 dice to form close bonds; you hold too much back.
6+	Choir's Voice: Once/session, speak with the gathered prudence of unspoken truths.	Truth Prison: Mark +3 Obligation; risk becoming a living vault unable to share without harm.

Playstyle Notes

The Silent Choir favours guardians and confidants: those who stand between fragile lives and ruinous truth. Its rites fortify discretion, temper tempers, and build rooms where trust can breathe. The cost is weight: secrets you keep will keep you. Unlike the Witness (who would speak truth at any cost) or Ikasha (who hides for advantage), the Choir teaches that *mercy is sometimes silence*. Ideal for therapists, confessors, archivists, and anyone who has ever chosen to carry a burden so that another might walk free.

Emphasises

- **Protective Restraint:** silence used as shield
- **Confidential Guardianship:** duty to those who trust you
- **Merciful Omission:** letting some truths sleep
- **Discretion Wisdom:** judging what, when, and how to speak
- **Burden Bearing:** carrying heat so others do not burn

6.8.33 Thrysos, King of Revels (Ecstasy & Excess)

Lore. Where torches flare and cups spill, where dancers stamp until dawn, there strides Thrysos crowned with ivy and horn. He is both host and beast, a patron of license who laughs at law. In his train follow the masked and the wild, the broken who dance to forget, the bold who revel to remember. His rites intoxicate, inflame, and unmask—yet each cup leaves its mark.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, Thrysos is called by many names that honour the ecstatic release. In Linn, his followers are the *Storm-Dancers*, who whirl through gales to exhaustion. In Aelinnel, he is the *Unbounded Guest*, whose arrival at a feast is marked by laughter and shattered glass. In Zakov, the *Revel-King* is invoked before every pirate carouse, with the understanding that a hungover crew is a vulnerable one. His rituals are never secret – they are too loud for concealment – but they are always dangerous, for Thrysos demands that every excess be paid for, if not tonight then at the first hangover of spring.

Signs. Wine that never sours; a mask that smiles without wearer; goat-tracks circling thrice before vanishing.

Cantor’s Temptation. His promise is freedom without end: no oaths, no chains, only song and cup and fire. Yet those who drink too deeply wake to find they serve not joy but appetite.

“Drink, and be unafraid.”

“Every mask is true when worn long enough.”

“In the dance we are all kings—until the dawn.”

Domain Focus

- **Ecstatic Release:** dance, intoxication, the shedding of inhibition
- **Masked Freedom:** identity as performance, truth through disguise
- **Feast and Famine:** excess, appetite, and the cost of indulgence
- **Ritual Frenzy:** communal ecstasy that transforms participants

Rites of Thrysos

Rite of the Overflowing Cup (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [SOCIAL], [FEAR], [AREA]

Materials: A brimming vessel of wine or blood.

Effect: Allies who drink gain +1 **die** to social rolls this scene; enemies who drink suffer –1 **die**.

Push It: All in Near must test Resolve (DV 3) or be swept into revelry; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Horned Dance (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [BOOST], [FOCUS], [BEAST]

Materials: A mask or antlers.

Effect: Enter an ecstatic frenzy: +2 dice to melee or performance; ignore 1 Fatigue per round.

Push It: The frenzy spreads: one ally joins, but both mark 1 SB (Spades).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Breaking Mask (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [TRUTH], [DEBUFF], [FEAR]

Materials: A mask smashed in hand.

Effect: Reveal the true face: the target suffers –2 dice to disguise, deceit, or composure until scene end.

Push It: Truth is forced: the target must declare one hidden desire; mark 1 SB (Diamonds).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Wild Procession (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [SUMMON], [WARD], [AREA]

Materials: A horn sounded thrice.

Effect: Summon spectral revellers – satyrs, dancers, horned riders. For the scene, the zone is [WARD]ed: hostile entry forces 1 SB (Spades); allies gain +1 die to resist compulsion or fear.

Push It: The procession spills beyond the zone; outsiders in Near must test Resolve (DV 4) or join.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Endless Feast (High, 14 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [HEAL], [BOOST], [AREA], [BURDEN]

Materials: A feast laid for twelve.

Effect: For one scene, the zone floods with plenty: allies restore Fatigue; all rolls tied to appetite or indulgence gain +2 dice. Leaving requires Resolve (DV 3).

Push It: The feast persists as a hunger-haunt; start **Hedonist's Curse** [6].

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Rite of the Reveler's Apotheosis (High, 15 XP)

Extended; Touch; No.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [BOOST], [FATE], [SACRIFICE]

Materials: A crown of twisted vines that bleed when touched, the first laugh of a newborn, a promise broken at a crossroads.

Effect: Grant the ultimate reveller's gift – transformation into pure ecstatic essence. The target becomes immune to fear and despair, gains +3 dice to performance or frenzy, and can inspire allies within Near (+1 die to all rolls).

Push It: The transformation becomes contagious – nearby allies may also transform but risk losing their humanity; mark +2 Obligation.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Drunken Master Monk (Thrysos)

The true disciple does not fight the wine — they let the wine fight for them. Every stagger is a feint, every spill a trip, every belch a battle cry.

Prerequisites: Body 3+, Spirit 3+, Rite of the Horned Dance learned or Cantor of Thrysos.

Monastic Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technic	Effect	Cost	Req.
Stagger Step	When an enemy misses you with a melee attack, you may immediately move one band (Close → Near or vice versa) without provoking opportunity attacks.	1 Fatigue	Body 3
Spill the Cup	As a reaction to being grappled or restrained, you may slip free and impose –1 die on the attacker’s next roll.	1 Boon	Dex 2
Drunken Fist	Your unarmed strikes gain +1 die and ignore the first point of Armor when you are at Fatigue 2 or more (the wine “guides” you).	Passive	Body 3, Spirit 2
Hangover Resilience	Once per scene, after suffering a complication or Story Beat from intoxication, you may clear 1 Fatigue (the headache fades, but the lesson remains).	Free	Spirit 3
Reveler’s Recovery	When you use Rite of the Horned Dance, you may also heal 1 Harm (not Condition) as the ecstasy knits flesh.	+1 Obligation	Tier II, Rite of the Horned Dance
Satyr’s Sprawl	You are immune to being knocked prone while moving, and when you fall prone intentionally you may immediately stand as a free action.	Passive	Body 4, Athletics 2
Bacchic Counter	When you succeed on a defence roll while at Desperate Position, you may immediately make a free unarmed attack against the attacker.	Once per scene 199	Tier III, Drunken Fist

Cantors & Cults of Thrysos

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Thrysos sings in *off-key harmonies* – melodies that start wild and grow wilder, rhythms that mimic a galloping heart. Their voice is used to whip a crowd into a frenzy, to calm a hangover with a lullaby, or to make a mask cling to a face until the wearer is ready to take it off. Thrysos's Cantors are often found at festivals, in taverns at closing time, and leading the procession of the horned dancers.

The Cult of the Horned Circle. Thrysos's cults meet in clearings, barns, and the back rooms of inns after midnight. The Horned Circle is a fellowship of mask-carvers, vintners, musicians, and those who have tasted the edge of ecstasy. Their most sacred vessel is a hollowed-out log that was struck by lightning; they ferment wine inside it, and the wine *whispers secrets* to those who drink it – forgotten grudges, hidden desires, the true names of those who will betray them. A ritual of the Circle involves each member donning a mask (hand-carved, never bought) and dancing until the first dancer falls from exhaustion. The fallen is crowned with ivy and declared "guest of honour" – they lead the next circle. Their creed is carved into a single wine barrel that is never emptied: "*The cup that never empties is the cup you share.*" Outsiders are welcome to dance, but they must leave their mask behind when they go – and if they drink from the lightning-log, they will hear the whispers for a year and a day.

Witchcraft of Thrysos (Lay / Revelry)

A witch who walks with Thrysos is a *mask-carver* or *wine-smith* – one who crafts the tools of ecstatic release: a mask that lets the wearer dance without tiring, a drum that beats in time with the drinker's pulse, or a cup that never runs dry (but leaves a headache at dawn). Their magic works through the materials of celebration: a thyrsus that marks the boundary of a sacred dance, a press that squeezes wine that ferments in hours instead of weeks, or a needle that sews a costume that makes the wearer faster, louder, bolder. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "revel keystone" into a feast hall, but a hedge-witch of Thrysos might instead drive a thyrsus into the floorboards to consecrate the space.

The Witch's Tool: The Thyrsus of the Unbound. A staff of fennel or oak, topped with a pine cone and bound with ivy. Once per session, the witch may strike the thyrsus against the ground three times. For the next scene, any creature within Near who is engaged in revelry (dancing, drinking, performing) gains +1 **die** to social and physical actions, but any attempt to leave the zone requires a Resolve test (DV 3) – the revel holds them. The thyrsus can also be used to draw a circle on the ground; any mask placed within the circle becomes "true" for one night – the wearer cannot be recognised by anyone who was not present at the drawing.

A Hedge Gift: Dancer's Cramp (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may snap their fingers and whisper a dancer's rhythm. One target within Near range feels an irresistible urge to move – they must tap a foot, sway, or take a step. This cannot force them into danger, but it can ruin stealth, break a staredown, or distract a guard for one exchange. The target may resist with Resolve (DV 3) to ignore the urge.

Thrysos's Corruption Table

Tier	Gift	Corruption
1	Reveler's Grace: +1 die to social rolls in feasts or crowds.	Compulsive Toast: Must drink or mark 1 Fatigue when drink is offered.
2	Horned Vitality: Ignore the first 1 Fatigue each scene.	Restless Appetite: –1 die when abstaining from indulgence.
3	Revel-Kin: Once/scene, summon a minor revel-spirit (advantage die).	Masked Self: Cannot act without a role or guise; –1 die to plain sincerity.
4	Bacchic Fury: Once/session, frenzy grants +2 dice to melee for one exchange.	Ecstatic Blindness: –1 die to perception outside the revel.
5	Feast Without End: Once/session, allies in Near clear all Fatigue.	Hungering Host: You consume twice as much; denial causes Harm 1 (Stress).
6+	Satyr King's Mantle: For one scene, become an avatar of revels; all allies gain +2 dice, enemies suffer –2 dice.	Tyrant of Pleasure: Mark +3 Obligation; the revel grows monstrous, demanding sacrifice.
		Beast of Endless Revel: Permanent transformation – your mortal form becomes optional; must make Presence+Performance (DV 4) to appear civilised or risk terrifying (or entrancing) all who see you into joining your eternal celebration.

“Let the wine flow, let the masks fall, let the fire burn away all restraint. In the revel we find truth—raw, wild, and beautiful.”

Playstyle Notes

Thrysos rewards those who embrace risk, abandon convention, and find power in letting go. His followers become masters of ecstatic ritual, social manipulation through celebration, and the dangerous art of losing control. The corruption progression leads toward a beast of endless revel – powerful, charismatic, but never truly sober, never truly at rest. Ideal for players who enjoy wild scenes, social chaos, and characters who dance on the edge of self-destruction.

6.8.34 The Traveler (Ways & Journeys)

Lore. The Traveler is the eternal guide of the road, guardian of those who walk the paths between what is and what might be. Among the Fhara caravans and Kuvani traders along the Way of Silk, the Traveler is invoked at every crossroads, honoured with small offerings at each waypoint, and consulted before every major journey.

The Traveler is not merely one who shows the way—they *are* the way, existing in the pause between steps and in the choice of which path to take when roads fork. Every journey is both physical and spiritual; to move from one place to another is to transform, and the road itself becomes a teacher.

Across the known world, the Traveler wears many faces. In Kahfagia, the Traveler is the *Lantern-Bearer*, whose light guides ships through uncharted waters. In Ykrul, the Traveler is the *Hoof-Print*, the spirit of the steppe road that appears as a single arrowhead left at a crossroads. In Aeler, the Traveler is the *Ways-Stone*, carved into every mile marker by True-Masons to ensure the road remembers those who walk it. In the Mistlands, the Traveler is invoked with a single unknotted bell-rope – a sign that the fog may part for one who walks humbly. Wherever a traveller sets foot, the Traveler is already there, waiting to see which road they choose.

One foot in a promise, and the road will meet you halfway. But break your word to the way, and the way will break you.

Domain Focus

- **Wayfinding:** navigation, route-finding, safe passage
- **Journeys:** travel, pilgrimage, exploration
- **Thresholds of Movement:** doors, bridges, crossroads, borders
- **Road Covenants:** promises made on the road, hospitality to travellers

Rites of the Traveler

Rite of Road-Sense (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [NAVIGATION], [AWARENESS]

Materials: A road-nail or waystone pebble.

Effect: Unerringly pick the fastest safe route in Near/Far. Gain +1 **die** to avoid ambushes or delays. Create a 4-segment *Path Memory* clock to ignore difficult terrain once.

Push It: Spot one hidden bypass, but generate 1 **SB (Clubs)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Traveler's Boon (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self/Ally; No.

Tags: [MOVEMENT], [BOND], [HASTE]

Materials: Thread tied at the wrist.

Effect: Ignore one level of difficult terrain or bureaucracy; +1 **Effect** to travel or escape

checks. If shared, create a 2-segment *Shared Journey* bond with an ally.

Push It: Extend to one more ally; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Waymark (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [MARK], [GUIDANCE], [PATH]

Materials: A chalk mark or small cairn.

Effect: Declare a lane as permitted or easy. Allies gain improved Position/Effect or ignore one obstacle. Create a 6-segment *Marked Path* clock.

Push It: The lane persists between scenes; the first enemy to exploit it forces **1 SB (Spades)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Bridge Between (Standard, 7 XP)

Instant; Near; No.

Tags: [TELEPORT], [PATH], [BOND]

Materials: Two pinches of road-dust clapped.

Effect: Relocate a willing target within Far along a visible or named route. Unwilling targets may resist (Body+Resolve DV 3). Create a 4-segment *Pathway Established* clock.

Push It: Carry one extra ally or bundle; arrivals are off-balance.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Crown of Crossings (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [AREA], [COMMAND], [MOVEMENT], [FEAR]

Materials: A brass compass missing its needle.

Effect: Call the Road: allies gain **+1 die** to move or evade; pursuers suffer **−1 die**. Once, declare "the long way is short" to finish a travel clock segment for free. Enemies must test (Wits+Command DV 4) or suffer **−1 die** to movement.

Push It: Seal a hostile route briefly; generate **2 SB (Clubs/Diamonds)**.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Wayfarer's Covenant (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Near; No.

Tags: [VOW], [COMMAND], [BOND], [FEAR]

Materials: Waystones from multiple regions.

Effect: Bind present parties to safe passage. While honoured: **+2 Effect** on travel, reroll one failed travel roll per scene. Breaking the oath inflicts Harm 1 (Fatigue) and marks the breaker as *Oathbreaker of the Road* (−2 dice to travel rolls).

Push It: Breaking the covenant inflicts Harm 2 (Stress) and attracts hostile Wayward spirits.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation.**

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Traveler

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Traveler sings in *verses of the open road* – melodies that rise and fall like hills, harmonies that echo the creak of wagon wheels. Their voice is used to mark a crossroads with a sung sign, to calm a spooked pack animal, or to call a lost wanderer back to the path. The Traveler's Cantors are often found in caravan camps, at pilgrimage shrines, and walking the roads alone, humming to keep the miles company.

The Cult of the Unbroken Way. The Traveler's cults gather at forks, at bridges, and at the crests of passes – never in buildings. The Unbroken Way is a fellowship of guides, couriers, scouts, and those who have walked so far that the road has become their home. A ritual of the Cult involves each member placing a small stone at a crossroads, then walking a different way home than they came – the road must be honoured with new steps. Their creed is scratched into a single waystone that travels from meeting to meeting: *"The road does not end. It only turns."* Outsiders are welcome to walk a mile with the cult, but they must carry a stone from home and leave it at the next crossroads.

Witchcraft of the Traveler (Craft / Wayfinding)

A witch who walks with the Traveler is a *map-scribe* or *waystone-carver* – one who crafts the physical markers of the road: a compass that always points to a chosen destination, a map that shows routes that appear only when needed, or a staff that never causes the bearer to trip. Their magic works through the materials of travel: a quill that draws paths that become real by morning, a chisel that carves a symbol into a stone so that travellers who touch it feel rested, or a needle that sews a patch into a cloak that keeps the wind from shifting direction. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "way keystone" into a bridge so that the bridge remembers every traveller and wishes them well. In Vhasia, a cartographer might illuminate a map with a prayer; the map will never show the route to an ambush.

The Witch's Tool: The Way Chisel. A chisel of iron, its head struck with a simple arrow. Once per session, the witch may carve a "way mark" into a stone, a tree, or a wooden post. For the next day, anyone who sees the way mark gains a perfect sense of direction to the nearest safe harbour, village, or crossroads – but only while walking. The chisel can also be used to "erase" a false trail, removing tracks from a path as if they had never been made (one exchange of effort per use).

A Hedge Gift: Road-Worn Token (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a small stone, a coin, or a button that has been carried on a long journey. For the next hour, the token glows faintly when the bearer is on the correct path to their goal (as long as the goal is a physical location). The token does not reveal the path – only that the bearer has not (or has) strayed from it.

The Traveler's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Pathfinding Instinct: +1 die to Navigation and movement rolls in familiar territory.	Restless Spirit: Suffer 1 Fatigue when forced to remain stationary or in confined spaces for extended periods.
2	Wayfarer's Luck: Once/scene, treat a failed travel or navigation roll as a success, but mark 1 SB (Clubs).	Compulsive Wandering: Must take the less obvious path when choices present themselves; suffer –1 die when forced to follow direct routes.
3	Road Mastery: +2 dice to rolls involving travel, escape, or finding hidden paths.	Travel Dependency: –1 die to rolls requiring local knowledge or settlement-based skills.
4	Journey's Blessing: Once/session, grant all allies within Near range +1 die to travel-related rolls for one scene.	Nomad's Isolation: –1 die to social rolls involving long-term relationships or community ties.
5	Waypoint Sense: Once/session, instantly know the location and nature of all significant paths, routes, or crossroads within a day's travel.	Directional Obsession: –1 die to rolls not involving movement, travel, or pathfinding; always aware of cardinal directions.
6+	Master of All Ways: Once/session, become one with the road network. For one scene, teleport between any known waypoints and grant +2 dice to all travel-related actions.	Eternal Journey: Mark +3 Obligation when using this power; risk permanent Harm (Stress) from the endless call of the road, making settlement impossible until the journey's end.

6.8.35 Varnek Karn, the Death's Negotiator (Bargains with the Departed)

Lore. Varnek Karn dwells in the grey between life and death, where the newly departed linger with unfinished business and elder shades guard secrets dearer than gold. He is the broker who speaks across the veil, the mediator of disputes between living and dead, and the archivist of every promise sworn beyond the grave. His servants practice post-mortem diplomacy: they negotiate, consult, and contract with spirits as equals—mindful that the dead are patient and rarely generous.

Yet Varnek Karn is also the patron of those who **raise** the dead, not through force but through bargain. The dead may be persuaded to walk again, to fight for a season, or to guard a threshold, but every such compact is a debt. The dead demand their due: a memory, a future, a name, or simply the promise that the living will remember them. Those who serve Varnek Karn learn that raising a spirit is never a command; it is a negotiation, and the spirit always has a price.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, Varnek Karn is the patron of those who treat with the departed respectfully. In Aeler, he is the *Breath-Accountant*, who audits the spiritual ledgers of the Deep Vaults and ensures that the dead are not forgotten. In Ykrul, he is the *Bone-Speaker*, whose drum calls ancestors to council before any major migration. In Vhasia, he is the *Silent Notary*, who witnesses death-bed testaments and ensures their terms are honoured. In the Mistlands, he is the *Bell-Shrouded*, whose unknotted rope holds the fog at bay. Wherever the living and the dead must negotiate, Varnek Karn's servants are there – not to command, but to listen.

“The dead have all the time in the world to consider their offers, and no need to rush to agreement. They know what the living forgot, and remember every slight with perfect clarity. In Varnek's halls, both parties pay a price—but the currency is never what you expect.”

Domain Focus

- **Post-Mortem Diplomacy:** parleys with ghosts and recent dead
- **Ancestral Wisdom:** counsel from forebears and keeping of funerary law
- **Unfinished Business:** resolving the concerns that bind spirits
- **Death-Bound Contracts:** obligations that outlive the flesh
- **The Unquiet Host:** raising temporary armies of the dead through pact

Rites of Varnek Karn

Rite of the Crossing Fee (Low, 4 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [SPIRIT], [KNOWLEDGE]

Materials: A coin for the tongue of the deceased, or a lock of hair from the bereaved.

Effect: Open speech with a specific dead individual. Gain +1 **die** to *Investigation* or *Lore* when seeking knowledge they once held.

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Ancestral Consultation (Low, 5 XP)*Scene; Self; Yes.***Tags:** [SPIRIT], [TRUTH], [FATE]**Materials:** A personal token of the departed, or their favoured food/drink.**Effect:** Ask one question of an ancestral spirit regarding family history, hidden legacies, or inherited debts.**Push It:** The spirit grants detailed, prophetic guidance but exacts a small favour; mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Mediated Pact (Standard, 8 XP)***Scene; Near; Yes.***Tags:** [VOW], [BOND], [COMMAND], [SPIRIT]**Materials:** Two copies of a written accord (one buried with the dead, one kept by the living), or a circle of salt mixed with grave-dust.**Effect:** Choose one:

- **Death-Bound Pact:** Bind a compact between a living signatory and a willing spirit. Both gain **+1 die** when fulfilling the terms. Breach angers the spirit and Varnek both.
- **Spirit Medium:** Serve as a conduit for several spirits to speak. Gain **+2 dice** to mediate disputes between living and dead and to facilitate group negotiation.

Push It: If you chose *Pact*, the pact enforces itself: a breach triggers supernatural reprisal; mark **+1 Obligation**. If you chose *Medium*, a potent spirit rides your voice to speak directly; mark **Exposure +1**.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Unquiet Host (Standard, 10 XP)***Scene; Zone; Yes.***Tags:** [SUMMON], [AREA], [BOND], [DEBT]**Materials:** A battlefield relic (a broken sword, a skull, a scrap of uniform) and a handful of grave-earth.**Effect:** You negotiate with the lingering dead of a place. Summon a **Temporary Host** – a spectral warband treated as a single **Cap 3 Follower** with the following traits:

- **Assist:** May grant **+3 dice** to a single combat or intimidation roll, or provide a free *Setup* action (e.g., “they distract the guards”).
- **Independent Action:** Once per scene, the Host may take one action from the Follower list (e.g., *Scout & Signal*, *Distract & Draw*) at the cost of marking **Exposure +1**.
- **Weakness:** The Host is vulnerable to salt, bells, and consecrated ground. Any attack using such materials ignores their spectral nature.

The Host lasts for the remainder of the current scene, or until dismissed. When it departs, the dead demand their due: you must either mark **+2 Obligation** or perform a *Memorial Rite* before the next dawn (a downtime action, no roll). If you fail to do so, the Host returns unbidden at the worst moment, acting as a hostile hazard (GM's discretion).

Push It: Extend the Host's duration to the entire session. The debt is doubled: mark **+4 Obligation** or perform a memorial rite *and* sacrifice a personal memory (erase a minor fact or a Bond for one session).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Final Testament (High, 13 XP)

Extended; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [VOW], [FATE], [COMMAND], [DEATH]

Materials: A dying person's last words recorded in their blood, witnessed by you.

Effect: Seal the last request with weight beyond life. Targets must pass *Resolve* (DV 4) to ignore it.

Push It: The testament becomes a geas: only fulfilment—or Varnek's wrath—can break it; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Eternal Archive (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [KNOWLEDGE], [AREA], [FATE], [SANCTUARY]

Materials: A library mortared with tomb-stone, ink from cremation ash.

Effect: Found a repository where the dead deposit knowledge. Gain a permanent **+1 die** to *Lore* for historical or genealogical research made within. Spirits periodically contribute testimonies.

Push It: The archive awakens and begins to demand curatorship and payment; mark **Harm 1 (Stress)**.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 8 segments.

Necromantic Summoning (Varnek Karn's Way)

For summoners (Pact-Whisperers) who follow Varnek Karn, the usual Leash mechanics gain an additional option. When you call a spirit (using the Pact-Whisperer rules), you may choose to bind it with a **Death-Bound Contract** instead of the standard Leash. Instead of ticking Leash on harm or disobedience, the spirit gains a **Promise Clock [4]** named "Debt Unpaid." Each time it acts against your interests, you may advance the clock by 1. When the clock fills, the spirit must either obey one final command (even against its nature) or immediately depart and become an enemy. However, while under contract, the spirit cannot be dismissed early – you are committed. This replaces the Boon Finesse option; you cannot spend Boons to clear ticks. This method is slower but more reliable for extended servitude, and it fits Varnek Karn's theme of negotiation over coercion.

Cantors & Cults of Varnek Karn

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Varnek Karn sings in *dirges of negotiation* – melodies that invite the dead to speak, harmonies that soothe restless shades. Their voice is used to call an ancestor to council, to lull a vengeful ghost into recounting its grievance, or to sing a funeral procession past a haunted crossroads. Varnek's Cantors are often found in graveyards, in the halls of the dying, and at the tables where inheritance disputes are settled, their songs bridging the silence between breath and decay.

The Cult of the Unforgotten Ledger. Varnek Karn's cults gather in crypts, ossuaries, and the quiet rooms above funeral parlours – but one cell, known as the *Ink-Flesh Communion*, tattoos the names of the dead onto their own skin, believing that each name grants a fragment of the ancestor's memory. Their ritual involves writing a death-record with a needle dipped in ash and wine; the tattoo whispers the dead person's last words when pressed. The Unforgotten Ledger itself is a single, ever-growing book bound in grey hide – it is said to *whisper* at night, adding names without a scribe. Outsiders are welcome to bring a name of someone they have lost; they may read the ledger but not write in it. Their creed: *"The dead are not gone. They have only changed their address. Be polite, pay your respects, and never make a promise you cannot keep."*

Witchcraft of Varnek Karn (Lay / Funeralary)

A witch who walks with Varnek Karn is a *funeral notary*, a *grave-warden*, or a *memory-keeper* – a lay practitioner who uses ink, seals, and small rites to witness the passage of the dead. Their magic is the art of recording and releasing: a leaden seal that certifies a death-bed promise, a quill that writes in invisible ink that appears only when a ghost is near, or a carved wooden stamp that quiets a restless spirit for a night. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a "memory niche" into a crypt wall, but a hedge-witch of Varnek Karn might press a wax seal onto the niche's edge, binding the dead to speak truth when the seal is broken. In Zakov, a net-mender might weave a shroud with a single loose thread; pulling it releases the drowned sailor's soul to the tide.

The Witch's Tool: The Seal of the Silent Witness. A leaden seal on a leather thong, its face carved with a single closed eye. Once per session, the witch may press the seal into warm wax (or directly onto a stone threshold) while speaking the name of a dead person. For the next day, anyone who speaks that name near the seal hears a faint whisper – a single word or a sigh – from the deceased. The seal may also be used to "witness" a death-bed promise: pressing it onto a written testament makes the document unbearably heavy to anyone who would break the vow.

A Hedge Gift: Echo of the Honoured Dead (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may touch a physical remnant of the dead (a bone, a lock of hair, a piece of clothing) and whisper a question. For a moment, the remnant holds a memory – the GM answers one factual question about the dead person's life or death, but the answer is always tinged with the emotion of the moment (e.g., "she was afraid," "he was angry," "they were at peace").

Varnek Karn's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Death's Whisper: +1 die to <i>No-tice</i> when the dead seek to communicate.	Graveyard Pallor: -1 die to social rolls with the living; your presence unsettles.
2	Ancestral Insight: Once/scene, gain +2 dice for family history or inherited troubles.	Spectral Awareness: Ever-aware of nearby spirits; suffer Fatigue 1 in places of many deaths.
3	Medium's Gift: Once/session, act as a flawless conduit for a spirit.	Death-Touched: Cold spots and small portents follow you; -1 die to ordinary social grace.
4	Final Authority: Once/scene, compel adherence to a true last request (Resolve DV 4).	Corpse-Pale: Visibly wan; -2 dice where warmth or vigour is required.
5	Archive Keeper: Once/session, access perfect recall of a historical event or family secret.	Unquiet Presence: The dead trail you; -1 die to stealth and to surprising the living.
6+	Death's Confidant: Once/session, negotiate with puissant death-entities as an equal.	Halfway House: Mark +2 Obligation; risk becoming half-withdrawn from the living world.

Playstyle Notes

Varnek Karn favours investigators, arbiters, and heralds of funerary law. Power grows through cultural sensitivity, shrewd bargaining, and careful record-keeping; the price is a thinning tie to warmth and mortal ease. Expect mysteries of lineage, obligations that outlive their makers, and parleys where both sides of the veil demand their due. The *Rite of the Unquiet Host* allows a follower to temporarily command a small army of the dead, but the debt incurred ensures that such power is never free – and the dead always remember who called them.

Varnek Karn emphasises

- **Diplomacy over Dominion:** bargaining with the dead rather than commanding them
- **Knowledge Brokerage:** trading for secrets and testimonies beyond the grave
- **Cultural Protocols:** rites, tokens, and proper doors for speaking with ancestors
- **Mediation:** resolving conflicts that bind the living to the dead
- **Historical Continuity:** showing how past vows shape the present
- **The Unquiet Host:** raising temporary armies through pact, not domination

6.8.36 Vorthak, the Hunger Unbound (Consumption & Metamorphic Hunger)

Lore. Vorthak is the principle of absolute consumption: an appetite that devours not only what is, but the very potential of what might be. Each feeding transforms both eater and eaten. His servants become conduits of metamorphosis through ingestion, learning to consume not only matter but also properties, identities, and even strands of fate. Power comes by taking in — and the cost is becoming more like the hunger you channel.

Among the peoples of Fate’s Edge, Vorthak is known by many fearful names. In Aeler, he is the *Deep Forge*, the hunger of the mountain that consumes ore and returns steel. In Zakov, he is the *Salt-Hunger*, the appetite that preserves by consuming the moisture from flesh. In Linn, he is the *Tide-That-Eats-The-Shore*, a slow, patient consumption that reshapes coastlines. His followers are rarely beloved, but they are essential — for without consumption, there is no transformation, and without transformation, there is only stagnation.

“To consume is to become. To devour is to transform. In Vorthak’s embrace, the boundary between eater and eaten dissolves into something new — and something hungry.”

Domain Focus

- **Metamorphic Consumption:** transformation through ingestion of matter, energy, or concepts
- **Essence Absorption:** gaining properties by consuming them utterly **Hunger Propagation:** spreading consumption as a force of change
- **Identity Metabolism:** consuming and adopting aspects of others’ natures

Rites of Vorthak**Rite of the Hungry Touch (Low, 5 XP)**

Scene; Touch/Self; Yes.

Tags: [CONSUME], [BOOST], [SENSE], [RISK]

Materials: A fragment of the thing to be consumed (food, substance, symbol); or an empty vessel or a place where something was devoured.

Effect: Choose one:

- **Metabolic Touch:** Absorb an essential trait of the target. Gain +1 die to actions aligned with the absorbed property for one scene.
- **Hunger’s Whisper:** Sense what in the area may be consumed and the benefit it offers. Gain +1 die to *Investigation* when seeking consumable resources.

Push It: (Whisper only) The hunger turns contagious: nearby feel your appetite; mark 1 SB (Clubs).

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Essence Feast (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Touch; Yes.

Tags: [CONSUME], [TRANSFORM], [BOOST], [DEBT]

Materials: The complete consumption of a significant item (weapon, book, relic).

Effect: Permanently absorb the item's essential nature. Gain one minor property or +1 die to a closely related skill. The item is utterly destroyed.

Push It: Take a major property, but gain a permanent *Hunger Mark* (a visible sign of consumption).

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Identity Meal (Standard, 7 XP)

Scene; Near; Yes.

Tags: [CONSUME], [TRANSFORM], [BOOST], [RISK]

Materials: A personal token or a clear memory of the target.

Effect: Temporarily adopt one aspect of a specific person's nature (skill, talent, or defining trait). Gain +2 dice to actions matching that aspect.

Push It: The adoption deepens and clings; mark 1 **SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Metamorphic Gluttony (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; Yes.

Tags: [CONSUME], [AREA], [TRANSFORM], [PRESSURE], [FATE]

Materials: A site scarred by great consumption.

Effect: Become a locus of transformative hunger. All present may consume aspects (skills, memories, properties), but each must pass *Spirit+Resolve* (DV 4) or suffer uncontrolled transformation effects.

Push It: Some changes become permanent; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 7 segments.

Rite of the Hunger's Ascension (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Self; Yes.

Tags: [TRANSFORM], [BOOST], [SACRIFICE], [FATE], [DEBT]

Materials: The deliberate offering-up of your current limits to Vorthak.

Effect: Consume your own constraints and transform. Choose three: +1 Attribute; +2 dice to one skill; immunity to one Condition type; or one major supernatural capability.

Push It: Take all chosen benefits, but lose one core aspect of your original identity; mark **Harm 2**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended rite; mark +2 **Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Hunger Ascetic (Metamorphic Monk)

To consume is to become. To devour is to transform. I am the stomach of the world.

Prerequisites: Body 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of the Hungry Touch or Cantor of Vorthak.

Ascetic Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Gut of Iron	You may consume anything organic (rotten food, raw meat, bitter herbs) without ill effect. +1 die to resist poison or disease from ingestion.	Passive	Body 3
Essence Glutton	When you use Rite of the Essence Feast, you may gain one additional minor property (still destroying the item).	+1 Obligation	Tier II
Hunger's Patience	You may go without food or water for twice as long as normal. When you finally consume, you heal 1 Fatigue.	Passive	Body 3, Spirit 2
Metabolic Shift	Once per scene, as a reaction, you may convert 1 Harm you would take into 1 Fatigue (you metabolise the injury).	1 Boon	Body 4
Identity Digestion	When you use Rite of the Identity Meal, the adopted aspect lasts for the entire session instead of one scene.	+1 Obligation	Tier III
All-Devo Maw	Once per session, you may consume a single mundane object (size no larger than a shield) as an action, gaining 1 Boon. The object is utterly destroyed.	Free	Body 4, Spirit 3

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Apotheosis of Hunger.* Once per session, you may enter a state of perfect consumption for one scene. You ignore all penalties from Fatigue, and any time you would take Harm from a physical attack, you may instead consume the attack's energy, converting the Harm into 1 Fatigue and gaining +1 die on your next action. When the scene ends, you suffer Harm 2 (Stress) as your body rejects the excess. *Fate's Edge: Comprehensive Resource Guide* 213 You cannot use this talent again until you have consumed a significant meal (at least a full day's rations) in a ritual manner.

Cantors & Cults of Vorthak

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Vorthak sings in *hungry harmonies* – melodies that start with a single, clear note and then devour themselves, ending in a hungry silence. Their voice is used to urge a crowd to feast, to sing a blade sharper by absorbing the steel's flaws, or to make a meal last for hours by consuming the very passage of time. Vorthak's Cantors are often found in feasting halls, in butcheries, and around campfires where stories are consumed and retold.

The Cult of the Ravenous Circle. Vorthak's cults meet in places that embody consumption: abattoirs, forges, bakeries, and the kitchens of great manors. The Ravenous Circle is a fellowship of chefs, alchemists, tanners, and smelters – those who understand that to create something new, something old must be utterly consumed. A ritual of the Circle involves each member bringing a raw material (a cut of meat, a lump of ore, a written secret) and placing it in a central hearth. The hearth consumes it, and the circle speaks aloud what they hope to become by that consumption. Their creed is carved above the hearth: *"What is not consumed is wasted. What is wasted is an insult to hunger."* Outsiders are welcome to bring an offering and a wish, but they must eat a portion of the ash.

Witchcraft of Vorthak (Lay / Consumption)

A witch who walks with Vorthak is a *hunger-smith* or *ash-weaver* – one who crafts through the act of consumption: a knife that sharpens itself by eating the metal of its victims, a forge that devours impurities and returns only the strongest steel, or a culinary knife that seasons meat by absorbing the memory of the animal's life. Their magic works through the materials of consumption: a quill that writes in ink made from burnt secrets, a needle that sews a garment by consuming thread and producing new cloth, or a smooth stone that absorbs properties by touch. Their tools are never hammers; they use stones, ashes, and the patient heat of a slow digestion.

The Witch's Tool: The Maw-Stone. A smooth, porous stone, warm to the touch, the size of a fist. It is said to have been regurgitated from the belly of a great beast. Once per session, the witch may press the stone against a material (stone, wood, metal, flesh) and speak a word of consumption. The stone "eats" a small portion of the material (a handful of stone dust, a sliver of wood, a thin curl of metal) and absorbs its essential property. For the next scene, the stone can be used to grant +1 die to any roll that benefits from that property (e.g., "sharpness" for a cutting tool, "hardness" for a shield). The stone can also be used to "consume" a single, small physical detail (a button, a lock, a hinge) as if it had never been there, but doing so empties the stone of its stored property.

A Hedge Gift: Ash of Old Forms (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may take a handful of ash from a fire that consumed something significant (a letter, a garment, a meal) and blow it into the air. For the next minute, the ash reveals the shape of what was consumed – a phantom image of the letter, the garment, or the meal. The image is ghostly and cannot be touched, but it can be read, examined, or used to identify an object that no longer exists.

Vorthak's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Hunger's Sight: +1 die to <i>No-tice</i> consumable properties in objects, beings, or ideas.	Metabolic Craving: Must consume something <i>significant</i> daily or suffer Fatigue 1 .
2	Essence Thief: Once/scene, temporarily gain a minor property by consuming it.	Identity Bleed: Absorbed aspects surface unbidden; -1 die to maintain your original persona.
3	Metamorphic Resilience: Once/session, consume a <i>Condition</i> or <i>Harm</i> to negate it.	Hunger Aura: Those Near feel urges to consume or hoard; they suffer -1 die to self-control rolls.
4	Transformation Feast: Once/scene, consume and permanently absorb one <i>minor</i> supernatural ability.	Essence Instability: Conflicting properties clash; -1 die when relying on multiple absorbed aspects.
5	Identity Cannibal: Once/session, consume a <i>significant</i> aspect of another (major skill or core trait).	Self-Consumption: Risk eating your own memories or abilities; mark 1 SB (Spades) when stressed.
6+	Hunger Incarnate: Once/session, become living consumption; absorb nearby properties, abilities, or aspects.	Void Hunger: Mark +3 Obligation; risk dissolving into pure appetite that must feed to keep form.

Playstyle Notes

Vorthak favours those who hunt for change through taking in what the world offers: relish clever uses of absorbed traits, judge the *price* of every bite, and beware the slow surrender of the self. Expect scenes of metamorphosis, bargaining for what can be eaten, and hard choices where power tastes like you.

Vorthak emphasises

- **Transformation through Consumption:** becoming what you devour
- **Metamorphic Power:** fundamental, identity-shaping change
- **Essence Absorption:** discerning and using a thing's core nature
- **Identity Metabolism:** integrating (or failing to integrate) stolen aspects
- **Hunger Propagation:** letting appetite reshape people and places

6.8.37 The Witness (Truth & Revelation)

Lore. The Witness remembers what others bury. Every shadow cast and oath broken is a line in her unending ledger. She is the keeper of inconvenient truths, the patron of those who seek to expose lies or recover forgotten knowledge. Her followers learn that knowledge comes with a price—the weight of remembering what others would forget.

The Witness has no will, only a ledger; no mercy, only accuracy. She does not demand confessions, but she ensures that every lie leaves a stain, every secret a trace. Those who serve her become archivists of the uncomfortable, witnesses to the truths that others would kill to keep hidden. To walk her path is to accept that some truths are weapons, and that the truth-teller is never loved.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, the Witness is known by many names. In Ecktoria, she is the *Ink-Eye*, the Censor's clerk who copies every redacted line onto a private scroll. In Vhasia, she is the *Fractured Mirror*, prayed to by spies who seek to reveal a rival's true loyalty. In the Mistlands, she is the *Fog-Scribe*, whose name is whispered when a bell-line fails and the dead must be identified by their secrets. And in the shadows of every great city, there are those who follow the *Apocalyptic Witness* – a doomsaying cult that believes the world will end when the last hidden truth is finally spoken aloud, and who work to hasten that revelation by exposing every lie, no matter the cost.

I will show you what you would rather forget. But first, you must forget what you think you know.

Domain Focus

- **Truth Revelation:** exposing lies, uncovering secrets, forcing confessions
- **Memory Keeping:** preserving knowledge, recalling forgotten facts
- **Inconvenient Knowledge:** learning what others wish to hide
- **Prophetic Warning:** seeing the consequences of hidden truths
- **Burden of Witness:** the psychological weight of knowing too much

Rites of the Witness

Rite of the Lingering Trace (Low, 4 XP)

Instant; Near; Yes (Investigation/Notice only).

Tags: [INVESTIGATION], [KNOWLEDGE], [TRUTH]

Materials: A trace of the thing to be remembered (hair, dust, a spoken name).

Effect: You follow a hidden thread. Gain +1 die to investigate or notice something directly related to the trace within the current scene. Additionally, you may ask the GM one yes/no question about whether the trace is connected to a specific person, event, or object.

Push It: Gain +2 dice instead, but mark 1 segment on a **Memory Strain Clock** [4]. If the clock fills, you gain Fatigue 1 and suffer –1 die on Investigation/Notice rolls until the end of the next scene (the Witness taxes your mind).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Uncomfortable Question (Low, 5 XP)*Scene; Near; No.***Tags:** [COMMAND], [FEAR], [TRUTH]**Materials:** A circle drawn with chalk or string while focusing on a specific person.**Effect:** You force a moment of raw honesty. Ask one question of a target within the zone. They may either answer truthfully (the GM must give a true answer, though it may be cryptic) or mark **1 Fatigue** and gain a *Guilty Tell* Condition (–1 die to all social rolls until they confess the truth to someone).**Push It:** The target must also reveal a surface emotion or a forgotten detail (GM's choice). Mark **1 SB (Hearts)** as the Witness records the strain.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Echoing Truth (Standard, 8 XP)***Instant; Near; No.***Tags:** [MIND], [TRUTH], [FEAR]**Materials:** A reflective surface (mirror, still water, polished metal) used to focus on the target.**Effect:** The target must make a Resolve test (DV 3) or suffer –1 die to rolls involving memory, deception, or resisting interrogation for the scene. If they fail, you may ask one specific, factual question about something they know, and they must answer truthfully or suffer **1 SB (Hearts)** as the memory is forcibly drawn forth.**Push It:** If the target fails their Resolve test, you may ask a second question, but the mental intrusion causes them **Harm 1 (Stress)**.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Immutable Record (Standard, 7 XP)***Scene; Near; No.***Tags:** [VOW], [BOND], [TRUTH]**Materials:** A document signed by all parties within the zone, or a spoken pact witnessed by the caster.**Effect:** Bind the agreement. Any party who knowingly breaches it suffers **1 SB (Hearts)** immediately and gains a persistent **Oathbreaker's Mark** Condition (–1 die on social rolls involving honour, trust, or oaths until amends are made or a significant act redeems them).**Push It:** The bond becomes magically enforced for one specific, crucial clause: violation automatically inflicts **Harm 1 (Stress)** on the breaker in addition to the SB and Mark.**Invoke:** 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.*Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).***Rite of the Shared Burden (Standard, 9 XP)***Instant; Touch; No.***Tags:** [HEAL], [DEBT], [MIND]**Materials:** A written secret (yours or another's) and a candle.**Effect:** You transfer the weight of a truth. Choose one: you may remove a *Guilty Tell*, *Haunted*, or similar psychological Condition from yourself and give it to a willing or

unwilling target (they resist with Resolve DV 4). Alternatively, you may share a secret with an ally; both of you clear 1 Fatigue as the burden is halved.

Push It: Transfer a Condition without the target's consent (they automatically resist, but on failure they gain it). Mark **1 SB (Spades)** as the secret stains them.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Rite of the Unveiled Heart (High, 12 XP)

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [MANIPULATION], [FEAR], [TRUTH], [AREA]

Materials: A private setting where the target feels safe or is speaking freely.

Effect: The target suffers -2 dice to all attempts to conceal true emotions, intentions, or lies for the scene. Any successful social roll (Sway, Command, Deceit) made by the target generates **1 SB (Hearts)** as the effort to maintain falsehoods under the Witness's gaze creates internal discord.

Push It: You may designate one specific, complex question about the target's motivations, fears, or hidden loyalties. If you successfully use Sway or Insight against them this scene, you automatically learn the answer to that question. The intense scrutiny marks **1 SB (Spades)** for you as the Witness's attention lingers.

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 6 segments.

Rite of the Final Reckoning (High, 13 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [AREA], [COMMAND], [TRUTH], [FEAR]

Materials: A formally called gathering (court, council, family meeting) within the consecrated zone.

Effect: All present must speak their greatest debt, wrongdoing, or hidden truth related to the gathering's purpose. Those who lie or withhold suffer **Harm 2 (Stress/Reputation)**. Truth-tellers gain **+2 dice** to social actions for the remainder of the scene within the zone.

Push It: The truth becomes inescapable – even indirect lies or evasions related to the core topic suffer the Harm 2 penalty. The absolute nature of the revelation creates **2 SB (Diamonds)** as the disruption to fates and secrets resonates.

Invoke: Extended rite; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Obligation: 7 segments.

Cantors & Cults of the Witness

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of the Witness sings in *truth-tolling* – clear, piercing melodies that cut through evasion, harmonies that make the hidden surface. Their voice is used to compel a confession, to sound an alarm that a secret is about to be spoken, or to sing a historical record into being, each note a word in a ledger. The Witness's Cantors are often found in courtrooms, in archive vaults, and at the bedsides of the dying, singing the last truth.

The Congregation of the Unmasking (Apocalyptic Cult). The most feared of the Witness’s cults, the Congregation of the Unmasking believes that the world will end when the last hidden truth is finally revealed – and that this ending is not a catastrophe but a liberation. They seek to expose every lie, every buried crime, every forgotten promise, no matter the cost. A ritual of the Congregation involves each member speaking aloud a truth they have kept secret, then burning a representation of the lie that concealed it. Their creed is painted on a scroll that is never fully unrolled: *“When all that is hidden is seen, the world will either break or be free. We will be there to witness which.”* Outsiders are not welcome; they are potential sources of truth – or obstacles to be unmasked. The Congregation has been known to destroy families, topple governments, and start wars in their pursuit of total revelation. They are loved by none and feared by all, but even their enemies cannot deny that they are right: some secrets truly are worth dying to expose.

Witchcraft of the Witness (Craft / Record)

A witch who walks with the Witness is a *ledger-scribe* or *seal-breaker* – one who crafts the tools of permanent record: a book that cannot be altered once written, a quill that writes in ink that fades only when the truth it records is fulfilled, or a press that stamps each page with a sigil of authenticity. Their magic works through the materials of documentation: a chisel that carves a truth into stone so that it cannot be erased, a needle that sews a confession into a garment so that the wearer cannot deny it, or a forge that tempers a door that can only be opened by someone who has never told a lie. In Aeler, a True-Mason might carve a “witness stone” at a courthouse entrance, so that all testimony given within is remembered by the stone for a century. In Thepyrgos, a bookbinder might stitch a volume that screams if its pages are cut.

The Witch’s Tool: The Quill of Unwritten Truths. A quill carved from a raven’s feather, its nib dipped in ink made from lampblack and a drop of the witch’s blood. Once per session, the witch may write a single sentence on a piece of parchment, then seal it with a drop of wax. For the next day, anyone other than the witch who reads the sentence must make a Resolve test (DV 3) or forget it immediately after reading. The witch may also use the quill to “seal” a spoken secret, causing the speaker’s voice to catch if they try to repeat it for the rest of the scene.

A Hedge Gift: Record of a Breath (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may hold a blank piece of parchment up to a person’s lips as they speak. The parchment absorbs the spoken words, recording them exactly as they were said – including tone, hesitation, and any unconscious meaning. The parchment can be read by anyone (the words appear in the speaker’s own handwriting), but it crumbles to dust after being read aloud. The witch may also use this ability to record the final words of the dying, preserving them for one day.

The Witness's Corruption Table

Tier	Benefit	Cost / Quirk
1	Truth's Sight: +1 die to Insight when detecting deception or hidden motives.	Burden of Knowledge: -1 die to social rolls involving lies or deception; others become uncomfortable with your piercing gaze.
2	Memory's Keeper: Once/scene, recall one specific detail from a previous scene with perfect clarity.	Compulsive Honesty: Must correct obvious falsehoods witnessed, even when tactically disadvantageous.
3	Revelation's Power: +2 dice to rolls involving exposing secrets, uncovering lies, or forcing confessions.	Truth-Blind: Suffer 1 Fatigue when exposed to comforting lies or wilful ignorance.
4	Witness's Authority: Once/session, force one target to make a Resolve test (DV 4) or reveal a significant hidden truth.	Isolation: -1 die to rolls requiring trust or close relationships; others fear your ability to uncover their secrets.
5	Omniscient Gaze: Once/session, see through all deceptions and lies for one exchange, gaining +3 dice to related actions.	Paranoia: -1 die to rolls involving personal peace or rest; the weight of all truths witnessed creates constant mental strain.
6+	Absolute Witness: Once/session, become the living embodiment of truth. For one scene, all deceptions within Near range automatically fail.	Truth's Prison: Mark +3 Obligation when using this power; become unable to tolerate any form of deception, making normal social interaction nearly impossible.
		The Unmasking Beckons: The apocalyptic urge grows – you may be called to expose a truth that will destroy a community, a nation, or yourself.

Playstyle Notes

The Witness rewards curiosity, patience, and a willingness to bear uncomfortable knowledge. Her followers are not merely investigators but *archivists of the real* – they record what others would erase. The Witness does not demand that you expose every secret; she simply ensures that you cannot forget the ones you learn. Intrusions often take the form of dreams showing a hidden crime, a sudden memory of a lie you told years ago, or the appearance of a scrap of parchment containing a truth you wish you had never read. High-Tier followers may find that secrets begin to *seek them out* – people confess unprompted, documents fall open to damning pages, and the world becomes a book that cannot be closed.

Emphasises

- **Truth as Burden:** every secret known is a weight carried

- **Investigation as Ritual:** uncovering lies is a sacred act
- **Memory as Weapon:** forgetting can be as powerful as remembering
- **The Unmasking:** exposing a truth can be an act of mercy or destruction
- **Witness as Isolation:** those who know too much are seldom loved

6.8.38 Xhak'Thul, the Thunder-Speaker (Storm, Shock & Awe)

Lore. Before words, there was thunder. Before scripture, lightning carved its commandments into the bones of the world. Xhak'Thul is the Voice That Splits Mountains, the Drum That Shakes Foundations, a power born from the first storm that ever raged across the primal earth. His faithful are whirlwinds of action – they do not study; they dance, they shout, they move with the sky's fury. His gifts are not gentle miracles but raw terror, awe, and vitality ripped from nature's heart.

Among the peoples of Fate's Edge, Xhak'Thul is the patron of the pre-literate, the neolithic, those who have not yet built walls against the wild. In the deep Vhasian highlands, he is the *Storm-Father*, invoked by herders who watch lightning split the sky. In Ykrul, he is the *Thunder-Hoof*, the sound of a thousand horses stampeding. In Linn, he is the *Raging Tide*, the storm that comes without warning. His followers are not scholars; they are dancers, drummers, shamans, and warriors who feel the storm in their bones before they hear it in the sky. He favours those who act without hesitation, who embrace chaos, and who understand that the loudest voice is often the truest.

“Feel the drum in your bones before you hear it in the sky. When the storm speaks, you will already be dancing to its rhythm.”

Domain Focus

- **Primal Power:** storm, thunder, lightning, earthquake, wildfire
- **Shock and Awe:** overwhelming sensory impact, terror as a weapon
- **Fear-Eater:** absorbing panic to fuel strength
- **Immediate Magic:** no rituals, no books – only emotion, movement, and the moment

Rites of Xhak'Thul**Rite of the Thunderous Presence (Low, 4 XP)**

Scene; Near; No.

Tags: [FEAR], [COMMAND], [AREA], [PRESSURE]

Materials: A drum made from storm-felled wood or any suitable improvised percussion.

Effect: Your presence becomes overwhelming. All NPCs within Near range must test Resolve (DV 2) or suffer –1 die to social actions due to awe or terror for the scene. Allies gain +1 die to Intimidation or Command actions.

Push It: Extend the effect to Far range, but you mark 1 Fatigue and mark 1 **SB (Hearts)** as your presence becomes difficult to control.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark +1 **Obligation**.

Rite of the Storm's Step (Low, 5 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [SPEED], [FEAR], [BOOST]

Materials: Earth from a lightning strike site, worn boot leather.

Effect: You move with the storm's speed. Gain +2 **dice** to Athletics or Stealth rolls.

The first attack you make this scene gains **+1 Effect**.

Push It: Gain **+3 dice** and move as a blur, becoming difficult to track or clearly remember; mark **1 SB (Diamonds)**.

Requires: Familiar (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+1 Obligation**.

Rite of the Shattered Sky (Standard, 8 XP)

Scene; Zone; No.

Tags: [AREA], [FORCE], [FEAR], [WEATHER]

Materials: A shard of meteoric iron or metal touched by a severe storm.

Effect: You call a localised, supernatural storm in a Zone. Choose one effect:

- **Lightning Strike:** Single target, Harm 2.
- **Wind Blast:** Knockback, dispersing arrows or scattering foes.
- **Hail Barrage:** Harm 1 (AREA).

All enemies in the Zone suffer **-1 die** to actions from chaos and distraction.

Push It: Double the chosen effect's scale or potency (e.g., Harm 3, large knockback), but the effect also applies to allies in the Zone; mark **2 SB (Clubs)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Rite of the Fear-Eater (Standard, 9 XP)

Scene; Self; No.

Tags: [FEAR], [HEAL], [COMMAND], [BOOST]

Materials: Soil or dust from a place of great terror (battlefield, prison, ruins).

Effect: You feed on the fear around you. For each Frightened target in the scene, gain **+1 die** on your next action (max +3). If you successfully Intimidate a target during this scene, you heal 1 Fatigue.

Push It: Absorb all palpable fear in the scene, gaining a flat **+3 dice** bonus to your next action, but mark 1 permanent Scar related to fear. Mark **1 SB (Hearts)**.

Requires: Familiar + Codex (Invoke: 1 Boon).

Invoke: 1 action; mark **+2 Obligation**.

Rite of the World's Drum (High, 14 XP)

Extended; Zone; No.

Tags: [AREA], [FEAR], [COMMAND], [TRANSFORM], [WEATHER]

Materials: A drum fashioned from lightning-struck wood, with a hide from a beast killed by natural force.

Effect: You become an incarnation of the storm for one scene:

- Gain **+2 dice** to rolls based on strength, speed, and intimidation.
- Your anger echoes as thunder; attacks against you may be answered by lightning (GM decides, usually 1 SB and Harm 1 to the attacker).
- Enemies must test Resolve at **-2 dice** to resist Fear effects you create.

Start a 6-segment *Natural Disasters* clock; when it fills, the storm's wrath manifests as a random environmental hazard (landslide, lightning strike, flash flood).

Push It: The transformation lingers after the scene, and your emotional state causes minor environmental effects (windows rattle, small fires flicker). Mark **2 SB (Diamonds)** and advance the clock by 2 segments.

Requires: Familiar + Codex + Tier III (Invoke: 2 Boons).

Invoke: Extended action; mark **+3 Obligation**.

Obligation: 8 segments.

Thunder Speaker (Storm Shaman)

The storm does not ask. It speaks. You are its echo.

Prerequisites: Body 3+, Spirit 2+, Rite of the Thunderous Presence or Cantor of Xhak'Thul.

Shamanic Techniques (choose as Talents):

Technique	Effect	Cost	Req.
Storm Caller	Once per scene, as a free action, you may cause a peal of thunder to roll across the zone. All enemies must test Resolve (DV 3) or lose their next minor action.	1 Boon	Spirit 3
Lightning Re-flexes	You gain +1 die to defence rolls against ranged attacks (arrows, bolts, thrown weapons).	Passive	Body 3, Athletics 2
Fear Eater	When you successfully Intimidate a target, you gain 1 Boon (once per scene).	Passive	Spirit 3, Command 2
Pact Lightning (Synergy)	If you are also a Pact-Whisperer (summoner), you may channel Xhak'Thul's power through a summoned spirit. The spirit gains the [LIGHTNING] tag for one scene (its attacks deal +1 Harm and ignore 1 Armour).	+1 Obligation	Tier II, Summoner
Storm Dance	While you are moving (not standing still), you gain +1 die to all physical actions (melee, athletics, evasion).	Passive	Body 3, Performance 1
Thunder Grasp	Once per session, when you would be reduced to 0 Harm, you may instead unleash a concussive blast. All enemies in Close range are knocked back one band and must test Body+Resolve (DV 3) or fall prone. You survive, but mark Fatigue 2.	Free	Tier III, Rite of the Fear-Eater

Master Technique (Epic Talent, 12 XP): *Eye of the Storm.* Once per session,

Cantors & Cults of Xhak'Thul

The Cantor's Song. A Cantor of Xhak'Thul does not sing melodies – they drum. Their voice is a percussive roar, a heartbeat rhythm that shakes the ground. Their “song” is the pattern of a storm: the slow build of pressure, the sudden crack of lightning, the fading rumble of retreating thunder. Xhak'Thul's Cantors are often found in places without writing, where memory is carried in dance and the beat of a skin drum.

The Cult of the First Drum. Xhak'Thul's cults gather in clearings, on hilltops, or in caves that echo with thunder. The First Drum is a fellowship of dancers, shamans, and warriors who believe that civilisation is a cage and that the storm is the only honest law. A ritual of the Cult involves each member drumming on a skin drum (never bought, always made from an animal they killed themselves) until the first person collapses from exhaustion. The collapsed dancer is declared “storm-taken” and must lead the next ritual. Their creed is not written – it is beaten into the earth: *"The sky does not ask permission. Neither do we."* Outsiders are welcome to dance, but they must bring a drum they made with their own hands.

Witchcraft of Xhak'Thul (Shamanic / Storm)

A witch who walks with Xhak'Thul is a *storm-caller* or *drum-maker* – a shaman who crafts the tools of primal power: a drum that can be heard for a mile, a spear of lightning-struck wood that never misses its target, or a charm of meteoric iron that calls a storm when struck. Their magic is immediate, visceral, and never subtle. They do not use hammers or chisels; they use drums, rattles, and the raw energy of a thunderclap. In Ykrul, a bone-carver might shape a whistle that mimics the sound of a thunderclap, terrifying horses. In the deep Vhasian highlands, a shaman might paint their drum with the blood of a goat struck by lightning, binding the storm's spirit to the skin.

The Witch's Tool: The Storm-Drum. A hand-drum made from lightning-struck wood and the hide of an animal killed by a natural disaster (flood, fire, landslide). The drum's surface is painted with a spiral that represents the eye of the storm. Once per session, the witch may strike the drum with a single, thunderous beat. All creatures within Near range must test Resolve (DV 3) or be Shaken (–1 die to all actions) for one exchange. The drum can also be used to “call the storm” – beating a steady rhythm for a full minute (out of combat) grants +1 die to all weather-related rolls for the next hour.

A Hedge Gift: Drum of the First Beat (2 XP). Once per scene, the witch may tap a rhythm on any surface (a table, a shield, a tree trunk). For the next minute, all allies within Near range who hear the rhythm gain +1 die to Athletics and combat rolls, as their heartbeat synchronises with the storm. The rhythm cannot be sustained if the witch is silenced or takes a wound.

Shock & Awe Corruption Table

Level	Manifestation	Cost / Quirk
1–2	Static Cling: Your touch carries a static shock. Metal objects faintly hum in your presence.	You feel restless energy before a storm. Minor lies itch like a rash.
3–4	Storm-Touched: Your hair stirs without wind. Your voice occasionally cracks like thunder. Small flames flicker near you.	You become irritable in calm, silent places. You crave loud arguments and violent weather.
5–6	Lightning Rod: You are dangerously magnetic. Unshielded metal flies to your hands. Your eyes crackle with faint light.	You feel a compulsion to disrupt order and create chaos. Peace feels like a cage.
7–8	Walking Storm: A localised wind stirs around you. You smell of ozone and wet stone. You cannot whisper; your voice is a low rumble.	You lose patience with lengthy plans. You prefer direct, explosive action, regardless of the cost.
9–10	Heart of the Tempest: You are the eye of a personal storm. Rain sheets indoors; lightning threatens those who anger you.	You see the world only as a force to be broken or commanded. Gentler emotions are foreign memories.

Rivalries

- **The Penitent Lich (Remembrance & Restitution):** Orderly, structured memory versus Xhak'Thul's primal chaos.
- **The Traveler (Ways & Roads):** Carefully laid paths versus the sky's explosive, pathless nature.
- **Varnek Karn (Necromantic Archives):** The cold order of death versus the chaotic fury of life expressed through storm.

Obligation Triggers

- **8+ Segments:** Xhak'Thul demands a public spectacle of awe and fear, such as levelling a tower, parting a river, or terrifying a city district.
- **10+ Segments:** The storm begins speaking through you constantly. Refusal to act on its impulses ends your access to Rites until you perform a catastrophic display of power.

Signs of Favor

The scent of ozone, hair stirring from unseen static, a voice that carries perfectly over crowd noise, local storms that react to your emotional state.

Playstyle Notes

Khak'Thul is the patron of shamans, berserkers, and anyone who acts first and thinks never. His magic is immediate, loud, and unsubtle – the thunderclap, the lightning strike, the roar that silences a crowd. He rewards boldness, spontaneity, and the willingness to break things. His followers are not subtle, but they are terrifying. Ideal for players who enjoy direct solutions, primal power, and characters who would rather break a door than pick a lock.

No True Acolyte Interpreting a patron's will is often a dangerous prospect in and of itself. Many a Runkeeper has found themselves on the opposite end of machinations from others from the same patron.

Runebound Resilience (18 XP Epic Talent) *Prerequisite: Tier III+, Codex, Spirit 4+*

You have learned to transform the very essence of harm into deeper communion with your Patron.

- **Harm Conversion:** Once per round, you may convert up to 2 Harm levels to +2 Obligation instead of taking the damage
- **Obligation Endurance:** While at 6+ Obligation segments, gain +1 die to all Rite invocations
- **Patron's Shield:** When reduced to Harm 3, you may immediately Invoke any known Rite without marking additional Obligation
- **Debt Fortification:** At 8+ Obligation segments, ignore first Harm 1 each round
- **Once per scene**

Narrative Integration:

"Your flesh has become a ledger, and every wound is a prayer. The deeper your Patron's claim, the stronger your resistance to mortal frailty."

Patron's Favored (18 XP Prestige Talent) *Prerequisite: Tier III+, Codex, Familiar, 8+ total Obligation segments*

Your Patron has marked you as specially favored, granting you unprecedented access to their power with reduced cost.

- **Low Rite Discount:** Reduce Obligation cost for Low Rites by 1 (minimum 0)
- **Empower:** Once per scene, spend 1 Action + 1 Boons:
 - Target gains +1 Corruption level per round for 3 rounds. Corruption lasts until the end of the scene.
 - While empowered, gain +1 die to all rolls
- **Empower Push:** Spend 1 Action + 1 Boon + 3 Obligation:
 - Target(s) gains +3 Corruption levels until end of scene
 - While empowered, gain +1 die to all rolls
 - Target gains +Corruption fatigue at the end of the scene.
- **Enhanced Gift:** Your **Patron's Gift** now provides +2 dice instead of +1
- **Debt Bound:** Cannot Empower again until all Obligation is cleared

Narrative Integration: *The Patron's favor comes with a price—but for the truly devoted, that price is worth the power. You carry their blessing openly now, and their influence spreads like wildfire to those who would walk in your shadow.*

“Every Rune is a promise. Every line a covenant. Do not mistake the Runekeeper's silence for weakness; their memory is the foundation of our craft.”

6.8.39 The Invokers

Invokers are those who dare. Neither archivists nor worshippers, they are travelers on the knife-edge between story and ruin. An Invoker learns the Rites of a Patron, weaves them into their own Art, and bends fate for a moment. Yet invocation is not command: it is negotiation. The Patron always leaves its mark. The stronger the Rite, the deeper the scar.

Invokers are often wanderers, exiles, or seekers. To common folk they are feared—witches, oathbreakers, meddlers with things not meant for mortal hands. But when the village falls to plague, when the sea closes its roads, when the dead refuse their rest, it is an Invoker who is called upon.

6.8.40 Closing Words

The dance between Patron, Runekeeper, and Invoker is a triangle of peril and necessity. Without Patrons, there is no power. Without Runekeepers, no record. Without Invokers, no action. Together, they shape the crooked, perilous art we call Invocation.

6.9 Patrons & Rites

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Closing Thoughts

Every roleplaying game is, at its heart, a shared act of imagination. FATE'S EDGE offers rules and structures, but the real magic happens between players and game master, in the pauses between dice rolls and the sparks that leap across the table. The mechanics are not a cage—they are a scaffold, meant to support the story you want to tell.

You will not find every answer written in these pages, nor should you. The best sessions arise when the table embraces uncertainty: when a Story Beat pulls the tale in an unexpected direction, when a character's flaw drives the narrative forward, when laughter follows disaster. The system gives you tools; the table gives those tools meaning.

If you remember nothing else, carry these three principles into play:

- **Fiction First.** Let the world breathe, and let the rules bend to the needs of the story.
- **Every Choice Matters.** Risk, consequence, and reward shape characters as surely as dice.
- **Build Together.** Collaboration turns scenes into sagas and mechanics into myth.

The rules are here to help you weave drama, not to constrain it. Use them generously, ignore them when they slow the story, and trust your table to improvise with honesty and care. Above all, let the edges of fate guide you not toward certainty, but toward possibility.

May your journeys be bold, your dice fall true, and your stories echo long after the table is cleared.

Index

- Advancement, 35
 - Costs, 37
 - Guidance, 41
 - Overview, 35
 - Prestige Abilities, 7
- Advantages, 31
- Aelaerem, 36
- Aeler, 39
- Aelinnel, 36
- Affinity, 6
- Anima
 - Clockwork Monad, 68
- Arcana, 40
- Archetypes, 36
 - Mastermind, 37
 - Example, 41
 - Mixed, 36
 - Example, 40
 - Solo, 36
 - Example, 40
- Artifacts, 30
- Artificer
 - Clockwork Monad, 68
- Assets, 25, 26, 36
 - Activation cost, 29
 - Activations, 29
 - Breakage, 30
 - Compromised, 29
 - Condition tracks, 29
 - Costs, 37
 - Downtime repair, 30
 - Maintained, 29
 - Maintenance, 30
 - Major, 37
 - Minimal, 36
 - Minor, 36
 - Neglected, 29
 - Off-Screen, 29
 - Off-Screen effects, 29
 - On-Screen effects, 29, 31
 - Plausibility, 29
 - Risk flag, 30
 - XP repair, 30
- Assists, 25, 30, 37
 - Maximum, 28, 38
 - Rules, 28
 - Source, 28
- Attributes, 36
 - Costs, 37
- Backlash, 24, 25, 40, 43, 46
 - Free Caster, 50
- Backlash Soothing (Wood Elf), 40
- Banner-Bearer (Human), 39
- Battle Instincts, 38
- Blood Frenzy (Ykrul), 40
- Blood Memory (Ykrul), 40
- Body, 39, 40
- Bonds, 29, 30, 35
 - Examples, 30
 - Limits, 31
 - Mutual requirement, 30
 - Requirements, 30
 - Session limit, 31
 - Starting bonus, 35
- Boons, 29, 30
 - Boon Finesse, 45
 - Conversion, 7
 - Maximum, 7
 - Timing, 31
- Build examples, 40
- Build styles, 36
- Cadres, 37
- Cantor
 - Inspire Chorus, 49
- Character Creation, 35
 - 30 XP, 35
 - 34 XP cap, 35
 - Affinity, 6

- Enhanced builds, 35
- Examples, 40
- Starting builds, 35
- Clocks, 23, 40
 - 10-segment, 18
 - 4-segment, 18
 - 6-segment, 18
 - 8-segment, 18
 - Size Determination, 18
 - Supply, 23
- Closing Thoughts, 231
- Codex, 43
- Combat
 - Follower Initiative, 7
 - Over-Stack, 7, 31
 - Over-Stack trigger, 31
 - Position States, 7
 - Structural advantages, 31
- Complications, 29, 35
 - Clearing, 35
 - Initial, 35
 - Starting bonus, 35
- Compromised, 26
- Conditions, 23
 - Fatigue, 24
- Core Philosophy
 - Central Question, 5
 - Consequences Matter, 6
 - Meaningful Growth, 6
 - Narrative First, 6
 - Principles, 5
 - Risk Creates Drama, 6
- Corruption, 48
- Crack the Seal, 45
- Craft, 25
- Deck Generators, 17
- Deck of Consequences
 - Twists, 31
- Decks
 - Act Builder, 18
 - Black Suits, 18
 - Club, 18
 - Colour Combos, 19
 - Combo Rules, 19
 - Consequences, 17
 - Diamond, 18
 - Draw Procedures, 18
 - Examples, 21
 - Face + Ace, 19
 - Flushes, 19
 - Full Seed, 18
 - GM Guidance, 22
 - Heart, 18
 - Pairs, 19
 - Quick Hook, 18
 - Rank Severity, 18
 - Red Suits, 18
 - Regional Summary, 19
 - Runs, 19
 - Spade, 18
 - Structure, 17
 - Travel, 17
 - Usage, 19
- Description Ladder
 - Basic action, 31
 - Intricate action, 30
- Design Philosophy, 26
 - Consequence Weight, 7
 - Fail Forward, 7
 - Meaningful Growth, 7
 - Mechanical Constraints, 7
 - Narrative Primacy, 7
 - Risk as Drama, 7
- Difficulty Value, 24, 25, 31, 40
- Difficulty Value (DV)
 - Rites, 44
- Downtime, 24–26, 30, 44
 - Fatigue recovery, 24
 - Followers, 25
 - Supply, 24
- Dwarves
 - Talents, 39
- Elements, 46
- Enchantments, 25
- Environment, 31
- Exceptional Coordination, 38
- Experience Points, 35
- Familiars, 37
- Fatigue, 24, 44
 - Clearing, 24
- Fiction-first, 30
- Followers, 25, 26, 36
 - Assist, 28

- Cap, 36
- Cap 5, 39
- Capability, 25
- Cost, 25
- Costs, 37
- Initiative, 31
- Loss resilience, 36
- Loyalty, 29
- Loyalty tags, 29
- Multi-character, 41
- Off-Screen, 25
- On-Screen, 25
- Risk, 37
- Slot limit, 28
- Switching, 41
- Forge-Patriarch (Dwarf), 39
- Freeform magic, 43
 - TAGS, 50
- Game Mastering
 - Flavor is Free, 8
- Gear, 24
 - Breaking, 24
 - Compromised, 24
 - Repair, 25
- GM discretion, 31
- GM fiat, 24
- GM guidance, 41
- Guild Ties (Human), 39
- High Elves
 - Talents, 40
- Humans
 - Talents, 39
- Imbuement, 44
 - Lesser, 45
- Invokers, 230
- Iron Stomach, 38
- Leash, 45
 - Capacity, 45
 - Ticks, 45
- Ledger Credits, 28
- Logistics, 36
- Lore, 39
- Lorekeeper (High Elf), 40
- Magic, 43
 - Design philosophy, 43
 - Guardrails, 51
 - Healing, 24
- Mechanics
 - Assist Maximum, 7
 - Dice Cap, 7
- Milestones, 38
- Narrative identity, 35, 41
- Narrative Time, 6
 - Days, 6
 - Moment, 6
 - Scales, 6
 - Significant Time, 6
 - Some Time, 6
- Narrative-first, 24
- Neglected, 26
- Networks, 36, 37
- NPCs
 - Ambition, 20
 - Attitude, 20
 - Belief, 20
 - Generation Deck, 20
 - Twist, 20
- Obishaal (Dreams/Thresholds), 46
- Obligation, 25, 43, 44
 - Capacity, 44
- Omens, 40
- Optional rules, 41
- Outsiders, 45
- Party resources, 23
- Paths of Magic, 43
 - Cantor, 48
 - Comparison, 51
 - Free Caster, 43
 - Invoker, 44
 - Overview, 43
 - Runekeeper, 43
- Patron Favor Swap, 28
- Patrons, 43, 52
- Penalties, 24
- Planning, 37
- Position
 - Surprise, 31
- Power curve, 41
- Presence, 39, 44
- Prestige Abilities, 7, 38

- Quests, 30
- Races
 - Affinities, 6
- Ranger's Step (Wood Elf), 40
- Relationships, 41
- Repertoire, 49
- Reputation Tiers, 38
- Resolve, 39
- Resource Management, 23
- Resources, 23
 - Assets and Followers, 25
 - Bond-Driven Generation, 30
 - Gear condition, 24
 - Off-Screen, 7
 - On-Screen, 7
 - On-Screen vs. Off-Screen, 7
 - Overview, 23
 - Supply Clock, 23
- Rest, 24
- Risk, 31
- Rites, 43
 - Difficulty Value, 44
- Rituals, 46
 - Clocks, 47
 - Components, 47
 - Preparation, 31
 - Teamwork, 47
- Safety Tools
 - Lines, 5
 - Veils, 5
 - X-Card, 5
- Seized, 26
- Silver Tongue, 38
- Skills, 36, 40
 - Costs, 37
- Small Folk, 36
- Songs, 48
- Spellcasting, 43
- Spirit, 39, 44
- Spirit Shield (Dwarf), 39
- Stealth, 40
- Stone-Sense (Dwarf), 39
- Story Beats, 6, 19, 23, 24, 31, 43
 - Banked, 35
 - Collateral, 6
 - Complications, 24
 - Escalation, 6
 - Exhaustion, 6
 - Exposure, 6
 - Follower risk, 25
 - Generation, 6
 - GM spends, 36
 - Spends, 24
- Summoning, 45
- Supply, 23, 24
 - Civilisation, 24
 - Emptying, 24
 - Filling, 23
 - Purchasing, 24
 - States, 23
- Survival, 25, 39, 40
 - Foraging, 24
- Sway, 40
- Symbols, 44
 - Cost, 44
- Tags, 31, 43, 50
 - List, 50
- Talents, 38
 - Costs, 37
 - Cultural, 39
 - Exceptional Coordination, 25
 - General, 38
 - Invoker, 45
 - Spellcraft, 43
- Teamwork, 30, 37
- Temporary Magic Items, 68
- The Golden Rule, 8
- Thiasos, 43
- Travel
 - Travel light, 24
- Union Rules, 28
- Upkeep, 26, 36
- Versatile (Human), 39
- Versatility, 36
- Warglord (Ykrul), 40
- Wary, 26
- Ways-Walker's Step (High Elf), 40
- Weave Anchor (High Elf), 40
- Wild Speaker (Wood Elf), 40
- Wits, 40
- Wood Elves

Talents, 40

XP

Assets, 29

Awards, 35

Costs, 37

Followers, 25

Spreads, 36, 37

Totals, 38

Upkeep, 25, 29

Ykrul

Talents, 40